

FREEHAVEN ONLINE
LADY
THUNDERLORD
INTO HADES



A LitRPG Adventure
JUN PRINCE

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Prologue - Far from Home

A little over two weeks trapped in virtual reality, and I sometimes think about my body. I'm still alive and don't feel mind-fogged, so I can only assume that someone's found my lifeless husk back in Meatsville slumped in my beanbag chair, and that I'm now on life support. Whether I'm occupying my old bedroom in my parents' house with an IV and a private nurse, in some sort of improvised ward for company employees at HQ, or in a regular hospital with all the coma patients is anyone's guess. For now, I'm still breathing.

Staying connected to Freeworld Online this long messes with your head. You remember the real world, but with each minute that goes by you begin to think of the game environment more and more as your real home. It's like taking a long vacation, when on day twelve of fourteen you think, "Do I still remember what working's like?" Of course I do, but with NPCs acting more and more like real people and our guild chef, Pehrom, cobbling together more tasty meals, this place feels more like an actual location than a bunch of code stored on Freehaven servers.

* * * * *

Tako and I are facing off on the training grounds of Cupcake Keep. He comes in with a quick strike with his dagger in his left hand. I slip out of the way, and counterattack with Bite, my electrified staff, which sends snakes of electricity crawling over his leather armor.

He says, "Damn! I can't hit you!"

"That's the point." As an evasive tank, the best way to prevent taking damage is not to get hit in the first place. I say, "Now come on at me."

The boyish half-elf rogue disappears. I drop and roll for cover. Instead of appearing right behind me as I would have done in his position, he re-emerges in the shadow of one of the archery targets and hurls a knife in my direction. It nicks me in the thigh, delivering a sensation like a muted bee sting.

I flick my darksteel chakram at him. The difficulty of the shot is high because I'm uneasy on my knees, and he dodges to the left, leaving my pie tin sized ring of death embedded in a practice dummy. A few counts later it disappears and a new chakram materializes on my wrist in the way of in-game ranged weapons. I can throw it about a hundred times before durability hits zero and I need a blacksmith to repair it.

I scramble to my feet expecting more blades to come launching at me. None do, and I get the hazy feeling the world's grown a little too quiet. I stand taller, brush the dirt off my Swiftstrike leathers, and wonder why he's not attacking.

"No follow through?" I ask, "You could have had a few more hits on me. Nice move, by the way, shadow stepping a different direction. I wasn't expecting it."

Tako looks like he's seen a ghost. Instead of talking, he holds the screen of his virtual tablet (VT) toward me. He swallows hard, and looks like he's about to cry.

I say, "Dude, what is it?" and pull out my own VT.

I've toggled my user interface to filter most system messages out during combat to avoid visual clutter, so I didn't see it at first. The system message at the top of my feed stops me cold.

Mirae has come online.

Tako still hasn't found his words. His mouth moves, but no sound comes out. I fill the void between us by saying "Holy hell." Mirae's dead, or so we believed. I fire off a quick message, or at least try to.

Melpomine: Mirae?

You cannot send messages to that player.

Melpomine: Is that you?

You cannot send messages to that player.

Melpomine: Where are you?

You cannot send messages to that player.

Tako says, "I can't send her a message."

"Neither can I." I say, and check her location on my friends list. Instead of the name of an in-game city, tavern, or dungeon, the text in the location column reads "Unknown." Beside her name, where there was once a blue cross incapacitated icon, is the Oroboros; a serpent eating its own tail.

Tako says, "Do you think it's her?"

I want to believe, but it's scary. We had a funeral. Her bow serves as a magically preserved tombstone in our garden. I don't want to have hope and go through the mournful battery of loss all over again. It hasn't been that long so the wounds are nowhere close to healed.

Among her last words were "When I get back here you'll be my family. Big sister with a cool job, okay?" but she never reemerged from the digitization station like the other people who survived, sacrificing their real lives to live

forever in a digital world. The news said they were gone, and yet the alert kindles a small ember of hope... miraculous, and terrifying.

My frightened astonishment gives way to joy as I feel an expression of wonder spread across my face. I'm already clinging to the chance that she hasn't appeared as a permanent digital resident of Freehaven Online because all the data containing her mind, character and emotions is locked away in a protected folder somewhere. She's online now, and unreachable. We have to find her because it's a hell of a lot better than losing our friend forever.

I say, "Let's go to the digitization station." instead of answering his question directly. I call out, "INFERNO!!!" and wave my middle finger in the air. There's a pop of red like a supernova, and a powerful mechanical growl as my fire Elechopper appears. It's a hot red motorcycle, that spits long tongues of flame out its exhaust, powered by a fire spirit swirling in a burning tornado within the gas can.

Tako nods, and says "Let's go." Instead of waiting for me to summon him a bike, a practice that has become a guild tradition when we travel together, he calls his great black war tiger mount, which is unlike any animal I've seen in the real world. It roars when summoned, and has a coat of black fur with even blacker stripes.

It only takes a few minutes to arrive at the digitization station and it's a lot quieter than before. The nightly protests warning players of the dangers of undergoing the process died out after a half a week when more or less everyone had heard the news that it's not a guaranteed process. We're alone save for the stoic black angel guardians, and a little gnome that looks confused. He's got round ears, a ZZ Top beard that nearly touches the cobblestones underfoot, and a wild hairstyle that sweeps forward over his forehead in imitation of a Nike swoosh. I imagine our own expressions are much the same; bewildered and hopeful.

I ask, "Looking for something?"

The gnome looks down and says, "Nothing... I just..."

I give him a push knowing how intimidating it can be to have hope. "Someone you didn't expect to see come online?"

The little man looks startled and says, "Yes... Yes! How did you know?"

I ask, "Is it Mirae? Sea Elf, greenish hair, about this tall." I hold my hand out for demonstration. I hadn't seen the gnome at the funeral, but I suppose it's always possible that she had in-game friends we might have missed.

"Mirae?" He asks. "No... I don't know who that is. I'm looking for Jonah. He's a half gnome."

Tako says, "Well, have you seen a Sea Elf?"

The gnome says, "No... I haven't seen anyone like that. I'm Magnus by the way."

I feel the urge to chortle seeing such a little guy with such a powerful name, but the seriousness of the situation keeps the impulse under control. With a name like Magnus you'd expect him to be a six foot tall hulking warrior. I say, "Nice to meet you. I'm Mel, and this is Tako. We haven't seen anyone like that since we arrived."

The gnome frowns, "I was sure I'd see him walking out of there."

Tako's wandering, trying to get a look along the side of the building, and I say, "Me too." I sigh. "Of course it wasn't going to be that easy."

Magnus asks, "You know someone that wasn't digitized too?"

"Yeah." I say, and motioned to Tako. "That's her boyfriend... Kinda. I don't think they actually confirmed it. Can you send Jonah a message?"

"No" he says.

I say, "Neither can we. It just says she's online, with an Oroboros next to her name." I can tell from the gnome's crestfallen expression, that he's seen the same thing. "Why don't you add me to your contacts? We can let each other know if anything changes."



Chapter 1 - The Lost Champion (Part 2)

Later that day, I'm sitting before three men, two in blue, one in cream colored caster's robes. The table's round, but I'm sitting at one end, while they are in a cluster at the other. A jar of faintly glowing azure energy sits between us.

Essence of the Lost Champion (Limited Edition)

This item begins a quest.

Description:

A jar of faintly glowing energy that could wink out if improperly handled. Someone in Durolan may find this interesting.

The man on the left strokes his white beard, not bushy like Santa, but long and narrow with flecks of gray. Both he and the Cleric have one, whereas the navy clad mage in the middle is younger, and clean shaven about the mouth though he has robust brunette side burns.

The guy in the center, Rael by his nameplate, says, "We are dealing with a fragment of soul that can return one of the Lost to the living. There is no precedent."

Lost. That's what they call the permanently dead. The unfortunate NPCs, and I hope PCs, who died and for whatever reason weren't eligible for respawn or resurrection. I'm hoping with all I've got that this may be a way to retrieve Mirae, my new little sister from another mother, who said we'd be family in game just before failing digitization.

"Necromancy!" the elderly man with the long beard and blue robe spits. His name is Marulan. "Your plan is reckless and ill conceived. If we follow your course we could create an undead horror that will plague us for centuries. Let the dead rest in peace."

The long bearded cleric in off-white clears his throat, "From a spiritual standpoint, this is not necromancy, at least, not in the traditional sense of the word. The spark contained within that jar is the antithesis of death magic, a pure ember of concentrated life." His name is Aluwyn, Priest of Gaia, Lady of Life.

"Exactly!" Rael says, speaking more to his colleague than anyone else, "I gather you all together, and the only person to agree with me is the light blinded

cleric. We're magus alumni of the same academy, if anyone, I should have your support."

"Not when you're spouting madness!" Marulan says.

I've been watching these guys go back and forth for the last hour on the ethics and potential uses of this item. I clear my throat. "Ahem..." All three sets of eyes turn to me, as if having forgotten I was in the room. "I've yet to voice an opinion." I feel those old role-play bones stirring in my body. "As a Paladin of the Sun Lord, and owner of the object in question, I believe I have some say."

As soon as Aluwyn had been called into the discussion, I assumed my Scootiwutams alias. For just a moment, they saw me as a ripped dwarven paladin, in full plate, bearing a shield with the sign of Helios. It's like switching to an alternate character without having to log out.

By revealing my alternate identity to these men, all of Scooti's in-game reputation and social status had been transferred to Lord Melpomine, my primary alias, so far as these three men are concerned. I've since reassumed my Melpomine alias, thus taking on the original appearance and mannerisms of my half-elf martial artist.

The mage with the long beard sounds embarrassed as he coughs and says, "Yes, of course, Lady Lord Melpomine. We hadn't intended to exclude you." The beginning of a smile tugs at the corner of his mouth. I have no doubt he expects me to agree with him.

"Of course..." Rael says, his voice sounds less than confident.

"Before I speak, I want to be sure of one thing. The essence, it is not necessarily a fragment of a specific spirit. Correct?" This is important because we'd found the item before Mirae had attempted digitization. My heart can't take finishing this limited edition quest, without any promise of restoring Mirae when I thought there was. I need to know exactly what I'm getting into.

Rael says, "Yes and no, who can say? There's no proof that the essence came from a living person one way or another."

Aluwyn adds, "The essence foundation is a building block of a living spirit, the same as steel is to a sword. Say you find a hunk of formless steel. Might it have once been a sword? Perhaps, but then it might also be just an ingot forged of raw materials before taking on the shape of a weapon."

"I see." I say, considering. "So, if we use this to bring someone back it doesn't matter who we choose. This essence isn't paired with a specific spirit?"

"Correct." Aluwyn says.

Rael adds, "We've done a lot of tests, and there's nothing to indicate that this was once a person."

I nod. *Except the name of the item. Does it matter?* I don't think it does. We have a tool, and I'd be foolish to waste it. I say, "I agree then."

Rael smiles, and Marulan stiffens in his seat, straight backed and aghast at my pronouncement. He speaks in a carefully controlled voice, "With whom do you agree?"

I clarify, "Master Rael and Aluwyn. In fact, I've already decided who to use it on."

Marulan says, "Now, just wait a minute! You can't just go off and do something like this lightly."

I say, "My essence, my decision. We don't need you. "

**You have lost 500 personal reputation with Marulan.
Current level. Neutral.**

Rael beams and rubs his hands together like he's building a fire. He says, "I supposed one individual is just as good as another." He grins at Aluwyn, "Just think, we'll be doing magic that no one in living memory has ever done before!" The old priest bows his head, though his body language is less manic than the mage. "I follow the will of the Lady, and she has asked me to bring this girl to life."

"Wait..." I say, "This girl? I wasn't aware I told you who we'd be resurrecting."

"This is no resurrection." Aluwyn says, "She will be reborn with great life."

"Yeah, well... Okay," I say, "I understand, but who do you think I'm talking about?"

Aluwynn says, "Lady Mirae is favored by the goddess. Lost as she is now, I will do my best to return her."

My skin grows cold to hear the name spoken aloud. I can feel the small hairs raising on the back of my neck. I'm not scared, it's just my catch all response to a brush with the uncanny. Of course, the game could be aware of what happened, our mourning, Mirae dying, but the less rational part of me imagines her lonely ghost placing a hand on my shoulder. *I'm coming.*

"So what do we have to do?" I say.

Rael shifts in his chair uncomfortably. "That's... a bit more difficult."

"Tell me." I say. "There's no use holding back."

Rael and Aluwyn exchange looks, but Marulan responds, "You'll have to go to Hades."

I raise an eyebrow, having anticipated something along these lines. In the last week, my discussions with the mages have often touched on the afterlife. However, I've never heard of a player actually going there. I ask, "Is that a place? I mean, of course I've heard of it, but how do you get there?" Marulan looks like he's about to say something so I hold up a finger and say, "Without dying." He closes his mouth.

Rael asks, "May I see your map?" I push it across the table. "We believe the closest entrances are here." He touches its surface with his finger, which leaves a red mark in the way of games. "And here."

He pushes it back toward me. Unlike a lot of games, Freehaven Online uses compressed versions of real world GPS maps as the basis for its geography. I whistle because both locations are in the equivalent of the Southwestern United states, meanwhile we are still north of what would be California. I say, "We're going to need a portal."

Rael says, "... and I'll gladly provide one for you." *Well, good. That's one worry taken off the list.* "Once you're there, you'll have to find the soul you wish to bring back, and feed her the essence you've brought us. From there you'll have twenty four hours to get her to us so we can complete the ritual. You don't want to eat the food of Hades, so you'd best go well provisioned."

I ask, "How are we supposed to find her once we arrive?"
Rael just shrugs, and neither of the other men seem to have ideas.
Aluwyn says, "That's something you'll have to figure out for yourself, so I advise you to go with strong magic."
"Hades curse you if you bring back a monster." Marulan says.
My virtual tablet buzzes. Havenfolk remain indifferent, as if locked in time, while I check the alerts.

You have completed The Lost Champion - Part 1.

The following quest is now available.

Limited Edition - Quest
The Lost Champion - Part 2
Difficulty: Hard

To restore one of the Lost to the living, you must enter Hades, the underworld, where unknown troubles await. Find the soul you wish to restore, feed it the Essence of the Lost Champion, and return to Durolan where Marulan, Rael, and Aluwyn await.

Warning: After leaving Hades the ritual must be performed within 24 hours to complete this quest.

Objectives:	
Enter Hades	0/1
Find Soul	0/1
Feed Essence	0/1
Complete ritual in Durolan	0/1

Rewards:
Return one of the Lost to the living.
Reputation: +10,000 Reputation in Durolan
Point Break x 2

Cost of Failure:
Failure to retrieve soul from Hades
(Essence of the Lost Champion destroyed)
Ritual Fails, and Soul Becomes an Undead Monster
(-15,000 Marulan, -5,000 Reputation Durolan)

Suggested party size: 5
This quest can be shared if you have five or less people in your party.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I tap "Yes."

If we botch this and Mirae becomes a zombie or a vampire, I can almost guarantee that Marulan will be an enemy for life. Not the end of the world since he's not the ruler of this city, but only a fool makes enemies of influential NPCs if they don't have to. All three of these men are respected scholars. In Durolan arcane knowledge is social clout, which translates to more than one kind of power.

A few seconds later, a global alert fills my vision.

GLOBAL ALERT

The Realm of Hades has been unlocked and can now be explored by all adventurers! Who among you will dare traversing the lands of the dead?

WARNING: Characters that are not undead or undying who set their bind points within Hades will become Lost themselves. Lost characters cannot enter the Freeworld, or Haven without the aid of powerful magic.

All adventurers? Does this imply that some adventurers already have access to Hades, or have a few hopeful digitizers been stranded there since the digitization stations opened? I attempt contacting Mirae.

Melpomine: Mirae?

You cannot send messages to that player.

Melpomine: Can you see this?

You cannot send messages to that player.

Damn.

I'd hoped unlocking Hades would allow messages to go through. No such luck. Apparently, short of visiting the underworld in person, it's no easier to contact the Lost in Freehaven than it had been for me to speak to my dead brother.

I say, "I'll need a few days to prepare and gather a party."

"Fantastic!" Rael says, "Bring your group to the Lodge of Arcanum and I will make a portal for you when you're ready."

I ask, "Do you have any idea what we'll be facing?"

Aluwyn says, "There may be undead just outside the gates, but once you cross the river you should mostly encounter spirit entities, or the dead themselves."

Thinking of the global alert I ask, "... but undead can enter, correct?"

"They can..." the old cleric trails, "...but it is not their home. Vampires, for example, would soon go mad from hunger as souls have no blood. Expect any you find there to be little more than beasts."

"Good to know." I say, while mentally crossing off undead fighting enchantments from my shopping list. "What do you mean by the river?"

"There are five major rivers in the underworld" Aluwyn says, "Acheron, Cocytus, Phlegethon, Lethe, and Styx. One must be crossed or sailed to enter Hades, and each possesses its own dangers."

Rael says, "The two entrances I marked on your map correspond with the Rivers Lethe and Styx."

I follow, "... and each entrance will result in a different kind of encounter."

Aluwyn says, "Hatred and forgetfulness."

"Oblivion." Rael amends.

I say, "I'll keep that in mind while I'm preparing."

Marulan says, "If that's all, I have more important things to do than help you embark on a suicidal quest."

I know a dismissal when I hear one so I stand, collect the essence at the center of the table, and say "Thank you for your time."



Chapter 2 - Let Them Eat Steak

I'm mounting my Firechopper outside when a red skinned man poofs in front of me in a human-sized explosion of flame and dark smoke. He's wearing a black tunic, has small horns and wolfish teeth. His long whip of a tail that ends in a two prong fork and his name plate reads, "Lorak the Messenger."

The creature reaches into a deep pocket, bows, and passes me an envelope sealed in red wax. He says, "Leroy Jensen of the Malefactors guild sends his regards."

"Thanks." I say. The demonic creature disappears in another gout of flame as soon as the letter leaves his hand.

The Malefactors? That's surprising. Their one of the top tier raiding guilds in Haven. I wonder what I could have done to earn the attention of one of its members, let alone the likes of a pro gamer like Leroy Jensen. The guy has an entire in-game fan club that worships at his feet. I break the seal to see what he's sent.

LeroyJensen wants to become mutual friends. Do you accept? Yes / No

Personal messengers are a bit more expensive than the normal in-game post, but they find the recipient wherever they are almost immediately and allow you to make mutual friend requests at a distance so that you can send direct messages to people you haven't yet encountered face to face.

I choose "Yes," Then unfold the letter.

"Jordan? WTF man? Grats on the world first Dragonslayer title, but WTF? The Muffins are still alive? Why aren't you on anyone's contact list? Did you sell your account? Man, it's been forever. Hit me up, when you get this."

LeroyJensen: Jordan, is that you?

My breath catches. I'm just staring at my brother's name in the private message because I don't know how to react. This is the first person I've encountered in game that knew him while he was still alive. I can't believe that

Leroy Jensen was a guild member, or at the very least, one of his friends. My heart beats fast, and my hands feel shaky as I send my response.

Melpomine: This is his sister.
LeroyJensen: Oh, 'sup? Where's Jordan. I haven't seen him in ages. He gave his guild to you?
Melpomine: It's a long story.
Melpomine: Can we meet? I'm in Durolan heading back to Cupcake Keep.
LeroyJensen: I just wanted to say hi to Jordan. Tell him to message me, and that he's a dick for blocking me and everyone else.
Melpomine: He didn't... and I can't. He's gone.
LeroyJensen: Did he quit the game? What's he playing? If we ever get out of here I'll look him up.
Melpomine: Can't do that... Find him in another game, I mean.
Melpomine: Were you friends? If you were, we really should meet so I can go over things with you.
LeroyJensen: Yeah, I guess. Alright, fine. Whatever. I'll be there in a few minutes. Tell Cupcake to let me in.

His use of the name "Cupcake" sends blasts of topless redhead elf woman in chainmail bikini bottoms coursing through my head. I haven't used that name for the personality attached to guild headquarters since my first night there and I met the castle for the first time. Thereafter, I've called that entity Alfred since he... she... it... can also take on a male butler appearance.

Melpomine: We call him Alfred now, and I will. I'll meet you in the lounge or dining room. If we're lucky Pehrom can whip up some lunch for us.
LeroyJensen: Haven food tastes like crap. Who's Pehrom?
Melpomine: He's our chef, and if he's around you're in for a surprise.
LeroyJensen: If you say so.

I fire off a message to our chef before the ride home.

Melpomine: Incoming. VIP guest. Are you available for some grub?
Pehrom: Yeah, I ain't gone out yet. Just checkin' out the garden. You know, I need to get me some of that earth magic. Did you know they can make plants grow in like a second?
Melpomine: They can in Freeworld, but not many people do it.
Pehrom: I just had a Havenfolk buddy of mine replenish the garlic, tomatoes, and onions. Months of growin' just like that.
Melpomine: I look forward to seeing it.
Pehrom: Who's the guest?
Melpomine: Leroy Jensen.
Pehrom: No shit, you know him?
Melpomine: I do now, and he's coming. I should be too. Putting the VT away because I don't want to text and ride.
Pehrom: I'll be in the garden.

I call, "Alfred!" as I step through the iron banded gate of my castle. He appears wearing a tuxedo in a cascade of purple smoke like a stage magician. A pencil thin moustache decorates his upper lip.

"Master." He bows respectfully.

"Do you remember Leroy Jensen?"

"Yes, a former guild member." Alfred says, "He left six months after I last saw your brother."

I say, "So, he was a Toxic Muffin. I'll be damned."

"Yes, master."

"Anyway, he's coming. You have my permission to let him in, and escort him to wherever I am at the time."

Alfred asks, "Is that all, master?"

I say, "Set the table for two since we'll be having lunch."

I expect him to disappear in a waterfall of smoke, as I walk toward the training area, which connects to the food garden, but he doesn't go. Instead he walks, keeping pace with me.

"There's a surprise in the master bedroom when you are ready."

"Oh?" I say. Looking ahead, I can see all the plant life looks a lot more lush than it did this morning. Bright green and red tomato vines crawl up trellises along the wall of the courtyard. and healthy shoots of garlic and onion plants spring up from the earth.

Alfred says, "The painting from the front hall has been restored. I thought you might like to see it before deciding whether to return it to its original location, or to house it in your personal quarters."

"About damn time." I say. "That thing's been torn up for ages."

"My apologies master. I have no excuse except to say I grew a little mad in those years spent alone."

I feel bad about complaining upon hearing that. Even though he's a machine, I expect that Alfred's been more a person than other Havenfolk for some time now. I've worked with advanced AIs for the last several years, and know that they are capable of eliciting just as much, if not more, emotion than some humans I've known.

I say, "It's alright." I want to let him know that I feel bad for leaving him alone in a vacant castle for eight years, but it comes out as, "We're back on track now."

He bows, and disappears, in that collapse of purple smoke that I've been expecting.

I say, "Hey Chef!" as I approach the goblin in the garden. He's wearing a green apron, and a pair of yellow gloves. He's standing with a human mage in muddy brown robes. A translucent bumblebee the size of my fist buzzes around spell caster like one of my vanity pets. I laugh. "You look domestic."

"What?" The big eared, green skinned man says. He has a New Jersey accent. "You think I'm gonna dirty up my good clothes?"

"Who's this?" I ask, noting the mage.

Pehrom says, "This is Hersevig. He's the grower I was tellin' ya about."

I extend my hand, "Melpomine. I hear you've done wonders in the garden."

"Oh it's nothing." The mage says, "Just a little plant magic know-how. I'm glad to help a new friend."

"Want a job?" I ask.

Both he, and the goblin look at me in surprise. "What? We need skills like this. If you want to join the Toxic Muffins, I'll save a spot for you."

"I uhm... This is very sudden." The mage says.

Pehrom says in an unconfident voice, "I'm not sure if Havenfolk can join guilds. I've never heard of it."

"Why not?" I pull up his nameplate, select him in my VT, and tap "Send Guild Invite."

Hersevig's eyes go wide.

Hersevig has declined your invitation.

"I'd have to talk about this with my family, and we haven't discussed terms..."

Pehrom says, "Did it work?"

I shrug and say, "Looks like it."

"Fuck." The goblin says, "The world really is changing. Who ever heard of an NPC joining an adventurer guild?"

I say, "I take it that's not supposed to happen?"

He says, "I've never been a leader but... "

I say, "Don't know until you try, I guess."

Hersevig says, "It was good to meet you, but I'd best be going."

Pehrom says, "See ya later."

I say, "Nice meeting you." before he turns to make his way out.

The heavy door squeals and shuts behind me.

Pehrom says, "How the fuck do you know Leroy fuckin' Jensen?"

"Ready to go in?" I ask, as I begin drifting toward the castle. "He sent me a demonic courier with a friend request after my thing at the Lodge of Arcanum. After that it was just 'Congratulations on being the world's first Dragonslayers.' and that he knew my brother."

Pehrom asks, "So you haven't met him yet?" he's walking with me to the keep.

I say, "This'll be the first time."

Pehrom says, "I'll see if we still have steaks. If not, at least we've got chicken."

I'm relaxing on the sofa when Alfred escorts a human with two day stubble into the lounge. He moves a few steps ahead of the butler which tells me he's already familiar with the layout of Toxic Muffins HQ. I know who it is, but I welcome him with a question.

"Leroy Jensen, I presume?" He's wearing a red leather jerkin with the burning hammer mark of the Malefactors guild emblazoned on his breast.

He says, "You presume correct. He never told me he had a hot sister."

"Err..." I say, "I doubt he'd have described me with those words."

Pehrom peeks in from the dining hall and calls out, "Leeeeerooooooyyyy Jennnnnnssseeeen!" There's an awkward pause. Before he continues, "....Guess what, we have steak."

"Thanks." I say. "You're our hero."

Now it's our guest's turn to look embarrassed. He gives Pehrom a pinched smile before looking back to me and saying, "Is this your chef?"

"It is." I say, "And he's amazing."

Leroy asks, "What's your cooking at?"

Pehrom says, "Fuckin' goose egg! Cooking skill's bullshit."

I say, "If you don't mind, can you turn off your feed if you're recording? This meeting is personal."

Leroy says, "Done."

I say, "We've discovered a new way of cooking."

Pehrom adds, "Name's Pehrom by the way."

Leroy says, "I saw your nameplate. Does it give buffs?"

"Not really," I say. "Just what you'd get from eating the basic ingredients. Well fed, and all that."

Leroy says, "So what's the point?"

Pehrom says, "Can you believe this guy? No faith."

I say, "You'll see in a few minutes."

Pehrom ducks out and I take a deep breath. Leroy settles on to the couch beside me. My heart's beating faster. I don't want to beat around the bush, because I'm afraid that if I don't get to it now, I'll start rambling, and won't say anything about my brother at all.

"Jordan's dead." I say.

A pregnant quiet that rings in our ears befalls us. I'm stock still, he shifts uncomfortably.

"I..." A false start from Leroy. "You mean... like for real?"

"Yeah..." I say, my voice feeling heavy. My body tingles under the emotional realization that I've taken one step along the path toward accomplishing my goal of letting Jordan's old friends know what happened.

"Did he digitize?" Leroy asks.

"No." I say, "He's been gone some eight years now. If he were here now, I doubt he'd do that. Not yet anyway."

"Damn..." Leroy says. No tears, but I wouldn't expect them over a person he hadn't been in contact with for so long. "I'm sorry."

"Yeah, well..." I shrug as if to say 'What are ya gonna do?' "Me too."

"What happened?"

"Hard to explain." I say. "A perfect storm of medication, physical exertion, and an undiagnosed medical condition that caused a heart attack."

"I just..." Leroy starts, "I can't even. We all thought he couldn't play the game anymore, and maybe lost his account when he disappeared from our contact lists."

I sigh. "That was my fault. I called customer service to see if I could inherit his account. When they moved the license to my email, all his friends were wiped, and I just had my friends list."

He says, "Damn... That explains it."

I say, "This is a good day for me. Since I've been back in Haven, I've been hoping one of his old guild members would see a Toxic Muffin running around and send me a message. First step to letting everyone know what happened. He didn't forget about you."

"Yeah well, being a world first certainly helps." He says, "Your name and guild are on the leader board. That's how I found you. Anyone who checks it can see that the Toxic Muffins, run by Stabbies, Melpomine, and Scootiwutams became the first Dragonslayers. I guess those are your alts?"

"Yeah. I have all his and my old characters in my aliases. I don't think it'll let me appoint additional leaders."

Leroy says, "I'll spread the word around to the people I still keep up with."

I say, "Let em' know that the Toxic Muffins are reopen for business if they want to come back. We've got limited edition quests and all that."

"What do you mean?" Leroy asks.

"Dragonsbane Part One was a limited edition quest. That's how we got the title."

"Really?" Leroy asks, "I think all guilds can do it now."

I say, "Can you do part two?"

"I don't think so." Leroy says, "I haven't heard of anyone getting the next quest."

"Huh..." I say in contemplation. "Maybe it unlocks for everyone once a LE guild finishes it, or after some period of time."

"Probably." Leroy says, "What kind of Limited Edition quests have you had?"

"We're on two now. Dragonsbane Part Two and The Lost Champion. I'm going to start recruiting today."

The door leading to the dining room swings open and Alfred pokes his head in. "Master Pehrom says your food will be ready in--"

He's cut off by the goblin's holler of "Five fuckin' minutes!" all the way from the kitchen.

"Yes, that..." Alfred straightens his tie. "Five minutes." He then collapses into a puddle of smoke in the way that he does.

I say, "We better relocate." We stand together. I hold the door for Leroy as he passes into the dining room. It's a long table that could easily sit twelve people, but three places have been set with steel plates, and wooden beer mugs at the end closest to the kitchen. "Sit wherever you want."

Leroy takes the seat on the left, and I sit on the right, leaving the spot at the head of the table empty. Leroy meets my gaze from his side of the table and says, "What's 'The Lost Champion?'"

"It's an underworld quest."

"You mean like the global alert?"

"Yeah... Actually, the alert sounded right after I accepted a quest to enter Hades."

Leroy looks thoughtful, and his voice becomes measured. I don't want to call him greedy, but I can sense something like it stirring in his next words.

"Is it guild only?"

I think I know where he's going with this, and to be honest, I'm shocked. What does a recently casual player like me have to offer a pro-Gamer like Leroy Jensen? My voice is skeptical when I respond, "I don't think so, let me check."

I open up the quests interface of my VT, and sort by quest type.

Guild Quests

(Limited Edition) Dragonsbane (Part 2) - 4% Complete

Personal Quests

(Limited Edition) The Lost Champion - 10% Complete

New Magic - 0% Complete

Looking over the short list, I say "It's a personal quest, but we obtained it from a drop while completing Dragonsbane One. Says it can be shared with party members so long as there are five or less people in the party."

"Add me." Leroy says. "It'll be great for ratings."

This has me taken aback. *You still care about ratings while we're stuck in-game?* I don't even know what to say. How can I not accept the help of someone with such a high profile, and yet...

I say, "We already have a tank." and point my thumb at my own chest. "Two other guild members have guaranteed spots because they have a personal stake in this. For the rest, I was planning to give Toxic Muffins members first priority. I get that you're eager to explore new content, but why do you care about ratings anyway?"

"Whoa..." Leroy holds up both his hands in a placating gesture. He must have heard the sharpness in my voice. "We got off to a bad start. Let's try again. I didn't mean to be presumptive."

I glance at the kitchen door, and then back to him with a raised eyebrow as if to say "I'm waiting."

He says, "First, yes I care about ratings because it's my income. I've got a wife and child out there that are depending on me to earn the bread. Their need for groceries hasn't stopped just because we're all trapped in game."

Hearing him talk about his family reminds me of Frobod, one of my first guild recruits, and how he wants so badly to get back to his daughter. My heart sinks for having not thought of that, being the loner in Meatsville that I am.

"Second," he says, "The day after Archangel showed up, I made an announcement and pinned it to the top of my channel. 18% of revenue generated from my streams is being donated to a fund that I hope my wife has set up. The money will go to players who are locked in game that don't have enough money to pay for life support. We're lucky with all the cost-free assistance we've had in America, Canada, and the UK, but players in other parts of the world haven't been so fortunate. I've recruited 29 other pro-gamers to contribute to the fund, and have given them instructions for how their finance people in the real world can get in touch with Lisa... That's my wife. So yes, even though I'm still in game, I care a hell of a lot about ratings."

"Sorry..." I say, sounding sheepish.

"Also..." He says, "I don't know how serious you are about building the Muffins up again, but all the dedicated airtime on my feed with a Toxic Muffins group, will make recruitment easy."

The kitchen door swings open and Pehrom calls, "Leeeroooooyyy Jennnseeenn!" Leroy looks down and pinches the bridge of his nose upon hearing his name.

The chef's carrying all three plates like a boss, in his chef's apron and poofy Toque Blanche. I see that all three meals are the same as he sets dishes in front of Leroy, myself and the empty seat at the end of the table.

Leroy says, "Smells good." as he pokes his meat with a knife.

"Damn right it does." Pehrom says. "You're lookin' at the best chef in all of Haven."

I amend, "All of Freehaven most likely. I haven't found anyone else that's figured out the new skill."

Leroy says, "I'll take your word for it."

I cut a bite size chunk off the end, and close my eyes in pleasure as the juices roll over my tongue and down my throat. Speaking right after swallowing, I say, "What was this again?"

Pehrom says, "Giant Lambox."

I say, "Well, it tastes like angus beef."

Leroy says, "You guys are crazy." and eyes his meal dubiously. I don't blame him, until now in-game food has had texture but tastes like nothing.

"Try it." I say.

Leroy cuts his meat, as Pehrom opens his mouth for another cry of 'Leeroy Jensen,' but our guest stops him with a raised hand. "You don't have to say that all the time. I get it enough when I see the fan club. It's kind of annoying."

"Oh." Pehrom says, in an abrupt tone. "Then take a bite."

Jensen's eyes grow wide the instant the meat hits his tongue. Instead of commenting, he rapidly cuts more pieces, and begins shoveling them into his mouth while he's chewing. Now he looks a bit like a chip monk, with a third of his stake vanished into his mouth.

"I almost forgot." Pehrom says. He dips back into the kitchen and returns with a basket of golden fries served over a bright red handkerchief, and a pitcher of amber liquid in the other. As he fills our mugs, and sets the fries in the space between us he says, "New oil. Whatta ya think?"

I try one, about the length of my index finger, it's crunchy outside, and has perfect fluff within. "It's good." I say, and then swallow. "It has kind of a.... mushroom aftertaste."

Pehrom looks to Leroy who is still stuffing his face, and asks, "It's good, ya?"

Our guest takes a deep breath, still chewing, and drops his fork beside his plate. "That..." He begins, working the last of the food down his throat, "Was..." he pauses again for breath.... "The best thing I think I've ever had. Holy shit... I thought we were doomed to tasteless slop forever. How did you..?"

"Special preparations..." The goblin winks. "Trade secret."

"Actually..." I say, "It was one of our other members that discovered it."

Pehrom huffs. "Way to take the fun oughta it."

"This is amazing." Frobod says, "Like... A game changer."

"We're still deciding what to do with the knowledge. Let it out for free, or make big bucks selling food to adventurers."

"Let it out, whateva." Pehrom says "Even knowing the secret, ain't none of them gonna be as good as me."

Leroy eyes the pitcher, "Is that beer?"

"Nah," Pehrom says, "If you're lookin' for booze, you got the wrong guy. AA - 12 years sober."

I say, "Congratulations." not having known this about our chef.

"Yeah, thanks." Pehrom says, "It's made me a better person, and a better man."

Leroy takes a swig of the not-beer drink, holds it to his lips, and finishes half the mug. He gasps a satisfied "Ahh!" as he returns it to the table. "Apple juice. I'm not complaining."

"Anyway..." I say, "So that's the quest. We have a jar of essence that we need to feed to one of the Lost in Hades, and escort the spirit back to Durolan."

"Is this for Mirae?" Pehrom removes his apron and fills the empty seat at the table. A note of hope sounds in his voice when he says, "I saw her come online, but haven't been able to send messages."

"I think so." I say, "Or at least, that's what I'm hoping."

Leroy says, "Who's Mirae, and what's the reward?"

I respond, "Mirae's our friend, one of the people who died during digitization. Apparently, as of this morning, they all came back online, but no one can contact them."

"No way..." Leroy says. "I didn't have any friends who tried and failed so I didn't know. "

I say, "The quest reward is to return one of the Lost to the living and two point breaks. I'm pretty sure it'll work on NPCs, but with those login alerts, we're hoping it'll also apply to adventurers."

Pehrom wipes the corner of his eye, "Fuck... and we just buried her."

"Actually...." I start to clarify things for Leroy, but the goblin cuts me off.

"We had a funeral, is what I mean."

I sigh, and say "Yeah, we did that." I look to Leroy and say, "That's what I mean by 'This is personal' with the quest. Tako, her almost boyfriend, is coming. I'd also like to bring Pahrem, who was also her friend, and now our replacement healer."

"You're a healer?" Leroy asks.

"Fuck no. I'm Pehrom. Pahrem's my kid game-sister."

Leroy says, "You people are confusing. The double point break reward is nice, even if there's no loot."

I shrug, as if to say "You get used to it," and continue "You get some Durolan rep too. That leaves two spots. I'd like to give Frobod a chance since his alt was a necromancer. He might have something useful for the underworld. Also, he's obsessed with finding one of those logout quests, and thinks that chasing all our limited edition leads is the best way to do it."

Leroy says, "Can't argue with that logic... Which leaves one more person. I understand better why this quest is personal to you but... I think we could do

good things if you put me in the group. The Malefactors are going to explore Hades anyway, but right now you're the only one I know with a clue on how to get there. "

Pehrom says, "This guy wants to join the quest?" Surprise sounds in his voice. "Fuck, Mel, you've gotta bring him. The adventurers in our guild ain't chopped liver, but this is Leroy Jensen we're talkin' about here. Leroy fuckin' Jenson. Raiding shit's his fuckin' job."

My esteem for the celebrity rises considerably when he doesn't immediately agree with Pehrom. He says, "I'll help where I can." It's hard to believe this man's fame spawned a legion of cacafuego wankers like Payneskill. He continues "You can even be main tank. It'll be nice to go off-heals and DPS for a while, and help the Toxic Muffins."

"Off heals?" I ask, "Do you have a res?"

He stands and bows from his side of the table before retaking his seat, "Paladin of Astraea, Lady of Justice."

"That could be useful. I don't know if you saw the alert, but there's no binding yourself in Hades unless you want to stay there permanently."

Pehrom says, "Take him. This ain't the time for sentiment if Mirae's life is on the line. Think of it this way. You're buddies trapped in a burning car, and the fire department's on scene. Do you tell em' to back off so you can play the hero, or do ya let the professionals do their job."

"I let them work." I say.

"Yeah." Pehrom says, "Well, it's the same shit. I know a lotta people who'd want the final spot you got, but I don't think any of em' would risk Mirae not comin' back just so they could be in the party."

"You make a good point." I say, then look to Leroy, "Consider your offer cautiously accepted. Feels wrong to make a decision like this without even talking to the others."

Pehrom says, "They'll get over it."

Leroy says, "Here, I'll sweeten the deal for you. For as long as we're adventuring together, I'll give you free training on whatever skills and abilities I can teach."

That causes me to raise a brow, free instruction from a guy who got famous by tanking is nothing to turn your nose up at, and I ask "What's your mentorship at?"

Leroy says, "Just hit level five."

"Not bad." I say, having not ever imagined Jensen as an in-game tutor. Sure, a lot of people have learned from his live feeds and uploaded videos, but that shouldn't award in-game skill points.

He asks, "What's your Stamina and Endurance at, and are you a clergy member?"

I check my VT. "Stamina is currently at... twenty. Endurance is.... thirteen, and my other alias is a Paladin of Helios."

"Oh, I can work with that." Leroy says, "To be honest I expected worse."

"Alright." I say, "You can join the group. I've also got twenty four dex, and martial arts ten."

Leroy whistles, "Dodge tank, eh?" I start to wonder if he's Canadian. "...and Martial Arts too. Now you're talking dirty. What monastery did you learn from?"

"All my MA comes from the Freeworld Dojo." I say sarcastically, referring to the other half of the game that no natives of Haven have experienced yet.

"Sweet," Leroy says, "Do you have Freeworld spells?"

"A few." I say. "At my current rank, Flow Like Water allows ten health levels of physical damage to go right through me."

Leroy says, "I think you and I are about to become very good friends."



Chapter 3 - Initiation

After lunch Leroy and I agree to meet back at Cupcake Keep in a few hours to round up the party, and plan for our adventure. It's been a bother not having access to divine spells while using my non-Paladin aliases, so I'm now alone, and ducking into a rustic temple of Sune, God of Travel and Lightning, to see about becoming a clergy member.

The sound of wind chimes fills the air—hundreds of them, hanging from fragrant evergreens along a gravel path leading to a granite altar. A blue and white clad priest is perched in a stall near the entrance.

The man, Ariel by his name plate, asks, "Incense for the god of travel?"
I browse his wares.

Basic Incense	20 Copper
This item is used for everyday worship.	

Incense of the Stormlord	10 Silver
Incense made of herbs that are pleasing to Sune. He may take notice.	

Powerful Incense of the Stormlord	1 Gold
Blessed incense consisting of uncommon herbs that are pleasing to Sune. Used when praying for safe travels and good fortune. He smiles on such offerings.	

Supreme Incense of the Stormlord	10 Gold
Blessed incense containing rare herbs that are very pleasing to Sune. Used in marital ceremonies, before dangerous journeys, and when considering a change of vocation.	

Immaculate Incense of the Stormlord	500 Gold
This incense takes a full week for clergy to create, and consists of the most scarce herbs of Sune's	

liking. Used when seeking divine intervention, or in matters of state.

I settle on buying ten sticks of Supreme Incense, and set them all to smoking by thrusting the bunch into an iron brazier. The smoke twirls in the air in streamers of black, grey, and baby blue.

Ariel asks, "Dangerous travels in the immediate future?"

"Yes," I say, "And also, maybe a change in vocation. Perhaps we can discuss once I make my offering?"

"You go right ahead." He says, "I'll be here all day."

"Thank you." I say, and then turn to continue along the path to the alter. I'm listening to rocks crunch underfoot, and the gentle songs of wind chime metal as critters shake branches in the trees. Once there, I place my incense upon the alter, and kneel before the slab of granite. On the ground in front of me is a polished, jellybean shaped rock with a lightning bolt etched into its surface. Still on my knees, I press my forehead to the sacred thunderbolt and close my eyes.

You are praying. Do you want to offer tribute to Sune, God of Lightning and Travel? Yes / No

I choose "Yes." Thunder rumbles in the distance in spite of the cloudless sky. My incense vanishes like the face of a ghost, as a new icon appears in the top left corner of my vision.

Blessed

Sune favors you.

+1 Dexterity

+1 Stellar Navigation

You've earned the respect of Sune's clergy.

Duration: 24 hours

I bow my head and say, "Thank you" to the virtual god.

"Now..." Ariel says, as I begin to turn back. I jump, having not expected him to sneak up on me. "How may I help you?"

I say, "I want to join your order."

"Oh?" Ariel says, "We can't just accept anyone who walks through our doors. Everyone of us must be proven in the eyes of Sune. Tell me, do you follow the road of the healer, or the path of the warrior?"

"I'm a warrior." I say, assuming this will unlock the paladin quest.

"Are you now?" Ariel says, "Not all warriors can become one of Sune's Thunderlords. You must embark on a journey that shows that you can embody his code. Bring me a trophy from a far off land and together, we will offer it to the Stormlord. If your sacrifice is accepted, you may join our number."

The following quest is now available.

Quest - Thunderlord

Difficulty: Moderate

To become a Thunderlord in Sune's service, you must travel to a far off land, and return to the temple of Sune in Durolan with a trophy which will be sacrificed on his alter.

This journey must be completed in a way befitting a member of Sune's clergy.

Objectives:

Return from Journey	0/1
Offer Tribute (once every 24 hours)	0/1
Sacrifice Trophy	0/1

Prohibitions:

Sune's thunderbolts are long and far reaching. You may not use any weapon in battle that is less than 35 inches in length until this quest is completed. This prohibition does not apply to ranged weapons.

Rewards:

Title: Thunderlord

Reputation: Clergy of Sune (Honored)

Ability to Cast Divine Spells

+5000 reputation with clergy of allied deities.

Cost of Failure:

Cannot attempt to join Sune's clergy for six months.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes and say, "I accept."

"Wonderful!" Ariel says.

I ask, "What is considered tribute to the Stormlord?"

We begin walking back to the incense stall as he says, "A stick of basic incense should suffice."

"Alright..." I say "I'll take a hundred since I have no idea how long I'll be gone. What happens if I don't have any incense on hand to pay tribute."

Ariel says, "Incense is not strictly necessary to pay tribute, though it is certainly the most common. If you're lacking incense, press a symbol of the Lord to your forehead, and dedicate an act of sacrifice to him. The faith is a matter of feeling, not logic. A true priest will know if their dedication is worthy." He places something cool, round, and weighty in the palm of my hand, about the size of a stress ball, and shaped like a bar of soap. "Use this to make your dedications." I look to see that it's a miniature version of the polished stone before the alter, with Sune's lightning bolt engraved on its surface.

You have received Meditation Stone (Sune).

Meditation Stone (Sune)

Used in prayers, and offering tribute to the god of
Lightning and Travel

"Thank you." I say. The shiny rock disappears into my inventory. I also hand over five silver for the bundle of basic incense which quickly joins it. "It's exactly what I needed for my travels."



Chapter 4 - Preparations

Back at the keep, Leroy and I are on the training grounds, He showed up a half hour before the scheduled meeting and is already making good on his offer to train me for the duration of the quest. I've decided to keep quiet about it so as not to ruffle feathers about who is and is not going. My hope is that when we return, everyone will be so happy to see Mirae, they won't think about whether or not they had a direct hand in the rescue mission.

Shield of Harmony, Aura of Emptiness (Rank One)

Cost: N/A

Target: Self Only

Duration: 1 Hour

Requirements:

Martial Arts: 5, Stamina: 12, Endurance: 7

Your soul has evolved to a perfect state of harmony with the universe, which allows you to shrug off the effects of magical and elemental attacks that would leave lesser warriors crippled. You are surrounded by a shield of emptiness that protects your harmony and prevents hostile forces from breaking through.

Effect:

While Aura of Emptiness is active, incoming magical and elemental damage has a 7% chance to be nullified before rolling to resist damage.

LeroyJensen wants to teach you Shield of Harmony, Aura of Emptiness (Rank One). The cost of this instruction is 0 gold, and will require 10 special ability points.

You currently have 124 unspent special ability points.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes.

Leroy says, "At level five you'll get a flat thirty percent reduction to magic and elemental damage, plus twenty percent damage reflection from those sources."

Aegis (Rank One)

Cost: N/A

Target: Self Only

Cooldown: 7 Days

Requirements:

Stamina: 20, Endurance: 10

You are the embodiment of toughness. A half-elven mountain. Invincibility personified. Nothing harms you.

Effect:

When you take fatal damage, you may activate Aegis which reduces all incoming damage to you to zero thus preventing you from being destroyed. If you are in combat, this protection lasts for twenty seconds and does not reduce your threat. When activated outside of combat, you become invulnerable for five minutes. You still suffer from non-damaging harmful effects.

Aegis must be activated within three seconds of taking fatal damage .

LeroyJensen wants to teach you Aegis (Rank One). The cost of this instruction is 0 gold, and will require 10 special ability points.

You currently have 114 unspent special ability points.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes.

Leroy says, "Normally I'd ask for a demonstration by trying to blow you up with something ridiculously overpowered, record it, and rake in the big bucks, but with a one week cool down you're going to want to save it for the quest. At rank five, you can use it once every six hours and have fifteen seconds to decide. At level three, you can sacrifice a permanent point of endurance to reset the cooldown. Not worth it if you ask me, unless you're about to make a world's first kill for a golden title."

Reading over the skill again, I'm starting to see some broken possibilities. "Does this mean that I could activate it before a boss fight when I'm out of combat, and be invincible for five minutes during the battle?"

Leroy says, "It doesn't work like that. As soon as someone attacks you, it'll consider you to be in combat, and you'll just have twenty seconds. Believe me, I've tried. To get the five minutes of invincibility, the damage has to be environmental."

I say, "I guess that makes sense." Considering that most bosses, excluding the ones you fight in ten plus player raids, go down long before five minutes are up, it'd be a bit OP to give tanks an ability that allows them to avoid all damage for the duration of the fight.

Leroy says, "I've also got a divine spell to get you started, if you want to switch over to your Paladin alias. It requires you to be a clergy member."

"Hold off on that one" I say, "I just visited the temple of Sune about their initiation quests. I'll be a clergy member when we get back."

"Why Sune?" Leroy asks.

"It fits the storm theme that I've been building on this character. Lightning staff, lightning gloves. I even like the travel angle since I'm one of the only adventurers I've seen with stuff you can only get in Freeworld."

"Whatever you want." he says. "It's a spell that helps you gain more threat, by damaging magical opponents each time they attack you."

I say, "I'll let you know as soon as I become a Thunderlord. Worse comes to worst, I'll switch over to Scooti later, but for now I'd rather save the points."

Level One special abilities aren't too expensive, ten points when you pick them up, but thereafter they cost seven times your current rating with a teacher, and fifteen x without. Those one hundred plus points I've been banking could disappear fast if I'm not careful.

Leroy says, "I'll have a better idea of what to do with you once I see you in action, but I'm probably going to recommend you pump Shield of Harmony up a few levels so you can reflect spell damage. It helps a lot when it comes to holding agro on casters that are out of range."

I say, "My staff has an AoE taunt. I usually use it to gather up the melee, and then shadow step behind ranged, so they follow me."

"Not bad." Leroy says, "I'm surprised you have that, but it won't work if there are multiple ranged targets that are spread out. A good tank isn't going to need an off-tank in most fights 'just in case.'"

I shrug, "I'm working up to it. There's only so many points to spend."

Leroy says, "How's your non-divine magic?"

"It's like I said, I've got some Freeworld spells, mostly martial arts based, and nothing from Haven since I never played a caster here."

LeroyJensen wants to teach you Haven Arcane Magic (Rank One). This ability allows you to learn first level arcane spells. The cost of this instruction is 0 gold, and will require 10 special ability points.

You currently have 104 unspent special ability points.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose, "Yes."

LeroyJensen wants to teach you Haven Elemental Magic (Rank One). This ability allows you to learn first level elemental spells. The cost of this instruction is 0 gold, and will require 10 special ability points.

**You currently have 94 unspent special ability points.
Do you accept? Yes / No**

I choose yes.

Leroy says, "How many points do you have left?"

"Ninety-four." I say.

"Alright, lets wait until we fight something before you learn spells. I can teach you Mage Shield, all the size altering effects up to Super Size, and down to Micro, and Fire or Acid elemental weapon. You don't really need me for this since you can get all of them except Acid in town now that you have the base abilities."

I ask, "Do you have anything from Freeworld?"

Leroy says, "Not much."

I pull up my VT and bring up my list of Freeworld spells, I tap "Flow Like Water," find the instruction icon, but it's grayed out like our logout button. I say, "I was going to teach you Flow Like Water, but I can't yet."

Leroy asks, "What's your mentorship at?"

I laugh, "Zero."

He says, "That's why. Try to teach a few people how to use your primary weapons, or really any other skill, and you'll get it automatically. Then practice teaching until you hit level two. At that point you can teach level one spells and special abilities."

"Damn." I say, "I kinda wanted to pay you back for what you just taught me."

"Don't worry about it." Leroy says. "Helping you is helping me. If I'm gonna DPS, I want a good tank to be a monster magnet and soak up the damage. We can't have us wiping every pull while I'm live streaming." He chuckles, "Well, I guess we could, but you might find yourself the star of a bunch of Hades fail videos."

It's at this time that I see Frobod lumbering through the front gate with his greatsword strapped to his back, and the sun glinting off his black Deadplate armor. The chest piece looks like the top half of a skull with the lower jaw removed. I say, "That's one of our other party members." and shout "Hey Frobod!"

"He the necromancer?" Leroy asks.

"Yeah." I say, as the burly man looks our direction and begins lumbering over. "You've got a lot in common, which is to say you've both got families to get back to."

"You don't?" Leroy asks, as Frobod comes within earshot.

I say, "Lets just call me a crazy cat lady without any cats."

"Which means...?" Leroy says.

I say, "Total loner."

"You don't seem like it." Leroy says.

Frobod says, "Hey." and then pauses, and takes in Leroy's appearance. "Is that Leroy Jensen?" He speaks as if he isn't even here, just another piece of equipment.

"Yeah." I say. "He's been sharing some skills. He's also coming with us on the Lost Champion quest assuming you're still interested."

"Oh yeah. You had the meeting today. How'd that go?" He extends his hand, "I'm Frobod by the way."

Leroy shakes it, and says "Good to meet you."

He must be putting on a nice face for our guest, because he's been glum ever since the first leg of Dragonsbane didn't give him the reward he wanted, in the form of a logout button. As far as anyone knows, no one has discovered the quest to end our virtual imprisonment. Frobod continues, "Yeah, I'm in. What's the quest?"

"We're going to Hades." I say, "Global alert sounded right after I accepted."

"Hades..." Frobod says, sounding contemplative. "The new zone. Maybe that's where all the log out quests are hidden."

I give Leroy a look as if to say, "See? Told you. This guy's got a one track mind." and then say, "Who knows?"

Leroy says, "No one until we get some parties in there."

I say, "I'll go over the details when Tako and Pahrem get here. That way I don't have to keep repeating myself." Frobod laughs, and I say, "What?"

"Tako..." He responds. "I can't wait to see his reaction to Mr. Leroy Jensen." Jensen cocks his head, inviting an explanation. "He's not a fan of your guild."

Leroy says, "What's he got against the Malefactors, did we reject him or something?"

"The other one." Frobod says, "The Leroy Jensen Fan Club."

Leroy purses his lips. "That's not my guild." He doesn't say it out loud, but there's an unspoken current beneath his words that makes me think he wants to say, "I don't like them either." I imagine being a pop star and deathly ashamed of what should have been an annoying one hit wonder.

My mouth grows tight with a smirk when I say, "You'll either love or hate each other. In either case, it'll be interesting." I check the time on my VT and see we've got three minutes until the meeting starts. "Let's go in. They'll be here soon."

* * * * *

We're in the lounge when Pehrom pops his green nose in and says, "Mind if I drop in?"

I say, "You're in the know, so I don't care."

Pahrem, his in-game sister has joined us, so we're just waiting on Tako. She has green skin, light freckles, enormous ears, and wears a brown garment that looks like the bastard love child of a mechanic's overalls, and a wizard's robe. She says, "Straight into Hades. This is gonna be awesome. Ain't no one's seen the underworld yet." Like her brother, she uses the default goblin voice filter which gives her a New Jersey sounding accent.

Tako comes in a few minutes later sucking on an apple juice popsicle from the kitchen. "Sorry, I'm late." He crashes his whole body on the couch in a way that makes my side of the seat poof up for a just a moment. He makes a loud slurping sound, and pulls the frozen treat from his lips. "Is Leroy Jensen sitting in the love chair?"

It seems that a byproduct of being a celebrity is that people talk about you like you're not real in private settings.

"Yes." I say, "He's coming with us for the quest."

Tako says, "I thought you were tanking."

I say, "I am... Besides, you don't even know what the quest is yet."

"Yeah well..." Tako trails, "You're always tank."

Leroy says, "I'll be on off-heals and DPS, unless our leader says otherwise. I've got a res."

"Huh..." Tako says. I'd expected him to be more animated. It makes the stiffness in his voice all the more funny. "So what's the quest?"

I pull the Essence of the Lost Champion from my inventory for demonstration, though everyone present except Leroy has seen it. I say, "Party up." and send invites out using my VT.

TakoStar has joined your party.

Pahrem has joined your party.

LeroyJensen has joined your party.

Frobod has joined your party.

I go to the quests menu, select "The Lost Champion" and tap "Share Quest."

LeroyJensen has accepted your quest.

Pahrem has accepted your quest.

TakoStar has accepted your quest.

Frobod has accepted your quest.

I give them a chance to read it over.

"So..." I begin. "We don't have to worry about finding it, because Rael over at the Lodge of Arcanum has already agreed to port us to a location where we'll find a gate taking us into the underworld. Once we're there, we've just got to find Mirae, feed her what's in the jar, and bring her back to Durolan. When we leave Hades, we've got 24 hours to get her back to the lodge to complete the ritual."

"She's your friend." Leroy says, "Do you guys have any idea of how to find her?"

Pahrem says, "I tried scryin' but it don't work. Says ya can't scry on this character."

I say, "We'll see if that changes once we're in Hades. In the worst case scenario, I have a Freeworld spell that might help but... I don't like using it."

"What's wrong with it?" Tako asks.

"Makes me angry. It's were magic, and Freeworld races have nasty weaknesses."

"You play a werewolf?" Frobod asks.

"Wererat actually, but I barely put any time in on her because she's a loose cannon. One minute you're fighting, the next all you see is red, and you're attacking anything that moves."

Tako says, "Shouldn't you still be a wererat now, since all our stats merged?"

"That's..." I trail, "A very good observation. I haven't even tried skipping to one of my Freeworld-Super aliases. If I have to guess, their abilities and weaknesses won't work unless you are in that skin. The weaknesses are a lot harsher than the racials we get in Haven, and all their powers tend to be linked to their character types. I mostly stuck to playing a Freeworld human-Mage so I wouldn't have to deal with them."

Frobod says, "We're moving off topic. Where's the entrance?"

"Thanks." I say, glad for being set back on task. "There are two 'nearby' entrances, and they are far."

"How far?" Tako asks.

I say, "Get on an airplane or buy a Hyperloop ticket in the real world, far."

Someone whistles, but I'm not sure who.

Leroy says, "Good thing we've got that portal. If the entrance is near a major city, we can probably find someone to port us back."

I say, "If I switch to caster gear, I should be able to chain us all with a Thunder Bridge."

Leroy asks, "Sounds like Freeworld stuff. I don't know that one."

Frobod says, "You know that roller coaster that made you puke all over a total stranger when you were a kid?"

Tako says, "Can't say that happened."

Frobod continues, "It's like that, but way worse."

I say, "It's like the Freeworld version of a portal. You call down a bolt of lightning, and then ride it to your destination."

Leroy looks impressed. "Bad ass. You need to get your mentorship up so I can learn it."

I say, "More immediately however, we need to decide which entrance to use. We've got to cross a river to get into Hades, and the gateways correspond to the rivers Lethe and Styx."

"What's the difference?" Leroy asks.

"No one knows because no one's ever been there." I say "... but the theme of Lethe is forgetfulness and oblivion, and Styx is hate. My gut feeling is that Styx will be more violent, but that doesn't mean that Lethe won't be challenging."

Frobod says, "My vote's for Lethe. It sounds more interesting."

I shrug and say, "It's all the same to me, though I am curious to see how they'll turn forgetfulness into a game event."

"Whateva ya want." Pahrem says.

Tako says, in an uncharacteristically serious voice, "My vote's for Lethe too. This whole guild's founded on memorializing. First your brother, and now Mirae. I like the idea of fighting the forces of being forgotten."

I could kiss him in that moment for remembering Jordan, and say, "Thanks. I change my answer. My vote's for crossing the River Lethe."

"This place has changed." Leroy says, "This used to be a clubhouse where we could do raids whenever and shoot the shit. It wasn't always so serious."

Tako asks, "Leroy was in the guild before?"

I give him a nod, turn back to Leroy and say, "Yeah, well... Death happens, and one of those people doesn't have a chance to come back."

"I feel ya," Leroy says, "It's just weird to be here and not have your bother pushing alerts to everyone to start shit."

"That sounds like something he'd do." I say, "There were a few guild alert macros before the update. Something about a guy called 'R-Twined' being a 'PvP Dick,' and some other person murdering kittens."

Leroy laughs, "I don't remember R-Twined... I guess the name's a little familiar, but that masturbation thing was a long running joke. We were getting ready to run Blackscythe when his mom bust in his room and he was forced to log out. Jordan called him when he DCed and heard his mom yelling 'Put yer pants on! I ain't payin' your subscription so you can do things with make believe nekkid girls. Tomorrow after religion you go talk to Pasta Joe.' followed by 'Gotta go. Bye.' Pretty much every time he wasn't paying attention after that, your brother sent us all a message about not killing kittens."

Pahrem says, "I don't get it."

Tako explains, "God kills a kitten every time your masturbate. How do you not know that?"

Leroy says, "Maybe it's not common knowledge for the ladies but yeah, back then everyone knew that meme."

The comment is a new door opening up on Jordan's past that I never knew. I was always aware of the meaning of the joke, but not the story behind it. Hearing Leroy reminisce breathes life into my brother's memory so that I can imagine him in the next room.

I say, "If you still know other guild members, I'd appreciate it if you could connect us."

Leroy says, "I've been thinking about that, and got you covered. I think when I announce the quest I'll say something live to commemorate him, and anyone who sees and remembers will know who to contact."

"Thanks..." I say, feeling the warmth of gratitude. It's a big step toward letting all his friends know what happened. "I really appreciate it."

Leroy waves his hand. "It's nothing. It's like I said, we were friends. You can deliver the message yourself if you want."

I look to Pehrom, who has been quiet until now, and say "I'm promoting you to officer. Recruit whoever you need for the kitchen. I have no idea how long this quest will take, or if we'll still be in contact so we need to have someone in Haven who can make decisions. I trust your judgment." I make the changes in the guild section of the VT and say, "I hear the rank gives your room a hot tub."

He says, "Thanks boss."

"Enjoy." I follow, "Use what you need for food, but I'll be pissed if I come back and find completely empty coffers."

Leroy asks, "How are we on provisions?"

Pehrom says, "I've got some jerky and dried fruit for ya. Beyond that, you're stuck with what the Havenfolk give ya."

I say, "I bought a lot of incense for my Thunderlord quests, and I want to swing by Dragonswood Keep to check on my quest reward."

Leroy asks, "From Dragonsbane?"

I say, "Yeah, the local mage is designing a new kind of enchantment for footwear, to add damage to my kicks."

He says, "Not the most tanky option, but kinda cool that you get a unique enchant. What kind of damage?"

I say, "It'll either be light or holy. We'll see about the rest. He's studying my monk gloves and working from there."

Tako asks, "Should we bring Mirae's bow?"

The room goes quiet. No one's touched her Dragonsbane reward since the funeral, in fact Mirae herself hasn't even seen it since it was being crafted while she died. Frobod says, "It's not like we've got limited bag space. I say we bring it. It'll help her damage when we're escorting her back."

I nod reluctantly, while I certainly don't have a problem with arming Mirae, moving the bow from her memorial mount in the garden feels like an act of desecration. I know we can always put it back, but it feels wrong to disturb her shrine until I know she's really coming home. Then again, if she dies on the way back on account of not being able to protect herself. It'd be a shitty way to fail the quest.

Leroy says, "She an archer? Add arrows to the list then."

"That and heals." I say.

"That does it then. I say we spend the rest of the day to pick up any last minute things we need in town, get a good night's sleep, and then get moving tomorrow early afternoon." Then to Leroy I say, "You're welcome to one of the guest rooms if you want to stay overnight."

"Oooh.. Swanky." He says, apparently remembering the cushy atmosphere, but then says, "No. I've got to get back to Malefactor HQ. I'll get you guys put on the approved visitor list in case something comes up, and I've gotta let everyone know I'll be gone for a while. Also, FYI, I won't be joining you as Leroy Jensen. I'm going to use a disposable alt until we're in Hades to avoid stalkers and public fan-girling."

"Alright, what do we look for?"

"Let me see..." Leroy says, scrolling through his VT. "How about this guy?" He stabs a button with his index finger, and a cyclone of burlap colored magic spins around him, stripping away his crimson leathers, and replacing them with starting gear. Instead of the human we've come to know we're staring at a four foot tall man with slightly pointed ears and big hairy feet; a hobling. The race is a bit taller than a gnome, and more human in their appearance.

I check his nameplate.

Butt-Trumpet	
Type:	Player
Race:	Hobling
Appearance:	4
Challenge:	Extreme

"You want us to travel with a guy named Butt Trumpet?" I ask.

Leroy says, "It's a throw away character. I'll go back to Leroy once we're inside, and unlikely to bump in to other adventurers. I don't usually release the feeds until five to ten days after exploring new territory so we're not overrun by people trying to catch up."

"Alright." I say, "I'll make sure Cupcake puts Butt-Trumpet on the approved list."

* * * * *

It's the first time I've been in the master bedroom since Alfred warned me of a surprise. A covered canvas awaits me right in front of my bed. I remove the sheet used to obscure it and my breath catches. I'm staring at my brother's high school year book photo, filtered and super imposed on a fantasy portrait to make him seem more heroic.

A sad smile touches my face as I caress the canvas with my fingertips. The portrait is so like Jordan, his high school boy face dropped on to a fantasy body that could break mountains.

I whisper, "Thanks Alfred," wondering if any of his Toxic Muffins realized what a shrimp he was offline.



Chapter 5 - Cerberus

I touch down in the center of Lord Zarentu's courtyard in Dragonswood Keep. It feels empty compared to when we competed in the Dragonswood Tournament. Gone are the many tents, festival booths, and lively music. Instead, I'm surrounded by a well manicured lawn, at a fork of two dirt paths that run in a wide Ellipse to the draw bridge.

"Ahem-hum! Who goes there?" Says a man in a conical helm with a robust blonde walrus moustache.

I say, "It's just me Archibald. I'm the only one who rides the lightning."

"Yes yes, of course!" He says, "I know that Lady Lord Melpomine, but we can never be too careful! Where art thou... elechopit?"

"I've still got it." I respond, "But today I'm in a hurry. I've got a quest this afternoon, and I've got to talk to Master Aztram before I go. Can you take me to him?"

"Yes yes... Of course." He pauses. "Lyle! Man the gates!"

"Yes sir..." A clean shaven bean pole of a man peeks in from around the other side of the gate, and speaks in a drowsy voice. "I'm on it." His head disappears behind the stone pillar the gate is mounted too, but I imagine him easing down on to a stump or folding chair to catch some Zs.

Archibald claps my shoulder. "As you can see Lady Lord, Dragonswood Keep is in good hands! Master Aztram? Just this way!"

I say, "I never doubted you." with a hint of amusement creeping into my voice.

We walk together, with Archibald's heavy boots clunking over the draw bridge within the courtyard. Not much later we're through the antechamber, to the study where I'm greeted by multiple stories of glorious leather bound books. The smell of the pages and bindings is unlike anything I've experienced back on earth, where most libraries have been long since digitized.

Archibald clears his throat. "Master Aztram!" Is voice is thunderous in such a quiet workspace. "You have a visitor. May I present Lady Lord Melpomine of Durolan."

The old half elf wizard creeks down the too-tall ladder, on the left side of the room, and strolls toward us. He's got long hair with slightly pointed ears much like my own peaking through curtains of grey and white. He gives me a

grandfatherly smile and says, "Lady Melpomine. So good to see you. If this is about Lord Frobod's request, I'm afraid I haven't got any new information."

I shake my head no. "It's not about that. I'm here about my boots. Any chance you can enchant them this morning? I'm embarking on a major quest this afternoon. It's about Mirae."

"Ah! ... the poor girl." He says, "I am continually sorry for your loss."

"Yeah well... She might not be as lost as she once seemed. I've got a mission to go find her in Hades."

"Hades? Oh dear. That is dangerous. I'm quite busy, but under the circumstances I'll make an exception and enchant your item. Follow me back to my workshop."

I do so, as he leads me to a door in the far corner of the room that I hadn't noticed before due to a large bookshelf blocking the way. Inside is a stone basin, and a number of shelves housing jars of glowing essence, and obscure spell components.

"Thank you." I say.

"It's no bother for my would be apprentice, if you're still interested."

"Actually." I say, "I just learned the basics of arcane and elemental magics." I'm a little worried because I don't want to offend him.

He says, "Take off your boots." I do, and he says, "Wonderful. What spells have you learned?"

I say, "None yet, but I think Mage Shield is a high priority."

He tisks me as he places them in the stone bowl and fetches several vials of glowing liquid... (or are they just energy?) from a nearby shelf. White and green color swirls within each one like tiny glow sticks.

"You disappoint me. If I thought you wanted common magic, I'd not have offered to be your teacher." He pours several vials of the glowing substances over my boots. The green behaves much like liquid, but the white behaves more like smoke from a fog machine, billowing out and engulfing my footwear in a magical mist.

I say, "Yeah well... My teacher's a famous dungeon raider. I doubt he knows your more refined brand of magic."

"Well, do come back when you're done adventuring so we can turn you into a proper scholar. It'd be a great honor to tutor the first adventure to learn the higher arts."

I say, "I'll keep that in mind."

Instead of responding he takes an enchanting wand in hand, raises a finger for me to shut my mouth, and begins incanting in a language I don't understand. The fog within the bowl stirs, and swirls to match his wand movements. He reaches for another vial, this one of a smoky grey pigment, and adds it to the mix. His words are low and musical, if I had them on a repeat recording, it could help me sleep.

Suddenly he flicks his wrist, taps the top of my boot, and an audible ping sounds. The foggy energy grows smaller, and seems to sink into the leather.

"Why don't you examine them."

To my surprise, the quality has been increased from Rare to Epic, and the name has changed from "Swiftstrike Boots" to "Swiftstrike Kickers of the

Thunderlord." The box around the stats is also gold, implying that these are the first of their kind to appear in the game.

Swiftstrike Kickers of the Thunderlord

Set Completion (3/4) +1

Quality: Epic

Type: Leather

Slot: Feet

Armor: 1

Equipped Bonus: Dexterity + 4, Stamina + 3

Special Properties:

+3 bonus light damage (Applies to kicks only)

+2 bonus holy damage (Applies to kicks only)

Static Shield:

Each time you dodge an attack, at one counter to Swiftstrike Kickers of the Thunderlord. If Swiftstrike Kickers of the Thunderlord has more than 3 counters, deal 1 Lightning damage to attackers when struck with a melee attack. If more than five counters are accumulated, damage is increased by two, and rebounds on non-magical ranged attacks.

Bonus Damage Ignores Armor

This item counts towards the Swiftstrike Set Completion, however provides no additional benefits, if four other Swiftstrike items are equipped.

My jaw drops at seeing the enhancements. Bonus damage to each kick I expected, but something like "Static Shield" hadn't even been discussed.

Aztram says, "You like it?" and smiles.

I say, "You've outdone yourself. How did you..?"

"A little experimental research goes a long way. I saw your role in the Grand Melee, and thought this added benefit might suit you. Thank you for lending me your gloves. You may have them back now."

You have received Fists of the Thunderlord.

Fists of the Thunderlord

Description:

Left is Thunder. Right is Lightning. Don't get caught in the storm.

Quality: Epic

Type: Leather

Slot:	Hands
Armor	1
Equipped Bonus:	Dexterity +2, Strength +1, Stamina+1
Special Properties:	
(Right Hand Only)	Unarmed attacks inflict +4 Lightning Damage.
(Left Hand Only)	Unarmed attacks inflict +4 Sonic Damage
(Left Hand Only):	33% chance on hit to deafen your opponent for 20 seconds. Effects are cumulative.
	Bonus damage ignores armor.

"No." I say, "Thank you. This enchantment will help a lot on my journey."
 "About that," Aztram says, "What are your plans to pass the gate?"
 I say, "Just walk through, I guess. We're playing it by ear."
 "Yes," Aztram says, "But you'll face a guardian. Cerberus if I'm not mistaken. You could try to fight him, but I don't recommend it."
 "That's the three headed dog, right?"
 Aztram says, "Yes... amongst other things. He's quite large."
 I ask, "So what do you suggest?"
 "Bring a Bard. Orpheus is said to have played the lute with such beauty as to lull the monster to sleep. If you can manage the same feat you may be able to sneak past without anyone dying."
 "Great..." I say, pondering how that'll work with our full group. So far as I know, I'm the only one who knows anything about in-game music, and I'd hardly call myself a bard. "We'll see what I can do."

* * * * *

I check my interface and discover that none of us have left the party since last night except Leroy who must have been doing something with his guild. I send a message to the party chat.

Melpomine: Back in Durolan, but I might be late. We need a Bard.
 TakoStar: For what?
 Melpomine: Aztram gave me a tip about the first boss. It'll either be a brutal fight, or something we can bypass entirely.
 Frobod: You mean we can sneak around?
 Melpomine: Kinda. It's Cerberus from the Greek legends. He says a really good bard can put him to sleep.
 Frobod: Didn't you say you played a musician for a while?
 Melpomine: Yeah, but she wasn't my main. If I can't find someone, I'll give it a try, otherwise I have an idea.
 Pahrem: They won't get the quest.
 Melpomine: I'll worry about that later.

I close the chat on my VT, go to my contacts, and select the two protestors I encountered outside the digitization station before Mirae disappeared.

**You have invited: Ashlynn, Ceris to group chat.
Ashlynn has accepted your request.**

Ashlynn: Hey.

A few moments pass, and I wonder if the golden hair and skinned elf will be coming.

Melpomine: Hey. Give it a sec, I also invited your elf friend. I've got some news about the whole digitization thing.

Ashlynn: Wait. I'll send him a message.

Ceris has entered group chat.

Ceris: Hi. Who are you again?

Melpomine: We met outside the igloo when digitization started.

Ceris: Oh right, the guild leader. I forgot your name. Did you hear something?

Melpomine: I did actually, and I need your help. I guess you already know by now that people who died while digitizing, came back online.

Ashlynn: Yeah... but no one can message them.

Melpomine: Same for me, but I've got a quest to go to Hades, and find a soul to bring back to the living. We're thinking it might be for the people who didn't make it.

Silence settles on the moment as neither person answers. I can only imagine what's going through their minds. Hope. Disbelief. Maybe a little bit of fear since they don't strike me as the adventuring sort. It'll be hard enough for our group, and we like dungeon crawling. What must it be like for players who come online and spend all their time in taverns shooting the shit instead of killing monsters?

Melpomine: Are you guys there?

Ceris: Yeah.

Ashlynn: Here, sorry. Do you want us to come?

Melpomine: Eh... Not really.

I'm sure they have their own people they want to bring back, and I don't want anyone in the group whose not set on restoring Mirae.

Melpomine: The quest requires a Bard and I don't know any. I was hoping one of you might know that guy who plays in Fire and Soul every night.

Ceris: I know of him, but he's not on my friends list.
Ashlynn: I've got him on my friends list. Should I invite him to the chat?
Melpomine: Please, or we can meet up if you're all still in Durolan.
Ashlynn: Wait...

A minute goes by without a reply, and I buy some trail rations from a man in a green apron towing a wooden cart that hovers a meter off the ground on a bed of cotton cloud. As a general rule, anything mundane is made magical on the streets of Durolan, and in the case of mobile vendors, unfashionable. Wheels on carts just aren't gonna cut it.

Ashlynn: He says he'll meet us at Fire and Soul.
Melpomine: I'm five minutes away.
Ceris: Sorry, I'm busy.

Ceris has left the group chat.

The tavern by day is different from the tavern at night. There are fewer patrons by comparison, and notably less chatter. There's certainly no musician on staff at this hour. Nevertheless, Freya, the hostess greets me with a smile that then flattens when she sees I'm an adventurer.

"Spring water for you then? She asks, having become accustomed to adventurer habits. No one buys food because the buffs are pointless in protected areas, and every single food or drink item is tasteless. The one exception to this rule is Pehrom's cooking.

She escorts me to a cozy booth and I say, "Yeah, just waiting for someone." I fetch a silver piece from inventory, and press it into her palm. "For the trouble." It's enough for her to buy half a week of meals from the establishment at menu prices. "I know we don't ever order anything, but you should be compensated for your service."

You have gained 200 personal reputation with Freya. Current level: Neutral.

This considerably improves her disposition as she curtsies, and says "I'll be right back with a pitcher."

"Three cups." I say. "I have two guests coming."

"As you like, m'Lord."

I'm looking to the entrance waiting for either Ashlynn or the musician to stroll in, when the very person I'm looking for approaches from the opposite direction. Like most elves, he has a lithe build, and long pointed ears. His lustrous sandy hair reaches down to the small of his back, and would be the envy of many real world women. He sports a crimson cape, a feathered cap, and a pair of poofy dark pantaloons. His dazed expression makes him seem like he just rolled out of bed.

He says, "Lady Melpomine I presume?" in a honeyed voice that hits my ears like silk.

"Yeah..." I say, "Where did you come from?"

"Upstairs." He says. "I get free room and board in exchange for my service."

"I see." I say. It makes sense. Soc customers would frequent the taverns with the best entertainers.

"I'm Devarin." He says.

"Nice to meet you Lord Devarin." I extend my hand to shake, but he takes it and presses his lips to my fingers. I'm feeling awkward as I take my hand back. Social gamers are different animals, so I'm sure he's just trying to be polite.

He then smirks and says, "I'm no Lord." as Ashlynn ducks her way through the entrance.

Freya offers her a much kinder greeting than the one she gave me; must be a perk of becoming a regular customer. I wave her over and scoot over so they can sit wherever. It's unnecessary because they both sit opposite to me.

"Hi." I say as she sits.

Devarin says, "So what's this about needing a bard?"

I say, "I've got a quest to enter Hades, and one of my contacts told me we should have a bard in the group to clear the first boss. It's an enormous three headed dog with a fondness for pretty music. Do you adventure much?"

"Eh..." He makes a teeter tottering so-so motion with his hand. I'm just going to assume he's a noob. Freya brings our drinks.

"If it's anything," I say, "I'm not expecting you to fight unless you want to. We've got a good group that can protect you."

"I'll think about it." He says.

"I can pay you." I say.

"Where is it, and how much?" Devarin asks.

"It's in the Southwest." I say. "We've got a portal arranged to take us there. How's 500 gold sound?"

"That's far." Devarin says. "How long will it take?"

I shrug and say, "Who knows? It's new content. You can go home after the first boss."

Ashlynn looks to Devarin and says, "This could be big. They're trying to bring back people who were lost in digitization. If they succeed, there's hope for everyone else."

"I guess..." He says reluctantly. "You promise I don't have to fight?"

"Not while you're with the party." I say. "Look, we have five people and three tanks. One of which is one of the most famous in the game. Nothing's gonna hit you unless you stand in an area of effect. We're leaving this afternoon so we're pressed for time. I just got the news about needing a bard this morning."

"Uhm." He says.

"A thousand gold." I say. "That's more than enough to compensate you if you die, and to buy a portal back."

"Alright." He says. "I'll do it. It's been a long time since I used my adventure skin."

"You mean an alias?" I ask.

"Yeah." he says. Then turns and hollers back to Freya. "Looks like I'll be gone for a few days. Tell the boss I'll pay him twice what he pays me if he doesn't give my job to someone else."

I say, "Come with me to Cupcake Keep and I'll write up a contract. I'm also stating that if you accept my coin, you're giving up your share of the loot. If for some reason you choose to join us for the entire duration of our quest instead of just hanging on until the first boss, you can give up the gold in exchange for a fair share of whatever drops."

"Can I join the quest?" He asks.

This gives me pause. I pull out my VT and double check the wording.

... This quest can be shared if you have five or less people in your party....

"I don't know." with a thoughtful tone creeping into my voice. "Would you want to? If you did, the choice on who we bring back is my call since it's my quest that I'm sharing." He shrugs, and I say "Just a minute. I want to try something."

Melpomine: Hey, do you still have the quest?

LeroyJensen: Yeah, why?

Melpomine: You're not in the group. I want to see if I can offer it to someone else since it says it can be shared as long as there are five or less people in the party.

LeroyJensen: Try it.

Melpomine: If your quest disappears, I'll kick the other guy and share it with you again.

I say, "You need to join my group for me to share it. I don't know if it'll work since we already have five people on it." I send him an invite.

Devarin has joined your party.

I pull up the quests menu, select "The Lost Champion" and tap "Share Quest."

Devarin has accepted your quest.

Melpomine: Do you still have the quest?

LeroyJensen: Yeah.

Melpomine: I just shared it with someone else.

LeroyJensen: Nice exploit.

Melpomine: You disapprove?

LeroyJensen: No. All's fair in buffs and questing.

I say, "Looks like you've got it, of course you can't complete it without my item." reminding him of who's the leader just in case he gets any ideas of running off and completing it on his own.

Devarin says, "I wouldn't anyway."

Ashlynn says, "Well good. I'm glad I could set you up. Good luck with this, and let me know how it turns out."

"I will." I say, and finish off the last of my drink. "Let's head over to Cupcake Keep and meet the others."



Chapter 6 - The Road to Hell

We're sitting in the dining room when I place my mark on the contract. It indicates that once I, TakoStar, Pahrem, Frobod, and either Butt-Trumpet or Leroy Jensen clear the gates of Hades, 1,000 gold will be paid to Devarin from the guild coffers, and that he relinquishes his claim on any and all loot. Now that I've placed my mark, the funds are being held in magical escrow. It also states that should Devarin fail to complete his duties, or if we clear the gates of Hades without his help he's entitled to only the cost of return transportation to Durolan. Furthermore, it states that if Devarin chooses to accompany us across either the river Lethe or Styx, he will forgo the 1,000 gold, and be entitled to an even share of the loot.

I push the paper across the table and say, "Make your mark."

He speaks with his mouth full, "You have chicken.... Honey glazed chicken. and it tastes... If he was a woman, I'd be making vows to that little green man."

"Glad you enjoy it, and he's taken." I say. "Make your mark."

He wipes his hands on a napkin, and presses his thumb to the parchment.

You are bound by the terms of this agreement.

You have received: Signed contract.

I ask, "Ready to get in your adventure skin?"

He says, "Better to wait until we're out of town. Sometimes the guards don't like my appearance."

I raise a brow, and give myself a chance to be surprised when the time comes rather than asking questions. I count the baggies I have spread out on the table. "40 servings of jerky, 50 dried apricot, and 150 bags of Havenfolk trail rations. That should be more than enough."

He says, "I can conjure an arcane banquet."

"You're just now mentioning this? ... Never mind... I already bought everything before we met. Good to know. I forgot to tell you, we've been warned not to eat or drink anything from Hades. My guess is that it'll have the same effect as setting your bind point there."

"We can't leave?" He asks.

"That's my guess, but only if you eat something."

It doesn't escape my notice that he's talking like he's decided to cross the river. Frobod, Tako, and Pahrem enter, chit-chatting in a cluster. They must have run into each other outside their rooms.

Tako says, "Last meal before we leave this place." He clutches his heart melodramatically. "God, I'm going to miss it!"

I say, "CK will still be waiting for you when we get back."

"The castle?" He asks. "Well that too, I meant the food."

I throw a bag of Pehrom's jerky at him. "Cry me a river. This is for Mirae."

That sobers him up, and he says. "I didn't mean anything by it."

"So we're waiting on one more." I say. Leroy, in the guise of Butt-Trumpet, enters the room. "... or not."

Leroy says, "Am I late?"

"Just in time to meet our bard." I motion to Devarin, I can see he's about to ask, so I say "I got a tip from someone at Dragonswood Keep that we'd need a musician to clear the first boss."

"Good call." Leroy says. "We ready to go?"

"Yeah." I say. "Everyone take a share of the rations. I don't want anyone hogging the good stuff."

Leroy says, "I bought some buff food for before the boss fights if we need it."

"That's good." I say. "I want to show you my boots."

Leroy asks, "Get something good?"

I say, "Big upgrade."

Leroy says, "Let me see."

I walk around to his side of the table so he can examine them. They look almost the same as before, but now have a faint glow about them like the moon's corona. You can't see it in daylight, but in the shade beneath the table it's just visible.

"Hot stuff, golden item." He says. "That's a lot of dex. Not so good for a traditional stamina tank, but for you they'll do nicely since you'll be dodging a lot to build up charges. How'd you get them again?"

"I asked Lord Zarentu for a custom enchant based on my PvP gloves as my reward for Dragonsbane Part One. Before that, the boots were the standard boots in the Swiftstrike set."

Devarin finishes off his chicken, takes in our party and says, "I thought you said you had someone famous."

Leroy says, "That'd be me."

Devarin says, "I've never heard of Butt-Trumpet."

Leroy says, "It's an alt. I'll pull off the mask when we get inside."

* * * * *

After lunch, second lunch for Devarin, we're all at the Lodge of Arcanum. It's surprisingly empty for the middle of the day. My voice echoes down empty halls as I call, "Paging Magus Rael!"

I hear the sound of quickly shuffling footsteps on stone floors as a round faced human page boy in grey apprentice robes hastens to greet us. He's got dark

brown hair, and light freckles on his cheeks. I guess him to be fourteen or fifteen years of age, and judge that this must be where he gets schooled.

"So sorry!" He says, "I didn't hear anyone come in."

I ask, "Where is everyone?"

He says, "Master Marulan is giving a speech about the dangers of necromancy."

I sigh.

Frobod says, "Doesn't sound like we're endearing anyone."

The boy, named Wren, says "It's mostly just him. The majority of Magi view the art as just a tool. I'll bring you to the portal chamber, and fetch Master Rael. He's been expecting you."

We're escorted to a circular stone room the size of half a tennis court with a massive half-bubble skylight which allows us to see blue sky and white cumulus clouds above. The mosaic white and violet floor tiles form a pattern of three interlocking rings arranged in a Borromean link. A metal fixture that resembles a five pronged crown rests at the center.

Tako says, "Let me guess. The portal goes there." pointing at the centerpiece.

I shrug.

We don't have to wait long before Rael enters wearing the same blue robes he's worn every time I've seen him. Either he really likes this style, or they're some kind of uniform.

"Thank the gods." He says with a smile. "Your presence was the perfect excuse to ditch that old windbag."

I say, "Still not loving our plan I take it."

Rael says, "He'll get over it once you come back and the ritual's successful. He's always nay-saying new magic that might actually be fun." He claps his hands and rubs them together, eager to get started. "Where are we going? Styx or Lethe?"

"Lethe." I say.

He says, "Good choice." and I wonder if his response would have been any different if we'd said Styx. "Everyone ready?"

We all nod.

He walks to one of the archways with a stick of chalk, and writes a bunch of round wavy characters in an unfamiliar language, paired with a trio of sharp angular marks. Now that Leroy's taught me the Arcane Magic ability, I instinctively recognize them as arcane sigils related to displacement and travel. At the center, he draws three interlocking rings in a pattern that mirrors the ones on the floor. I'm watching in fascination.

I wonder if I can learn that spell.

Rael turns from his work and waves us back, and speaks a single word in a language I don't understand but can infer. "Aportanta!" A globe of yellow energy with a black spot rises from the pointy fixture at the center of the room, looking like a giant eye. A bar of light then shoots from the spot into the exact center of the three circle mark Rael drew. The wall ripples as if under water, glows cloudy, and begins to change. A moment later, we're staring out on a brown and gold desert landscape under blue skies and a burning sun.

Rauel says, "Now you may enter." and gestures to the wall. "May you quest with the favor of many gods."

"Thank you." I say, and look to Tako, "Looks like you were wrong."

He says, "What do I know about spell casting?"

I motion to the others and say, "Let's go."

I'm not a fan of bright sunlight, which is what hits me along with a wave of heat as soon as I step through. *Thank God, it's only temporary.* I squint and look around, as Tako and Leroy drop out of the portal followed by Pahrem, Frobod, and Devarin. From this side, it looks like a bunch of people are stepping out of thin air. *No going back the way we came.*

"Hold up." Devarin says as he pulls out his VT. "I've got to change my alias."

Strands of stone colored light twist around, and engulf him as he changes appearance. His nameplate fades, and is replaced by one that reads "Sajina." Aside from having a head, two arms, and two legs Devarin, now Sajina, couldn't be less human. His skin and clothes have changed to living stone, and a pair of massive, dark, bat like wings sprout from his back. His wide jaw now sports a pair of monstrous rock tusks, and a thick tail like a dinosaur extends from his butt.

"Gargoyle!" Tako shouts, in a voice that sounds impressed.

"You can make those?" I ask, having never seen the race on my creation screen before.

Sajina says, "The race was unlocked when I was trick or treating a couple of years ago."

Frobod must see my confused expression and says, "There are rare trick or treating candies that unlock new races, attract special pets, or give you vanity items. Unlocking a new race has a chance of something like one in a thousand candies."

"What are the benefits?" I ask, "You get a minus to intelligence, and your appearance drops to zero but you can raise it with points, but you get two extra health levels, and a bunch of extra stamina. You can also learn the special ability 'Flight.'"

I say, "Twenty percent extra health... I want to play a gargoyle."

Leroy says, "They're a strong tank race, but almost no one has them. They also have problems walking around in cities during any month that's not October."

I ask, "The guards will attack you?"

Leroy nods, "Sometimes."

I say, "We need to get you an electric guitar from the Freeworld, because that skin is pure metal."

Sajina says, "Stone actually."

I squint under the bright sun, and say "Ha ha."

I look around trying to get a sense of where we're supposed to go when I hear Pahrem call out, "Ova here." She'd wandered off from the group without me noticing. I approach to discover she's standing at the edge of a gaping hole in the ground with a switch back path leading down into the earth. "Get ya spelunkin' hats cause we're goin' deep."

Sajina says, "That doesn't look inviting." It's the first time I've heard timidity in his voice.

I say, "Anything's better than all this sun. Carry over from the real world I guess, I never tan. I just burn."

Leroy says, "Let's go. I'll cast light spells when we're inside."

Nothing attacks us on the way down, I don't even see other creatures. The air is dry, Leroy and Frobod's armor clunks with every step along the path. I'm thankful for the shade at the mouth of the cave, and say "So far, so good."

Leroy says, "Illuminatus!" and makes a circling gesture with his hand. A white light pours off me as if my armor was a sixty watt light bulb. He calls out, "Illuminatus!" making the same gesture, and Pahrem begins to glow. Leroy says, "I'll keep it at two for now. Tank in the front, heals in the back. Too many lights can be distracting. Everyone gear up."

I equip Bite, my electrified staff, whereas Frobod hefts his greatsword, and the gargoyle is armed with a woodwind flute, a quill, and a leather journal. I give him a look, and he says "I'm an artist." followed by blowing a steady note on his instrument.

Sajina casts Inspire.

Inspired.

+1 Charisma

+2 to Highest Stat. (Dexterity)

+1 Health Levels

Duration: 30 minutes

"Alright." I say, "I admit that was useful. Can you fight?"

"I have a sling." He says uncertainly.

"Alright." I say, "Stand near Pahrem and use that to try and hit whatever I'm attacking."

Pahrem speaks in a sympathetic voice, "We're gonna be good friends."

Tako says, "Can we go?"

I say, "Just a sec." and take Bite through a martial arts casting kata.

Cast Flow Like Water (Rank 3) - Success!

Then I say, "Yeah." and step into the darkness. With each pace, more rock becomes visible ahead. Stalagmites and stalactites hang from the ceiling and sprout from the ground like giant teeth. It feels like walking into a dragon's gullet. The way light just stops beyond the twenty-five foot range of Leroy's light spell is unnerving. We're literally passing into the unknown. Sometimes I grip my staff a tighter, thinking I see something scurry across the ground ahead, but it's just a shadow created by my light on all the uneven surfaces.

Pretty soon, there will be real monsters.

I don't like the sound of just my feet in the dirt and on rock followed by the clunks and rustles of the group behind me, so I ask "Everyone okay?" Not really

expecting or caring if anyone answers. Nevertheless, there are a few murmurs of ascent. Leroy's nearby so I ask, "Have you ever been here?"

He says, "This is a first for me."

There's plenty of space to walk, but I feel claustrophobic. The incline is getting steeper, and the terrain more rugged. We can't sprint in an desperate retreat.

Leroy stops me by touching the back of his hand to my chest. He holds his war hammer at the ready and whispers "Get ready."

I respond, "What?" having not seen anything.

He looks like he's about to strike, but strike what is beyond my comprehension.

He says, "Now!" as a four-legged shadow creature leaps off the ceiling and makes a grab for Tako. It has a long body, four legs, and catlike ears. Instead of claws, it has a set of five-fingered hands.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I disappear from where I'm standing, and reappear behind the monster in a single stride. My staff smashes into its flank sending small worms of electricity crawling over it's body. It yowls like a cat, and whirls to face me standing upright on a pair of stubby hind legs. Its long body makes the creature taller than me. It has human arms, a pair of short swords, and red eyes that burn like hot coals. It's unnerving how little I can make out of its physical texture. It's a hole in the world, a creature shaped demon of infinite darkness.

It comes in for a strike, I slip out of the way. A white circle with the number 1 appears in the top right corner of my vision. It must be the counter from my boots. It swipes again, I parry with bite, and counterattack with the other end of my big stick.

CRITICAL HIT

You hit Shadowstalker for 12 damage.

Shadowstalker resists 8 points of damage.

An electric zap sounds as Bite kisses him with bonus damage. Tako makes a move from behind, but I can't see whether he connects. Leroy on the other hand roars as he brings his hammer down on the beast in a powerful blow. It collapses into nothing like a banished ghost, though it leaves a small sack behind.

Butt-Trumpet has killed Shadowstalker.

Tako picks up the loot.

Shadowstalker drops 30 silver.

Your share of the loot is 6 silver.

Leroy says, "Not too bad, but they're sneaky."

Pahrem asks, "Bones okay?"

Frobod answers, "We're all good."

I say, "This is rough because I can't see the mobs to make a good pull."

Leroy answers, "Caves are a bitch."

Not ten steps later I hear a serpentine hiss, the moment new monsters are brought within the radius of the light spell. Two brown hooded serpents as tall as I am slither toward me, and bats the size of bus tires take to the air.

I yell, "Incoming!" and rush to meet the new monsters. *Why did it have to be snakes?* The way they move fast across the ground without any limbs makes my skin crawl. To make matters worse, as we close on each other, I realize the snakes don't have any eyes. Their entire heads consist of mouths, tongues, nostrils, and teeth. *Talk about creepy.*

It's a close call as I slip out of the way of the first snake's strike. I evade serpent number two, and hurl my Darksteel Chakram at one of the dire bats. It connects. The other's almost at Leroy so I whistle at the other and shout "Hey!" to draw its attention.

Taunt. Successful. Dire Cave Bat attacks.

Now all four monsters are coming at me. I shout, "Hold!" and take purely defensive actions until they're all in range. My dodge counter quickly rises to three, four, and then five as I rapidly duck and jerk out of the way of incoming blows. When the last bat arrives and attempts to dive bomb, I bring bite up and knock it in its scrunched up face. Electricity jumps from it to the other mammal, down to the two serpents. "Go!"

Leroy charges for the reptile on my right, as I slink out of the way of another bat. Tako tries cutting it from the side while Frobod tries for the one on my left. A bat swoops again and I'm out of the way, but the evasion of that attack puts me right in the path of the snake that Frobod's fighting, and it nips my forearm. Fortunately my flesh reshapes itself around its fangs as though passing through liquid. *Thank you Flow Like Water.* Two absorption levels fall off my Flow Like Water defense.

Leroy's making fast work of his snake as its health is already down to thirty percent. Frobod's is only down forty, so I switch targets and clobber the beast with my staff, bringing Bite's glowing tip down right on top of its head. Electricity leaps off it, and into the neighboring monsters. *I've got this.*

I dodge out of the way of another serpent strike, then duck a bat when I hear a high pitched scream somewhere behind me. I catch Pahrem in my peripheral vision doing her thing, so the only non-melee person left is Sajina. I sidestep another serpent strike, as Leroy finishes off his target. He and Tako join Frobod in cleaning up the rest of the ground group... or so I think.

In party chat Sajina shouts, "It's got me! Help!" I take a look back and shadow step to his attacker, another Shadowstalker is dragging him by the arm on the ground. The bard's kicking and yelling, but doesn't seem to be doing much to stop his abduction.

Fortunately, I'm there to knock the creature in the back with my staff. I hear the death cries of a cave snake, and the two big bats are chasing after me

while ground DPS awkwardly try to bat them out of the air above them. It's not working all that well.

The shadowstalker unhands Sajina, and turns to face me with a longsword in hand. Like the other one, it stands on its hind legs while in single combat.

It strikes. CRACK! The sound of Bite intercepting metal rings through the passage.

Sajina says, "Wait! Don't attack it!"

Another CRACK sounds as I parry another blow with the shaft of Bite. "Easier said than done buddy!" I dodge out of the way of another shadowstalker strike, and realize that the dire bats are almost here. "Whatever you want to do, hurry it up because the bats are almost within range!"

The gargoyle presses his flute to his lips, and begins playing a simple melody. I duck out of the way of an aerial attack just to see the shadowstalker's name plate change from red to blue indicating that it's become a friendly target. A reverse whirlpool icon, surrounded by spinning stars appears over its head.

Sajina casts charm monster on Shadowstalker. Success!

"Got him!" the Gargoyle says.

The shadow creature runs from me and creeps up the side of the cave wall, and then crawls on the roof like a lizard. I evade another strike from a dire bat, when the creature drops down and attacks it, knocking it out of the air with its body weight and wrestling it to the ground. The shadowstalker pulls out a dagger and begins cutting tears in its wings.

I say, "Go for the wings!"

Tako hurls one of his throwing knives, and makes a direct hit on the spot where the wing joins with the other bat's furry body. Both bats are now on the ground. Leroy obliterates Tako's bat with a thunderous smash of his war hammer trapping the animal between steel and stone. The other oversized critter squeals its dying cries when the Shadowstalker ventilates its body. Repeated dagger strikes leave a bloody mess.

A crossed swords icon next to my name disappears, indicating that the combat has ended. I glance uneasily at the gargoyle's pet.

I ask, "How long will that last?"

He says, "I've gotta renew the song every fifteen minutes. ...or, if one of us attacks it it'll break free."

"Alright." I say, "Don't let it go. We need to bump up your physical game."

It's not lost on me that our most fearsome looking party member, by race is turning out to be the biggest wimp.

Pahrem says, "You guys ain't givin' me nothin to do. No damage!"

"You can DPS until Flow Like Water goes away. With all of us fighting, these groups will go down quick."

"Rodger." Pahrem says.

Frobod says, "What's that?"

"What's what?" Tako says.

"Shhh!" Frobod says. "Don't say anything."

A faint rumble like white noise intrudes on our new silence. I say, "Sounds like water."

Leroy says, "I'll bet there's a waterfall farther down."

I look to Sajina, then to his pet, and ask, "Can your guy talk?" The shadowstalker just stares with its mysterious red eyes.

The bard says, "I guess not."

"Alright." I say, "Move out."

We collect the loot and continue our descent. It feels good having some direction, and with each meter we advance, the sounds of fast water grows more powerful. I wonder if the gate will be at the waterfall, or if it'll barely mark the start of our journey.

We come around a sharp corner. I'm surprised to find a steady stream of blue light ahead. In party chat I say, "Hold up. Light up ahead. Tako you can come up if you're sneaky."

He's at my side and we both drop into stealth.

Sneak - Successful! **Dexterity + Stealth**

So long as we're in the same party, the game shows us as slow moving transparent images like ghosts while the skill is active. To everyone else, we're invisible. The game doesn't seem to take Leroy's light spell into account when determining whether or not we can move about intentionally unseen.

I say, "Party chat only." since NPCs can't hear anything we say on that channel.

Moving forward, Tako and I come to an abrupt ledge that drops into an open room alongside an underground river. The light spills from bioluminescent mushrooms growing in clusters around rock formations in shades of hypnotic blue, violet, and periwinkle. Stalactites hang overhead but the ground is remarkably smooth with a few fingerlike stalagmite exceptions.

I take a deep breath, and marvel at how the air here feels fresher. I suspect it has something to do with the water, and leafy growths like forest ferns that appear alongside the mushrooms. The way the plants lean toward the source of light makes me believe that whatever's causing it, be it biological or supernatural, acts as surrogate sunlight.

I can also see several cook fires, with three to four shadowstalkers loitering around each. No sounds save for the rivers and occasional crackles from the fires, so they must have alternate means of communication.

I say, "There's a ledge overlooking a shadowstalker camp, about 12 are visible."

Pahrem says, "How far's the closest one?"

"There's a cluster of four about fifteen feet out, and however many feet down. Why?"

Pahrem says, "I wanna try something."

"Alright." I say. "Come forward, but stay quiet."

The green skinned girl says, "You're the boss."

She creeps beside me, crouches, and pulls a pair of transparent baubles from her inventory. They look like fish bobbers with green goop sloshing around inside, and metal pins sticking out of corked tops.

"You're throwing a grenade at them."

"I told you it's not a grenade." She eyes the shadowstalkers, and says, "I can totally hit that."

I'm half way through asking, "Then what is it?" when she yanks out the pin with her teeth and chucks it directly in the nearest campfire. Three.... Two... One.... Nothing happens. She chucks another one. *Direct hit.* ... assuming she was aiming for the fire, and I say "Good arm." Still, nothing seems to be happening. *At least they haven't noticed us.*

She stands a little taller when a sudden POP sounds followed by sizzling from below. Shadowstalkers scream and alternate between clutching their dark faces, and swatting their bodies. POP! The second one goes off, to the sound of more pained cries.

Pahrem has killed Shadowstalker.
Pahrem has killed Shadowstalker
Pahrem has killed Shadowstalker.
Pahrem has killed Shadowstalker.

She says, "It's a G'NADE!" and cackles. "Don't mess with a gobo alchemist biotch!"

I say, "I hope you've got a plan, because you just pulled agro."

The other eight of the shadowstalkers stand on their hind legs by their fires with black twitching noses. They look around for the source of the commotion. As if that isn't bad enough a patrol of three more comes into view skulking along the riverbank and point our direction. Moving like a herd of antelope, they lope towards us, scurrying on all fours until the moment they engage. One by one, they disappear under the shelf beneath us. I know it's because they're scaling the wall.

"Pahrem get back, major incoming! Melee to tank now!"

A pair of glowing eyes peeks over the ledge. I kick it in the face. To my surprise, an explosion of light like a strobe ignites when I make contact. *Bad ass!*

Taunt - Successful.
Shadowstalker attacks.

Frobod and Leroy rush in behind me. They're swiping at, and bashing individual stalkers slowing their advance, but there's too many. I bring Bite down on top of the one I kicked's head, and electricity spiders out over the group so that they're now crawling over each other to get to me. I shadow step behind Frobod and bring bite down on the closest one I can reach repeating the process so I can round up the other half of our attackers.

"Fall back! Bottleneck!" I say, coming up with a plan. Everyone takes the cue as they turn tail and run back around the bend. I'm the last person to join them, as red eyed shadow creatures pull their bodies up over the ledge looking

like the shades of demonic cat eared ferrets. I walk backward and smack Bite against the stone wall of the cave to draw their attentions.

Taunt - Successful. Shadowstalker attacks.

Here it comes. Shadowy bodies press into each other armed with a wide variety of bladed weapons. I smack the one in the front, and send Bite's energy creeping over the crowd like a lightning spider. They moan in pain and howl in bestial rage as the three in front try in vain to land a blow.

Pahrem shouts, "G'nade! Incoming! As a little globe flies overhead and drops in the center of the horde. Frobod impales the front mob on the left with his sword, and the monster goes down only to be replaced by its fresh, infinitely dark, red eyed cousin. Leroy smashes the one on the right with his war hammer.

I see Shadowstalkers near the back take to climbing on the walls when POP, a splash of green erupts in the middle. The guy in front nearly takes my head off, but I slip out of the way of its longsword just in time. I bring my staff around to block a short sword strike from the creature to my left. The guys on the walls are hit with the most jelly and fall, howling, crashing onto their brethren.

Pahrem shouts, "G'nade!" as another one of her projectiles sails overhead. The crowd's growing thinner as the foe on my right collapses under the might of one of Leroy's blows. The one in front finally falls with a quick strike from bite when another "POP!" sounds followed by an explosion of caustic goop. Shadow demons scream and fall. Only three remain standing. Tako hits, one between the eyes with a throwing knife, and Leroy and Frobod advance on the two remaining opponents. Leroy's drops with a bone grinding crunch, and the death knight lands a critical hit that separates a glowing eyed head from its body.

The crossed swords combat indicator fades, and in a matter of seconds, shadow bodies become small bags of loot. Tako does the honors, in picking everything up. and says, "Lots of coin, some vendor trash weapons, a blue sword, and five shadow essence. Anyone know what that's for?"

Pahrem says, "I can use the essence for my boom booms."

Frobod says, "Let's see the sword."

Long Claw of the Shadowstalker

Type:

Sword

Quality:

Rare

Base Damage:

Strength + 2 (Slashing)

Equipped Bonus:

Strength + 2, Stealth +3, Swords +1

Special Properties:

Chance on Hit: 3% chance to ignore armor.

"Anyone need it?" I ask.

Frobod says, "What I have is better."

"Tako?" I ask.

He says, "Doesn't hold a candle to Zarentu's daggers."

I say, "Roll for it."

Frobod rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 6

TakoStar rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 7

Melpomine rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 9

Pahrem rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 4

Butt-Trumpet rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 6

"I can't roll." Sajina says.

I say, "That's because you signed a contract giving up your claim to the loot. You're getting a thousand gold at the end of this."

Tako says, "You're paying him that much? What is he doing for us?"

I say, "Hopefully clearing the first boss."

A note of skepticism sounds in Tako's voice, "If you say so."

I feel a little bad for people going hard on Sajina, but I see their point. So far as I can tell he hasn't done a single point of damage since we've been here. I'm really hoping he'll find redemption when we face Cerberus so we don't both look like fools.

You have received Long Claw of the Shadowstalker.

"Congrats on the sword." Leroy says.

I say, "It's just going in the guild vault to help out less advanced members. If you weren't with us, I'd suggest all items we don't need go there."

I walk back out onto the ledge, and examine the camp now devoid of monsters. The party follows. "Since we know we have to cross the River Lethe, I think our best bet is to follow the water and see if it leads to the gate."

Frobod asks, "You want to jump, or follow the path and see if it loops around?"

I look to everyone and say, "Any chance one of you can cast 'Float?'"

Leroy says, "You and I can survive the fall. Probably wouldn't even feel it. Maybe the other guy in plate too. "

Sajina says "I can glide down with my first level of flight."

Tako says, "I've got a rope. You good with that Pahrem?"

"I think I'll manage." She says. "I don't look it, but my athletics score's somethin' else. Guess what skill covers throwin'."

I say, "We'll use Tako's rope then. Sajina you're last since you can unhitch it and glide down. Leroy, you're second to the last to protect our bard just in case something sneaks up on us."

Sajina says, "Who's Leroy?"

Butt-Trumpet winks, and says, "Stone-Bard go ahead. I'll bring up the caboose."

It only takes a few minutes for us all to drop down to the lower level. Sajina glides in a big circle and lands smoothly, and after Pahrem descends, Leroy grabs the end of the line in his fist and jumps down slamming into the rock with two feet like a gorilla. It's a move that would have taken most adventurers down a few health, but for a super-tank like Jensen the jump doesn't phase him. His in-game stats grant him superhuman endurance. He casually winds up the line and tosses it back to Tako in a tidy bunch, and says "Onward." gesturing to the water.

The passage narrows as we walk, but there's a good twelve feet between the wall and the water's edge. Pahrem and I still glow with Leroy's light but the spell's no longer necessary due to the abundance of mushroom luminescence hugging the walls and on the ceiling. Sometimes I hear the flapping of mundane bat wings and their high pitched chittering overhead. They don't attack and we leave them alone. The only reason I can see for killing them is food, and we've got plenty of that.

I say, "I think the camp's clear." having not encountered any new enemies in the last five minutes of walking.

Leroy says, "That means there will either be a bigger group, or new monsters up ahead."

Tako says, "There could be an ambush."

Leroy nods, "That too. It would match their style."

"You think they're undead?" I ask. "Why do you think they were trying to drag Sajina off."

"No." Leroy says. "It didn't say they were when I inspected them. As for the dragging..." He shrugs.

Frobod says, "I saw plenty of cook pots."

"Yummy." I say, "Rock soup. I just ask because the guys at the Lodge said that we might see undead as we get closer to the gate."

Sajina looks uncomfortable, and plays a quick tune on his flute to reinforce his charm spell. The farther we descend into adventure land, the more his confidence evaporates. His minion, quiet as ever, follows. It's red, slanted eyes, smolder in a face so dark I can't even tell if it has sockets.

I ask, "How many mobs can you hold at once with that spell?"

Sajina says, "For now, just one, but I have other things. I'm gonna hold on to this guy as long as I can and try to make him a groupie."

"A groupie?" I ask.

Sajina says, "It's a bard magic thing like an NPC fan."

"I know what a groupie is, but what does it mean in the game?"

"If you keep an intelligent monster charmed long enough, you can dismiss them, and call them back like a pet. The cook fires and weapons make me think that the Shadowstalkers are more than dumb animals."

"Good on you." I say. "Using your powers doesn't count as loot."

Quietly, I'm glad that Sajina will have a trophy to bring back home from our adventure. He doesn't seem to leave the city much, so amongst his Soc friends, the shadowstalker will be a rare find.

"Incoming!" Tako shouts, and hurls a knife, though it doesn't seem to hit anything. Sajina's pet leaps on the wall and scuttles forward on all fours like

gravity doesn't matter. I don't initially see anything, but then a fist sized rock whizzes past my ear. *Bastard! That could have hurt.* My dodge counter rises to one. More stone projectiles come at us from up the tunnel but I can't see who is throwing them. I dart out of the way of one, and then knock two to the ground with the end of my staff.

"Plate on either side! Wall up 'til we see what's coming. Clothies and leather take cover!"

Jensen equips a shield with his war hammer. It'll be harder for him to hit, but the sound of a sharp CLACK against it's face proves it'll knock back projectiles better than just his hammer ever could. I'm tempted to do the same, but I'm worried about endangering my Sune quest by equipping an item that's been blessed by another deity.

My dodge counter leaps up to four and then five as I dip out of the way of more flying rocks. I've got an idea, and say "Pahrem get ready!"

Instead of knocking the next rock that comes our way with my staff, or trying to evade, I intentionally place myself in the stone's path. My flesh twists around the object and allows it to pass through me. More importantly, the static shield on my boots activates and send an arc of electricity flying from my feet back at my opponent. It'd been invisible before, but now I can see the clear shape of one of the creatures ahead wielding a sling.

I charge forth shouting, "There may be more!"

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I don't give the Shadowstalker time to react, I appear behind him, deliver a fast hook kick which flashes like a camera, and bring Bite down hard on his shoulder. Electricity jumps from the monster I attacked to two other individuals that had been invisible. *I guess doing damage is the key to revealing them.*

Now that we know what we're facing, I kite them further down the passage so their backs are facing rest the party. Two come in with daggers which I manage to slip past, and I disarm the third by cracking my staff against its knuckles. The blade clatters against the rocky ground. Frobod, Tako, and Leroy all hit the same target, one after another. First the sword, then the hammer, and a needle to the abdomen. It didn't have a chance.

One of the enemy weapons takes a bite out of my skin, shaving off the last of my Flow Like Water defense.

"Get ready to heal!"

Two more to go.

They don't last long. Leroy smashes his hammer into the one I'd first stepped behind, while Frobod and Tako take down the other with a series of great sword slashes, and dagger piercings.

The in-combat icon fades from my view as Tako loots.

"Just coin." He says.

I ask, "How'd you see em'?"

He says, "I didn't. I just threw in the direction of the first stone."

"Does that ever work?" I ask.

He says, "Doesn't usually hit, but sometimes they'll drop out of invis and have a run at me."

The sound of rushing water is growing stronger, and it seems like the river's flowing faster. I say, "Were coming up on something." as I realize we're approaching the edge of a cliff. I hurry to get a better look leaving the rest of the party behind. I'm not worried, if I run into nasties I'll call out. If not, we're all good. The roar grows ever louder. By forty feet, I doubt I can hear anyone if they call for me. *Bad tank*. I'm tempted to wait, but the view ahead is so beautiful. I slow my pace.

Ten feet from my position the ground just stops, a sharp drop overlooking an underground cove where the waterfall ends. A mist from the rushing water wets my face. Mushrooms dot the ceiling like galaxies of stars, while similar lambent vegetation in the form of vines reach up tall cave walls.

The group is catching up now. Frobod says something, but I can't make out his words. I pull out my VT and type a message in the group chat.

Melpomine:	It's a long way down. I guess 100 to 150 feet.
Butt-Trumpet:	Can't survive that.
Pahrem:	Is it a dead end?
Melpomine:	Looks like the path bends around.
TakoStar:	There's also a ladder.

I hadn't noticed that, and move to where Tako's standing. Sure enough there's a stretch of metal rungs set in the stone.

Melpomine:	I can't see what's down there.
Pahrem:	Better use the rope to be safe.
Frobod:	Go down or follow the passage?
Melpomine:	As much as I hate heights when I'm not on a mount, I think the ladder looks more interesting.
Sajina:	I can glide down.
Melpomine:	Don't. We can't see what's down there. I'll go first. If I die, one of you can res me, and if you cant. I'm the only one with a Thunder Bridge to get back here quickly.
Melpomine:	We all good with the ladder?
Butt-Trumpet:	Follow the river. That's the plan.

The metal is cold and hard under my fingers, and I'm not thrilled with how slick the surface is from the waterfall spray. The descent takes far longer than it should. I catch sounds within the water's static, a dull moaning, but my ears only lock in on it once every few seconds. The deeper I drop, the louder those foreign sounds become, and it's hard to get a good look at whatever might be beneath me. I feel like an unseen horror's about to reach up and grab me, so I'm surprised when my foot touches solid ground.

CRITICAL HIT

Wight strikes you for 29 damage.

Resist: Stamina + Endurance.

You resist 24 points of damage. -5Health. 6 Health remaining.

Fuck!

As soon as my health drops, party members yell in party chat. I can't make out what they're saying due to the sound of the water, and there's no way I'm checking my VT at this moment.

My instinct is to drop and roll for cover, but aside from the cave wall I just crawled down, I can't make out my surroundings. A milky eyed dead skinned, man in a loin cloth swings his fist at me. This time I'm ready and able to dodge. Severe tissue damage, perhaps his death blow, makes him look like he only has half a face. Bite appears in my hands in the way of newly equipped items, and I bash the walking corpse in the side, and follow up with a roundhouse kick to the chest. Light flashes beneath my boot. It stumbles back. I dodge an awkward attack from the undead, and hit it with another duo of strikes from the Lightning staff. Electricity stings its body. I'm relieved to see that there are no additional targets for it to jump to.

Another swipe with its cold hand and I'm on the defensive, slipping out of the way. Another blow with bite and another kick and he's staggering back. A powerful roundhouse and... he disappears. *What?*

I look around, clutching Bite in white knuckled hands. I don't like violent surprises. The crossed swords indicator shows that I'm no longer in combat. I check my VT.

Butt-Trumpet:	What's happening?
Pahrem:	You're out of range. I can't heal you.
TakoStar:	Did you fall?

I catch my breath a moment, before submitting my response.

Melpomine:	Found the undead.
Frobod:	Where are you?

That's a very good question.

I look around. The light on the ceiling seems dimmer, like those stars of fungi are much farther away than they'd been a mere few dozen feet above. Hard rock underfoot, but like the edge of the waterfall, it seems to stop overlooking open space. The moaning is louder. I creep to the edge, acutely afraid of anything that could make me go over.

A mass of decaying groaning bodies writhe some fifteen feet below me. *At least now I know where the wight went.* I can't see how far back the wights and zombies go due to the poor light in spite of my racial ability. I liken the group to mass of fans crowding the stage at a rock concert, but instead of cheers I behold an unending chorus of moans.

Melpomine: I'm okay, but damn. There's got to be at least two hundred of them. I'm on like a five foot ledge that seems cut out of the cliff. Looks like it wraps around the whole area.

TakoStar: Think we can do it like the Windroost?

Melpomine: One of those things took 40% of my health in one hit. It'd be better to AOE if we have it. Come on down but be careful, the rungs are slick.

Melpomine: Sajina don't even try flying. You'll die if you miss the ledge.

A few minutes later, the last of the party joins me on my stone platform. It's crowded on the narrow space.

Melpomine: Let's walk around so we can talk again. It's too loud right beside the falls.

Instead of taking the time to type a message, Leroy and Frodo nod, and I assume the rest of the group is in agreement. Another wight appears just within range of the light spell, but it's a lot easier to deal with it when I can see it coming. A few blows, not necessarily trying to kill, and he's over the edge like the first one. All in all, we encounter three more such lone creatures before we come to the end.

"Well shit." Leroy says.

The crowd of undead doesn't look any thinner, and we're standing at the end of the shelf. We have two choices, jump in the water and hope this isn't the River Lethe or descend another ladder that leads right into the creatures that'd like to eat us, or bash us until we join them.

I say, "Please tell me someone has AoE."

"I do." Leroy says, "but it's centered on my position so it won't be that helpful if we're trying to avoid a fight."

Where's Laurelade when you need her?

Pahrem says, "I got g'nades."

"Enough for all of this?" I ask.

Pahrem says, "Probably not."

Tako says, "We could try stealthing..."

I say, "I don't like our chances. We'd probably be spotted."

Frodo asks, "What about that Thunder thing?"

I say, "Maybe if we had more light, but it only works within line of sight, or to a place I've already been. I haven't been to whatever's on the other side of this."

Pahrem says, "Well, anyone got any ideas? We ain't comin' down here for nothin'."

I say, "We could go back up and try the other path."

There's a long quiet as everyone considers, but no one's keen on that suggestion. For all we know, the other passage will take us the opposite direction of our destination.

Sajina says, "Uhhmm... I've got something. They're all undead, right?"

"Looks like it." Leroy says.

Sajina asks, "Can any of you play an instrument?"

I raise my hand. "Played a musician in Freeworld, but didn't get any magic."

Sajina says, "That won't matter as long as I'm casting the spell. Each additional player increases the area of effect."

Tako says, "I had a recorder in fourth grade. Never found the brown note. Always wanted to make my teacher shit her pants."

Pahrem says, "That's a horrible thing to say!"

Tako responds, "You didn't know Mrs. Seagull. Lady had rage issues. The whole class was looking for the brown note."

I catch a snicker on Leroy's face, and turn to Sajina. "What do ya got?"

The gargoyle says, "I can't kill em, but I think I can keep them from attacking us with The Dead Can Dance."

Tako asks, "Do you only play during Halloween or something?"

Must be another seasonal reward. I say, "Show me." Sajina shows me the spell in his VT.

The Dead Can Dance (Rank 4)

Cost: 5000 Manna

Duration: One Performance (Extendable)

Requirements:

Bardic Magic (1 per Rank) or Necromancy (1 per Rank)

Performance: 12

Charisma + Performance (vocal or any instrument)

(Bardic)

Charisma + Occult (Necromancy)

Effect:

Upon successful cast, all dead and undead characters within a twenty foot radius must cease all other actions and dance. Undead players may resist these effects by spending 100 manna per second. Players that resist this spell for 30 consecutive seconds may not be affected by The Dead Can Dance again for 30 minutes. If a dancer is attacked, it will enter a horrifying rage and pummel the attacker until it is destroyed. If the attacker dies, the dead will resume dancing, and the aggressor will join them.

Bardic casters may extend the duration of the spell to subsequent songs by succeeding in an additional Charisma + Performance roll so long as they do not stop singing or playing.

The radius of this spell is extended by 10 feet per additional musician that contributes to the song so long as the player succeed a Charisma + Performance check.

"That might work." I say, "Let's give it a go."

Sajina, seeming glad that the adventure has wandered in to his realm of expertise says, "Does anyone besides Melpomine have any music related abilities?"

Frobod says, "Mel and I both have head gear that gives us bonus points to dancing."

Sajina says, "That won't help. It's got to be for playing." Everyone else just shakes their heads. "Okay, I can buff you."

The gargoyle opens his mouth and unleashes a long powerful note like an opera singer standing before a captive audience in a theater. He holds it for one... two... three ... seven... ten seconds. I blink in surprise. *The man's got lungs.*

Then, as if attached to an invisible string, a new light appears over the pit of zombies. It's a great mirrored globe, that slowly rotates in place, and scatters bubbles of multi-colored light throughout the environment. It's like being in a club or a high school dance.... plus zombies. A new buff appears in the corner of my user interface.

Party on!
Performance+1
Charisma+1
Seduction+1

Tako laughs, "You have the most useless spells."

As he says this a few of the groaning zombies startle like infants, and look up in exploration of the new light. One guy in particular, bald headed, missing a forearm, and wearing a blood soaked jerkin wears a comical expression of wide eyed bewilderment... As bewildered as a dead guy can look with a missing jaw anyway.

"Give him a chance." I say.

Sajina says, "The bonus performance should be enough for you to hold a beat." He shuffles through his inventory to retrieve a mobile drum which he loans to Leroy, and a couple of tambourines which are given to Pahrem and Tako. He looks to Frobod and says, "Sorry, those are all the loaners I've got."

I say, "I've got maracas" as I put away Bite, and pull them out along with my Elebass, an elemental powered electric bass from Freeworld, out of my inventory.

As I hand them to Frobod, he asks "Do I even want to know why you have these?"

"Cinco de Mayo?" I ask with a hopeful tone in my voice. "Actually, I bought one of pretty much every instrument I could afford while playing my music character." I look to Sajina whose now armed with a lute, and ask "So now what?"

He says, "I'll bet none of you spent money on the good songs..."

Leroy says, "That's a negative."

For musical characters, to get auto-play songs from modern artists like Jarl Bang and Pin Head Toby Vs. the Nightmare you have to pay real money to the same as you would pay for the sheet music. Otherwise, you're stuck using

either your personal music ability, or choosing a track from the library of thirty to forty year old plus pop music that's included for free. If your real world playing skills outstrip your in-game ability, the game engine will f' up your performance so you sound like an amateur.

"Okay..." Sajina says, and plays a few chords on his lute.

**Sajina requests your help in casting The Dead Can Dance, by playing bass.
Do you accept? Yes / No**

I choose "Yes," and catch the rest of the party doing the same.

**Library Title: Murder on the Dance Floor
Artist: Sophie Ellis Bextor
(C) 2001 Polydor Ltd. (UK)**

Without my having to think on it, my hands move over the fret board of the bass and pluck the strings. Frobod's maracas crash in time, along with Leroy's thumping of the drum and the rattle of tambourines. *I can't believe we're doing this.*

**Sajina successfully casts. The Dead Can Dance.
Duration: Performance**

He begins by singing the title of the song, "... Murder on the Dance Floor..." which, as it turns out, is a catchy tune that matches the disco ball atmosphere.

Tako says, "This is fuckin' weird." as he shakes his tambourine to the beat.

Pahrem says, "I feel like I'm possessed." as she hits the same notes.

To my surprise, all of the undead in our vicinity have ceased their moaning. Without saying anything, I suppose he cant since he's singing, Sajina begins going down the ladder. His shadowstalker follows, leaping over the edge like a giant cat. *He better not kill the groove, or we'll all be dead.*

Standing close to the edge of the drop, I now see zombies bobbing their heads in time with the beat. *Craziest dungeon ever.* Tako goes down next, followed by Leroy, Pahrem, and now I bring up the rear.

It's a lot eerier being on the ground plucking at my bass surrounded by zombies and wights that are mostly taller than I am. A dot of light hit's one right in the face, and I see an eyeball hanging out on to it's cheek. It claps, spins, and dances off the opposite direction.

Using party chat I say, "Keep heading toward the river. See if there's a way to cross."

An unspoken effect of the spell also seems to be that the dead make room for musicians as we pass through them. They part before us like Moses and the Red Sea. It's strange to see the dead moving about in different dances to the same song. A few of the new ones smell of rot and death, but most of the dried out husks and skeletal remains are thankfully absent of scent. Most dancers are garbed in worn or decomposing adventuring gear.

We just passed a group of about twenty shambling in a synchronized line dance, meanwhile up ahead at 2 o'clock I see a dead man and dead woman in travel leathers, spinning about in a style that's pure tango, throw in a bunch of 70s struts and pointing from our left, and the whole unliving throng is a soup of boogie chaos. Decrepit limbs, and emaciated hips often make gut turning grinding sounds as they are pressed into fluid motion so alien to their deceased state of being.

Frobod calls back, "Bridge up ahead!" in between shakes of his maracas.

Good. I'm just waiting for the spell to snap like a rubber band, and have us all turned in to bloody smears under pulp on the cave floor. *Can't stop playing.* I look to Tako shaking his tambourine. *You better not kill the groove.*

I want to run for safety as I set foot on the bridge, but maintain a steady pace. Coast looks clear up ahead, but the water's choppy underneath. I don't want to even think about what might be lurking in there. I doubt we'd be so lucky as to see little blind fish. The Freehaven style would be to include giant piranhas or ten foot long leaches, that are as big around as my thigh.

We're all still playing when we cross, but Pahrem stops shaking her Tambourine. I suspect the radius of effect just dropped by ten feet. I give her a questioning look, but she ignores me. Now she waves her hands in an intricate gesture, and barks a word in a guttural language of which I am unfamiliar.

"Giralatu!"

A rectangle, much like a sheet of glass pushes away from her palms and grows larger, as it settles across the half way mark on the bridge.

"What's that?" I ask.

Pahrem says, "Ward vs Undead." I'm about to ask why she didn't mention that sooner when she adds. "It's for blocking doors or a bridge like this, but they can go around. Let's just hope these guys can't swim."

Most likely, so long as none of them are attacked, they'll stick to their designated area. Even so, just to be safe, I take the party a good thirty feet from the bridge before saying "We can stop playing now." I stow the bass in my inventory, and re-equip bite. Frobod returns my maracas, and Leroy laughs.

He says, "This is going to make great viewing! A melee group like ours, and no AoE magic... That could have been almost an hour of fighting, and we just walked through."

I say, "Give your thanks to Sajina."

Leroy says, "Well done bard. Well played!" and claps the gargoyle on the shoulder. Sajina collects his drum and the tambourines.

Pahrem adds, "Yeah kid, ya did good." as she hands hers over.

The disco ball still shines on the other side of the river, and I ask "How long will that stay up?"

Sajina sounds uncharacteristically shy, comparing to the elf from Fire and Soul, and says "Thirty minutes if I don't renew it."

Tako says, "I want to see the looks on adventurers faces that stumble across it."

Frobod points and says, "Look."

In the distance, illuminated only by glowing flora there's an archway, and at it's center is a spinning portal.



Chapter 7 - Through the Gate

I say, "Slow down" as soon as I'm sure what we're looking at. "I think that's it."

Leroy says, "Good thing we didn't go back the other way."

Pahrem says, "That could have been the really long way."

I say, "Sajina get ready. Once we're at Cerberus it's your job to play. Something nice... Something beautiful. The legend says that it'll put him to sleep."

He asks, "Should I use the sleep spell?"

I shrug, "It couldn't hurt. Tako, you and I drop into stealth and scout ahead to make sure there's no monsters and see about the setup."

Tako asks, "Isn't Cerberus a dog?"

"Yeah..." I say, "With three heads. Why?"

Tako says, "Dogs and wolves are good at piercing stealth. Not saying it's impossible but... It is a boss."

"In that case," I say, "We'll have to be extra careful. I've got an 'Oh shit' button that'll drop me out of combat, plus we have three resers. It'll suck if we die, but better us than have the whole group blindsided."

"I see your point." He says.

I say, "Plate wearers, you're on guard duty 'til we get back, just in case anything sneaks up. If undead start crossing let us know asap and we'll come running."

Leroy salutes with his gauntleted fist, and Frobod adds a double thumbs up. I'm surprised at how well Leroy is doing in the group. Not by his performance, he easily hits the hardest, but by his willingness to follow orders. Being the big name that he is, I can easily imagine him trying to steam roll me into doing things his way.

I nudge Tako's arm and say "Let's hit it."

There's a notable lack of monsters as we approach. Mushrooms still, along with the weird ferns and luminescent vines, but I've yet to hear a single bat chitter after crossing the bridge. The air also feels heavier... More still, as if we're now some how disconnected from the breezes that occasionally rushed past us on the other side.

"Coasts looks clear." I whisper.

Tako says, "It's party chat, so you don't have to hush your voice."

"Habit, I guess. Makes me feel more stealthy."

Still no monsters. It makes me think about what they say about the forest; all the animals go silent when there's a predator around, and I don't think I'm the one they are afraid of. All we can do is creep forward, and scope out the gate.

"There." Tako says, and points. There's a small nook to the left side of the gate, with a hulking figure tucked into it. It's hard to make out all its features, but from where I'm standing it could very well have three heads. "Is it sleeping?"

I hold my hand up signaling Tako to stop and creep closer on my own. The great beast yawns and shakes its heads. The black and white furred animal stands on all fours at an astonishing ten feet tall.

"Not sleeping." I say, as six eyes stare down at me. The center head has the droopy eyed face of a Greek sheep dog, where as the two on either side have tall ears and angular features. A long time ago I had an ex who lived with too many animals, and the heads on either side of the center remind me of what I was told was an alopekis. *Greek animals for a Greek hell, I guess.*

I take a step forward, and the center head growls. I raise my foot to take another step, and both the alopekis heads bark. That's my cue to inch myself back. My heart's pounding. I know that death is only temporary, but I'd really rather not go out with a mauling.

Dropping out of both party chat and stealth, I say "Cerberus?" It's hard to keep my voice from shaking. I just breathe deep, and put everything I've got into making my tone non-threatening.

You have gained the skill Animal Ken.

Current level: 1

I'm surprised by the notice. Changing my tone while addressing Cerberus was apparently the first step along the path of animal handling and training. Basically anything animal care or behavior related outside of riding a mount comes down to the Animal Ken skill. I'm also glad for the extra points this will give me to invest in special abilities. Every time you get a new skill or skill up, you get additional points to invest in spells or abilities like Aegis.

Now that I'm out of its apparent agro radius, all three heads tilt on an axis to question me. A tail that ends in a giant spade swishes back and forth. The expression in those many eyes seems to say, "Hey... durrrr.. What are ya doin'? Got a bone? I like bones. How about rawhide? Elephant ear? It's been so long since I chewed a dried elephant ear! ... Durrrrr... Wanna play?"

I take a deliberate experimental step forward. The tail stops moving, and a deep rumble sounds in the center head's throat. The way all those eyes narrow makes me feel like the animal's thinking "Don't have bones, but I'll gnaw on yours!" *Okay, time to move back.*

I look around, and find a large mushroom stalk growing out of a crevasse beside me. I pick it. The head's the size of two of my fists. It glows in my hand like a flying saucer.

"Cerberus!" I wave the mushroom around like a stick. "Catch!" The fungus leaves my hand flying high in the air. I get an abrupt chill as I realize that if I'm unlucky, the game will consider this an attack.

Oh shit. Oh shit!

My heart about stops when one of the alopekis mouths snatches it out of the air. With a devilish tail wag. All three heads look to me expectantly.

"Hey Tako." I say. "You wouldn't happen to have a ball in your inventory, would you? Maybe a vendor trash bow?"

"Yeah, why?" He says.

"I want you to slowly approach and give it to me. Nothing expensive. I don't think you need stealth as long as you don't come too quick, and don't set a foot past me."

"O..kay..." He says. A few moments later I hear his footsteps in the passage behind me. I hold out my hand, not for a second turning my gaze from Cerberus. "What are you doing?"

I say, "Watch." as he places the shaft of a poor quality bow in my palm. "Cerberus!" I wave the bow around more effectively than I had the mushroom; a proper stick. Fetch!" I heave the weapon through the gate. Though there's a shimmering translucent portal, it seems to only work for adventurers. The monster's head follows its path, up, through the air and down to where it clatters on the rock. "Go get it." I make kissing sounds. "Go get the stick."

"You've got balls." Tako says as Cerberus turns tail and runs. It's only now that we can see, hundreds of long necked dragon heads sprouting up like garden flowers along the monster's spine down to it's butt. Each of the little heads spews puffs of orange flame when Cerberus is excited. They wiggle, and squirm from it's back like a Medusa Mohawk.

"Oh, God..." I say. "I thought it was just a dog."

Cerberus bounds back, clutching the bow in the mouth of the center face. It drops the bow some five feet away, and nudges it closer with it's big black nose. Tako gives me a look, as I bend down to retrieve it. The happy body language seems to fade from Cerberus, though there's no growling. I'm very careful as I reach forward not to move my toes an inch from where they're planted.

You have received broken Short Bow.

I carefully pull it back over the course of agonizing seconds, and blow out a deep breath when I'm standing straight again. That pointed tail starts wagging, even more ferociously than before. "You want to fetch?"

"Woof." From the sheep dog.

"Play go get the stick?" The alopekis heads bark together. "Go get it!" I heave the bow as hard as I can. It flies through the open gate. Cerberus doesn't wait for it to land before charging after.

You have gained 500 personal reputation with Cerberus - Guardian of Hades.

You can get reputation with a dog?

I say, "Let's get back to the group before he comes back."

We hurry back down the dark passage from which we came, but not in time to avoid hearing a trio of canine whimpers, which bleed into raucous howls

of loss as we go. It's chilling in a way that makes me wonder how long this virtual animal has been down here alone. Five hundred rep for a couple of stick throws should have told me something.

"OWWWEEEEEEEEEEEE!!!!!!" A trio of howls sound.

I stop.

"I can't take this." I say to Tako. Go back and bring everyone here. We've established there are no other monsters. Just make sure you approach slowly. I don't know how it'll react if you're all running.

"What are you going to do?" Tako asks.

I sigh. "I'm gonna go back and play fetch."

"Really?" Tako asks.

I say, "I don't think it'll shut up any other way."

"OWWWEEEEEEEEEEEE!!!!!!"

"See what I mean?" I say, "I'm getting a headache."

Tako says, "I'll go get em'."

The howls stop as soon as I see Cerberus's silhouette in the mushroom gloom. Its tale wags, and it pants eagerly. When I get closer it pushes the broken bow on the floor toward me. *This is pathetic.*

"Alright." I say, "I'm back. Are you going to let me pick it up this time without playing Twister?"

I decide to give my rep gain a test, by taking a full step closer than I had before.

"Grrrrrrrrrrr." Snap! Vicious teeth clack together mere inches from my face. Hot smelling breath pours on to my cheek. I stumble back and fall on my ass. The monster whimpers.

I take a moment to feel the cold cave stone beneath my palms, and listen to the sound of my heart. *That... was... close.*

I stand, brush myself off, and equip Bite and attempt to drag the bow toward me. This is a lot more effective than reaching forward on my hands and knees. Once I have the broken short bow in hand, I give it another good toss, and watch the monster give chase.

We're on our third fetch when I hear armor clunking in the background. Pahrem says, "This is one wacky dungeon." when she see's Cerberus carrying back the bow.

Tako says, "What do you know about wacky Pahrem?"

No one seems to know what to say to that, so we let it drop. When the boss senses the others he approaches more cautiously. Some of the joy fading from its demeanor. Nevertheless, the sheepdog head drops the bow and pushes it on the ground, half way across that invisible line that must not be crossed. When I don't make any attempt to retrieve it, the head on the left bends down and tries to nudge it toward me.

"Whatta we do now?" Pahrem asks.

I ask, "Got your lute?" with a glance to the gargoyle.

Sajina gulps and says, "Yeah."

"Well, get ready and start playing." I turn my attention to Cerberus, and speak in a baby talk voice. "Cerberus!" kiss kiss kiss "I've got a surprise for you?"

Do you want a surprise?" The tail wags. "Oh boy! Cerberus loves the surprises!" Wag wag wag.

Tako says, "He could literally kill someone with that thing."

Leroy just looks amused, whereas Sajina.... I can't exactly call him pale since he's made of stone, but if he were still in his elf form I'm pretty sure he'd look a lot whiter.

"Do you like music?" I make more kiss kiss kiss sounds. "Someone told me you do." I'm reaching into the realm of heavy deep baby talk. "Nice music for the..." the word 'doggy' feels awkward on my lips. "Do you like music?"

The sheepdog woofs at the exact same time the right alopekis unleashes a shrill bark.

Slipping out of baby voice, I regard the gargoyle and say "It's time to make the big bucks. Lets hear that lute." He's hesitating. "Pick an auto song if you've got nerves. I don't know if you ever relied on your own skill."

He nods and plays, a gentle song I haven't heard before. I inspect him and discover it's called "Nothing Else Matters" by a some band called Metallica from the early 1990s. *So old.* I wonder if all their songs are so peaceful. Cerberus lays down on his stomach, and gets a dreamy expression on all three faces.

When he finishes the song, the sheep dog face rumbles a low "woof." While sleepy, all eyes are very much open. I pull out my VT and watch the combat log to see what's happening.

Sajina casts Sleep. Target: Cerberus. Failure.

Song: Nothing Else Matters

Artist: Metallica

(C) 1991

Channeled Effect: 30% Completion

Channeled Effect: 25% Completion

Channeled Effect: 20% Completion

Sajina says, "I don't know why it says channeling. It's supposed to be an instant cast spell."

Channeled Effect: 15% Completion.

"Keep playing," I say. Cerberus becomes restless, looking around like he's about to stand on all fours. "Completion drops the longer you're not playing."

Sajina starts on another free to play tune from the 90s.

Sajina casts Sleep. Target: Cerberus. Channeling.

Song: The Quiet Room

Artist: Babes in Toyland

(C) 1991

Channeled Effect: 25% Completion

I put my VT away, and see that Cerberus is mellowing out again. His eyes close, but his monstrous tail still sometimes flops around, and the little dragon heads on his back are puffing little blasts of steam.

The completion bar rises. No one else moves or says anything for fear of breaking the spell and causing Cerberus to attack.

Butt-Trumpet: If this works, it'll be Epic.

The next tune runs out, and the hell hound's eyes creep slowly open. Instead of stopping, Sajina jumps into a mellow song by one of my favorite bands Jarl Bang. *At least he has good taste in real life music.* The melody soothes Cerberus until his eyes shut again. A minute or two into the performance quiet canine breathing transforms into a chorus of three-headed snoring, and gentle whistling through dog noses.

I check my log to be sure.

Sajina casts Sleep. Target: Cerberus. Success!
Duration: Minimum 10 minutes, or until attacked.

I motion everyone toward the portal and mouth the words "Go! Go! Go!" I'm the last on the retreat. Leroy, Tako and Sajina along with his shadowstalker have all passed through. Now Frobo's going.

Pahrem: You comin'?

Melpomine: Just a sec.

I double back and place the old broken short bow beside Cerberus, before darting back toward the portal.

Loading....

Loading....

In the way of portals, my whole body feels weightless before my feet touch the ground.



Chapter 8 - Welcome to Hades

GLOBAL ALERT

The world's first adventurers have bested Cerberus and entered the Realm of Hades! Congratulations to Melpomine, TakoStar, Pahrem, Sajina, Frobod and Butt-Trumpet!

They have all earned the title Helldiver!

Achievement Unlocked: Kindness Unto Monstrous Beasts
Enter the Realm of Hades without harming Cerberus.

Rewards:

+ 1 Animal Ken

+1000 Personal Reputation with Cerberus

A large chest appears as soon as we arrive on the other side. We're no longer in a cave. It's... not what I thought it'd be. We're standing at the top of a gentle sloping hill covered in long yellow grass. A dirt path wide enough for us to walk single file extends from where we emerge to as far as the eye can see. The air is fresh, and the sun glimmers in a red sky, as it dips under the horizon. I turn around to see a large, stone archway filled with a translucent shimmering portal that I assume leads back to the caves.

Leroy abandons the Butt-Trumpet alias. For a moment he's wrapped like a mummy in ethereal streamers of Red that match the jerkin he wore to Cupcake Keep. When they fade, we're looking at the same Leroy that visited HQ.

He says, "There goes my anonymity. As soon as this feed airs, everyone will know the Butt-Trumpet connection."

Sajina, now seeing Leroy in his natural form says, "I've been traveling with Leroy Jensen?" To his credit, the gargoyle hasn't shouted out a chorus of Leroy's name. Perhaps, as a more social gamer, he's less likely to watch videos about raiding.

"Surprise." Leroy says with a grin. "On a quest like this, I didn't want to attract stalkers."

Sajina says, "Whoa..." as if trying to make sense of it. "I always thought you were taller."

Tako says, "I want to see what's in the box."

Lyre of Cerberus

Type: Instrument (Harp)
Quality: Epic
Base Damage: N/A

Equipped Bonus:
Charisma + 3, Performance + 5 (Any Music)

Special Properties:

Soothe - Channeled Ability

(Use: Once Per Hour)

Casts "Sleep (Rank 5)" Unlike the normal sleep spell, this is a channeled effect and may be used on hostile targets that are currently engaged in combat. If completion rises above ten percent, and then drops to zero, you may not attempt to use Soothe for one hour.

Hades Pauldrons

Type: Plate
Slot: Shoulder
Armor: 3
Quality: Epic
Equipped Bonus:

Intellect +2, Strength +3, Stamina + 4

You have received Hades Gold Mark x1.

I say, "Leroy and Frobod, either of you need the Pauldrons?"

Leroy shakes his head. "They aren't any better than what I already have."

"Frobod?" I ask.

Frobod says, "They're an upgrade for me."

"Congratulations." I say and hand them over.

The rest of the party, all but Sajina, echoes a chorus of, "Grats" and "Conga-Rats" and "Congratulations."

"What's the mark for? Did you get one?" Frobod asks. "Do they have a different currency here?"

"Yeah, I got one. I think we all did, I don't think so." I say. "Examine it."

Hades Gold Mark**Description:**

Used to pay fares to cross rivers in the underworld.

Type:

Currency

Frobod says, "I just did. It says currency."

"Yeah," I say "But the description says it's for transportation. I think it's more of a quest item."

Pahrem asks, "So if we all got one coin to cross the river, and Mirae's on the other side, how are we gonna get back?"

I say, "Let's cross that bridge when we come to it... No pun intended." This whole time, the gargoyle looks like his tongue's about to hit the earth as he ogles the harp. "One more item. It's obvious that this is a Bard item. That said, Sajina's not getting it. At least, not yet, because we have a contract. Is everyone cool with me holding on to it until we know if the gargoyle's coming with us?"

Tako says, "I have no use for it."

Leroy says, "As long as you're not automatically keeping it for yourself without a roll, I'm good with that."

Sajina looks like he's about to protest, but I raise a finger that makes any arguments die on his lips. "Rules are rules. Unlike the rest of us, you're getting paid, and now you've got a decision to make. Give up the gold, take the harp, and continue with us across the River Lethe, or we leave you here, you become a thousand gold richer, and you find your own way back to Durolan."

"Back through the cave?" He asks with a note of fear sounding in his voice.

I shrug. "You could die and go back to your bind point, or try a recall stone if you have one."

"Can I think on it?" Sajina says.

I look to everyone. "Are you guys tired? Sun's going down, this might be a good place to make camp. Do you all have tents?"

Leroy says, "I've got a big one."

I say, "Looks like we're camping so I'll give you till we leave tomorrow. Otherwise, everyone will either roll for the harp or it'll go to the guild bank." I pause looking out over the serene environment, and say to everyone "Go ahead and start setting up. I'm going to take a walk. I've got something to do for my Thunderlord quest."

Frobod asks, "Are you sure you'll be okay?"

I say, "No monsters in sight. I think I'll be fine. If something comes up I'll shout in party chat." Then, in a louder voice I remind everyone "Remember no eating anything you get here. If you're hungry stick to jerky and trail rations. If you find water, don't drink it."

Sajina says, "I can conjure water and wine... and the banquet table, but it all tastes like standard Haven fare...." He adds in a wistful tone of voice. "Not like what your used to."

"You heard him everyone. Use your water skins, or see the bard. I don't want to have to do any more rescue missions." That last comment is a stark

reminder of why we're all here. "Pahrem... If you don't mind, try scrying. Now that we've cleared the gate, it might work here."

She says, "You've got it boss."

Leroy says, "I'll get started on the tent."

I walk down the hill on the right, ignoring the path in front of us, looking for some place to set up a temporary shrine where I can burn incense. I like the feeling of the vegetation brushing up against my body, and drag my fingers through the top of the waist high tall grass appreciating the texture.

There's a cherry blossom tree up ahead where the grass is shorter that reminds me of the Quad at the University of Washington campus. I discover a log of another type of wood beneath it and decide it's a good location to perform my ritual. The log can be used as a make shift altar. The floral scent in the air reminds me as much of Mirae's healing as the colors remind me of school back in the real world.

I pull a stick of the common incense from my bag, along with the meditation stone. There's a little crack that allows me to wedge the wood end of the stick so that the incense stands upright. Using flint and steel to start a fire will take forever, so I begin a simple kata to trigger the most basic Freeworld fire spell.

A pinch of yang magic energy rises within me, and I direct it at the tip of my offering with slow motions and intention. It starts as a flash of heat in the small of my back, creeps over my shoulders, and brushes my cheek. It then runs down the length of my extended arm and leaps to the target from my fingertips.

Cast. Budding Flame (Rank One). Success.

In moments the incense begins smoldering. I kneel before the log, and touch my forehead to the meditation stone.

You are praying. Do you want to offer tribute to Sune, God of Lightning and Travel? Yes / No

I choose yes, and the stick of incense vanishes in much the same way my more expensive offering did at the temple. *Prayer heard... I guess.* I check the quest log to see if there's anything else I need to do.

Quest - Thunderlord Difficulty: Moderate

To become a Thunderlord in Sune's service, you must travel to a far off land, and return to the temple of Sune in Durolan with a trophy which will be sacrificed on his altar.

This journey must be completed in a way befitting a member of Sune's clergy.

Objectives:

Return from Journey

0/1

Offer Tribute (once every 24 hours)	1/1
Sacrifice Trophy	0/1

Prohibitions:

Sune's thunderbolts are long and far reaching. You may not use any weapon in battle that is less than 35 inches in length until this quest is completed. This prohibition does not apply to ranged weapons.

Rewards:

Title: Thunderlord

Reputation: Clergy of Sune (Honored)

Ability to Cast Divine Spells

+5000 reputation with clergy of allied deities.

Cost of Failure:

Cannot attempt to join Sune's clergy for six months.

"Okay then." I say aloud, assuming that if I miss a day, that 1/1 in the tribute objective will go down to 0/1.

Praying in the game is an odd experience because I know, better than most players as a game developer, that Sune's just some guy we made up and gave domains and stats to provide Freehaven with culture and lore. At the same time, going through the motions of burning incense, getting on my knees, and going through the physical motions of prayer feels oddly spiritual. Not that I'm reaching out to the God Sune, though I know that within the context of the game I am, but somehow, somewhere an unknowable being that transcends both the real world and the virtual one might be there with me.

I wish I knew what it wanted. It's like having a ghost loom over my shoulder. So long as I'm alive, I can't say I mind being stuck in the game for an extended period of time, but like a pack rat, I'm still not ready to let go of my body. It's the whole "What if I might need it for something?" thing, and I think I'll need a lot more than a few weeks away to divorce my relationship with Earth.

I'm not like Mirae who saw digitization as her one, possibly limited time, chance to escape a broken body. My body's good back in Meatsville. I've got a good life, if a bit lonely, comparatively speaking. I kiss my meditation stone, look to the sky, and say "Thank you."

Without rain, thunder sounds in the distance.

As I walk back to camp, I see that Leroy has already erected a tent. It looks like one of those family sized things for the car camping we used to do as kids. I'm also thinking about Mirae... *So, we're in Hades. Now what?* It's not exactly like the quest gave us instructions. There's also the very real possibility that Mirae isn't actually here, and we're gonna have to bring back some random NPC to complete the quest. I don't think, or want to believe that will happen since we got the "Mirae has come online" message, but who knows?" Now that we're actually in Hades, I can't think of anything we've found so far that indicates that she's actually here.

When I hit conversation distance from the camp Pahrem looks excited. "I got somethin'! Scryin' works!"

"Really?" I say. *So much doubt for nothing.*

"Yeah!" She says, "Check it out!"

"Hold up. Better get Tako, he'll want to see." I call out, "Tako! C'mere. Leroy, if you're done with the tent, you too."

We all huddle around Pahrem who has a bowl filled with water sitting on a blue cloth. She has four grey and white feathers as if from a seagull framing the outside of the bowl like silverware. The goblin mumbles something in the harsh goblin tongue, and then splashes a couple of spots of green energy into the dish from a dropper. It reminds me of the stuff Aztram used while making my boots, until she stirs it with her fingers, and blows over the surface creating small lime colored waves in the water.

Pahrem casts Scry (Rank 3). Success.
Duration: 1 minute

As she blows in the bowl, the liquid begins to take on new colors until the green is just a ring along the outside edge. The center is much like a video feed focused on a Sea Elf girl with minty green hair, and long ears.

"It's Mirae...." Tako says, in a tone of wonder.

I try to focus in on her surroundings which are unfortunately not helpful. She's sitting at a table with a book open in front of her. I can't make out the text, but by the way she sips a glass of water while reading, I assume she's in either a private room at an inn, or a sparsely populated tavern.

Leroy says, "Can't make much of that. It could be any of a thousand places across Haven." I sigh, knowing the odds of recognizing a place that's probably in the underworld was a long shot.

"Yeah..." Tako says, "... but it's Mirae!" I share his elation, as he grasps my hand. "She's not dead. She's still here!"

I'm not going to split hairs over the dead vs. alive thing, so I smile and say "Yeah..." I don't want to seem weak by crying, but nevertheless dab the corner of my eyes with my index finger. "We didn't come all this way for nothing."

Pahrem says, "Hey, uhh.. guys... I can't send messages to our guild members. I was gonna let em' know we found her."

I give it a try of my own.

Melpomine: Hey Chef. We found Mirae. We can scry her now.

You cannot send messages to the living without the aid of magic.

I say, "Well that's unhelpful."

Pahrem says, "They'll just have to wait for the news."

"Hey guys," Tako says, "I can't send a message to Mirae either."

I give it a go to see what he's talking about.

Melpomine: Mirae! You're okay!

You cannot send messages to players that may be the object of your current quest.

Tako says, "I'm gonna drop the quest and try contacting her."

Leroy gives him an "Are you serious?" look, and I say "Chill. You'll be kicking your ass if you miss out on extreme loot. There could be hidden rewards."

Tako say, "But I've gotta tell her we're coming! She'll never know unless we tell her."

I say, "She'll know anyway as soon as we find her." I turn to Leroy, "What about that Lorak guy? Can we use him?"

Leroy says, "I don't know, I've never been in Hades."

"Try it." I say.

He says, "First I need to write a letter."

Tako and I speak at almost the exact time, "Then do it!"

Leroy gives us a look that says "Patience... I was just about to." and pulls out a quill, a book to serve as a hard surface, and a sheet of parchment. He begins scrawling in the same script I remember from the letter I received outside the Lodge of Arcanum. Pauses, and says "Is everyone's in game clock working?"

I give mind a check, and see the digital read out in my feed. "Looks like it."

"Pahrem... Is there anything stopping you from using the scry spell again tomorrow?"

"Nah.." She says. "I'll be full on manna, and got plenty of reagents. It's just the basic version of the spell."

"Okay, good." Leroy says, and continues writing. He signs his name with a flourish, and toggles something in his VT to initiate a friend request, which shows up on the paper as a pair of glowing blue brackets around his name. He re-reads to make sure he hasn't forgotten anything.

"Mirae,

Melpomine, Tako, Frobod, Pahrem, the bard Sajina and myself are in Hades, and are coming. Be ready to move when we arrive. We're bringing you back to Durolan and your guild.

If your clock is still working, please visit a landmark of the place you are located at 8:00 AM, Durolan time tomorrow morning. We will be scrying, and it will help us find you.

Sincerely,
Leroy Jensen"

"Tell her I miss her!" Tako says.

I put a calming hand on his arm and say "She already knows. Short and to the point is better." I regard Leroy, "Good thinking on the landmark."

Leroy nods, folds the letter and pushes it in a course brown paper envelope. He touches the end of the triangle where the envelope closes with his thumb, and a wax seal appears with a stylized "LJ" where he touched it.

Leroy says, "Now to see if Lorak will do his job."

Tako asks, "Who's Lorak?"

I say, "If this works, you'll see."

Leroy retrieves a glass orb with red smoke that swirls around inside like a snow globe from his inventory. He rubs the surface like he's making a wish on a magic lamp, and says "Come forth my messenger."

A gout of flame and black smoke erupts with a whiff of brimstone startling Tako and Pahrem into taking steps back. Standing before Leroy where the flame vanishes is a horned man in a black tunic and red skin like a bloody sun. His thick two pronged tail lurches around like a fish on land when he bows and says, "I serve the Malefactors."

Leroy passes him the note in two fingers, "Deliver this to Mirae in Hades."

Lorak grins a wicked smile filled with wolf's teeth, "You have my coin?"

I look to Pahrem and say, "As soon as he goes, start scrying. I want to see this.

Tako says, "Yeah me too."

Leroy tosses the devil a black drawstring bag, filled with coins that make a hearty clink.

Lorak catches them in a fist, and says "Consider it done." and disappears in the same puff of soot and fire he arrived in.

Leroy regards Tako and answers his earlier question, "Demonic messenger. He works for the guild."

Pahrem says, "I've got her. Look."

We gaze down to see Lorak materializing in front of Mirae in his customary bow, and holding out the letter. There's no sound, but I can almost hear him saying "Leroy Jensen of the Malefactors sends his regards." after having my own experience.

She looks confused, breaks the seal and reads. Her green eyes dart back and forth across the page. A moment later she breaks into a big smile, and presses the parchment to her breast. She looks up, staring out into space, as if trying to peer back through the scrying pool, before looking back down to the letter and re-reading.

Leroy says, "She just accepted my friend request. She's online. Weird. What's that snake thing next to her name?"

"It's an Oroboros." I say. "Not sure what it means within the context of the game. Only the people who failed digitizing seem to have it."

Leroy looks to Pahrem. "Eight AM tomorrow. Don't be late."

She says, "Who do ya think I am? I ain't no slouch. I'll be ready."

"It's been a long day." I say. The sun's now gone leaving only a starry sky in its wake. Leroy's cast a light spell on a stone beside the tent, so it's not too dark. "I think we ought to get some rest, and break into that jerky. Tomorrow we search for the River Lethe."



Chapter 9 - Charon's Boat

My eyes pop open. It's still dark. The light of Leroy's stone has long faded. We're all inside the tent, and I'm situated on a bedroll with Frobod to my right, and the much smaller Pahrem to my left.

Tako says, "Hey, Mel, are you awake?"

"Yeah..." I say, then take a deep breath through my nose. *What is that? Sweat... Stale corn chips?* My eyes pick up the outline of Tako's boots in the darkness, and I say, "Your feet stink. Haven't you washed your feet since we got stuck here."

"Uhhmm..." He says. "My feet specifically?"

"Come on..." I say, trying to keep my voice down. "It's not like Cupcake Keep doesn't have baths."

Having been stuck in game for over a week now, I've come to learn that as a half-elf as soon as I answer "Yes" to the sleep prompt I'm out for exactly six hours unless something intentionally wakes me. For humans it's eight, and goblins about seven. I eye Sajina having no clue how much sleep gargoyles require each day. In any case, Tako and I are the fully refreshed early risers due to our half elven heritage.

He says, "Want to go outside?"

"Might as well." I say, and sit up.

The cool morning air is nice and fresh on my face. Far better than a tent filled with six adventure worn bodies. After closing the front flap, I stroll away, and ask "How'd you sleep?"

He says, "Like the dead. Same as always."

I ask, "Do you ever dream?"

Tako says, "Not since we've been in the game."

"I wonder if that'll ever change." In the real world I've always been an active dreamer, and I'm coming to miss those nocturnal adventures. Tako just shrugs, so I add "How are you feeling?"

"Good." He says, "I mean... We've got proof that she's down here. Some part of her still exists in the game."

"I know what you mean." I say, "It was really hard at first just to believe. I was afraid of having hope, and losing her all over again. Now, we even have proof that we can bring her back for this quest because of that error message."

"I wonder what she's been doing all this time."

I shrug, "This isn't exactly the hell we're used to thinking of. Everything we've seen suggests this place is based on ancient Greek religion, which places us..." I trail, as if searching a map while digging through my memory.

"Where?" Tako asks.

I say, "In or near Elsyium or the Asphodel Meadows."

"Awesome." He says, sounding relieved and as if he knows exactly what I'm talking about. A few seconds later he asks, "What's that?"

I say, "Elsyium's where the souls of heroes, demigods, and the especially righteous go, and the Asphodel Meadows are for average folks that didn't do anything especially great or evil. Thinking of this like a designer, the Meadows make the most sense upon arrival. That way you can quest to enter the more exclusive parts of the underworld. There's probably a rep grind to enter Elysium, aka the dead cool kids club, and quests to defeat monsters in or near Tartarus. That's hell."

Tako says, "You're really into this mythology stuff."

"I guess so. It's a hobby of mine. I like learning about old religions and have been reading about them for years."

Tako says, "I just want to see her."

"Me too."

Tako asks, "What do you think will happen when we get back to Durolan?"

I say, "They'll do some ritual and bring her back to life, I guess."

"Do you think it will change her?" Tako asks, "I mean... more than just making her alive again."

"I'm sure she'll be the same person if that's what you're asking." I say. "Who knows what'll happen to her stats. This is the perfect opportunity for the game to introduce new gear or bonuses. Perhaps even a new race to go with the expansion."

"You were a dev, did you even know anything about in-game Hades?"

That gives me pause, and I choose my words carefully. "I didn't know about it, and if I worked on the project, they certainly didn't assign me to a Hades team. Most of my work was in creature, item and mount design, though in the past I've done environments. I know for a fact that I haven't made any Haven specific content because I worked for VWI, before the buyout."

VWI, aka Virtual World Innovations, was the company that created Freeworld Online before Haven bought it, and merged the games Haven and Freeworld Online into Freehaven Online.

Tako says, "Maybe we'll see something you made up ahead. What were the last things you worked on?"

"You've already seen one of my last two projects - the Elechoppers. They're clearly Freeworld items."

I hesitate to reveal more information about my other project due to my non-disclosure agreement and not knowing if they are yet in the game. They might already be live, and since I'm just talking and not delivering any character models, I decide to tell.

Freehaven is real now in a way that it was never supposed to be. If letting my project slip might somehow aid our survival or completing our quest.... *It's worth it.* If anyone comes after me I'll claim insanity due to having been locked

in VR for fucking weeks with people dying. Yeah, none too happy with my employer right now, in spite of knowing it was the hackers' the caused this.

I still feel a hesitation as I begin, "The other project was the Once Men."

Tako asks, "What are those?"

"Some Freeworld supernaturals have the ability to reshape flesh and bone like clay. The ghosts can do it too actually, but that's not what I was working on. The Once Men are victims of the bad guys, they started as people and were reshaped into killing machines given nasty teeth, claws, and all that. Now they're caught somewhere between beast and human. I have no idea what their stats are like since I just did the animations, skinning, and modeling."

Tako says, "Would they be in Hades?"

I shrug. "Lore wise, I'm sure some died during the creation process and could end up here, but without knowing what kind of stats they were given, I don't have much of an edge over anyone else while fighting them."

Tako says, "That's messed up."

I say, "Freeworld's a darker place in spite of its name."

Night is now fading to twilight, and I expect at any moment we'll see the sun peak up over the horizon. Pahrem and Sajina exit the tent looking awake, but groggy. I say to Sajina, "I was wondering how long you'd be out."

He answers, "Four hours of reverie. I still have elf stats, remember."

"Right." I say, having forgot that changing from one alias to another doesn't convey all their racial traits, penalties, and bonuses. The "perfect aliases" of our alternate characters are just magical costumes to swap appearances.

"Well, good morning to you both."

Pahrem chews on a length of Jerky and says, "I miss coffee."

I was never much of a coffee drinker, to me the stuff was just like hot dirty water, but I understand the missing caffeine sentiment. "If you drink a manna potion when you're filled up it's like a double shot of espresso in terms of waking you up."

"Really?" she asks, "How'd you learn that?"

I say, "Alfred showed me."

She pulls a tiny vial of blue liquid from her inventory, downs it and shivers. "That's brisk." She pinches her eyes closed and then wide again before saying "Hell yeah! I can already feel it."

I chuckle. "Just don't burn through your whole stock when you might need them. I don't need some manna-head healer in my crew."

"Manna head?" Tako asks.

"I dunno." I say "I just made it up. Like a crack-head with manna potions."

Pahrem says, "It was just a weak one."

I look to Sajina and ask, "Have you made up your mind?"

"I'm coming." He says.

"You sure?" I ask. "It'll be dangerous."

He says, "Yeah."

Tako asks, "Why? I thought you wanted to avoid the fighting."

Sajina just shrugs. "No time to learn like the present."

I extend my hand to the bard and he clasps it. "Glad to have you. You did well on all those undead and Cerberus. You'll get your harp as soon as we cross the River Lethe and I get my money back."

"Where is it anyway?" Pahrem asks.

"The river?" I ask. "No idea. I figure we can walk around until we find clues or someone to ask. Leroy and Frobod will be up soon, and we can get going."

"Still no monsters." Tako says.

I nod and say, "It's a quiet place."

* * * * *

After a while of munching on our rations and waiting for the humans Leroy exits the tent in a suit of burgundy full plate armor that reminds me of red wine. He still has his chrome colored war hammer, though it seems larger to me now that he's in human form. Right behind him Frobod dips out in his black Deadplate, and new Hades shoulders. They are a shade of tarnished bronze over the sleek black metal of his skull shaped chest plate.

I say, "We're ready to go once you put the tent away."

Rather than taking it down manually, the tent fades like a ghost as Leroy taps on his VT and sticks it back in his inventory. Our bedrolls are left on the ground where the tent stood, and we gather them up.

Leroy says, "Now we're ready to go."

"You all got flying mounts?" I ask, though I really mean "Sajina, do you have a flying mount?" Since we're traveling with Leroy Jensen and three members of the guild. Rather than answer, Leroy taps his VT, a pulse of red light flashes, and an avian shriek fills the air. Waves of heat blast our faces, as he mounts a resplendent red phoenix. Thankfully, it's coded not to set the ground on fire, or we'd all be standing in a grassy conflagration of trouble.

Sajina, looking embarrassed says, "Mine's slow. Just 100%."

"Ouch." Tako says.

I say, "Muffins, Sajina, I've got you covered." as I initiate my mount summoning macro. I wave my middle finger in the air and shout "INFERNO!!!" followed by a pump of my fist in the air and the words, "Let's ride."

A red pop of color, not unlike the one caused by Leroy's phoenix appears, followed by the monster roar of a motorcycle engine. I'm standing beside a hot red motorcycle in the style of a 1960's Harley, but instead of running on gas, there's a rude elemental spirit spinning in a tornado of flame in a fish bowl shaped containment cell where the gas can should be. It grins at me, and then gives me the middle finger. Next come explosions of green for earth, grey for ether, yellow for wind, and blue for water at the same time, with the loud grumbles of four gurgling engines.

Frobod takes his usual seat, on the grey etherbike, and Pahrem straddles the blue. I say, "These are the Elechoppers. You can use whichever you want."

Sajina moves for the green, but Tako darts forward and cuts him off by placing his hand on the handlebars before the gargoyle can touch it.

Tako says, "This is Mirae's bike, and I'm riding it."

Sajina looks startled by the intensity of Tako's voice, and then turns his head down and away. I can't tell if he's intimidated or just feeling like an outsider

in a group of adventurers that all know each other. I say "It's sentimental. Just pick a different bike."

Wind's the only choice left so the gargoyle takes it.

Leroy says, "Hot shit. Are those new? I've never seen them before."

I say, "They came out with the last patch. They're from Freeworld."

Leroy asks, "Can they fly?" while holding the reigns of his phoenix.

I say, "Mine can. I don't know about the others."

"How did you get them?" Leroy asks, surprised to see a collection of mounts he's never encountered before.

"I made them." I say, "I am... was... a developer. We get developer's editions of any in game items we create."

An uncomfortable quiet sits in the air between Leroy, myself and Sajina. I've become so used to the Toxic Muffins knowing about my offline profession, that it slipped my mind that other people might take exception to it.

"Hold up." Leroy says, "You're telling me that you're one of the bastards that got us stuck here? People are dying for real out there."

Angered by the insinuation I say, "You think I don't know that? You think I want to be here? Do I look like I have fucking angel wings?"

At this point Frobod chimes in, "She's good people. She's just as stuck as all of us."

I say, "The whole reason we're even on this quest is to save a friend who didn't survive digitization. You think I wanted that to happen? If I had some kind of insider information, don't you think I'd have said 'Hey Mirae, don't fucking do it, or you'll die.' or better yet, waved my magic wand to guarantee she'd come out okay?"

Tako says, "She's just a player in this. She had no idea the hack was coming."

"Thank you." I say. My tone is forceful, but I feel a hint of warmth beneath all my tense indignation. It's good to see the Muffins having my back.

Frobod says, "I've got plenty of reasons to be pissed off. I missed my daughter's birthday, and every time I wake up the first thing on my mind is how to get back to her. I am angry, but not at Mel. It's those Archangel fuckers that are doing this. As far as I can tell, Mel's working her ass off to make things right, or at the very least a little better by bringing us on these quests that might unlock the log out button, and organizing our guild so we have a support network."

I could kiss him in that moment, meanwhile Leroy looks like he's been caught flat footed.

Sajina says, "Don't cuss your waiter because the management's crap."

"Yeah... I guess..." Leroy says, "Sorry... I've just been telling myself I'd like to ring the neck of whoever caused this."

"You and I both." I say. "But that person is not me. I don't even know where my body is. Most of you've got families right? You got a wife? They're probably caring for you. I live alone. I could be in the hospital, at my parents' place in Hawaii, or at corporate HQ. How do I know who's washing my lifeless body, and taking care of my toilet stuff? I have no fucking clue because I don't have anyone in the real world looking out for me on a daily basis. The only way I know I'm still alive is that I'm still playing this game, which means someone out

there put me on life support. I keep a level head while I'm not thinking about what's happening now in the real world, but as soon as I do it's really damn scary. I don't want to be in this situation, and I sure as hell wouldn't impose it on anyone else."

"Jesus, Mel." Pahrem says. "You sure know how to make a person feel safe in the real world. Now I'm gonna be havin' nightmares about what people are doin' to my body."

"Can we just go?" Tako says, looking uncomfortable.

"Yeah." I say. and lift off the ground on the Firechopper "... but first I want to say that when we get back I think we ought to start making a list of people's real names and locations to memorize. If any of us gets out, they've got to check and see if the others are in good hands."

I'm trying to get a measure of Leroy's reaction, but he's good at hiding his emotions. He's quiet and still riding with us, so I can only assume that means he's no longer ready to kill me. It'd suck to die and get sent all the way back to Durolan, all he'd need to do is take out Pahrem before she could res me, and the whole quest would be FUBAR, or at least placed on long delay. I'm pretty sure he could do it.

We've been flying for ten minutes, and haven't seen any signs of life on the Hades landscape, when movement in the grass draws my attention. I'd thought the dirt path we've been following would go on forever.

"Did you see that?" I ask, coming to a stop and hanging in air as all flying mounts are able to do.

"Yeah." Pahrem says. "For just a second but now I don't see anything anymore."

Tako says, "It should be obvious from up here."

Frobod says, "Invisibility. Look." He points.

I follow his finger to see a faint line in the grass where something large, about human size, trampled it. The farther back the trail stretches, the more the tall grass seems to have sprung back into place. It abruptly ends, about twenty feet away with no person or creature to show for it.

Tako says, "Think it's hostile?"

I say, "We haven't been attacked yet. Just be ready in case something happens." and then call down "Hello? Is someone down there?" No answer. As moments tick by, the trail becomes harder for my eyes to follow. "We're not here to hurt anyone. We just want directions."

Leroy asks, "Maybe it was an animal?"

Pahrem says, "Didn't look like it."

Frobod says, "Maybe we should just keep going."

"Hello?" I call again, hoping for a response, some clue as to whether we're going the right direction.

Tako says, "Let's just go." and revs his engine.

"I guess so..." and begin moving forward.

I don't advance even five feet before I hear a man's voice respond something that sounds like, "How do I know you're alive?"

"Stop." I say to everyone and halt my bike. *That can't be right.* I call down again, "Hello?"

This time, without the rumble of accelerating engines the voice is clear. "How do I know you're alive?"

I answer, "Of course we're alive. What else would we be?" *Then again, this is Hades.* Realizing my blunder I say, "You'll just have to take our word for it."

The voice says, "Prove it!"

Leroy says, "Show yourself." Followed by, "Is being alive or dead a problem?"

I say, "If we come down, will you agree not to attack us?"

The voice responds, "My word, so long as you don't attack first."

Leroy repeats, "Show yourself, or we continue and no one's coming down."

There's a moment of soundless hesitation, before a man in garbed in black and grey appears in the way of a specter breaking into existence. He's got wide shoulders and an animal skin headpiece like a Davy Crockett cap. A thick bushy tail rides between his shoulders. His name plate says, Verade. I'm glad his hunting bow and nocked arrow aren't pointed in our direction.

Verade says, "Now you."

I take point, say "Come to the road." and descend to the dirt path we've been following, if it can even be called a road. The rest of the party follows suit, flattening tall grass beneath their rides.

We only have to wait a second before the man emerges onto the path. I'm surprised to see that it's not only his clothes that are black and grey, but his entire body. It's like someone peeled him straight out of an ancient movie, or off of a grayscale tattoo. He's about a head and a half taller than me and has a thick bushy black beard that feels like it should be brown.

Verade	
Type:	NPC
Race:	Human
Subrace:	Wraith (Lethekin)
Appearance:	3
Challenge:	Difficult
Status:	Neutral

Verade says, "Prove to me that you're alive?"

Tako says, "How do we even do that?"

I don't expect an answer, but Verade says, "Bleed for me."

Pahrem says, "I thought there was no attackin'."

I look to Tako, hold out my forearm, and say "Cut me with your dagger. I have a prohibition against using short weapons."

Tako arms himself and asks, "You sure?"

"Just do it." I say. "But try your best not to critical hit."

"If you say so..." he comes closer, glinting steel in hand.

I say, "Make it quick." He slashes into me, a line of crimson explodes onto my fair skin. I hiss as a whopping twenty percent of my health drops. Pahrem looks like she's about to cast a heal, when I raise a hand to stop her. Catching a stream of red in my other hand I hold it fingers up for Verade to see. "Satisfied?"

He nods, and returns the arrow to his quiver. I nod, and Pahrem makes some gestures to begin the heal. Unlike Mirae's green colored magic, hers is a tinted yellow-gold like the magic we encountered at Dragonswood Keep.

Verade's body relaxes as he releases tension that he probably didn't know he had. He eyes my forearm and says, "For that, I am sorry. These lands are haunted."

"Oh...kay." I say, not sure how to take the pronouncement of haunting from a ghost.

Leroy asks, "How do you mean?"

Verade says, "There's a settlement over yonder, but they're all dead. The residents don't bleed like men."

Tako asks, "Do you bleed?"

Verade sighs, and says, "I suppose fair is fair..." as he pulls a hunting knife from his belt. In a quick gesture, he slices his arm and... no blood flows. I can't say I'm surprised given his wraith designation, but then he says. "See? Just the same as all of you." Verade squats down, slings a travel pack around his shoulder that I hadn't noticed before, and withdraws bandages with which he dresses the wound.

I say, "I see..." playing into his narrative hoping to gain more information. "And where is this settlement?"

"A way down the path forks. If you go straight you come to the river. Go left and you'll hit Duskwallow, but you don't want to go there. It's right eerie."

For a moment I'm torn between going to the river and visiting the settlement. In spite of Verade's protests I'm intrigued, but then remind myself that we have more important business on the river. I ask, "Is it the River Lethe?"

"You have the right of it, or at least, that's what the dead say. You're the only other living people I've seen since I've come here."

Tako asks, "How do we cross? Is it something we can fly over?"

"You could try..." he trails, "But I ain't ever seen anything fly around here. 'cept for yourselves of course."

"Thanks for the information. "Looking between Tako and Frobod, and then to the rest of our group, I ask, "So head to the river? We can always back track if we need."

Leroy says, "There are probably quests in the village, but yeah. It sounds like the river's the most direct path."

I look to Verade and say, "Good luck in your hunting. We haven't seen much game."

The ghost hunter says, "Be safe." and becomes steadily more transparent until he has completely disappeared. The tall grass parting to our left is the only thing to mark his passing.

Frobod says, "Weird guy."

Pahrem asks, "You think he knows he's dead?"

I say, "Doesn't seem like it." as my Firechopper takes to the air. "It should be just ahead."

We soon hit the fork in the path, and continue straight toward the river. A few minutes after that, the water becomes visible. Long grass has given way to a gorgeous sandy beach that stretches forever in either direction. Aside from a

short wooden dock with a long gondola tied to it the environment is untouched by intelligent hands. The water's clear in a way I haven't seen outside of travel brochures.

Now we're approaching the dock on foot where a male figure in simple albeit well made travel clothes rests against a piling reading a book. A black wool turtleneck clutches his neck beneath a leather vest, and a black cloak with the hood down hides his shoulders. His name's Charon, ferryman of the underworld, and speaks in a soft spoken voice that reminds me of my old pastor, "I'm afraid there's no free passage for the living." Even his five o'clock shadow reminds me of how Pastor John always fell just short of clean shaven.

The river's long, wide, and haunting. A giant skeletal hand affixed to the bow pinching a lantern between thumb and forefinger adds to the eeriness along an otherwise pristine quiet landscape. The only sounds are our voices and the stirring of water lapping against the shore.

It's all much to contrast with the ferryman's appearance—nicely groomed, preppy-rugged. I could see him stepping right off the pages of an LL Bean catalog if they did fantasy wear. Though it's a clear day, an eerie mist collects at the river's center.

Tako asks, "Is this something we could fly over?"

Charon, closes his tome around a crow's feather used as a bookmark and says, "Don't think anyone's ever managed that. You could try, but you might also end up a permanent resident of Duskwallow. May I ask where you're going?"

"Err..." I begin. "I know we have to cross but..."

Leroy says, "If we gave you a landmark, would you recognize it?"

"Probably." Charon says, "I've been here a very long time, and you might say travel is what I do."

Leroy says, "Do you mind if we come back with an answer?"

Charon says, "I'll be here. Take all the time you like."

As we ready to depart, Charon reopens his book, and I wonder what he's reading. I ask, "What is that?"

"This?" Charon raises his book, so I can see the cover—Jane Eyre but set in a leather binding so it looks like a spell book. *Not what I expected.* He must read surprise in my expression because he says "One of the classics," and then sighs. "New reading material is so hard to find."

Tako stirs impatiently, and I can tell he wants to interrupt with something about getting a move on, so I speak fast, with my gamer sense anticipating a quest. "Why's that?"

Charon says, "Books here are rare, rarer still are novels. The only way they make it into the underworld is if one of the living smuggle them in, a person died with so much attachment to it that a spirit copy manifested in death with them, or if the book was magical and permanently destroyed. As you can imagine, under circumstances like these, very few new works come into my hands. I've read this one four-hundred-sixty-seven times. Soon to be sixty-eight."

I say, "That sounds horrible." and mean it. *What is life without a good story?* It's not exactly like Hades has television.

Charon says, "I would be extremely grateful to anyone who could bring me

something new. Romance, horror, great poetry; It doesn't matter. A new book for me in Hades would be worth it's weight in gold."

Quest - Charon's Library (Repeatable)

Difficulty: Moderate

The god Charon, Ferryman of Hades, is desperate for reading material to keep him company while he awaits new passengers for his boat. Bring him a novel he hasn't read before and you will be rewarded.

Objectives:

Find a novel that Charon hasn't read 0/1

Give book to Charon 0/1

Rewards:

+ 1000 Personal Reputation with Charon, Ferryman of Hades

(+200 reputation for each novel after the first)

Free passage along the rivers of Hades

50 Hades Gold Marks

300 Gold

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose, "Yes." and say "I'll see if I can find something for you."

Frobod asks, "Did you get a quest?"

Looking down at the quest interface of my VT, I say, "Yeah I'll share it." before looking back to Charon and saying "I'll see if anyone in our group can help too."

Frobod has accepted your quest.

LeroyJensen has accepted your quest.

Sajina has accepted your quest.

Pahrem has accepted your quest.

TakoStar has accepted your quest.

Charon smiles and says, "That would be wonderful."

Leroy says, "Just a little over an hour until we check in on Mirae. Why don't we have a look at Duskwallow while we wait?"

Tako asks, "Why don't we just go to the other side?"

Though Leroy opens his mouth to speak, I answer before he makes any sound, "Because if we're lucky Charon can tell us where we're going."

Sajina says, "If we're really really lucky, maybe he'll take us all the way there."

Tako asks, "You think he can do that?"

Pahrem says, "He did say travel was his thing."

"Yeah," I say, "Leroy's right. I'd hate to use our only coins now just to discover he could have taken us right to her."

Tako says, "You could use that messenger guy to tell her to go early."

I say, "For one, that costs gold, and another we have no idea how long it'll take her to get to the nearest landmark. We can afford to wait the hour."

Frobod says, "Besides, we might uncover some more hidden quests if we hang out a bit."

Duskwallow turns out to be a village with a large wooden gate, a pair of watch towers looking down on the path and a crude stockade fence. A sharp voice calls down as we approach.

A man from the right watchtower says, "Who goes there?"

I say, "We're adventurers waiting to cross the river. May we come in?"

There's a long pause. I don't think they'll open the gate when he says, "Do you know who you are?"

I exchange looks with Leroy and then Frobod. "I'm Lord Melpomine of the Toxic Muffins."

Leroy says, "Leroy Jensen of the Malefactors."

"Frobod of the Toxic Muffins."

"Pahrem of the Toxic Muffins."

"Sajina the Bard."

"Tako of the Toxic Muffins."

From the other watch tower, a different voice answers with a note of fear piercing the words. "How do you know?"

The first voice echoes this inquiry. "Yes, how do you know?"

"These are our names." I reply. "They always have been." Another long pause, I can see the first man consulting with another figure beside him. I wish I could tell what they're saying. I repeat. "These are our names."

"Right." says the original watchmen. "Let them through."

The heavy door creaks open.

We enter to a small crowd of men in typical guard armor—a mix of plate, mail, and long swords at the ready. They're all black and grey like the hunter. Their tabards however are a mix-matched bunch of grey shading and insignias I've never seen before. The guy standing closest and to my right as we enter wears a medium-dark color with a black unicorn silhouette, whereas the man beside him is garbed in white with a middle grey tree and tangled roots. Likewise, the hilts of their swords all take different shapes. Some cross guards are simple and straight, others ornate. Some pommels take animal shapes where as others are just round.

Frobod asks, "What's with their gear?"

"I don't know." I say, as a man, this one in very light grey with a honey bee crest reaches for my arm like a beggar.

He says, "Do you know who I am?"

It's the kind of feeling you get when you see something hopeless, but have no power to do anything about it. I don't want to make eye contact, but how can I not now that he's touched me?

"We've never met." I say, and quicken my pace, leaving him behind.

More hands reach out, but fail to make contact. A chorus of male voices echo questions like, "Who am I?" and "Have we met?"

"Creepy." Pahrem says.

Tako asks, "Are you sure this is better than crossing the river right now?"

Now that we've passed the dozen or so guards crowded to meet us, the questions have stopped, and the settlement is more familiar. Cobblestones underfoot make the place feel civilized. Up ahead there's a hanging sign made out of wood featuring a hefty frothing mug, a bowl of soup, and a loaf of bread. There's another wooden sign across the street with a generic depiction of shield and sword.

Leroy says, "The inn's as good a place as any to start."

"Alright." I say, "But remember, no food or drink."

There are a bunch of scattered tables inside, mostly empty, and natural lighting from the large windows on the far wall. A black and white human, like all the other Duskwallow residents, with presumably blonde hair, a small nose, and a barmaid's dress hurries to meet us.

"Imagine, customers at this hour of the morn'. Will it be eggs or oats for you?"

I'm quietly glad that she didn't start with "Who am I?" and check her nameplate Perris. *I'll take that.*

I say, "Just water for now. Do you mind if we sit over by the fireplace?"

"There's plenty of room." She says. "Sit where you like."

"Thanks." I say. "Out of curiosity, does this town have a library?"

Perris says, "Afraid not. We're pretty basic around here. Couple of inns, a blacksmith. Not much else."

"Too bad." I say.

Perris says, "I'll be back with your drinks."

Tako asks, "Why'd you order if we're not supposed to drink?"

"It feels rude not to. I hate taking up space in inns without at least buying something."

Tako huffs noting all the empty tables. "Not like we're stealing business."

I say, "It's the principle." and have a seat on one of the leather couches surrounding the hearth. Over here, it feels more like a hunting lodge than a restaurant due to a pair of large antlers mounted to the wall. Everyone follows my lead except for Sajina who's more at home directly in front of where they build fires. "Didn't you say that guards attack you in this alias?"

Pahrem says, "Maybe that doesn't apply to Hades."

Frobod says, "... or maybe they forgot."

Sajina says, "They do sometimes."

"Well don't worry." I say, "We'll protect you if anyone comes after you. Where's the shadowstalker?"

Sajina says, "Recruited him before bed. I can summon him whenever now."

"Congratulations." I say.

Leroy says, "I feel like any quests we find here are going to take a lot more time than we have. Uncovering the identities of strangers seems like a chain that could last all day."

"I agree." I say, "But I'm glad we stopped instead of just wondering what was here."

Perris returns with a tray and six glasses of water. She sets them on coasters atop a wooden coffee table, and says "You all look familiar, have we met?"

"I don't think so." I say.

Sounding disappointed she says, "I was hoping you could say something about me."

Frobod says, "Your name's Perris."

A hopeful expression crosses her face, "I thought so, but wasn't quite sure. It's what everyone calls me. Are we old friends?"

"No." Frobod says, "I just read..." He pauses, not sure how to explain the user interface to an NPC, "I have a gift with names. I can usually guess them without anyone telling me."

"Oh..." she says, "Well enjoy your water." That's spoken as if she doesn't think water is all that enjoyable, "and call out if you want any oats or eggs."

She leaves us to our discussion.

Pahrem says, "I guess now we know what they meant by Lethe and forgetfulness. Looks like they all drank the oblivion Kool Aid."

Frobod says, "Not too dangerous so far. I wonder if Styx would be any harder."

I say, "I think the real challenges for this entrance were Cerberus and the undead. It just doesn't feel like it because we cleared it without a fight, but really, how many people are gonna come with bard magic in their group?"

Cold steel pricks my neck. All at once Pahrem shouts "Behind you!" Frobod leaps off his couch sending it screeching against the stone floor and crashing his glass of water on the ground, and a slimy male voice growls "Spawn of a cursed elf. Half-bred mongrel."

Jarem hits you for 14 damage.
Resist: Stamina + Endurance.
You resist 14 points of damage.

No damage taken but it prick's enough that I feel a bead of blood rolling down my neck. It's just cosmetic, not enough to bring me closer to death. I pull his arm down with both hands and slam the back of my head into his face. The shock of my blow is enough for him to unhand me, and I jump off the couch, stepping on the coffee table in my effort to place distance between me and my attacker. He's a muscular man in his mid forties with long grey hair and a receding hairline.

"Dude!" Tako says. "What's your problem!"

A look of confusion crosses Jarem's face, as he struggles to find words to explain his actions. It lasts only a moment, because his weathered face twists into a grotesque snarl as he shouts, "Half-blood filth!"

I expect him to charge at us, but instead he flexes his fingers, jerks his arm, and hits Tako with a wall of force that can only be described as telekinesis. Thirty percent of my guild mate's health vanishes in an instant.

Taunt. Successful.
Jarem Attacks.

With his ranged attack on cooldown, the man darts around the sofa and I move to close with him. We're in close quarters, so equipping Bite seems like the wrong idea. It's time to use my unarmed gloves.

Hot Swap (Rank 3) - Success!
You have equipped Fists of the Thunderlord.

Fists of the Thunderlord

Description:

Left is Thunder. Right is Lightning. Don't get caught in the storm.

Quality: Epic

Type: Leather

Slot: Hands

Armor 1

Equipped Bonus:

Dexterity +2, Strength +1, Stamina+1

Special Properties:

(Right Hand Only)

Unarmed attacks inflict +4 Lightning Damage.

(Left Hand Only)

Unarmed attacks inflict +4 Sonic Damage

(Left Hand Only):

33% chance on hit to deafen your opponent for 20 seconds. Effects are cumulative.

Bonus damage ignores armor.

I duck out of the way of his incoming dagger. Only Tako reacts fast enough for an attack with a weapon, which he does by shadows stepping behind Jarem and sticking him with his dagger. It's not lost on me that neither his nose, nor the wound from Tako's knife bleeds. Frobod hits him with a blast of necro magic which flies through the air like a giant black sperm swimming in a cloud of black death energy.

Those two attacks paired with my head butt have dropped him down to eighty percent health. *Not as tough as I thought.* Now it's my turn as I move in with a flurry of jabs, and then a massive uppercut that lands square in his jaw. Lightning sparks from my right hand, and windows rattle in their panes as soon as I land a thunderous blow with the left.

There's too much furniture for Leroy to get into melee range, so he calls out "Astraea smite thee!" and lands a blast of holy flame dead center in Jarem's chest. Jarem health: 50%.

He comes in for another strike with his blade, but I drop down long before he can connect. I plant my hands on the cold floor and bring my leg around for a Dragon Tail Sweep. At first I'm afraid I won't get the knock down, but at the same time that my leg goes under him Leroy hits with another smite. The combination of the two attacks in unison sends him sprawling on the floor.

I'm now back up on my feet. Tako kicks him in the ribs. Before he can regain his feet I come it with a quick boot, not to kick, but to press against his throat. He's now down to thirty percent.

I say, "Let me reiterate what my companion said. What the hell is your problem?"

Jahrem stammers, "I... I... I don't know. I didn't know until I saw you and your long ears. Do you know who I am?"

Frobod says, "Know what, asshole?"

"I..." He starts, sounding confused. His expression is innocent, like an old man with dementia trying to figure out where he is. Then his voice hardens into something crisp and vile. His mouth warps into a rictus of murderous fury as he bellows "ALL ELVES MUST DIE!"

I feel the rattle of his breath through my foot, as cold clammy fingers creep under my pant leg and touch my skin. All of a sudden I feel like I've been hit by half a dozen blows at the same time. My nose throbs and begins to bleed. A double lance of pain explodes in my chest, and a sharp pain sinks in the fleshy part of my back beneath my ribs.

"Ugghh!" I gasp, and topple to the floor, not having expected so many varieties of stinging to strike all at once. Jahrem health: 100%. *What? No roll to resist damage?* It's like he transferred all his wounds into me. With just a touch, I'm now down to thirty percent.

Luckily, Pahrem's fast on the heal, and a golden halo surrounds me.

Pahrem heals you for 3 points of damage.

Pahrem heals you for 1 point of damage.

Pahrem heals you for 2 points of damage.

I'm up to ninety as I stumble to my feet, and shout "No contact once he takes damage!" Jahrem's already up and facing Tako. I kick him in the back with a bright flash from my enchanted boots and say "Hey, Jackass. Over here!"

Taunt. Successful.

Jahrem Attacks.

He whirls, I slip out of the way of his incoming strike and bolt the opposite direction. "Time to kite!" I say, as Tako throws one of his weighted blades, and Frobod launches another bolt of death magic.

I leap over the back of one of the sofas as I hear Perris shout, "Jahrem! What's got into you?"

He snarls in response, "The filthy half-bloods must die!" He twitches his fingers again, jerks his arm, and smashes me with a telekinetic blow that sends

me hurtling through the window. Bits of glass make harsh music as they skitter on the cobblestones.

My health drops, but Pahrem has me topped back up before I can gage the percent lost. I can't see the others now due to being outside, but the flashes of light and dark magic tell me that they are taking my ranged attack calls to heart.

Jahrem Health: 40%.

I flick my Darksteel Chakram through the broken window at him at the same time as Leroy calls "Astraea smite thee!" He lights up under a lance of holy fire. Jahrem health 20%.

A new Darksteel Chakram reappears in my hand to take the place of the old one. I toss it. Frodo launches another necro bolt. The magic hits, and then my thrown weapon lops off the ghost's head. *No blood, because the dead don't bleed.*

Instead of climbing back through the window, I circle around and re-enter the front door looking sheepish. I say, "Sorry about your window."

Perris says, "I saw everything, he attacked you! I don't know what's got into him."

I ask, "Did you see him come in? I thought the place was empty when we arrived."

She shrugs, "Must have been using a spell. One minute you were on the couch, and the next he was behind you."

I look to my crew, "Is everyone okay?"

Pahrem says, "After Tako, you were the only one to take damage."

Sajina says, "I guess it's a good thing I'm not in my elf skin?"

I laugh. The comment strikes me as so mundane after being attacked in what I thought was a safe zone that I can't help it. As I head back over I say, "Yes, very."

Frodo says, "I don't think he even knew why he was attacking. It was like he was two people trapped in the same body. One just a guy, the other a racist asshole."

Tako hefts a brown sack from where he fell. "Four Hades marks, and a common dagger."

I say, "Keep the dagger if you want, just hold the marks, and we can divide them up later."

Leroy says, "I say we get out of here. We might miss our window if we get pulled into another fight."

I pay Perris for our drinks plus a little extra for the commotion. We're now back in the street, and heading for the front gate. The guard with the tree on his tabard asks, "Do you know me?" as he pushes the gate open.

I say, "I'm sorry, I don't." as we move back outside. About fifty feet from the gate I call out "INFERNO!" and "Let's ride." to summon our mounts.

No one says anything until we can see Charon's dock. I can't tell if it's because they're bored, or if it's because a village full of people who don't know who they are and might become murderous at any moment was too unsettling. I for one half expect to see Jahrem respawned, and howling at us like a maniac running down the dirt path. Whatever the reason, the wind in my ears is all I hear until we touch down on the beach.

I break the quiet by looking to Pahrem and saying, "How's your manna? Are you ready to scry?" *Of course she is. What kind of healer runs out of manna on one mob?*

"I'm ready. "She says, and gets off her bike. I make the "bloop bloop" sounds to dismiss it, and everyone else's as they dismount. Pahrem says, "Just give me a sec to set up."

At the tail end of 7:59 AM our goblin begins casting, dripping green magic, and exhaling into her bowl. the water ripples under her breath as an image begins to take form... not one figure but two. *Sten!* A big eyed, half-goblin boy sits on a flight of steps beside her. She ruffles his hair affectionately. I'm glad to see that they're in full color, unlike the Duskwallow wraiths, and seem to look healthy.

I say, "I didn't think we'd see him again."

Pahrem asks, "Who's the kid?"

Frobod answers, "One of the people at Dragonswood Keep who didn't survive Cimmerian's attack."

Leroy asks, "He an NPC?"

I say, "Yeah... Looks like the engine is populating the underworld with both players and dead Havenfolk in addition to whatever it generated for the initial population."

"Huh..." He says. "Don't know what to make of that."

I gesture to the surrounding structure within the bowl and say "I think I know that place. "

"What do you mean?" Leroy says.

I say, "Pahrem, can you zoom out?"

She nods, and makes a motion with her knobby long fingered hand.

"Well shit." Tako says. "Even I know that place."

"Durolan bank." Frobod says.

I say, "Think there's a copy of the whole city in Hades?"

Leroy says, "Looks like it. What's she doing?"

Mirae fishes into her bag, and unfurls a cloth sign with a simple hand painted message written on it. I say, "Try to zoom in so we can see what it says."

It reads:

"High Hades

Durolan Necropolis

Fire and Soul

Every Night 7:00

Miss you. 

She also makes a heart shape with two hands by curling her fingers so her nails touch while pressing the pads of her thumbs together so they make a point. It feels very anime.

Frobod says, "It looks like she gave us an address."

"Yeah..." I say mystified. "It's even better than I could have hoped."

"Who would have known that there'd be addresses in the afterlife?"

Leroy chuckles and says, "I wonder if they have spectral postal workers, and dead milkmen."

It's been almost a minute now, and Mirae's image begins to fade.

I say, "This is good and bad news. If 'Necropolis Durolan' is as far away from here as the real world Durolan was from the entrance, we've got a long way to go without a portal."

Tako says, "Maybe they have portals in the underworld."

"In any case," I say while giving Charon a look from our spot on the beach. He bites into an apple, and turns a page in his book, still perched on his piling. "I think we're done on this side of the river. Agreed?"

The men in the group answer together, "Agreed."

As soon as our boots clunk on the dock Charon looks up with a happily sad expression. "I suppose it's too much to hope you've found a new book already."

"No library in Duskwallow." I say.

"Ahh well," Charon begins. "How did you like it?"

"Eerie." Pahrem says. "They don't know who they are or nothin'. Some whack job attacked us and didn't even know why."

Charon says, "That's the River Lethe for you. Some of them have been drinking from it a very long time." He pauses, "Do you know where we're going?"

Leroy says, reciting Mirae's message almost exactly, "High Hades, Necropolis Durolan, Fire and Soul."

Charon considers in a ponderous voice. "I suppose I could take you to the nearest bank for a thousand five hundred Hades Gold Marks each. One two thousand if you need a guide to the city. Add an extra hundred for that specific tavern."

Tako's jaw drops, aghast. "No way! That's highway robbery!"

The ferryman says, "It's quite a distance." Seeming to have guessed that we don't have anywhere near that kind of money he asks, "How many marks do you have?"

"... six." I say, a bit embarrassed by the small number.

"Make that ten." Tako says, "You forgot about the drop in Duskwallow."

"Ten..." I correct.

Charon gives us a wan smile. "I can take you to the far bank for one mark a piece. From there I can mark your maps with the nearest towns, and a dungeon where you can earn more coin."

Sajina asks, "They aren't going to be crazy like the Lethekin are they?"

"No more or less than anyone." Charon says.

"To the other side then." I say.

The water's so still while we're crossing that it's like floating in a pool. We can feel every stir of Charon's great oar as he sculls us across the surface. Now there's mist everywhere I can't see the land, behind or what's in the boat. Everything's bright like the sun wants to break it up, but... *Where are we going?* There are seven people in the boat with me, and they seem familiar but.... I can't place who they are. They feel more like silhouettes I've seen countless times before, but can't seem to place.

I touch the arm of the big male one sitting beside me and ask. "Do you know where we're going?"

"I'm... Not sure." He says in a baffled voice and asks. "Where did we come from?"

"I'm not sure..." I say. "You seem so familiar, but I can't place it. Like, maybe someone from school."

"Oh." He says, "I was about to ask you the same thing. Where'd you go to school?" He asks.

"Uhhmm... Something with a W I think. University of.. Wisconsin maybe?" The oar swishes back and fourth faster. The light seems brighter, the fog is breaking up. "Washington!" I shout. "I went to the University of Washington."

It's only then that I realize I'm touching Frobod's arm.

"Weird..." Frobod says. "For a second there it felt like I didn't know you."

Tako says, "Are we almost to the other side?" There's a tension in his voice that hadn't been there when we left. Already, the moments of before are fading like a dream, the kind when you wake up and for the first minute you're awake, you're forced you to acclimate to where you are.

Leroy says, "I wouldn't want to get stuck in there." Referring to the fog. "It's like a souped up confuse spell."

"Damn..." I say. "I hate when the game does that. I'm okay with it hijacking my brain to add stimulation, but I don't like thinking about it blocking my access to memories." My skin grows cold. "If someone really wanted, I'll bet they could make software to make us forget we had bodies to go back to."

Frobod says, "Let's just be grateful that those Archangel fucks haven't thought of, or aren't interested in that."

Pahrem who had been seated at the bow directly behind the big skeletal hand says, "Tell me about it."

The fog's completely gone now, and we're approaching a new dock, identical to the one we left. This shore line is a bit rockier, but every bit as peaceful. There's a small thump as the boat bumps against a piling. and Charon hops off with a line in hand which he ties off. The whole vessel wobbles when he leaves the boat.

He extends a hand that's surprisingly muscular to help me off. "Watch your step. You wouldn't want to fall in this river."



Chapter 10 - Ashe March

Charon touches each of our maps leaving red circles around the closest settlements and a sword on top of a place called Ashfall Crypt. *Why would there be a crypt in Hades?*

Leroy says, "Let's head to town first. We may get quests to earn more marks from the dungeon."

Frobod says, "The closest one is..." he trails while examining his map. "Ashe March. Looks like one road to get there."

Unfortunately that's all we know. The road could lead us through a war zone. As soon as Charon marked the locations on our map, the names of the towns and roads appeared, but no additional information about the surrounding terrain. The map will only show additional landmarks if we physically travel through the area for ourselves, or someone else, like Charon, populates it for us.

I say "Mount up." and summon all the bikes.

I'm relieved to say that this side of the river's more developed. No more wading through tall grass waiting for monsters that never come to jump out at us. We're flying over a road that's an actual road. Hard packed dirt wide enough for three automobiles, with wooden signs at forks and crossings. The main difference between here and the land of the living is that everything here feels still and quiet. I've yet to feel a breeze.

What's the point of the afterlife if it's so much like being alive? I feel like I'll have that answer sooner than later.

The trip to Ashe March is uneventful. We see a few ghostly travelers on foot, but don't stop to talk. The farther we journey from the River Lethe the more color they have in their appearance. I can almost see someone turning a dial to control the color saturation of their clothes and bodies.

Tako says, "Town up ahead."

Leroy looks down at his map from the back of his Phoenix and says, "This looks like it."

It's nice not to have to ask permission to enter this city. Since Dragonswood, it seems like every town we've encountered has been like passing through immigration at an international airport. Who goes there? What's your business? ... and so on.

The guards here, helmetless and wearing uniform tabards with a large red crosses that also kind of looks like stars. They wave to us as we pass and say

"Welcome. Welcome to civilization beyond the River Lethe." The man closest to us has short brown hair parted to the left, and a close cropped Fu Manchu beard. *We must not be the first visitors.*

Frobod asks, "What makes you think we're coming from the river?"

The guard, named Hector, laughs, "No one comes from the South except hunters and newcomers." He eyes Frobod's plate up and down. "You are no hunter. Him or her maybe." He indicates me and Tako wearing leather. "But not the others." His eyes rest a long time on Sajina.

I ask, "Is there a problem?"

The guard says, "Not in Hades. You'll see far stranger here."

"So why are you staring?"

The guard responds, "Just trying to figure out what he does."

I say, "Oh. He's our bard. That reminds me..." I pull out my VT and scroll through my inventory until I find the Lyre of Cerberus. "Deal's a deal. This belongs to you."

The gargoyle takes the harp in both hands with an expression full of reverence. "I've never held anything like this."

"Start adventuring." I say, "You'll get more drops."

"Yeah but..." The gargoyle starts. "Plus five performance. That's huge."

"Putting monsters to sleep in combat doesn't hurt either." Tako says.

Leroy says, "Congrats man." and then turns back to Hector. "We're trying to earn Hades Marks for transportation. Do you have any suggestions?"

"Where are you going?" Hector asks.

Leroy answers, "Durolan Necropolis. High Hades."

"You're in High Hades now, but Durolan is quite far. Your best bet is either seeing Charon, or catching a ride on the Shroudmoon Express. Starts in Low Hades, but they've laid track all the way up the coast now."

"Shroudmoon express, is that a train?" I ask.

"It is!" He says, "The wonders never cease. They say it comes from another world. I'm surprised you know what it is."

I look to Frobod, then back to Hector and say, "He and I have a little experience exploring other worlds. How can we get tickets?"

Hector says, "You can buy them in town but it's a bit of a wait. You're best booking a few weeks out."

"So long?" I ask.

Hector says, "There's only one train and it's quite popular." I can already feel myself deflating. "I wouldn't normally suggest this for commoner, villagers and the like, but you look like you can take care of yourselves. Your best bet for fast money is going to be the Adventurers Hall. You'll find a list of job openings and compensation for completion."

Tako says, "They actually made an Adventurers Hall? Like... That's the name of the building?"

Hector says, "Sure is! A lot of new souls are going to need money."

Leroy says, "We should start there."

Frobod says, "I smell quests."

I say, "Thank you, Hector. You've been really helpful."

He smiles and replies, "It's all in a day's work."

Leroy says, "Do you mind marking the Adventurers Hall on our map? Maybe also a blacksmith in case anyone needs to make repairs?"

Hector agrees, and marks all our maps.

Ashe March has a well maintained, rustic charm. Most buildings are wood with white side paneling, and the roofs are thatched though a few of the wealthier establishments have proper red or blue tiling. The city has multiple blacksmiths and armorers, but a close cluster of red marks indicates two have set up shop beside our primary destination.

Hunger stirs, so I fish out a few strips of Pehrom's jerky.

Frobod says, "We turn at the next street and the hall should be right in front of us."

He's not wrong. As soon as we round the corner a giant building in the stile of a log cabin towers over us. Unlike most of the one or two story structures, the Adventurers' Hall as a flight of steps rising upward, and three stories on top of that. A set of double doors at the top of the stone steps stand invitingly open.

I say, "Repair your stuff if you want. I'm going in."

Leroy says, "I'll go with you."

Most of the group scatters to check out the merchant's wares, except Sajina who takes a seat on the steps. "I'll wait for you here."

"Everything okay?" I ask

"Yeah..." He says. "I just don't think I'll be helpful in there, so I'd rather rest."

"Up to you." Leroy says.

I say, "Let's go."

The hollow thumping of feet on hard wooden floors inside tells me the Hall has a basement. There's a counter much like a hotel reception desk, and there are a few tables and benches, as I pass one I see the surface is painted with a map of the area. *Still no people...*

I call, "Hello?" not sure if I'll get an answer, but then a small bespectacled head pops up from behind the desk. No facial hair, and an unfortunate comb over that makes me think, "Buddy, you're not fooling anyone."

"Just a minute!" The man says in a slightly nasal voice. A chair scoots on the floorboards, the head disappears, and a little gnome in a gaudy Thanksgiving colored sweater waddles around the counter. He's got a big ass for his small flabby body, that makes me wonder if he's ever actually been on an adventure.

I ask, "Is this the Adventurers' Hall?"

"It is, it is!" he says, "... and you must be..."

There's a jolly leading tone in his voice, so I clap my hands and overact my enthusiasm, "Adventurers!"

He laughs. "Among the first!"

I say, "There were others here before us?" finding it hard to believe that anyone could have passed us without us knowing.

"A few..." he begins, "... but not like you. There's something of life still in you."

"So the others were dead." Leroy says.

That makes sense. Digitizers.

"Yes." The gnome says. "A few fallen heroes. I'm Milnus, the owner of this hall. How may I help you."

Leroy says, "We need to make money to pay for travel. The man at the gate said you could help with that."

"I see..." he muses. "Well, the public bulletin is over here." He leads us to the wall opposite the entrance which has a great many paper leaflets posted on it. "Browse these, find a suitable job and bring the listing back to me, or whoever's tending the desk. I've already been paid by the employer so once it's done you'll be paid immediately."

Leroy says, "That sounds good." as he begins examining the notes.

Milnus asks, "If I may ask, where are you going?"

I say, "Durolan Necropolis."

"I see... I think..." He begins moving back to the counter. "Just a moment." He disappears behind the desk, there's that scraping sound of a chair or stool on hard wood, and he returns with a box of note cards. He says, "Please sit." As he puts the box on a table like it's a top shelf, and pulls himself up on a human sized chair. We grab a couple of seats at the same table.

"What's in the box?" I ask.

Milnus says, "These are jobs for adventurers that have proven themselves. Important clients I wouldn't want to let down. They are non-public listings." He pulls a card and places it face down on the table, then another. "Have a look at these."

He pushes them toward us.

Quest - Netherwright Trading Company

Difficulty: Challenging

Duration: 3 Weeks

Join a Netherwright caravan as they travel north to Athelon necropolis, and serve as their guardian along the way.

Objectives:

Caravan safely reaches Athelon necropolis 0/1

Goods received in full 0/1

Rewards:

+3000 Reputation with Ashe March Adventurers' Hall

250 Hades Gold Marks

7000 Gold

Ineligible.

You must have a friendly reputation with Ashe March Adventurer's Hall to accept this quest.

Three weeks? I'm not liking the sound of that one so I check the other.

Quest - Shroudmoon Express - Cabin Security

Difficulty: Challenging

Duration: 2 Days

The Shroudmoon Express needs professionals to maintain the peace between traveling guests, and put down any monsters, bandits, or other undesirable entities that attempt to board in transit.

Objectives:

Ride the Shroudmoon Express to Athelon necropolis from Coldwash 0/1

Passengers arrive safely 0/1

Rewards:

+500 Reputation with Ashe March Adventurers' Hall

200 Hades Gold Marks

500 Gold

Ineligible.

You must have a friendly reputation with Ashe March Adventurer's Hall to accept this quest.

"This one. " I say tapping the job for the Shroudmoon Express.

Leroy nods. "Is that payment per person or per party?"

"Compensation is awarded for each person who participates. However,"

Milnus says. "Fine adventurers as I'm sure you are, I don't know you well enough to trust you with this work. These are prestigious clients. Prove yourself by completing a task or two on the public board, and I think we can work something out."

Leroy looks to me and says, "Rep grind." in a quiet voice.

I nod in acknowledgement and say, "You wouldn't happen to have anything up there that involves dragons would you?" sounding hopeful.

Milnus scoffs sounding incredulous, "On the public board? Not likely. We save the most advanced jobs for the private listings."

"Had to ask." I say. "Our guild has a thing about dragons."

The gnome says, "You're welcome to browse the listings to see what you can find."

We've been going over the board for twenty minutes when Tako, Frobod, and Pahrem enter together.

Tako says, "Anything interesting?"

"Yeah." I say. "It's basically like a wanted ads host for quests."

Leroy says, "We can do a bunch of small ones, or one big one to take us up to friendly status."

Pahrem asks, "Why do we need friendly status?"

I say, "There's a special job for security aboard the Shroudmoon Express, but we need at least Friendly status to take it."

"Hence the rep grind." Leroy says, and then passes me a note. "I like this one. +1000 rep, zero to friendly in one go."

I have a gander.

Quest - Missing Hunter - In Death We Are Parted

Difficulty: Challenging

Duration: N/A

The mortal hunter Zan recently arrived to Hades from Haven in search of his wife, Marcy. Shortly after finding her, he went missing; last seen in the vicinity of Ashfall Pass.

Discover Zan's fate and bring news back to his wife. If he is alive, escort him home. If not, present Marcy with a token of his death so she can summon him from wherever his spirit may be.

WARNING: Vampires and were creatures have been spotted in this area.

Objectives:

Discover the fate of Zan 0/1

Return to Marcy with Zan or a token of his defeat 0/1

Rewards:

+1000 Reputation with Ashe March Adventurers' Hall

75 Hades Gold Marks

300 Gold

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes and say, "I was warned that Vampires in Hades will be different from Haven or the Freeworld."

Quest provisionally accepted. No other parties may accept this quest. Visit the desk of the Adventurers' Hall within two hours to complete acceptance. Failure to do so within the allotted time will result in cancellation of this quest.

"How so?" Leroy asks.

I say, "Apparently they're likely to be going insane from starvation unless they brought a huge blood supply."

Frobod asks, "So they aren't ghosts?"

"I don't think so." I say. "If you remember the announcement when this part of the world opened, undead and 'undying' characters can enter Hades and leave Hades freely. I guess that means Cerberus won't attack."

Leroy says, "They'll probably be more like zombies then... driven exclusively by hunger."

I say, "That's what I was thinking too. So, what do you say? Are all of you good with this quest?"

"Works for me." Frobod says.

Tako says, "Whatever gets us to Mirae faster."

Leroy says to Tako, "That's why I chose it. It's just one quest to get the rep we need to ride the train."

"Then let's do it." Tako says. "How do we get started?"

I take the paper in hand and walk back over to the counter. Milnus is sitting in his chair behind the desk. I pass it to him between two fingers, and say "We'll do this one. There's six of us. Names: Melpomine, TakoStar, Frobod, Pahrem, Sajina, and LeroyJensen."

The status of quest: Missing Hunter - In Death We Are Parted, has been changed from "Provisionally Accepted" to "Accepted."

I guess we won't have to worry about other groups stealing quest items.

"Alright.." He says, writing down each name in turn. "If you want the Shroudmoon Express job, you'd better be back before tomorrow night. At the very latest the next morning. The train leaves at six PM and you'll have to ride some hours to get to it."

"Got it." I say, "Time is of the essence." I hesitate. "Does Marcy have anything of Zan's that we could use to locate him? I know a spell that might speed things up, but it usually requires something the target handled."

"I'm not sure." Milnus says, and writes something on a piece of paper. "Go see her at this address and I'm sure she'll answer all your questions. She's quite worried as you can imagine."

"Can you mark it on our maps?" I ask.

"Sure." He says.

Marcy lives in a cottage outside the trade district. It matches the rest of the city with its thatched roof and dark wooden struts. It's one story, with circular wood trimmed port hole windows, and a cute red door. I knock three times.

A few seconds pass before it opens revealing a brunette woman with slightly pointed ears like my own. *Aside from the gnome, she's the first non-human I've noticed.* I ask, "Are you Marcy?"

She answers "Yes." in a slightly high sweet voice that I'm sure her husband adores. Her eyes flicker from me, to Leroy and Frobod, then to the less armored members of the party. "You look like adventurers. Are you here about Zan?"

"Yes..." I say.

Her body language relaxes and a relieved expression crosses her face. Being dressed in a basic dress—earth tones and a simple silhouette—she doesn't strike me as someone who has interacted with many adventurers clad head to toe in magical gear. I can't see the inside of the cottage, but I imagine it's simple yet tidy like the woman herself.

Leroy adds, "We hope to find him within the next day, two at most."

She eyes Sajina in the back, and says "I'd ask you all to come in but I'm not sure you'd fit. Why don't we discuss around back in the garden, and help yourself to some Lemonade."

Tako looks pleased by the offer of something to drink, so I quickly add, "That won't be necessary. We've just had a big breakfast."

Little White Lies.

Manipulation + Subterfuge. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 3)

"Trust me."

Subterfuge skill increased by 1. Current level: 4

She says, "Alright then. Go ahead and walk around back. I'll meet you there."

As soon as the door closes, I shake my canteen at Tako. "It wouldn't be nice to rescue Mirae only to discover that you took her place because you got thirsty."

"Damn." He says, embarrassed. "I forgot. You'd think it'd give us a prompt or something if we were about to bind to Hades."

I say, "You're probably right, but I'd rather not risk it."

We begin walking around the outside of the little building when Leroy asks, "What spell were you thinking?"

"The one from the wererat I told you about. I'm kind of curious what happens if I switch to a Freeworld Alias down here."

Frobod says, "I thought you didn't like playing that character."

"I don't... kinda... It's kinda like the mist how the game warps your perception of things. They force you to feel things but, like... psychological conditioning based on the sensations in your body's perception of the environment that makes you downright irritable if not outright angry. It's why I never advanced any of my mammal weres. They all have this in common."

"I'll take your word on it." Frobod says, "Freeworld gaming sounds intense."

"It is, but then so is Haven. It's just intense in different ways."

Marcy's waiting for us out back where she has a round table large enough to seat two people. *Looks like we'll be standing.*

She says, "I'm so glad that you're confident. There haven't been many adventurers in Hades yet."

Leroy says, "We'll find him. We just need a bit more information. For one, am I to understand that he's still living?"

Marcy says, adding a sad exasperated sigh, "Damn fool. We're long lived. I'd have wanted him to move on without me. Do some mourning, but find a new wife so he could live fully in Haven. Who am I to take that from him?"

I ask, "So he's an elf, or some other long lived race?"

Marcy says, "He's like you, me... and that one over there." She notes Tako to the side.

"Understood." I say, "If your age is any indication, he could have had another seventy on up to a hundred more years in the living world."

"I know." she says, "That's why he's a damned fool for coming here." She adds sadly, "But I still love him."

"Do you mind if I ask how he got here?" I say, "Finding the gate and passing Cerberus isn't easy."

"Tells me he took a train!" She says, "The Shroudmoon Express of all things. Everyone knows there are no stops in Haven, but that's his story and he's sticking to it. Good Haven men coming across a train, wouldn't know what they were looking at."

"That's interesting," Frobod says, "But not very helpful in terms of finding his current location. Do you have his portrait, or perhaps something that belongs to him? Mel says she knows a spell that could help us find him faster."

"A portrait?" She considers, "No. Haven't been dead that long and haven't had money for such a commission."

I ask, "Something that belonged to him then? You said he was a hunter in the listing. Perhaps a spare bow or one of his arrows? Even a pillow would do if he slept on it."

"Just a moment." She says, turning back to the cottage. The rear door, unlike the front, is painted white. "I may have something that will work."

She disappears into her home, leaving us all surrounded by the plants in her garden. The heads of yellow red, and purple peaking through patches of green are all too nice, serene and calming. The scent is of a fine day, and a fresh perfume. I wonder if Marcy has a green thumb, or if this is just an NPC's version of heaven.

She returns with the shaft of an arrow in one hand, and an arrowhead in another. "Zan said the shaft wasn't straight and there was some kind of problem with this arrowhead. Will either of these help?"

I say, "The arrowhead would work best if you don't mind me making off with it."

Marcy says, "Take it if it'll help you find my husband."

Leroy asks, "Can you give us any information about why he went to such a dangerous area?"

Marcy sighs, "Pride I guess, Said he wanted to bring home the biggest kill he ever made to celebrate finding me here. I just hope he's okay. If he's still alive bring him back, but if not... I need something of his death so a priestess can call his spirit."

"Alright." I say, "We'll see what we can do."



Chapter 11 - Rage

We spend a few minutes repairing our gear in town and consuming rations so that we're alert and don't have to worry about anything breaking on us. After that, we're back on the road flying over the hard packed dirt that will lead us to Ashfall Forest, wherein Ashfall Pass is located.

Frobod says, "This quest is taking us pretty close to the Dungeon Charon marked for us."

"Zan might be inside." I say.

"Probably." Leroy confirms. "That's how these things usually work."

Having not fought any I ask, "What are Vampires like in Haven?"

"What do you mean?" Frobod asks. "You can't play them, so they're just mobs you can kill."

"Do they have any weaknesses?" I ask.

Leroy says, "Sunlight's the big one since they never come out during the day. They have a liquid diet, and tend to be pretty good at mind magic. You can also kill them with a stake through the heart, but that's usually not an option if their wearing armor."

I say, "In Freeworld, Fire's their weakness. The stick in the chest thing doesn't work, it'll just paralyze them. They also have a problem with were claws, but those hurt everything."

Leroy says, "I guess we won't know what we're facing until the first engagement."

I point to a smaller path forking off the main road, with a sign that reads "Ashfall Forest." I say, "Here's our stop." and bring the elechopper down. "We should go on foot just in case there are clues."

Leroy asks, "You want to do your spell thing?"

"Head into the forest first and see if it's necessary. I'd rather stay as Melpomine if it's at all possible."

"Up to you." Leroy says. "Weapons out, gear up. Cast your buffs."

I equip Bite but go through the motions to cast Move like Water, Enhanced Dexterity, and Enhanced vitality. A whistling wind sound surrounds me paired with a steady thump-bump, thump-bump when the last two buffs take hold. Tako has his daggers, and Frobod hefts his greatsword. Sajina, he's lingering in the back with his new harp. He plays a few notes to give us all the inspired buff.

I say, "Sajina and Pahrem stick together. Let's do this."

As soon as we set foot in Ashfall Forest, everything feels gloomy. It's still mid-day but the dense canopy gives the place eternal shade. It's also quiet like everything else in this world. Less rustling than Dragonswood, and our plate wearer's clunks are ever louder for it.

Tako says, "There's gotta be some game here, or that Zan guy wouldn't have come hunting."

I say, "That or he was as big a noob as the rest of us and didn't know better. Do animals have souls?"

To answer my question a "Thwap!" sounds from somewhere in the brush, and something moving so fast I can't see zings right over my shoulder. It disappears in the understory. I stand still, readying myself for an attack but none comes. If an archer wants to kill us, we're easy prey.

We're standing so still that even heavy armor fails to make sound. Tako says, "I think something glitched."

I say, "Keep moving and be on guard. This place just became unfriendly."

Three paces later, an arrow ricochets off Leroy's breastplate. We still can't see our attackers.

"Turn back mortals." a male voice says. "You're kind is unwelcome here."

I say, "Come out and face us!"

A skinny human man appears on the path before us, having dispelled a concealment or invisibility spell. His nameplate says Andrew. *Normal name for a place like this.* He's wrapped in brown monk's robes like he just left a Dojo. "Turn back." he says in a measured voice. "It's nothing personal. We can't allow you to feed the undead."

"We're looking for someone who came through here. A Half-elf like us..." I indicate Tako. "Dark hair. Male. Have you seen him? He probably had a bow."

"We captured someone like that a few days ago, but he escaped."

Leroy says, "Was his name Zan?"

"Yes." Andrew says. "Now leave."

Leroy says, "That's not going to work for us. See, Zan's got a wife in the village that's worried sick about him and we told her we'd bring him back."

Andrew hisses "Don't test me." in a voice that sounds a bleeding heartbeat from exploding into violence.

Leroy says, "We know what we're doing. I for one have been killing undead for years. Just let us go find our man, and we'll be out of your hair. No harm, no foul."

Andrew roars, "I SAID LEAVE!" as his whole body contorts, sending his limbs convulsing at unnatural angles. His arms hands, and face grow a lot furrer as he becomes taller. A hairless tail sprouts from beneath his robes. His round head elongates into a pointy rat face and lengthy whiskers sprout from either side of his twitching nose. He's unarmed, but ugly wicked claws tip each of his fingers.

"Wererat!" Tako calls.

Andrew bolts in to give Leroy a powerful claw with his bare hand. Wererat nails screech against metal armor leaving a quad rip of deep grooves.

"That's a hell of a rat!" Leroy says, surprised at the dent in his armor.

Tako says, "So is this the Haven or Freeworld kind?" and then shadow steps behind our attacker.

I say, "I don't know yet, he's not talking. We'll know if he tries to communicate." I then make a kissing sound, and spin Bite. "Over here!"

Taunt. Successful.
Andrew attacks.

I'm expecting Andrew's next attack and slip out of the way, but just barely. The wererats I know have a ton of dex. I call out, "Sajina! Harp! No one hit him. If this is a Freerat," I make up the neologism on the spot for Freeworld wererats. "I'm going to keep dodging until he burns up all his anger. If this is the Haven kind... We'll deal with him when he wakes up... or not."

I duck beneath another claw, and then slap an incoming hand away with Bite. Electricity crawls over his body. *Crap! I didn't mean to do that. The backlash of muscle memory.* The wererat shrieks in rage in response to my parry.

"Hurry up Sajina!" A quieter part of my mind recognizes that he's playing music, but it's hard to make out in all the commotion of combat.

Andrew comes in with another pair of quick claw attacks, one from each hand. I weave out of the way of the first, but the second knocks a level off my flow like water defense. I duck under his arm when he makes a swing for my face.

Frobod asks, "You sure you don't want us to engage?"

I say, "Yes!" as I side step another blow.

Andrew raises a hand for another strike, I'm ready to dodge, but his movement grows sluggish mid swing, and his arm falls to his side. The wererat's eyes lose focus, and he stumbles as if drunk, going down on one knee. A moment later, he's face down in the dirt, snoring like a combustion engine. Sajina halts his song.

"Now what?" Frobod asks.

I say, "We're still surrounded. So..."

I pull out my VT and scroll through the aliases menu listing all the characters Jordan and I built up over the years of playing Freeworld and Haven Online. I find the name I'm looking for—"Lilly" spelled with a capital i in place of a lower case L since the proper spelling of the name was already taken at the time of character creation. I receive a prompt I haven't seen before when I select that name.

Alias:
Lilly
Magical - Human (Wererat - Rodekin) - Female
Rank: Perfect (Grandfathered)

Options:
Change Alias
Infect Current
Cancel

Curious about the new choice, I tap on "Infect Current."

WARNING: Choosing this option will infect the current alias: Melpomine with the nativity pestilence. If magically cured before it runs its course, Melpomine will become immune to the pestilence. If the Melpomine alias survives the pestilence for one day, it will gain the subrace: Rodekin. These changes can only be undone via rebirth.

Do you wish to proceed? Yes / No

I tap the surface of my VT in an emphatic no. Unlike most shifters which are born to were creature parents, Freeworld wererats, otherwise known as Rodekin, are either born of Rodekin mothers and fathers, or being a normal human and surviving what is called the nativity pestilence. If you're a an adventurer it inflicts a crap ton of debuffs, but changes you into a wererat if you survive by resisting it's effects with your stamina. Looking to the future of the game, it's likely the only way the Haven races can become one.

Alias:

Lilly

Magical - Human (Wererat - Rodekin) - Female

Rank: Perfect (Grandfathered)

Options:

Change Alias

Infect Current

Cancel

I choose "Change Alias."

Do you wish to assume the Lilly identity?

Yes / No

I pick yes. It's been so long since I've played this character that I don't even remember what she was wearing. Rainbow colored streamers of magic light wrap me like a mummy, before pulsing a psychedelic glow, and fading. As it turns out, it's a pair of bell bottom jeans, a yellow and pink tie-dye tank top, and a pair of pink oversized heart shaped sun glasses.

Tako stares at me in stunned silence, before clearing his throat and saying "Holy disco Batman. We're going to funky town."

"Shit..." I say, it's all social clothes without any stats. I pull up my gear menu, and fast equip everything I'd been wearing as Melpomine. The tie-dye disappears,

Frobod says, "I don't know why, but it's weird seeing you as a brunette human."

"You've got bangs." Pahrem says.

I check my stats to make sure everything is as I remember. Same primary stats. Plus the ability to shape change into the following forms.

Nezumi (Rat Form)

Adjustments:

Strength: -80%

Dexterity: +60%

Stamina: -40%

Perception: +50%

Appearance: N/A

War Form (Anthropomorph)

Strength: +5%

Dexterity: +20%

Stamina: +10%

Appearance: -80%

+2 Unarmed Damage

Rattadon (Giant Rat - Size: Pony)

Strength: +10%

Dexterity: +15%

Stamina: +20%

Appearance: N/A

There are also a pair of new traits right under my name before all my attributes, skills, and special abilities.

Rage: 3

Calm: 2

Every time I get hit in combat, someone offends me, or I encounter something annoying the system rolls Rage, and then my Calm rating on a ten sided dice. I'm not quite sure how the game knows what qualifies as aggravating, but I assume it has something to do either with my heart rate, or the parts of my brain that are active. If Rage rolls more dice greater than six, my vent meter, a red bar now at the bottom of my vision goes up by 10%. If it gets up to 100% for more than five seconds, I see red and attack anything that moves. The only way to burn it off is by taking aggressive actions - punching a wall or someone, kicking an inanimate object, or screaming out loud. Meditation also works, but requires a period of inactivity.

The benefit of Rage is that 50% of a full vent meter can also be burned to shape change instantaneously, and 30% can be used to double my attack or movement speed for three seconds so long as I'm taking an aggressive action.

I look down at the snoring were rat, and change forms. It feels hot when I use rage for instant transformation, but since I'm not doing that it's a whole body tingling paired with the sensation of someone giving me an aggressive massage in every muscle that's reforming. My pants expand to allow for a long tail to push out my bottoms, and my face grows long and hairy. My skin itches as my entire body sprouts a layer of shiny brown fur.

I nudge Andrew with my foot to break Sajina's sleep spell, and address him in the Rodekin language. "Feel better now?" If he attacks, I'll know we're dealing with the Haven variety which are mindless monsters. I nudge him again, and say "Hey!"

His eyes flutter, then pop open. I hold my breath. He groans. *This is good.*

He eyes me skeptically, "Who are you? ... are you? You're wearing the same clothes as the blonde woman." and says "I didn't know you were a warrior of the Earth Mother. I didn't know it was possible for your kind to become... Your hair's different and your ears... Which face is real?" in the same language.

I look back to the group and say, "He's a Freeworld rat." in the common tongue. They're all looking at me astonished. It only now occurs to me that this is probably the first time any of them except Frobod has encountered one of the Freeworld races in game.

"Bad ass!" Leroy says, and touches my fur. I give him an angry chitter. My vent meter hops up to 20 percent as someone pulls my tail.



I whirl, unable to discern the culprit and snap, "Knock it off!" My vent drops back down to zero.



Tako says, "Angry ratty." Vent up to 10 percent.



"Bite me." Back down to zero.

I turn back to Andrew and say, "They're with me. I'm confident we can handle the vampires."

He laughs. "You're just a child. You can't expect me to send a pup like you into their den with a bunch of mortals."

"We can handle ourselves!"

"Prove it."

I'm about to throw the nearest object I can get my hands on at him when a coyote pads down the path behind him, and then a raven swoops down from the canopy and lands on its head. "Test." The raven caws. "Trial."

The Coyote then morphs into a Native American man with long black hair wearing a beaded animal skin vest, and a tattered cowboy hat. His fur fades into his skin and four legs become two in a split second. Unlike Andrew, a smirk plays at the corners of his lips. He says, "I'll watch them try to kill themselves."

The raven caws, "Sponsor." Then explodes in a flurry of wings and dark feathers to become a young Spanish woman, with baby fat on her cheeks and

black hair tied in a long braid. She's wearing a pair of jeans and a black t-shirt. Their names are Jeremy and Camilla.

Camilla says, "I'll sponsor you and name this your trial if for no other reason than to make rat boy angry."

Andrew sneers, "She's not your kind."

She grins, "I know! Isn't it fun? It's like you said, I've never seen one of the point ears in service to the Earth Mother." She gives me a look, and says "I know they're round now, but if you wouldn't mind I'd really appreciate it if you could pretend their still pointed while I'm teasing Mr. Andrew."

Andrew takes a deep breath, making a visible effort to remain calm. "That's not what I meant, and you know it."

Jeremy says, "Being that we're running in a mixed pack, I'm not sure that matters."

"Fine!" Andrew says, clenching a fist. "But if she dies, or the devourers get even a drop of blood it's on you. Got it?"

Camilla grins, "Wouldn't have it any other way."

Andrew burns a bunch of rage, and drops down into his nezumi form. His body contracts and implodes on itself almost faster than the eye can see. Once he's small and on all fours, he darts off into the foliage.

Camilla says, "Rat-man's got a hot temper."

"Don't we all." I mutter.

Frobod asks, "Not to be rude, and thank you for not killing us, but... What just happened?"

"Right." Camilla says. "Here's the rules. You go off, do your thing, and we follow."

"...and?" Tako asks.

"That's it!" Camilla says, "Our job is to watch, not interfere."

I say, "I thought you said this was a trial."

Camilla says, "Ahh well... Quite frankly, the spirits have barely heard of you." *Probably because I've barely played this character.* "Do your job well, and Jeremy here will sing your praises!"

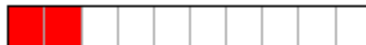
He tips his hat, "I'm good for that."

I'm surprised to hear Sajina chip in with "Does that mean you're a bard?" with a hopeful tone in his voice.

Jeremy shrugs, "Maybe if I were at a renaissance festival, but sure. Call me a bard. I sing the old songs."

Frobod asks, "I don't get it. What's the point if you're not going to do anything?"

Camilla says, "You want to explain ratface?" Vent meter's up to 20%.



"It's some stupid social shit." Vent down to 10%. "All Freeworld weres get their power from nature spirits. In order to get stronger powers, you need to impress them. Once you do, you can learn special abilities, and other shifters will instinctively treat you with more respect."

Leroy asks, "So it's a race based rep grind. What happens if we fail?"

Camilla grins, and answers in a sing song voice. "We destroy you before the leeches can consume you and become stronger, but no need to be negative. What's the first rule of fighting evil everyone?"

"Uhhmm..." Frobod says, we're all exchanging questioning looks.

"Don't leave anyone behind?" Frobod asks.

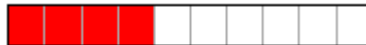
Camilla rolls her eyes, "That's like number four or five.... Rule number one: Have fun! No need to worry about the dark stuff if it's not gonna happen."

Frobod asks, "Can you remind me why we all need a trial?"

"You don't need anything." Jeremy says, "Unless you're secretly a Lupine that I can't smell."

"It's all about her." He points his finger at me. "She needs to make a name for herself and have her deeds acknowledged by the spirits. That way, next time she comes strolling through here we won't have this kind of confrontation."

Camilla says, "So Miss Rattypants." Vent meter creeping higher. I clench my fist. She tisks. "Temper temper..."



"WHAT DO YOU KNOW ABOUT TEMPER?" I take a deep breath. "... sorry."

Camilla says, "Yeah... You're gonna have to get that looked at. Your job is to go find that guy and keep these mortals safe from a bunch of leeches. Got it? Here," she pulls a tiny rectangular package from her pocket, and withdraws a shiny sleeve of foil. "Have some gum. You can't be angry while chewing Bubble Pop."

"I don't want it."

"What, afraid it came from Hades?" Camilla says. "I've got news for you. We've been stalking this nest since they snuck in from the Freeworld. This mondo chew is a-okay land of the living approved."

I give the stick a skeptical look and then take it not wanting to be rude. "I'll hold on to it for now. You never know when I'll need a better mood."

Camilla says, "Now that that's all taken care of, be good! We're watching." and takes two running steps toward me. I instinctively dodge out of the way but it's unnecessary because her body shrinks down and grows dark like a raven. The sound of beating wings fills the air along with a series of caws that sound like laughter. Jeremy tips his hat, and makes an equally quick change into his coyote form, running off the opposite direction.

"That was... interesting." Pahrem says, having been quiet until now.

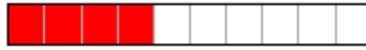
"Yeah..." I say. "I've got a feeling this is going to be a Freeworld dungeon."

"How do we find it?" Frobod asks.

I say, "Might as well do the spell now since I'm rat girl." and pull out a length string and the arrowhead. "Give me a little space." I say, and begin my preparations by threading the end of the string through the small hole used to affix the arrowhead to a shaft. I cup it in my hands, and raise it above my head as if making an offering to the forest. A high pitched chitter escapes my mouth.

Cast Seeking Stone. Failed.

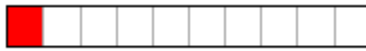
Tako says, "I don't think it's working."



I say, "Shut up! I told you I never play this name."

Pahrem asks, "Can't you just cast the spell as Melpomine?"

"I told you! It's Rodekin magic! Are you trying to piss me off? It won't work on non-were aliases. Just back off and give me a damn chance to work."



Pahrem says, "Touchy."

I try to ignore her as I attempt the spell again. I hold the arrowhead and string over my head in cupped hands and release another chitter. This time my efforts are rewarded when a large Magpie swoops down from a trees above. It's entire body is outlined in a blue glowing aura which tells me that it's a spirit rather than a normal bird.

"Hungry." The Magpie says in the Rodekin language.

"I need your help." I say.

"Hungry." the Magpie repeats.

I ask, "Will you help?"

The Magpie says, "Feed first. Help later."

Coming up with an idea on the spot, I open my inventory to find a pack of Pehrom's trail mix I haven't eaten, and pour it out on the ground. The black and white bird picks at the nuts and some of the raisins. I sigh with relief knowing that the offering has been accepted. I'm careful not to interrupt.

Tako asks, "Are we just going to stand around and watch a ghost bird eat?"

"Wait!" I snap in a stage whisper.

The magpie flies off, and I clench my teeth. *Son of a fuck.* A young sparrow comes down to take its place, and starts in on the nuts with its beak. It's not glowing, but its presence is reassuring. *Maybe there's still hope.*

I'm watching the little bird eat when out of nowhere the glowing magpie swoops down like an eagle and begins pecking. The two birds dance in a flurry of flapping wings and pained cries, but the smaller bird is no match for the magpie spirit. It stabs the little sparrow over and over, right in the eyes until the little brown bird no longer moves.

"Holy shit." Pahrem says.

"Look at em' go!" Tako cheers.

Unlike in nature, the sparrow despawns like a ghost, once the magpie has a few nips at its corpse to drive home it's fate. When finished with its meal the lambent spirit bird hops on the ground toward me, and caws "I help."

Feeling relieved with the last of my rage vicariously drained out of me, I say, "We need to find the man attached to this. Can you take us to him?"

It cocks its head, and then rustles its feathers. "Yes."

"Thank you." I say.

The magpie flaps its wings taking off from the ground. Instead of going into the trees however, it grows more and more insubstantial until it's nothing but a cloud of shimmering ether. I hold the string and arrowhead out in my cupped hands, the same as I did before. The cloud swirls like water into a drain leading directly into its face.

Pahrem says, "Freeworld magic is weird."

Leroy asks, "How's it work?"

"Watch." I say. With the Magpie gone, and the arrowhead now glowing with a faint light, I let it dangle from my fist like a pendant on a chain. Instead of hanging straight down it tugs north east of where we are standing as if drawn by a giant magnet. I point in the direction the arrowhead's pulling. "Looks like he's that way."

"Alright, let's go." Leroy says.

I say, "Leroy, if I lose control you're tank. I'd appreciate it if you didn't kill me if I enter the blood rage. It'll fade in a few seconds. Try to CC me if you can."

Frobod asks, "How do we know if that happens?"

I say, "If it looks like I'm attacking something I shouldn't and suddenly stop using my staff, I'm not in control anymore."

Leroy says, "Got it. Let's hope that doesn't happen."

Instead of following the path, I decide to take the most direct route possible walking between the trees, and crunching through all the natural debris on the forest floor. The terrain is getting steeper as we head into Ashfall Pass. Unlike the real world, we have decent enough freedom of movement, but in this section of the forest all the twigs, fallen leaves and earthy clutter on the ground makes it all but impossible to move silently.

A squeal sounds to our right. I look over just in time to see a boar coming at me. It has muddy fur, bright white tusks, and is so tall that if hit I'd receive a blow right to my sternum. *These aren't Old MacDonald's pigs.*

As soon as combat starts, the seeking stone vanishes into my inventory. I narrowly slip out of the way. I spin Bite, and hit the big ugly swine in the rump as it rushes past. Electricity leaps from my staff. *Those tusks look painful.*

Tako follows my hit with one of his throwing knives, and Frobod charges in with his greatsword. I get off a good taunt in time for the big boar to turn around and make another pass. I feel like a matador. I'm about to slip out of the way again when Leroy's hammer cracks square against its head sending it into a ear wrenching squeal of fatality. It's so still on the forest floor compared to just moments before. Tako loots and calls out "Boar meat." as the body vanishes.

Not too difficult.

I suspect the real challenge will be when we find the dungeon.

Eight or nine boars later, equally easy to dispatch, the terrain becomes semi-steep. Not enough for an interesting downhill ski run, but enough to get your heart pumping a bit faster than traversing flat land. There are more peaks of the sky here, and the trees are largely evergreen.

I can tell the earth becomes steeper far ahead, but we don't have to go there because we come to a structure built right into the side of the mountain. It's old and forgotten. Vines twist around the faces of four columns that remind me of the Parthenon. At the center of the middle two, a great black hole shimmers with a swirling portal. The arrowhead on a string reaches. leading us right toward it.



Chapter 12 - Ashfall Crypt

The feeling of weightlessness settles as my foot comes down on old, dry stone. Unlike the caves leading us into Hades, this place, the Ashfall Crypt according to our map, has ambient red magical lighting. It's not too bright, still a lot of shadows, but enough that adventurers can make their way through without a light spell.

Leroy comes in behind me. Followed by Pahrem, Frobod, and the rest of the crew. Once we are all inside, a coyote and raven both slip through the portal. I hadn't seen them following. Rather than stopping for a chat, the raven flaps off into a place I can't see, and the coyote runs ahead, becoming thinner and more translucent with each step he takes from the entrance.

I say, "Since they're Freeworld weres, I'm betting that these are going to be Freeworld vamps. Beheading works, as does fire. Everything else will reduce their health, but won't actually kill them unless they are burned or beheaded once they are at zero health."

Leroy says, "Awesome." speaks some arcane words, and sets his hammer on fire. "New dungeon with unknown mechanics, and if we die we respawn all the way back at Haven Durolan or wherever you have your bind point set."

"Sounds about right." I say. "You, me and Pahrem all have resurrections."

Leroy says, "Continuing our instruction, this may be a good time to teach you Minor elemental weapon if you have the points for it."

I check my VT.

Minor Elemental Weapon - Fire (Rank One)

Cost: 500 Manna

Target: Weapon

Duration: 1 Hour

Requirements:

Haven Elemental Magic (Rank 1)

Attunes your weapon to the element of fire.

Effect:

All physical damage caused by your weapon is considered to be both physical and fire for the purposes of elemental resistances and weaknesses..

Also adds up to 1 additional fire damage.

LeroyJensen wants to teach you Minor Elemental Weapon - Fire (Rank One). The cost of this instruction is 0 gold, and will require 10 special ability points.

**You currently have 110 unspent special ability points.
Do you accept? Yes / No**

I choose yes.

Leroy adds, "You want the acid one while I'm at it? That one's a bit harder to find."

"Sure." I say.

Minor Elemental Weapon - Acid (Rank One)

Cost: 500 Manna

Target: Weapon

Duration: 1 Hour

Requirements:

Haven Elemental Magic (Rank 1)

Attunes your weapon to the element of Acid.

Effect:

All physical damage caused by your weapon is considered to be both physical and acid for the purposes of elemental resistances and weaknesses..
Also adds up to 1 additional acid damage per attack.

LeroyJensen wants to teach you Minor Elemental Weapon - Acid (Rank One). The cost of this instruction is 0 gold, and will require 10 special ability points.

**You currently have 100 unspent special ability points.
Do you accept? Yes / No**

I choose yes. and say, "I know you only agreed to teach me, but considering the stakes if we die without being bound in Hades, do you mind teaching everyone else?"

Frobod shrugs, "Sure. If everyone has points."

As it turns out, Pahrem and Frobod already had the Elemental Magic abilities, so for them it was just a matter of taking on a new spell. Everyone else went down twenty points due to first having to learn Haven Elemental Magic and then Minor Elemental Weapon spells.

Leroy spends a bit longer with Sajina than all the others, "Hot damn boy. I could turn you into a monster if you raise some of those basic combat skills."

I look to him questioningly. Leroy says, "This guy has six hundred eighty six unspent points."

"Damn..." I say. *I thought I had a lot with my hundred.*

Tako says, "What do you expect? He's been sitting around doing social stuff the whole time. Every time he got a skill increase in... I don't know... Flirting or basket weaving, more points were added to his pool."

I say, "In this case, I guess it pays to be a soc."

Leroy says, "I'm not really a caster, but I've at least dabbled with all parts of the game since it's my job to play and review. I can get you started on some basic stuff so you can do something at range."

Ten minutes later, we're all re-buffed and sporting new spells in our repertoire. When I cast Minor Elemental Weapon on Bite, it doesn't catch fire like Frobod's hammer. Instead, either end glows like a hot coal, with little tongues of flame leaping up once every ten or twelve seconds. The electricity at either end still sparks and crackles. I also cast the spell on my Darksteel Chakram, which makes them look like wheels of fire. By the grace of game magic, the flames seem not to burn the wielders or their clothes. I wonder if we could cook food on them.

Leroy says to Sajina, "We should give you some caster gear if any drops, and heals don't need it. A bigger manna pool will help you keep casting."

Tako asks, "We ready to go?"

I say, "I think we are. Thanks for teaching everyone Leroy."

Leroy says, "If it helps us survive, I'm glad to do it."

I take in the environment, hard to see but it looks like a cross between a cave and cathedral. Natural stone walls, with large floor tiles. Slightly larger than life statues of men and women in hooded robes are made creepy by the red light as they look down at us from their lofty positions every few paces. We have a choice whether to go right or left. The Seeking Stone pulls straight ahead, which would lead us into a stone wall, and slightly to the left.

I say, "Seems like left is the best direction."

"Let's go." Frobod says.

I nod, proceeding cautiously. No sign of life yet, which makes me think we're walking into an ambush. My eyes are focused on the way ahead as I say, "Pahrem and Sajina stick together." An echoed drip sounds from deeper within the dungeon. I know we'll be facing vampires, but I also wonder if these statues can come to life. I'm always wary of human shaped ornamentation in a combat environment.

Something moves up ahead, a dark human shaped blotch within the ambient shadows. I say, "Get ready." and release a high pitched squeal which will have to serve as a battle cry from my rat face muzzle.

Taunt. Successful.

Blood Starved Vampire attacks.

I'd thought it'd already seen us, but I guess not because the vocalization causes it's head to snap up and charge at us like a bone thin gorilla. It shrieks from its human mouth in a way that sounds like a rabid raccoon. I brace for

impact, but then when I least expect it two more figures leap down from behind statues on either side. Their all draped in dirty clothing that's so tattered I can't tell if I'm looking at ripped up dress slacks or pantaloons. The shirts have, or used to have, buttons and dried blood stains their fronts.

The one on the right goes for Leroy, and takes the impact of the clawed hand and counter attacks with his burning hammer. The monster screams, both in pain and fear. The one on the left converges on me. I slip out of the way. A few more seconds until the one I taunted closes. Tako makes a go for my attacker, and I tag it in the side with Bite. It sizzles like a brand as electricity leaps from the tip and jumps in an arc to Frobod's attacker. Now I have all their attention.

I'm surprised when three violet mage bolts slam into the guy that tried to hit me. I spare just a moment to look back, and see the Gargoyle of all people holding out his hand to cast the spell. *New trick?* I guess so. I don't have time to evaluate because the first one I taunted is flying toward me in an impossible ten foot leap. Now that it's close, I can see that this one is female with dirty, brown matted hair. All three of the creatures have sunken eyes, and receding lips revealing monster canine teeth. *Note to self: Don't starve on a vampire character.*

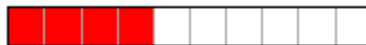
It crashes into me swinging a clawed hand that looks more like my wererat claws than the other two. Four health levels disappear from my Flow Like Water defense. *Holy shit.* That kind of damage is hard to resist.

I call, "Focus fire on the female! She's got claws and their damage is hard to take!"

Frobod hears the command and smashes her with his greatsword. Unfortunately, vampires are tough and while it makes a solid CRACK there's no dismembered limb flying through the air like I'd expect from a human. It knocks her off balance, but she springs back up like she didn't even feel it and snaps at me like a violent dog.

Starving Vampire #1 (Female): 90% health.

My vent meter is getting higher which is no bueno.



I burn off thirty percent of it in one go, channeling the rage into extra attacks. A bestial screech fills the air, and the fur on the back of my neck rises as I realize it's my own. *I didn't know I could make a sound like that.* Long before any opponents can attempt another swipe I'm on them, smashing the butt of Bite into the shriveled hissing woman's gut. This time a poof of flame appears on contact at the same time electricity jumps from her to her male companions.

Wild Woman's only down 80% health.

Pahrem shouts "Incoming!" as she lobs one of her g'nades into the fray. Leroy smacks Lady Vamp with another blow of his hammer, dropping her health down to 60% to my surprise, the rags she's wearing catch fire. She swats at her body with wild hands and begins to run the opposite direction, giving the flame much air to breath. Tako attempts to shadow step behind her, but as soon as he manifests she runs right past him before he can attack with his burning dagger.

He says, "Oh shit! I'm sorry!" turns, and begins sprinting back toward the party. That can only mean one thing... He's spotted new monsters, and they are coming after him. I call, "Tako to Mirae 'till I pick them up!"

I shadow step to his current position. Mirae's g'nades explode behind me in a blast of fiery goop that splatters the two male attackers, and sends them running as their clothes catch fire. As with the woman, the flames get bigger and hungrier as they run down the hall in my direction.

Three flaming vampires. Three more closing. I pick out the one leading the charge for Tako and shout "Over here!" clanking my staff against a statue. The newcomers are nearly skeletal.

Taunt. Successful. **Blood Starved Vampire attacks.**

He makes a beeline for me, and I run to meet his charge, spinning my fiery electrified staff and hand, ready to get down to business. POW! I knock him right in the forehead, sending him flying backward and onto the ground. The lightning from my strike snags the others, which turn their attention to me.

I must have critically failed my dodge roll, my combat logs are turned off, because I trip over my own feet and I struggle just to maintain my footing. My rage vent meter rises. Thump-bump bump bump thump-bump bump bump. My heart pounds in my ears. *Fuck!*



Two nasty blows hit me, stripping away what remains of my Flow Like Water Defense, and digging deep into my health levels. *Bastards!* At least they don't have claws like the lady vamp. If they did, I'd be dead. Another sloppy, albeit fierce blow smashes me on the side of my head as I try to catch my balance. Health 40%. Tump-bump bump-bump. Bumpbumpbump.



I shout, "Fucking heal me!" As another fist smashes into my face. I catch the faintest glint of Pahrem's golden heals. My health jumps back up to 90%. Bumpbump Bumpbump Bumpbump BUMP. A skeletal hand smashes into my body and gropes at my breast. It hisses through an open fanged mouth, trying to latch on, and pierce my skin for a drink.



There are only two colors now, bright red like burning coal, and the darker red of blood. The blood color makes the shapes of people and objects, and one is trying to latch on me, so I toss the stick and rip off the side of it's head where the

face should be. The reds begin to dim, but something else smashes me so I screech and rip into that body too. It's all hard and bony.

Something else attacks, I can't try to defend because the blood rage only allows for aggressive actions and everything's so red. As with the fog on Charon's boat I can't even tell who I'm looking at. I have no course of action except to strike. It feels like a ghost is making a puppet of me.

I claw my attacker, and kick to knock it back. Another body's coming at me, so I leap on it before it can hit me like the others. My claws scream against some kind of metal. Something tries to pull me back so I spin and slash at that interloper rending its shell with my claws. The last figure I clawed runs, but that's okay because the thing I've got is making a good struggle. I rip into a breastplate, the metal screams it's resistance.

Red starts to fade, as I make out... Frobod! I've ripped finger sized holes in his armor.



"Shit! Sorry." I say. Frobod has an unnerved look on his face. *At least he's still alive.*

I look back, and see Leroy tanking not one, but six hungry vampires. Three on fire, three not. He uses one of his divine abilities sending a blinding flash through the crypt leaving his opponents stunned as he lays into the one directly in front of him with his burning hammer.

I have no idea where Bite is, so I switch to unarmed.

Hot Swap (Rank 3) - Success! **You have equipped Fists of the Thunderlord.**

I wish these gloves had better defensive stats so I could leave them equipped indefinitely. Shadow Step is still on cool down, so I burn 60% of my rage meter to take aggressive actions in hot pursuit of the vampires. I'm a blur of motion as I turn from Frobod and close with the closest unburning vamp in no time flat. I go in with a wild right hook that flashes with blue lightning. I follow through with an open hand claw that makes my heart jump as it claps like thunder. It's so jarring to have such a loud sound in a confined space.

Leroy smashes one of the creatures I was just fighting with his hammer, and it goes down, exploding into ash. One of the burning vampires also collapses without him touching it. It reminds me of a long burning log crumbling in a fire pit.

I call, "Pahrem, Leroy's tank. All heals on him!"

Stupid. I should have never tried to tank as Lilly.

I hear her call back "Got it!" as Leroy lands another impressive blow. Frobod's only now catching up to me with his monster sword, having been unable to match my rage fueled speed. Tako must be behind one of Leroy's other targets because I don't see him.

I step aside to give Frobod an opening. He swings, I feel the heat from his fiery blade, and another vampire crumples before exploding into ash. Four more

to go. One of the creatures makes a solid crack on Leroy's shield. I know they don't feel pain because hitting his bulwark must be like punching a steel wall.

A trio of Mage bolts from Sajina hits one of the burning vamps, and it goes down. Leroy illuminates with Pahrem's golden healing. Three vampires left, one burning. Frobod smashes the one on fire, for a moment I think it' resists the blow, but then it collapses into a heap of ash.

Two more, Leroy's hammer connects. I hit it with a KA-BLAM POW! with a claw from my right, and then a thunderous crash from my left. It's less unsettling this time because I'm expecting the sound in close quarters. Vampire health: 20%. Tako shaves off the last of it with one of his burning blades as it screams and crumbles to ash. The last one throws it's body against Leroy's shield, trying to reach around and grab him with it's bony hands. It's not much of a challenge for him to stay safe, but the angle is awkward to smash the creature with his hammer. I go for a kidney shot, *if vampires even have kidneys*, which crackles with light and electricity. Tako stabs it in the back, and Frobod cleaves it with his giant sword smashing the undead body against Leroy's shield with his giant burning blade.

I hit it with another lightning flash jab, followed by and ear rattling BOOM of a left handed uppercut. The vampire drops to the floor. At zero percent health.

"No ash." Frobod says.

I say, "It still has its head, and my hands aren't burning."

Tako says, "I've got it." as he squats down, and buries his fiery dagger into his chest. The vampire ignites, as if doused in kerosene, and crumples into ash. "I could get used to these fire daggers. Thanks for teaching."

I look around and find Bite laying on the ground a few paces away, glowing hot red at either end, and crackling with electricity.

Frobod says, "You need more control."

"Yeah." I say, scratching the back of my head in embarrassment. "My rage is three, and calm is 2, so I'm already at a disadvantage."

Leroy says, "I don't know anything about these weres except what you told us, but I think if you want to tank as one you need to get whatever stat resists that berserk thing maxed out ASAP."

"Yeah..." I say, "Pretty much everything were specific is at starting level since I didn't really play this character before the merge, but all the basic stats are combined."

Leroy asks, "You can't do that seeking thing on any other characters?"

"It's Freeworld were specific. The only way for Melpomine to use it would be for her to become a were herself."

"Alright." Leroy says, "You go DPS until we find that Zan guy. Once you're back in your elf skin feel free to take over."

I say, "That's what I was going to say. Every time I get hit my vent meter gets a little more red, and when it's maxed out... Well, you saw it."

Tako says, "At least we cleared two or three pulls in one go. You're welcome."

"Dude." Pahrem says, "You were screamin' 'I'm sorry.' like five minutes ago."

Tako says, "That was before I knew it'd all work out." He bends down to check the loot. A few Hades marks, and some standard gold coins for all of us.

Leroy says, "Everyone behind me. Call out if you have incoming."

I stick Bite back in my inventory content to fight unarmed this battle. I linger beside Pahrem and Sajina for a few moments as Leroy with his plate and shield advances into the dungeon. Pahrem says, "Decided to hang at the back of the bus, with the cool kids huh?"

"For a few seconds." I say. "Gonna wait for them to get rock solid agro before engaging so I don't risk anything."

Up ahead, a snarling human shaped body leaps from behind one of the statues, and on to Leroy's back. I can tell it's trying to bite him, under normal circumstances, I'd say he shouldn't be worried, but Vampires can be strong, and I can see dents in his armor from where it bit. Frobod smashes it with his great sword, but it's still holding on. Tako needles it with his daggers. I look to Pahrem and say "That's my cue." as I launch a burning chakram from my hand hitting the creature right under the ribs. Vampire 30%.

I look to Sajina and say "Save your manna. Sure enough another burning cleave from Frobod connects with the monster falling apart in an explosion of ash. I check the seeking stone, from our current position it's pulling ahead and slightly to the right.

I say, "If you get a chance to go right, try that."

"Got it." Leroy calls back. "Pretty quiet so far, but they bite hard."

About a minute Leroy stops and says "I've got a passage going right. My gut says it doesn't matter which way we go."

I reiterate my earlier words. "Go right. Any mobs?"

Frobod says, "Nothing yet."

Which of course means we're about to hit either a boss, or an environmental challenge. Dungeons don't get left empty unless you've already cleared them.

Leroy says, "Looks like a big open chamber up ahead. Don't see any monsters."

Sajina, Pahrem and I fall in behind him so now the whole party's standing side by side. We're right at the threshold knowing that a step further could trigger a game event. The ceilings are high, at least two or three stories, and the lighting has shifted from red to violet. There are also a number of tall columns like the ones outside. The floors are tiled, same as before, and there are of course more statues. The only thing out of place is a giant stone pedestal that is conspicuously empty at the center of the far wall. It's large enough to showcase a rotating showroom automobile and I wonder why it's there. I search for exits and discover a door set at the far left corner of the chamber.

"Hold on to your butts." Leroy says, having instincts about an impending boss fight mirroring my own.

I reaffirm his call by saying, "All in."

As soon as we set foot in the purple room the floor starts shaking. It's not hard to keep our balance, but it sets our senses on edge. As it turns out, the pedestal isn't a pedestal so much as it is the opening of a well, or a wall around a pit leading deeper into the earth. A pair of monstrous clawed hands the size of my

torso grasp either side of the opening, and hefts a moaning hunchbacked body from the depths of its hiding place.

Standing at least sixteen feet tall it roars from a terrible circular mouth that looks like a lamprey. The worst part is that this "Once Man Amalgamation" named George judging by the name plate, seems to have been pieced together like Frankenstein's monster. The more my eyes focus, the more I see human faces, groaning in contortions of agony, fused into the monster's body.

"Suggestions?" Frobod asks.

Leroy says, "I'm gonna call it a tank and spank until we have reason to suspect otherwise. Frobod then Mel off tank if it's needed."

It's not lost on me that Leroy's giving more orders, but that's okay because he's now tank and it's expected. All I have to add is "Heals and bard stay safe, and call out if you're in trouble. I don't think this is a vampire." *A small blessing, that.*

Leroy rushes in with his shield in front of him, and swings his burning hammer like a hot meteorite. A flash of divine light flashes as it makes contact with George's shin. It swats him away like a bee, with a gigantic hand attached to a long arm proportioned more like an ape's than a human's. Leroy soars away from the group.

George takes a couple of big stomps toward us. Frobod tightens his grip on his sword, but then George stops dead in its tracks, turns, and begins thundering toward Leroy. I can only assume he got a successful taunt, as I yell "All in!" and flick my fiery chakram. It buries itself in the monster's back cutting one of the moaning faces peaking out of its skin in half.

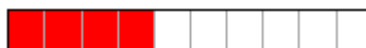
Tako and Frobod run to join, and I say to Sajina "Now's a good time to use your new magic." When he opens up with a volley of purple mage bolts I shadow step behind George, and deliver the old one two to his rear leg tendon. Flash! BANG! George howls in pain, though his health is still at 90%. He stomps his foot, I dart safely out of the way, and Leroy brings his hammer down on one of the monster's toes.

"Hot foot!" Tako says with a laugh.

I roll my eyes. Frobod lands a blow with his great sword and the monster starts kicking in all directions. Both he and Tako are knocked into one of the statues resulting in damage. When Frobod in his plate missiles into the statuary, a hooded figure's head breaks off and rolls across the floor.

The boys flicker with golden light as Pahrem is fast on her heals. Leroy now holds George's attention as it smashes his fists down on top of him. He's still over eighty percent, so I trust he knows what he's doing. I follow up with another flurry of punches to the back of George's leg, which results in more of his stomping and kicking every which direction. This time he connects, and now I'm flying fifteen feet into a wall.

Vent meter up to forty percent.



"Oof!" It knocks the wind out of me. A few seconds later I say, "Ranged DPS! He knocks back every time you engage from behind." and launch my chakram which has reformed at my belt. It moves through the air like a flying saucer, as another clawed hand comes down hard on Leroy's shield. Sajina sends another volley of mage bolts into George's back and Tako has since hot-swapped his bow and arrow.

One of the faces on George's back moans "Kill me! Kill me please!" Tako hits it between the eyes with an arrow. *Could that be the secret of this boss?* Another face sobs, "I don't want to live!" So I bisect it with another thrown chakram. George roars in pain. His health is all the way down to sixty percent. I can't help but notice that it drops a lot faster while we're attacking from afar.

I shout, "Try to hit the faces!" Another CLACK sounds as George's nails smash against Leroy's shield.

A face on George's side sobs, "Please help me die." Tako hits it in the nose with an arrow.

George is down 40%, occasional flashes of bright light spring up from where Leroy's smashing his hammer into George, and the monster continues his attempts to hit him. I say, "I think that's all the faces on the back." then yell, "Leroy, try to turn him so we can see the front!" He doesn't say anything in acknowledgement, though he does begin to move, slowly, between each of the monster's blows. As soon as one of the frontal faces becomes visible I slice it with a thrown chakram.

Sajina opens fire again with his low level magic sending arcs of color through the air. I'd be surprised if the low level spells are doing any damage to a boss like this, but I'm glad to see that he feels like he's making a difference.

Tako takes out another face with a well placed shot, and Frobod looses a volley of dark necro bolts. George health: 20%. Leroy groans as he's bashed with another hit, he's down to forty percent but then his health jumps right back up to eighty thanks to Pahrem.

The final face on George's chest shouts "Kill meeeeeee!" and I hurl a chakram right into it. George health: 10%. It silences abruptly, but the desperate cry is replaced by a terrifying bellow from the lamprey mouth that shakes the walls of the entire dungeon.

"ROAAAAARRRRRRRRR!"

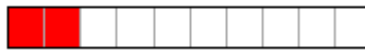
Faster than I thought possible for a creature this size, George scoops up the tank in one hand, and fastball pitches him into a statue. It breaks apart, and Leroy's dazed. It runs at us, reaches out, and takes me and Tako in two separate hands. The monster smashes us together in a violent clap between his palms and then discards us on the floor. My health drops forty percent. Tako's dead. I'm hobbled in a broken pile of my injured self on the cold floor tiles. Pahrem and Sajina run, but Frobod's not so lucky as the boss scoops him up, and then super-bowl spikes him into the ground.

My heart is thumping fast in my ears. Rump bump-bump bump-thump thump-bump! *Son of a shitty fuck!* Rage vent up to eighty percent.



Fortunately, Leroy's getting back to his feet, though he's only at 50% health. He shout's "Hey!" George gives up pursuit of the final two party members, and rushes at him. *Taunt successful.*

I burn sixty percent of that eighty into first doubling, then tripling the speed of my aggressive actions for the next three seconds. I'm charging the amalgamation in a blur of fur, leap into the air, and pound it with a flying kick. Holy light explodes from beneath my boot. This time the boss doesn't stop to kick so I'm hoping it's now safe for melee DPS. I've still got one more attack, before my speed lurches back to normal, so I follow the kick up with a pair of open claw swipes that zap him with electricity, and crack with a sonic BOOM. *Five percent remaining.*



Rage is now under control. I say "Pahrem, heals!" I do a backward walk over to put distance between me and the boss and I throw my Chakram hoping to get a shot on George's ugly face.. It hits him in the side of the head slicing off a malformed ear. I clarify for our healer, "He's not coming at you anymore!"

Frobod stumbles to his feet and lets loose another necro bolt. It crashes into George's side.

Leroy smashes the monster foot again at the same time as Pahrem enshrouds him in golden healing light. His health creeps higher.

"Go! Go! Go!" I cheer and rush in for another attack. My fist crashes into the back of the monster's leg, and I don't even have a chance to deliver my follow-up strike because the giant falls backward onto the stone howling something that sounds like "Groooooo!" No idea if that was supposed to be a word.

I breathe heavily. Now that we're out of combat, my health begins to creep back up as my internal injuries begin mending themselves. One benefit of playing a were that I'd forgotten was that outside of combat, they heal insanely fast.

Frobod says, "Someone raise Tako. Kid's always dying."

Pahrem says, "I'm on it." as she begins waving her long green fingers and channeling her resurrection spell. The longer she does, the brighter her hands begin to glow with white gold magic. An apparition like a grim reaper with angel wings appears over Tako's corpse, touches his face with a skeletal hand, and then vanishes.

Tako coughs.

Leroy says, "That guy was a bitch. Hits like a truck. Good call on that face thing."

"Yeah, thanks." I say, now almost fully recovered.

The boss despawns leaving a treasure chest in its place at the same time as Tako is brought back from the dead. I'm surprised to see that there are also fifteen translucent men and woman where George was laying wearing Freeworld clothing, modern compared to Haven fantasy garb.

At first they look around bewildered, but then recognize our party. A ghost woman reaches for my face, though she stands some six feet away and says "Thank you."

A man with a white Santa Claus beard also says, "Thank you." and bows his head. "We owe you our lives." He laughs, uneasily. "Well, perhaps not those, but our freedom. Thank you for setting us free."

Once his health is up to 100%, Tako opens the chest.

Low Hades Garb of the Invoker

Type: Cloth
Slot: Chest
Quality: Epic
Equipped Bonus:

Intellect + 3, Stamina + 3

Special Properties:

Reset... Reset!: Once per hour one of your spells, or special abilities that is currently on cooldown becomes instantly available. If the spell or ability is used again within three minutes of using *Reset... Reset!* it costs zero mana to cast.

Low Hades Garb of the Healer

Type: Cloth
Slot: Chest
Quality: Epic
Equipped Bonus:

Intellect + 3, Stamina + 3

Special Properties:

Your healing spells are 10% more effective.

In Dire Need: Once every 30 minutes the efficacy of spells and abilities that restore health is increased by 50% (rounded up). Lasts for one minute.

Tako says, "Double caster robes. I pass."

Frobod says, "Pass."

Leroy says, "Pass."

Pahrem says, "The healer robes are better than what I've got, so I'll take em'. That Reset-Reset thing would be nice for resurrections, but I'd rather have that bonus healing so you scrubs don't die in the first place."

Leroy says, "Give the other one to the Gargoyle. The extra intel should help with his mana so he can cast more."

Sajina says, "Are you sure?"

Leroy says, "For now you're learning to be a mage, so take em if no one wants them. They're a hell of a lot better than most people's first caster gear. We really need to find you a trainer for charismatic casting so you can make use of your Charisma rating."

I say, "I don't need them. I have a caster set from my alt, and that's not how I've been playing lately."

Pahrem auto-equips her new gear using her VT. As it turns out, like the souls released from George's body, the Low Hades Garb of the Mender is semi-modern—a long black knitted cardigan with a fantasy cloak style hood covering a skin tight t-shirt. When Pahrem lifts the hood, her bat-like ears stick out from underneath, and her face is replaced by a nimbus of swirling white and silver light with a pair of black dots for eyes. *Interesting effect.*

I look to Sajina and say "Try yours on." and he does. One of the peculiarities of the Gargoyle race seems to be that any armor equipped immediately takes on the texture and coloration of stone, so Sajina's brown cardigan quickly camouflages to match his granite skin.

"Try the hood." I say, and when he raises it, his face becomes a swirling orb of light and dark crimson, with two little circles where his eyes should be. He lowers it again, preferring his normal face, and I say "Lookin' good. Stone man."

The ghosts are still lingering about the chamber as if waiting for something to happen when I motion to the door to the left and say, "There's the exit." I look to the ghosts and say "Good luck in your afterlife."

The Santa Claus man says, "We are forever grateful."

Thinking of our quest, I add "Are any of you named Zan?" I'm not hopeful since none of the ghosts have half-elven features.

"Zan?" The man with the beard asks. "I .. we don't know a Zan."

The woman who first spoke to me says, "Of course we do. He's the new one with the master. Funny ears like that one over there?" She indicates Tako.

I say, "Yes."

"That's Zan?" The old man asks. "If that's who you're here for you'd better hurry. So far as I know he's still alive, but there's no guarantees when you're here with vampires."

Just to be sure I take out the seeking stone and note that it's still tugging deeper into the dungeon. Through a wall to be exact, but the closest door is the exit I noted before.

The room darkens as if we're standing in the shadow of a dragon, then the absence of light condenses into an intense silhouette, like black paint, in the shape of a man on the wall. It's hard to make out the details given that it is a shadow, but I know at least he's a slim man with a wide brimmed hat. From there he could be anything from a 1900s train robber to one of the Men in Black. When he speaks however, his haunting melodious voice resonates throughout the crypt.

"Visitors? So nice for the living to join us, though you shouldn't have killed George. You have no idea how long it takes to make one of those and Hades is short on building materials." The shadow rubs its chin pensively. "Tell me, would you like to become another George, or something else? I do appreciate a hot meal. Oh! I know." The shadow claps its hands, though the gesture makes no sound. "Surprise me. If we meet face to face again I may keep you around."

The figure spreads its fingers, and then raises them up as if lifting an invisible body. The ground trembles, and stones begin to crack with bits of rock scattering on the floor. One of the hooded figures leaps off its pedestal with two

feet, then another, and another. *Crap! I knew this would happen! Never trust human shaped decor!*

All together there are 13 stone figures animated in the room, with two having been destroyed in combat with George. They kneel before the shadow on the wall.

I say, "Pro tip for your vid, Leroy. Make sure to wreck the statuary while fighting the boss!"

He shrugs, and spins his sword in his attack hand preparing for another battle. "Too late now."

Pahrem says, "Woulda shoulda coulda and that shit."

I call out, "Get ready." *There's no way in hell the door's unlocked.*

The shadow, now speaking to it's new minions, "Bring these to me when they are bested. Quickly before the blood goes cold."

"They shant be fightin' alone!" Says a lumberjack looking man among the ghosts. He has a mighty bushy red beard, intense blue eyes, a red flannel and an Irish accent. "We've got a debt to settle, and I for one, intend to repay it."

"Yeah!" The chorus of ghosts answers, as they all equip weapons as if from player inventories. The Lumberjack man hefts a two handed hammer, perfect for busting apart stones, whereas others wield other blunt weapons like maces, heavy clubs, and more hammers.

The animated statues stand, robotically. I don't get the impression there's much personality in them. They turn as one to face our group like a well drilled army. The shadow slips down the wall, glides over the surface of the floor, and escapes beneath the door making the exit.

Lumberjack shouts "Charge!" as he rushes the nearest statue to him with his great hammer. It makes a solid KACK sound as it abuses the statue's chest. It turns to return the attack, now wielding a stone dagger I hadn't seen before. It nicks the ghost man, but Lumberjack is able to get in another shot which breaks his attacker's arm off at the shoulder.

Leroy smacks his burning hammer against his shield and a good half of the stone warriors turn to him. The rest fight one on one, and in some cases one vs. two against ghostly apparitions. A transparent domestic woman in a simple, drab dress, and a brown apron wields a hammer in one hand and a rolling pin in the other. She beats against a hooded stone figure with the roller, then with the hammer in a way I wouldn't think she could. Little flecks of rock fly off the statue's body. Her opponent comes in for a strike, but the ghost lady dips out of the way and knocks it in the forehead with the roller. Her weapon doesn't break, so it must be one of those fancy stone ones.

In another skirmish, Santa man hefts a two handed mallet and crashes it down on a statue's collar. He takes a wound from a stone knife, but that doesn't seem to hurt the ghost's resolve as he backs off a few steps, and then comes in for another strong hit to the same spot causing part of the face to break off, and the now inanimate limb to clunk against the floor.

For the second time this journey, I find myself wishing for an AoE damage caster like the gnome Laurelade to blow them all up at once, but these ghosts are holding their own.

Now it's my turn.

I move in on one of the ones approaching Leroy with a flurry of claw attacks. KA-POW! BAM! Flash of lightning. Ear splitting thunder. Chunks of stone fall from the statue's mid section. I'm thankful for my unarmed abilities which nullify the effects of attacking metal and stone with my bare hands. Otherwise, my knuckles would be bloody, and I may be doing as much damage to myself as my opponents.

Sajina blasts my target with a bunch of mage bolts and causes more cracks to appear. I deliver a killing blow with a hook kick which knocks the head clean off its body.

A burst of holy light surrounds Leroy, leaving me to see spots for a few seconds but stunning all opponents within a radius. That's my cue to body check the next one hoping to knock it to the floor. It doesn't work, but then Frobod shows up right behind me and does the same sending it crashing to the floor. A leg breaks off, but he's not using his sword. *Probably afraid of a nasty repair bill.* At least this one won't be chasing us when it's unstunned.

I call, "Pahrem? You got anything explosive?"

I hear her give a quiet "Uhhmm..." followed by a much louder "Maybe! Give me a sec."

Leroy gives the slightest nod to show that he's aware that there will be no heals for a few seconds as he smashes a statue with his hammer, causing it to explode as if the weapon had been tipped with dynamite. Just as the statues start to move again he unleashes another AoE stun.

"Frobod, Tako! Knock em down. Try to make a pile!"

Frobod and I slam the next closest one together sending it to the floor, and then the next trying to angle our blows so they land on each other kriss cross like logs in a fire. Tako groans as he pushes one toward us... it teeters, and then just barely falls over. *These things are heavy.*

"Pahrem calls G'nade incoming!" and we all back off, including Leroy. Her little bauble, filled with yellow energy lands right beneath the pile. *Three... Two... One...* One of the downed statues begins to move pushing itself up, and then BOOM Pahrem's projectile bursts with what seems like at least half the force of a real world grenade. Bits of rock go everywhere, some of those that were still standing collapse and the statues we toppled move no more.

We're now down to eight opponents between the statues surrounding Leroy and those fighting the ghosts. Sajina continues to hammer the statues with low level arcane energy, and I engage with more unarmed attacks. Frobod says, "I'm going to join the gargoyle, and dips out of melee range."

All in all, while busy with stone, adventurer, and ghost bodies, it's not much of a fight compared to George. No DPS are ever struck, and Leroy only requires one heal. When the last statue crashes to the ground the guy who looks like Santa says, "You go rescue your friend. We'll check the way out to make sure more of these statues don't come to life."

I ask "Are you going to be okay?"

He salutes. "We've got this. Go give that fanger what's coming to him!"

As soon as he finishes talking, a loud clicking sound fills the room and the door swings open, as if destroying the soldiers triggered a hidden unlocking mechanism.

"Sounds like a plan." I say. "And thank you."

"No, thank you." He says. "After this, we all have dates with the immigration office of Low Hades."

That gives me a chuckle, having lived in foreign countries during my adult life. It's just like Freeworld, being more closely related to our own, to require their newly dead to register as immigrants in the afterlife.

True to form, Tako inspects the loot, and is disappointed to say "Just a bunch of stone. Not even valuable ones."

Pahrem looks over the fallen bodies too and says, "I might be able to use some of this to make blasting powder. I'll take it all if no one wants it."

"Have at it." I say, as the crafting material disappears into our goblin's inventory.

Beyond the door is a long empty corridor painted in ambient red light that's much the same as when we entered the dungeon. I say, "Leroy, you want to take point?"

He nods, and steps through the door. It's a good thing for my suggestion because a few steps into the hall a click sounds, and a stone the size of a small pumpkin comes hurling at us. I instinctively duck, but Leroy raises his shield. It hits with a loud CRACK which forces the tank to stagger back. He lowers his shield to have a look, and discovers a sizable dent from the rock's impact.

"Traps." I say. "Super."

Tako says, "I can try to disarm them."

Leroy shakes his head. "I'll just power through and set them all off. I doubt I'll die. Everyone stay here."

"Err... Okay."

It's impressive to see how fast Leroy can run with his big shield and all that armor. A burst of fire erupts down the hall, but doesn't seem to connect, then I see a splash of what is surely acid. Leroy's health drops by twenty percent, as he calls back "I'm good!" and chugs a health potion. A few steps later spikes fall from the ceiling and finally a metallic SNAP sounds from ahead. It's hard to see Leroy from this distance when he calls back "Come on ahead! That should be all of them."

Leroy holds a bear trap attached to a chain in his fist and holds it out to us. "Maybe one of you can reuse or repurpose?"

"I can." Tako says, and reaches out his hand. "Don't have many traps in my collection."

"Well, here you go." Leroy hands it over.

There's a flight of narrow stairs that perfectly align with where the seeking stone's telling us to go. Leroy begins his descent. We come out on top of a ring shaped platform overlooking what reminds me of a cage fighting pit, only instead of a cage the walls are solid stone. Bestial snarling sounds from within. I peek over the edge to see at least 10 bare backed, half naked starving vampire bodies milling about and making noises at each other. One of them sniffs the air and looks up at us, hisses from a dirty mouth, and tries to leap out of the pit. It doesn't work, as his jump is about six feet too short, and a magical barrier shimmers at the height of his ascent. I'm pretty sure that's as much to stop them from getting out as it is us from throwing things in.

Taking in the environment, there are two iron doors in the pit. One leading in from another narrow flight of stairs that start near us on the platform, and another exiting to who knows where.

Frobod asks, "What do you think?"

Leroy says, "Normally I'd say we should try to pull em out one or two at a time, but...." his voice takes on a mischievous tone."

I say, "If we had AoE CC, we could lock them all down and run through, or crowd control three quarters of them and open the door to drag out the rest."

"Yeah..." Leroy says. "I'm sure that's how most people will do it, but for you, I've got another idea." Judging by the mirth in his voice I don't know if I like where this is going. "Pahrem, how many of those bomb things do you have?"

She answers, "They're called g'nades! ...and I have plenty. 'been grinding my skill before this."

"We could throw the g'nades down from here?" I say hopefully, not really expecting it to work. It'd be too easy if that magical shimmer only blocked objects from passing through one way.

"Yeah.." Leroy says, "We could try that... Doubt it'd work, but remember what I said when I taught you the Aegis skill?"

"Uh oh..." I say.

Tako says, "What is it?"

I say, "He wants to make a spectacular video of me blowing myself up."

Leroy says, "Give the lady a cigar! If we tied a bit of crafting thread to a bunch of those pins and pulled them all at once... She could jump down or go through the door and BOOM!"

Pahrem cackles. "I love it."

I say, "You're supposed to be on my side here."

Leroy says, "Call it payment for learning such an awesome ability."

I grumble. "I thought you being here was payment."

Leroy says in imitation of a sleazy Hollywood executive, "It's all cool baby, I'm gonna make you a star!"

I sigh, resigning myself to this. I guess It'll be nice to test the new skill. Pahrem's already setting out different colored globes filled with burping goop, or magical energy. I close my eyes and take deep breaths to vent some of that rage that's bubbling up. I try to put all my mind's focus in to the palms of my hands. It's an effort, but I slowly begin to feel my body relax, and my heart begin to calm.

Eutone

Perception + Meditation. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 4)

"I can feel it tingling."

Meditation skill increased by 1. Current level: 2

Sajina says, "It's gonna be like Holi!"

"Holi?" Frobod asks.

Pahrem says, "Ya know, that Indian festival where they throw colors all over each other."

I say, "Yeah, and now she wants to paint me the color of spring."

Pahrem laughs, a little too excited if you ask me. "Just like that if those colors were designed to blow you up, melt your face off, and set you on fire all at the same time!"

Grumbling, I say "I can't tell you how much I'm looking forward to this."

Leroy says, "Oh come on, it'll be fun. It's not like you'll die, and if you do... I've got a res."

"Fine... Fine." I say, "What do you have in mind?"

"Alright." Pahrem says, "Now we're talkin! Hey Jensen, you got craftin' thread?"

"I have better!" He says, grinning, and passes her a spool of clear string. "Fishing line!"

Pahrem says. "Hold this." She hands me a bubble filled with bright yellow liquid at the time. "This." She hands me a red one. "This..." The next one is green.

Frobod asks, "Is there any way to just stick them to her?"

I give him a suffering look as if to say "Aren't any of you going to support me?" He just shrugs.

Tako says, "I've got a vendor trash belt."

"Give it here." Pahrem says, extending her big green hand. She cinches it around my body, not too tight, and then begins tucking brightly colored containers of alchemical death against me. *Goblin ingenuity*. They have a racial bonus for war tinkering, aka engineering, jury-rigging and destructive alchemy. I don't know whether to feel like a Christmas tree, or a mad bomber.

"Perfect!" she says and begins tying threads to each of the detonation pins. "Okay here's what you do." Setting at least eight lengths of tied off fishing line in my palm. "Go down the stairs, or try your shadow step thing to surprise em'... Then yank em' out!"

"Really?" I say in mock excitement. I act as if I'm about to pull the pins. "Pull this, and then go visit the vampires. Right?"

"Nooooo!" Pahrem says. "Go down and THEN pull them. Ya wanna kill us or somethin'?"

Now, in a much flatter tone I say, "I've got that. Sarcasm." I pause and shake my head having thought it was obvious. "Sarcasm."

Leroy stands at the edge of the pit looking down, and says "I'm recording the whole thing. I'm good when your ready!"

I step beside him, take a deep breath, and say "You're welcome."

In spite of this bit of fun they're having at my expense I decide to shadow step down rather than risking opening the door and having all the vampires rush out. If anyone dies, it'll just be me.

Leroy says "Everyone else get to the door in case the goblin's stuff doesn't cover it."

"It will!" She says, in a tone of mock offense.

I take another deep breath. *I didn't get all dressed up for nothing*, and hiss "Let's go!"

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I appear in the shadow of the psychotic vampire that tried to leap out of the pit. It's surprised at first, but then snarls and reaches out both hands in an attempt to grab me. I side step, and bump into another vamp just behind me. It turns and this time manages to clinch my left arm. Now the other half mad starving vamps have been alerted to my presence and it's a full on fangy , gropey, bitey dog pile of ugly.

A new vamp wraps it's arms around my body and tries to sink it's teeth into my collar. My health drops. ninety percent... seventy percent... sixty percent remaining as I don't fight back beyond trying to keep a single arm free, and each and every one of these long tooth bastards wants a taste of me. My vision starts to turn red, though I'm doing my damndest to resist the Blood Rage with meditation. *Breathe in, breathe out. Focus on your little finger. Breathe in. Breathe out. Calm your heart. There's no need to see red.*

Some of the vampires moan in pain as tainted blood spills from their lips. It sizzles through their body, but their starving so even bad blood is better than none. *I forgot Rodekin blood was poisonous.* Their health begins to trickle away without me having to land even a single attack.

I feel a nasty sting as yet another vampire pierces the skin under my armpit with its fangs. I shout, "Fuck you!" and smash my elbow into its nose. I jerk my fist full of fishing line. Every one of Pahrem's pins come lose.

BOOM! The first blast is a lot like the last ones we used on the stone men, and three vampires touching me go to bits. There's no way to avoid friendly fire on this one, and my health drops to thirty percent.

This just clears a way for new blood crazed vamps to sink their teeth into me, as yet another hisses, snarls, and silences as it takes a bite. My health drops to twenty.

A raven caws and circles overhead. I suddenly remember the were's promise to obliterate us if we fed the undead. *Not now.* I think. She's got to realize these monsters are doomed. When the raven caws again, I become uneasy.

Endurance skill increased by one. Current level 14.

My health drops to ten percent under the fanger's relentless attacks when suddenly... BANG a flash of red blossoms in my face and there's vampiric shrieking. POP! A flash of yellow. Health down to ten percent. POP-sizzle... Caustic green jelly flies everywhere melting hideous undead faces. Chemical smoke sputters and rises off their burning bodies. I, on the other hand, feel like I not only have a nasty sunburn, but a bunch of dickheads at the beach are playing some kind of slap the red girl game.

Aegis.

Do you wish to use Aegis to negate this fatal damage? You will become immune to all damage for 20 seconds. Warning: Aegis cannot be used again for 7 days.

3....

2...

I quickly choose yes. My skin shimmers like mercury as I no longer feel the pain of any of the attacks. Bang! An explosion sends a burst of liquid fire into the vampires around me. Many are on already flaming, flailing, fleeing mindlessly

My heart is beating in my ears. Tump bump thump bump thump bump bump bump!



In spite of my invulnerability, and earlier attempts at meditation, my vent meter's all the way in the red due to everything attacking me. *Fuck*. All the vampires are splotches of burgundy over a back drop of red. A figure lunges at me at the same time as I lunge for it something bursts off my chest and my would be prey liquefies under a g'nade's force. Other figures, thoroughly burning collapse and turn to ash. I leap on one of the few that are still standing, raking with my claws while it tries to sink its teeth into me, but my skin's impenetrable. I scratch and rend with my supernaturally potent were rat claws until it drops in a pile of ash.

I jump on the back of the nearest shape to me, but it crumples under my weight, as it had already been burning. My vision starts to return to normal. One more vamp, down to twenty percent health. I rush in with a punch to the gut. It flashes blue-white storm light. I hit it with my left. Thunder cracks. My ears ring. It drops to the floor unmoving. I pull out my Darksteel Chakram, still enchanted with Lesser Elemental Weapon - Fire, and spike it right into the monster's chest. It explodes into ash.

My breath draws heavily in my ears. My health's down to thirty percent. The door with the stairs leading up reluctantly opens. Pahrem waddles in. The metallic look of the Aegis spell fades, and I'm left with just my bleeding, furry, were-rat body. I say, "A little help please?" Noting the constellation of two pronged vampire bites decorating my skin.

"You're not gonna eat me?" Pahrem asks, and begins waving her hands to cast a heal. A halo of mending gold pops into being around me. The sore wounded muscle, and raw sunburn sensations on my skin fade like memories until all my wounds are repaired.

I say, "Let's not do that again."

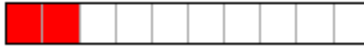
Tako comes in behind her and says, "That... was... AWESOME! Wait until you see the replay. Like, five of them were just demolished after the second burst. I bet you didn't even see it since you were wrestling with the ones that were trying to bite you!"

I kick a big pile of ash on the floor, scattering it across the stone, and grumble, "They were biting me. I was trying to keep myself calm so I wouldn't fly into the blood rage."

"Oh..." Tako says. "Good job with that."



Vent meter rising. "Go eat a dick." And now down to manageable.



Tako says, "You don't gotta be rude about it."

I snap. "Bite me."

Leroy taps his temple. "He's right. This is hot footage, plus we got to see you do that psycho rat thing again. A lot of my viewers never played Freeworld Online so it's even better!"

I dangle the seeking stone arrowhead on a string... It indicates we should open the other door. *I could have guessed that.* "I'll just be glad when I can go back to my normal body. I hate seeing things in shades of red, and having to worry about friendly fire."

Normal body. We've been in this game so long that some how half-elven Melpomine is what I've come to think of as myself, instead of my human meat suit in whatever set up keeps my heart beating. It gives me a chill that makes my breath shaky.

Frobod asks, "Did these guys drop anything?"

Tako says, "Regular coins and a bunch of vendor trash."

I say, "Just hold on to it for now. We'll split it up later."

The next gate creaks open. I look to Leroy and say, "Okay tank. You take the lead."

He nods and advances down another flight of stairs through a narrow passage. The bottom is a crossroad. One path leading ahead, and two hallways going right and left. The seeking stone tells me Zan's straight ahead.

Leroy says, "Ordinarily I'd suggest a full clear. I'll bet there are bosses on either side."

"No time." Tako says. "We've got to get back to town ASAP for the turn in so we can get the train quest."

"I agree." I say, leaving off the part about being eager to get rid of the seeking stone spell, and thus the wererat alias. "Sorry if it's not good for ratings, but we're only here to rescue Mirae."

Frobod says, "You're giving them a taste of this place, plus a look at the Shroudmoon Express. You're actually delivering more content."

Leroy holds his hands up in placation. "You don't have to convince me. We might still be able to catch the train with a full clear, but I'd rather have more time."

I say, "I also have a nightly ritual I have to do so.. yeah. There's that."

Leroy says, "Full steam ahead then."

I answer, "Lead the way."

This section of Ashfall Crypt feels less like a crypt and more like a castle. Shielded torches flicker on the wall, and every few paces there are colorful tapestries depicting battles, horses, or religious rights. One in particular catches my eye as it depicts a pallid man bleeding into a bowl from which a servant should drink. *Vampires.* It all feels so... lived in.

A warm light shines at the end of this corridor opening on a larger room. Fast footsteps run up behind us. Tako shouts, "Incoming!"

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

I disappear from my current location, and reappear directly behind a hunched creature with protuberant amphibian eyes, long clawed fingers, and a human torso. A violent barbed tail whips behind it like a raptor. My breath catches. *This is my baby.* It's the first time since being locked in game that I've encountered one of my own monstrous creations. My surprise causes me to lose focus as the creature makes a lunge for Pahrem who'd been bringing up the rear.

That snaps me out of my daze, as I call "Once man!" and then in a softer voice "Sorry Pahrem." as it connects with it's first attack, dropping her health by thirty percent. KA-CRAK! POW! I claw the creature in it's rear flank delivering a flash of lightning, and then hammer it in the ribs with my left fist. I snarl, "Come meet your maker!"

Taunt. Successful. Once man attacks.

I slip out of the way of a wicked claw. A quiet part of me fantasizes about the monster turning to see me, some how recognizing my face, and then backing off the attack, perhaps even joining our cause. No such luck. It opens it's mouth and launches a froglike tongue at my face. I catch it mid air, pull down, and reach for my Darksteel Chakram so I can cut it. It cauterizes as I sever, and I toss the squishy length of pink flesh to the floor.

Bastard!

I taunt. "I made you. I know all your tricks."

The once man's hips sashay, and that evil razor tail whips around seeking flesh. I duck, and it bashes into the cold brick wall. *Not this time.*

More footsteps, two more once men emerge in the corridor from whence we came. I shout "Leroy!" Not wanting to risk going into tank mode and savaging everyone.

"I'm on it!" He raises his burning hammer high into the air and calls out "Leeeeeooooooooooooooooooyyyyyyy Jeeeeennnnnnnnssssssseeeennnn!" his signature move. He shoulders Sajina out of the way, and rushes right past Pahrem to meet the new attackers. Even I'm knocked back against the wall as he smashes my once man in the face with his hammer, unleashing a flash of holy light, and keeps on moving. The man's like a super hero.

Instead of turning it's wrath back on me the once man I was hitting turns tail and chases Leroy. The paladin freight train smashes the new once man on the left with his shield, spins his hammer, and knocks the other in the chest filling the hall with another explosion of brilliant white.

"All in!" I say and throw my Darksteel Chakram at my original target. Sajina opens up with a volley of mage bolts on the one Leroy last smashed with his hammer, and Frobod unleashes a bolt of necromantic energy before rushing in with his sword in a valiant charge. My eyes meet Tako's, he shrugs, and shadow steps behind Frobod and Sajina's target, meanwhile Pahrem waves her hands, takes on a golden halo and brings her health back up to full.

I'm not the best ranged attacker, but I don't want to leave Pahrem and Sajina on their own in case there's another surprise attack, so as soon as my chakram reforms, it's spinning down the hallway and ripping into once man flesh. Leroy's doing a good job of holding the three attackers together, while Tako and Frobod cut into them from the sides. Sajina raises his hand, and casts another series of basic mage bolts.

It's calmer back here than in the thick of the battle. I toss another burning chakram, and say "How's that magic coming?"

Sajina says, "I'm doing okay but the damage isn't as good as yours and I keep running out of manna."

Pahrem waves her hand, and a bubble of healing gold appears around Leroy. It rains ethereal specks down on his head like ghostly glitter.

I say, "Sorry about that. You could always try putting a sword in your hand."

Sajina says, "I prefer to be out of harms way."

I throw my Chakram again. A Once man goes down. Just two more, but their attacks are swift and they're giving Leroy a good run for his money. A barbed tail smashes him in the face, and his health drops a shocking thirty percent. *They must have put fierce stats on these.* Pahrem fires off another heal. I don't know whether to be annoyed that they are slowing us down, or proud at creating such formidable monsters. Part of me wishes I could cast Smite to be more useful on healer protection duty, but I can't due to my current alias not being a clergy member.

"Tell you what." I say to Sajina. "If Ashe March or wherever we have to go to board the train, has a magic trainer I'll help you buy some more spells. I'd really like for you to learn Charismatic casting so you can roll Charisma rather than intelligence. Lore wise, it means you start approaching magic more like art. The important thing is that there should be some cross over with all those stats you use to make music."

Leroy brings down his hammer, and another once man drops in a bloody heap. Just one more to go and I can see Frobod chopping, beside Leroy, and Tako needling from behind. My chakram reforms, and I send it like a fiery guillotine at it's neck.

CRITICAL HIT

You hit Once Man for 14 damage.

Once man resists 8 points of damage.

Thrown skill increased by 1. Current level: 5.

It's head flies off its shoulders. Tako says "Uggghh!" and his clothes look bloody, which tells me that he's been playing the game on rated R mode, and just got showered in once man gore. I keep combat to the PG-13 rating for exactly this reason. Blood and guts flying around you in combat is distracting.

As the trio walk back, Leroy says, "Damn, those things pack a punch."

I nod. "Lore wise, they're fed vampire blood which makes them stronger. It adds one or more damage you have to resist to every successful attack that they don't even have to roll for."

Tako says, "I thought you said you didn't know what stats they gave them."

"I don't." I say, "But that's what happens to all living things that drink vampire blood, without being drained first."

Leroy says, "Should we try to just incapacitate this boss so we can take his blood?"

"Eh..." I'm tempted, given the combative benefits but ultimately shake my head no. "Freeworld's all about cool powers at nasty costs. Drink enough of it, and the vampire you drank from can start mind controlling you, and it's kind of addictive. Once you're hooked, you start getting debuffs for a while if you don't get a fix."

"Ouch." Leroy says. "Alright. We'll just ash him then."

"Also..." I begin, "I don't know if the vampire version of that shadow thing is anything like Shadow Retreat from Haven, but if he does it again, it might be worth trying to blast it with fire, light and holy magic given Freeworld vampires fire weakness."

"Good call." Leroy says.

Tako says, "Can we just go?"

I check the seeking stone and it's leading us directly to the well lit chamber at the end of the hall. I say, "Might as well before more once men show up."

Nothing attacks as we approach. We enter the next room to discover an antiquated lounge with plush red sofas and a bar stocked with wine glasses. I could imagine myself relaxing here for a 1920's costume party if not for the unconscious hog tied bodies hanging from the ceiling behind the bar counter. From what I can tell they're all humans in their undergarments. No boss in sight, but there is a man bound in chains, sitting on the sofa with slightly pointed ears. He stares despondently at the floor.

"Zan?" I ask, he looks up and startles, backing away in so far as his bonds will allow. It's only then that I remember that this is an NPC, and a Haven wererat would be ripping him apart just now.

My rage meter's not high enough for an instant change, so I walk myself through a slow shift from rat-woman back to human. My shiny brown hair sinks back into my skin, which becomes healthy and bright, as my long tail retracts back into my trousers. When my face is finally human I ask, "Are you Zan?"

The man says, "You're not... You're not a monster?"

I say, "No more than you or any of these louts." I motion to the rest of the party.

He says, "You've got to go, the monster will be coming back. You can't be here for him to find you."

Leroy says, "You still haven't answered the lady's question. Are you Zan?"

"Yes." He says. "Now go. Hurry."

Leroy says, "Marcy sent us, so you're coming with us."

I'm suddenly distracted by the seeking stone in my hand. It glows with eerie white light, and then erupts in a burst of magical motes which twist and

circle in the air until they settle into the form of the magpie spirit I bargained with.

The magpie caws, "Thus concludes our agreement. Lilly of the Rodekin. Call again if you want to feed me."

You have gained 200 repute with Magpie.

New classification of repute: Avian.

Avian spirits will be more helpful as your repute increases. Helpful spirits are more likely to teach new rites and shape changer abilities.

The Magpie says, "Farewell!" and takes to the air, flapping its wings right through a wall, disappearing like a phantom.

"Hold on." I say, "I'm gonna change again. Gotta get rid of the bitch meter."

Tako asks, "What's that?"

As I tap my VT to shift to my Melpomine alias, I say, "The thing that measures how close I am to ripping out all your throats."

"Oh..." Tako says. "There's a bar for that?"

Streamers of dark color enwrap me since my leathers are black and brown and both Mel and Lilly were wearing the same gear when last I used them. Zan looks perplexed as he says "What are you?"

I cock my head at him. This is the first time any of the Havenfolk have reacted to my switching aliases besides acknowledging pooled reputations. *Could it be that Havenfolk getting smarter is a gradual process?*

I say, "For now, I'm a half elf like you." *It feels so good to be back in my home skin.* I don't even feel the urge to snap at Tako for asking such an obvious question.

I look to the bodies hanging behind the bar. If this were a normal game where I could log out any time I wanted, I'd just get on with the quest, but now that I'm living here, however temporarily, I want to do something for them. I look to Pahrem and motion to the helpless humans, and ask "Can you do anything for them?"

"The NPCs?" She asks.

"Yeah." I say. "Leaving them up there feels wrong." Zan rattles his chains. "Tako you try to unlock him. I'm going to see about the people over there."

As it turns out, it's just rope that's binding them; not even magical. Each has been hoisted into the air via a pulley system which makes it easy enough to get them back on the ground. I use my chakram to cut through the ropes, but they're still unconscious.

Pahrem says, "There's not exactly a 'wake up' spell."

I say, "Try a normal heal. If that doesn't work..." I pause considering. "I'll figure out something."

Each of the three glows in turn—two men and a woman. I sigh in relief as I hear a punished "Ugh.." sounding from the woman, and indistinct groaning from the men. My first thought for waking them if Pahrem failed had been ice water, which I don't have. It would have been awkward hitting them with Move Like Ice.

I kneel down beside the closest body, the woman, and say "You're alright. Can you walk? We've got to get out of here."

All three bodies re-ignite with holy gold, as the woman stammers, "I... I think so." The goblin's healing must be doing wonders to ease cramped muscles. She, and the others struggle to their feet.

"Are you fae?" One of the men, named Jason, asks.

That surprises me. I haven't heard that term since I last played Freeworld Online, as "fae" is the catch all Freeworld term for faerie creatures.

"Ahh..." I say thinking how to answer. "Close enough. We're not in the Freeworld anymore"

The woman, named Annette, asks "Where are we?" Then her eyes discover Pahrem, and she asks "What is that?"

"She..." I put a lot of weight on that word. "Is our healer, and I don't have time to explain. We're in Hades, and a lot of the creatures you'll see are high fantasy."

"High Fantasy?" She asks.

I say, "Straight out of a Tolkein novel. We're the good guys and trying to rescue you, so if you can, please try to take things in stride so we can get out of here before the vampire comes back."

The other man, silent until now, named James, says, "I don't know what these guys are, but they can't be worse than the fangers. I say we shut up and do what she says."

"Thank you." I say, feeling an abrupt sense of relief. I look back to Zan and say, "Tako, how're those shackles coming?"

He says, "I'm trying. These things are magical and a lot harder than they look. "

Frobod asks, "Can we break the chain?"

"*Not easily.*" I think.

Pahrem says, "Cut his hands off. It'll be easier." Zan's eyes grow wide in panic, so she follows, "Relax, I'll put em' back. What kind of scrub healer do you think I am? No point in rescuing ya if you're just gonna bleed out and die."

"Errr." I say. "Even so that's gonna spill a lot of blood if he's not a ghost."

"So?" Pahrem says.

"Vampires..." I say. "Let's not ring the dinner bell. "

"I've got another idea." Leroy says.

"Thank the gods!" Zan says.

Leroy says, "Kneel down and put your hands on the floor."

Zan complies wearing an expression of gratitude for not losing any body parts. Leroy says, "What's that?" and points over Zan's shoulder. As soon as the half elf looks, Leroy brings his hammer down hard on his fingers. Zan opens his mouth to scream, but before he can Leroy's hammer drops again on the other hand filling the room with a meaty crunch that drives me to wince in sympathy.

Zan screams, "Ahhhh! You broke my hands! You broke my hands."

Leroy says, "I know. Be still." as he manhandles the half elf. Like a doctor explaining exactly what he's doing during a procedure, he says "Shattered thumbs and hands are a whole lot easier to...." He jerks Zan's hand out of the cuff. Zan screams. "Fit through small spaces. Other hand now." The half-elf recoils, but

there's not much he can do to escape Leroy's grasp. Still chained with one arm, he couldn't run if he wanted to. Zan shrieks as Leroy yanks the left cuff off, and says "Heals."

Before Pahrem can begin casting Zan says, "I liked the frelling vampires better."

The instant Pahrem's spell takes effect, Leroy says, "Don't be like that. You're free."

A golden aura engulfs Zan, and his breathing slows and becomes easier. Pahrem says, "What did I tell ya? I tell you goblins ain't got no respect."

I say, "Thanks Pahrem." then look to Zan and say "How do you feel?"

He hesitates, at first wearing a sheepish expression. Instead of meeting my gaze, he just stares at his now unshattered fingers with an expression of incredulous wonder. "I..." He begins. "I... feel okay..."

"Good." I say, "Now we've got to go. I'm surprised the boss hasn't attacked yet."

Leroy asks, "You want to go back on tank duty, now that you're back to normal?"

I say, "You can take it for the rest of the run. I'll off-tank guard the squishies."

Frobod, largely quiet until now, says "Alright let's move out." and hefts his greatsword.

I say, "Alright. Sajina and Pahrem you know the drill. Zan, Annette, Jason, James stay close to me and the green girl."

Jason says, "You have a gargoyle."

"Ahh.. Yep." I say. "That we do, but I don't own him. In Haven, the place we came from, they're a proper race, not something you take ownership of."

As soon as Leroy steps back into the hall across the threshold a human sized cylinder of black smoke sails into the chamber like a gaseous rocket. *Boss time.*

"Oh no, no." A smooth male voice says, the same we encountered while fighting George. "Stealing? Raiding the kitchen? Have I not been a gracious host?" The cloud of smoke condenses into a pallid male figure in a dark suit and wide brimmed fedora that reminds me of a 1920s gangster. A deep red handkerchief sticking out of his breast pocket evokes thoughts of blood. His name plate reads 'Dorian.' "I can't very well let you make off with all my food can I, and the elf? I'm still monitoring him."

"Monitoring?" I give Zan an inquisitive look. He turns his gaze down and away.

"Tell you what." Dorian runs his tongue over enlarged incisors, and says. "I'm charitable. Leave the elf and my humans here, and I'll let you leave unmolested. You can walk out of here free and unharmed. That mess with George was all a terrible misunderstanding."

Leroy says, "Not this time. Our buddy Zan over here has a family to get back to."

"Oh! A family." Dorian says, intrigued. "Are they like him? Why don't you invite them? You know what they say. two's a party. Three's a celebration!"

I say, "I don't think they say that."

"Oh, well I do. Especially when it involves..." He licks his lips. "Interesting little elves."

Frobod says, "This guy talks too much. Can we just..."

"ASTRAEA SMITE THEE!" Leroy waves his burning hammer and calls down a lance of divine energy. It connects with the handkerchief on Dorian's breast.

He grunts, "Oof! You just made a big mistake."

The vampire spreads his arms and fingers wide as if trying to catch a giant globe falling from the ceiling. Nothing comes, instead smoky tendrils of black billow out of his palms, mouth and fingertips.

Leroy rushes in with the charge raising his blazing hammer overhead, ready to turn the vampire into pulp. He bellows "Leeroooooooooyyyy Jennnnnnnseen!" Unfortunately he's not fast enough because before he can close the distance with Dorian the darkness creeping out of him has condensed into a murky blackness that distorts sound as if under water and makes it impossible to see. The air is heavy and hard to breathe.

A blue bar appears at the bottom of my interface "Suffocation."

Suffocation

Resist: Stamina + Endurance

(Caliber of Success: 14)

Success!

You take no damage.

Endurance skill increased by one. Current level 15.

Woot! Two endurance bumps in one run, and at current level fifteen. Pahrem's vampire bombs must have done a crap ton of damage to put me on the cusp of leveling Endurance again so soon.

...and well shit. Leroy and Frobod should be okay, but I'm worried about Pahrem, and Sajina since I can neither see nor hear them. Tako... I can't see him either, but I give him a fifty-fifty chance of resisting the suffocation effect.

In party chat I say, "Squishies are you okay?" My own voice is muffled and far away. I hear some kind of clunking from Leroy's general direction, and hope that in spite of the obscuring darkness he's managed to find his mark.

Pahrem responds, "Taking damage!" Her words received, by contrast are clear as a bell. Party chat sounds don't flow through the physical environment. They're more like mind voices.

I spin Bite in my hands looking for inspiration since there's nothing I can see to attack. It makes satisfying orange, red, and blue circle patterns as it moves. *If only I could attack the darkness.* I look down to my left hand and don't see anything, then to the end of my staff which still glows with smoldering light.

I look back to where my non-dominant hand should be and see nothing, then back to the end of my staff. *Why is that?* I wave it around and note that the blackness feels somehow thinner around it. I make a wide slow sweep with my weapon, and realize that I'm burning tunnels through the dark ether around us.

Using party chat again I say, "Fire kills the darkness! If you're not attacking the vamp directly move your weapons around."

Having an idea I hold my Darksteel Chakram right in front of my face like I'm about to blow out a flaming campfire marshmallow. I take a step back, sweep it through the space my head just occupied, and step back into the hole my weapon burned away. The suffocation bar disappears.

I say, "Once you burn away part of the darkness it sticks so you can get rid of the suffocation debuff."

Pahrem calls through party chat, "G'nade incoming!"

Tako says, "Like any of us can see it."

A glassy clink sounds from the center of the room. It sounds a lot farther than it probably is. Then another clink sounds, and another. *Oh shit.*

I say, "If you heard that, move the opposite direction."

Leroy says, "I'm clear at the bar I think. The boss is still on me."

"Good work." I say, "Keep taunting and tanking until we can become useful."

WOOSH! A gout of spectacular flame flares up to pierce the black some five or six paces in front of me. I'm thankful that by the look of everyone else's health meters, along the left hand side of my display no one got caught in friendly fire. After the suffocation damage, a fiery blast might well have ended our less enduring members.

FWOOF! The next fiery g'nade goes off, brighter this time and carving a greater cavern in the dark. When the third and final burst erupts, the darkness spell has been obliterated. I can't tell if this is because it has a limited duration, or if it automatically dissipates after enough of it has been eaten by fire. Little yellow and blue flames linger, dancing over the floor.

Pahrem's fast on the heals, as her, Sajina's and Tako's health spring back to full in bubbles of glimmering gold.

I say, "Get on the boss. Go go go!"

Tako shadow steps behind him, and pierces his suit with his burning blade. Frobod goes barreling in with his greatsword. A powerful CRACK sounds as Dorian punches Leroy's shield with his bare knuckles leaving a convex dent the size of a grapefruit. He counter attacks with his hammer and says, "You weren't kidding about free vamps hitting harder."

Dorian's health drops to sixty percent as soon as Frobod gets another nasty blow in with his monster sized blade. Tako takes him down to fifty with another strike with his dagger. Realistically, a blow like Frobod's should have destroyed an unarmed opponent, but when you're dealing with games and vampires the laws of physics don't always apply.

I hurl my burning chakram and Sajina launches a volley of purple mage bolts when the entire room goes faint as if someone half twisted the knob on a dimmer switch. The light fixtures on the wall and the chandelier casts indistinct halos like lanterns in fog. At the same time, Dorian's body collapses into a 2D shadow on the lounge floor and our own shadows grow artificially long and menacing.

The boss says, "You cannot kill that which is immortal. You cannot strike that which has no body."

In a move straight out of the pages of Peter Pan our own shadows take on a life of their own, peeling off the floor like ribbons of tape, and leveling shadowy weapons with inverted fire auras right at us. I'm quick on the uptake, as I spine bite, and smash my shadow double in the shoulder. It makes a sound like beating a pillow, unsatisfying compared to fighting flesh and bone. Nevertheless as soon as bite makes contact electricity jumps from my primary target to Pahrem and Sajina's shadow doubles so now they are all facing me.

Leroy calls out, "ASTRAEA SMITE THEE!" but I can't see his target given all the shadow bodies around me.

Using party chat I say, "DPS to me or Leroy so we can round em' up."

Shadow Sajina hits me with a trio of mage bolts, but it feels like nothing. *Is their strength determined by our stats?*

Leroy says, "Everyone with fire keep on the boss. Off tank, round up the shadows!"

"I'm on it!" I say, and dip out of the path of a clumsy unarmed strike from Pahrem's double, and then out of the way of a hit from shadow-Bite. My Swiftstrike Kicker dodge counter rises. Rather than using Bite to counter attack, I hurl my Darksteel Chakram at Leroy's double since it's the biggest threat. It connects, the living shadow looks around, then comes charging at me. Metallic clanks sound as Frobod and Leroy beat against the floor. I dip out of the way of another one of my twin's attacks, and shadow Pahrem and Sajina's unarmed strikes are so bad they don't require dodging.

I then shout "Hey!" at Tako's double and spin my staff.

Taunt. Successful.

Shadow Puppet (TakoStar) attacks.

Great. Just one more to go.

I perform an improbable acrobatic leap that sends me soaring through the air as if in lunar gravity. My foot barely clears my shadow self's head and I come down on the ground behind it, dragging the group of shadow people away from the vulnerable members of the party. I smash shadow Leroy's chest with Bite to build up agro, and electric arcs crawl over its body then jump to the others.

CRACK. KLACK.. CUNK.

Leroy, Frobod, and Tako smash the boss's shadow body, and damage the environment beneath. It tries to evade and run, but every few steps it's bombarded by a new flurry of strikes. *Is that actually working?* I spare a glance for Dorian's shadow body, and am surprised to see it's all the way down to twenty percent health.

Frobod's shadow double is about to chop him from behind, but I intercept it plunging my staff into its flank. Unfortunately I've closed the distance so fast that the other shadows are out of the area of effect radius. No matter, I still have all their attention so I begin backing into the far left corner near where Zan was chained.

I say, "I've got em' all in the corner. Fire on boss, everything else on adds."

Now positioned with my back to the corner of the chamber, Leroy's double comes in swinging a powerful hammer that misses by centimeters as I

duck out of the way. I can't see the rest of the party because I'm surrounded by a half circle of shadow doubles. Shadow Frobod comes in with a ferocious strike, and I parry with Bite. I expect a clang, but like making contact with the bodies, the impact is announced with a muffled poof.

Now Shadow Me is a part of the action, and nicks me with the shadow version of my own weapon. At the same time as I feel the ticklish jolt of electricity, from Shadow Me's strike, a tiny spidery lightning bolt jumps from my boots to the shadow person's chest. I counterattack with Bite sending a second, more powerful blast of electricity into my twin which then spreads to all shadow attackers.

I parry one of Shadow Tako's strikes, and dance out of the way of Shadow Frobod. Shadow Leroy unfortunately uses my evasion to land a vicious strike in my core mass. In a single blow, my health drops to forty percent.

I yell, "Damn it, Leroy! You're too strong." and grimace under the muted pain. It's not like getting hit with a steel hammer in the real world, but losing that much health in a single blow is still unpleasant.

A moment later, one of Pahrem's heal bubbles enwraps me, and I begin to mend. Up to fifty percent now. In not too long I'll be fully restored.

More clacks and clanks as metal weapons crash against hard floors and stone walls through Dorian's shadow body. Leroy says, "Almost!"

CLANG! CRACK! It sounds like someone just busted through the wall. Dorian releases a theatrical "Nooooooooo!!!" and then bursts into ash. All of my shadow opponents disappear with him. In the place of his body is a chest of loot.

WORLD FIRST

Congratulations!

You are the first to complete the Ashfall Crypt dungeon. As a result you have been awarded:

Point Break x1

Point Break! You have gained ten points to distribute among attributes

"Woo!" Pahrem says. "Point break! That ain't nuthin' to sneeze at."

Leroy says, "Whatever's down those side corridors must be optional."

"Everyone get it?" I ask. Everyone answers with "Got its" and "Yeahs" in the affirmative. I motion to Tako and say, "Go ahead and loot."

He opens the chest, and says, "About a hundred Hades marks, and 300 regular gold. Oh, and a 'Shackle Key.' I guess that was supposed to be for you." He looks to Zan.

Leroy says, "Sorry man. If I'd known it'd be that easy I wouldn't have broken your hands." Zan frowns and looks like is about to protest, but then seems to remember that our healer set his broken flesh and bone to right mere moments after they were ruined.

The rest of the loot is anti-climatic, a sword, a plate wrist guard, and a cloth bracelet. They're cool in the sense that we're the first players to obtain them, but nothing special in terms of stat upgrades for most of us.

I say, "I say we roll for them. Top three can choose an item, though I'd like to suggest that guild members consider donating gear to the armory for less advanced members."

Frobod says. "I'm good with that."

Leroy says, "You can take mine as long as you don't mind me going through all the donations at the end of the quest to make a clip of what the new gear looks like."

"That's fine with me." I say. "Thanks for the donation."

Leroy says, "None of this will help me anyway."

I say, "Alright roll 'em."

Melpomine rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 8

Frobod rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 6

LeroyJensen rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 10

TakoStar rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 8

Pahrem rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 4

Sajina rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 10

I look to Tako and ask, "Keep or donate?"

Tako says, "Donate. Whatever."

"Alright." I say. "Sajina? What do you want to do?"

Leroy says, "Give him the bracelet. It's gotta be better than whatever he's got."

I look to the gargoyle, who shifts uncomfortably. He says, "OK I'll take the bracelet."

Ashen Bracelet

Type:	Cloth
Slot:	Wrist
Armor	1
Quality:	Rare
Equipped Bonus:	Intellect +3, Stamina + 2

The rest of us respond in a chorus of "gratz," which is customary for an upgrade.

I say, "Let's do our point breaks and then head out." For me it's as simple as opening and closing the window. After raising my stamina up to 21 last time, I only have 20 points to spend. Raising twenty three natural Dex up to twenty four for a grand total of twenty five with my racial bonus will cost about 69 points, another bump in Stamina will be 63, and for the time being those are the only stats I care about. I'll need a few more Point Breaks before I'm ready to spend anything.

Of the group, only Pahrem and Sajina seem to be taking their time as they poke around their virtual tablets. "Done!" Pahrem says, as her VT vanishes into nothing.

Frobod asks, "What'd you get?"

Pahrem says, "Bumped up my intelligence again."

Leroy says, "Never a bad thing for a healer."

Pahrem says, "Yeah, and it helps my craftin' too so double whammy."

I say, "You might consider dexterity in the future if you're gonna make a habit of hurling exploding objects."

Pahrem says, "I thought about it. That's why it took so long, but I figure the stuff I'm throwin' doesn't have to be too exact to be awesome. Besides, I got good athletics."

"Fair point." I say.

"Is that what I should do?" Sajina asks, still staring down at his VT. "Intelligence for more manna?"

Leroy says, "Only if you want to become a traditional mage style caster. My advice is to bank it and see if we can get you started on charismatic casting. If you make the switch you'll get more manna from Charisma, and roll your charisma rating rather than Intel when you're casting spells."

I say, "There's also dex and stam if your physical stats are still low."

Leroy says, "I forgot about that. I keep forgetting you're a noob when it comes to adventuring. Let me see what you've got."

Sajina shows him his VT, "Alright, yeah. Your Charisma and Dex are prime, but go ahead and buy the next level of Stam. You might want to do that a couple more times before you raise anything else so you don't die in one hit if you somehow manage to pull agro."

Sajina taps the surface of his tablet in a way that I assume confirms Leroy's Stamina suggestion. I feel kind of bad for hijacking the build and play of Sajina's character but there's only so much a Bard can do combatively speaking in a small party. Usually they take on the role of light DPS and off heals, but it appears Sajina never leveled his weapon abilities.

Tako asks, "Are we good to go?"

I look to the group, including Zan and the trio of humans we rescued, "Everyone?"

Frobod says, "I'm ready."

Annette, one of the formerly hog tied humans. says, "I wish I wasn't so naked."

I fish my starting gear out of inventory and pass the straw colored linen pants and shirt to Annette. I ask, "Anyone got something basic for them to put on? Vendor trash?" I look to Tako since he's usually the one looting.

He sighs, no doubt loathe to give up the coin he'd get from selling common items, and says "Here..." tossing common, statless items to Jason and James. "Just hurry up. I want to get moving."

Annette, in a thankful tone, says, "I'll give them back to you when I can get some clothes of my own."

Tako says, "Now, are we ready?"

Heads nod, and Leroy says, "Let's go."

I look to the frightened NPCs and it dawns on me that they've been surprisingly level headed throughout their rescue and the boss fight. Their body language is insecure, with their arms held close to their bodies, but no one's

having a nervous breakdown. I wasn't looking at them during combat, and couldn't see anything through all the darkness, so I wonder if they entered a vacant trance for the duration of the battle.

I say, "Just stick close to me, Pahrem and Sajina on the way out and you'll be fine. Same as when we fought the vampire."

Jason says, "Can you get us back home? I don't even know where here is."

The following quest is now available.

Quest - They're Not Dead!

Difficulty: Variable

You have successfully rescued Annette, Jason and James from the vampire Dorian and his minions. Fortunately, or unfortunately as the case may be, they're not dead. Escort them back to the lands of the living, or make them permanent residents of Hades.

WARNING: Humans require food and drink to survive.

Bonus (Limited Edition):

Lord Zarentu of Dragonswood Keep, seeks more information about the Free World, and providing him with natives of that plane may yield valuable intelligence about the rip between worlds and earn his favor.

Objectives (Easy):

Annette made permanent resident of Hades	0/1
Jason made permanent resident of Hades	0/1
James made permanent resident of Hades	0/1

Objectives (Moderate):

Annette immigrates to Haven	0/1
Jason immigrates to Haven	0/1
James immigrates to Haven	0/1

Objectives (Hard):

Annette returned to the Free World	0/1
Jason returned to the Free World	0/1
James returned to the Free World	0/1

Bonus (Limited Edition)

Bring Annette, Jason, and James to Lord Zarentu	0/1
--	------------

Rewards:

Dependant on grade of success.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes.

"One thing at a time." I say. "First step was to get rid of the guy who imprisoned you, now we've got to clear out of enemy territory." My voice rises. "Everyone. Just hold your questions until we get back to town, and don't eat anything unless one of us gives it to you. The food's not safe here."

An expression of glee enters Frobod's face. "Hold up. Did you guys just get a quest?" I can read the unspoken hope in his expression - logout button.

"Yeah." I say.

"Got it." Tako says.

"Cool beans." Pahrem follows. "A limited edition bonus."

Leroy says, "I don't have anything about this being limited edition."

Sajina says, "Neither do I."

I say, "That's because you're not Toxic Muffins. It has something to do with a quest we got back in Dragonswood, and an alliance I struck up between our guild and Lord Zarentu."

Leroy stares at me slack jawed with a confused "O" parting his lips.

"What?" I ask.

"Your guild has an alliance with an NPC settlement?"

I say, "Yeah, Dragonswood Keep."

Leroy asks, "It's official? A signed treaty and everything? Not just a rep grind?"

I say, "Yeah... Why?"

Leroy says, "How is that even possible?"

I say, "Diplomacy, I guess. It's only good for a year. After that we've got to renegotiate."

Frobod adds, "Tako and I were there. She negotiated it as part of her winnings from the Dragonswood Tournament."

"I don't know whether to be shocked or impressed." Leroy says. "I didn't know the game was programmed for that. It's like you've uncovered a secret that no one even suspected could exist."

I uneasily scratch the back of my head as my thoughts drift to Archangel. "I guess this is part of what they meant by enhanced realism."

Leroy's face scrunches as if fighting an internal battle. "I guess this means you're gonna want to do the moderate quest line if your bonus has something to do with Dragonswood."

"I think so." I say.

The pro-gamer sighs. "Damn. I would have liked to try for Freeworld, that said, anything connected to an in-game alliance between a guild and a hamlet might be worth documenting. Do you mind if I follow you around for the turn in so I can make a video?"

"Talk about it after we rescue Mirae." I say. "That's why we're all here."

Tako says, "I was gonna say we just kill them all and make em' permanent residents. We don't have time."

Annette gasps.

I put a comforting hand on her forearm, and say. "He doesn't mean that. We're only in the underworld to rescue a friend, and he's afraid that helping you will take too much time from our objective."

"We won't be a burden!" Annette says. "I promise."

My stomach twists. 'I don't want to be a burden anymore.' was one of the last things Mirae said to me before she died. I look to Annette who's now thoroughly shaken. "We're not leaving you behind. One way or another, we'll get you to safety... and not as new immigrants to Hades. You might have to come to our world first however. There's someone we know who'd like to meet you. It's not quite like the Free World, but the magic is grand, the feasts are great, and the residents are all breathing. From there we can see about getting you back home."

James says, "As long as they're not going to eat us."

Tako says, "He is a dragon."

Annette's eyes widen.

I give Tako a look and say, "You're not helping." I re-center my attention on the rescuees, say, "He's a good dragon." and then shifting to address the group as a whole, "Let's move out."

Leroy says, "Got it.... I keep forgetting we're pressed for time."

The other players nod their agreement, and the four NPCs cluster around Pahrem, Sajina and me in the back as we take our first steps along the path out of the dungeon.

A lot of dungeons have portals at the end that will take you back to where you started. They save you a bit of time and the manual effort of going back to the beginning. Not so with the Ashfall Crypt. Splashes of dark, drying blood decorate the floors and walls where we'd done battle, though the enemy corpses have all disappeared as they are prone to do after looting.

Now, I'm part of the caboose of our train of people heading up the narrow staircase leading to the arena where we blew up all the vamps. It smells of blood, scorched enemies, and alchemical destruction but there's no sign of hostile respawns.

The thought that George's ghosts might have cleared any mobs we might have missed hits me when a soft melodic sound touches my ears from behind. I slow.. "Ah. Ah. Ah. Ah. Bum da de do." *That's music.*

I say, "Stop." Leroy halts at the front of our parade, right on top of a giant splatter of old blood on the floor. We're now closing in on the entry hall with the tall statues where we fought the starving vamps. Everyone follows his example. He looks over his shoulder and gives me a questioning look. "I think I hear something." The halls of the crypt, bathed in their crimson light, are too quiet. I can almost hear my pulse. There's no music.

"Never mind." I say. "I must be crazy."

Jensen shrugs, and continues on. We pass beneath the gazes of those eerie statues that greeted us in the first segment of the crypt when I hear it again.

"Ah. Ah. Ah. Dum bum aliveeeee."

"Stop!" I say. "Did you hear that?"

Leroy turns and says, I didn't hear anything.

Sajina says, "I heard it."

"Oh thank God." I say. "I'm glad I'm not the only one."

A deep. dark. silence descends as we all pause to listen, punctuated by the bloody lighting and sinister décor. My skin tingles and muscles tense, anticipating another Once Man leaping out of the shadows to tear into us.

Ten seconds. Nothing. Twenty, armor rustles as Frobod stirs in place. The longer we wait, the more sinister the environment feels. I want to get out of here, but I hate the idea of being stalked and ambushed even more. Give me a proper head on battle any day.

"Ah. Ah. Ah. Ah."

Sajina exclaims, "That's the melody of Stayin' Alive!" He launches into singing the first verse. his voice becomes improbably high for his monstrous stone skinned avatar. He's full on finger pointing into the air by the time he hits the chorus.

Zan's eyes go wide, as he begs "I'm sorry! I sing when I'm nervous."

Pahrem asks, "Ya know... disco?"

Zan's face goes red, "Don't judge me! You don't know what it was like."

I say, "That's not quite what she was getting at. You're a half-elf like me. How do you know disco?"

"It's the vampire." Zan says.

The prisoner Jason, shudders behind me. "No joke."

I say, "I'm missing something."

"You don't know what it's like without adventurers in the Dungeon. All disco all the time. From the bastard's... juke... box..." The words sound foreign in the Haven man's mouth. "The Bee Gees. Y.M.C.A.... Funky Town! I swear that bastard serenaded us with I Will Survive just to taunt us, but after a while... it starts sinking in and you find yourself tapping your foot and bobbing your head."

I hear Tako murmuring "Funky town... a-funky town." I give him a look. He says, "What? Funky Town. It's a good song."

Frobod, quiet until now says, "You're telling me that the noir shadow man had a secret passion for disco?"

"Had." Annette corrects, in a weary voice. "He's dead now."

James says, "Good riddance."

Leroy says, "Can't judge a book by it's cover I guess."

Tako, seeming to have forgotten his Funky Town amusement, says "Mystery solved. Can we go? We still got a train to catch."

I sigh, and say, "He's right. Sorry. I was just afraid we were going to be ambushed." I look to Zan and say, "Your good. Just... don't spook me like that. It's time to get you back to your wife." I'd expected him to be happy, but instead he looks down and away reluctant to meet my eyes. "What?"

"Nothing." Zan says. "Lets just go."

We're at the exit portal now, and are greeted by the specters of the people that composed George. The man with the flannel shirt and ruddy beard kneels, before us and says "We are forever grateful."

"Stand." I say, "Come with us through the portal. There's a village near here, that you can make your new home. They're good folk who'll help you start your new life."

"New life..." The lumberjack says.

"New life!" The rest of the ghosts echo.

The guy who looks like Santa says, "Go, Lord Melpomine, and we will follow."

The following quest is now available.

Quest - New Life!

Difficulty: Easy

By destroying George, the Blood Horror, you have freed the souls of the people that were used to create him. They're all dead now, thanks to you, and homeless. Guide them to a Hades settlement and register them as new citizens at the town hall.

Objectives:

Ghosts registered 0/1

Rewards:

56 Gold

10 Hades Marks

Ring of Hades Fellowship (Rare)

+500 Reputation in Settlement

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes.



Chapter 13 - In Death We Are Parted

My foot touches down on soft, dry earth in the way of portals. Party members materialize behind me along with no small number of NPCs. I wave my middle finger and shout "INFERNO!!!" then pump my fist in the air and declare "Let's ride!" One by one Fire, Earth, Air, Ether, and Water elechoppers materialize with pops of light and guzzles of magical engines. An avian screech sounds as Leroy calls forth his phoenix mount in a wave of heat and a pulse of fiery light.

"Woooooooow." Annette, and several of George's ghosts cry in unison. Awe paints their faces. I'm about to leap into my spiel about how the elechoppers come from another world with alien magic, but the words die on my lips when I realize it's not our bikes they're gaping at. All eyes on Leroy as he mounts his resplendent bird.

Speaking to the three Freefolk, the name given to NPC residents of Freeworld Online, I say, "We come from a place of magic, similar to and yet not at all like your own. The emergence of magic in the 60s never happened, because it never disappeared from Haven in the first place. Try to think of your favorite fantasy books and movies, and that might prepare you for what Haven's like."

Annette says, "I know, that's what you said, but it's a wonder to see such a creature in the flesh. I can feel the heat on my face. How is it that he doesn't burn?"

Pahrem says, "What am I chopped livas? You got little green ladies where ya come from? And what about him? Guy's six feet of walkin' stone."

I ignore Pahrem's comment for a moment and say, "Magic." with a shrug. I then look to the goblin and continue, "Freeworld has a type of Gargoyle." I straddle my fire chopper, and the rest of the players follow. "We can each take a passenger, but there's no way we've got room for all the ghosts."

Mr. Lumberjack says, "We will follow."

I ask, "Sure you can keep up?"

He reiterates, "We will follow."

"Alright." I say, "You three and Zan pick your partner." I pat the back of my seat, and the rescued half-elf reluctantly snuggles up behind me. His eyes are still downcast, and not a word about alien magics. *Captivity hasn't been good to him.* Annette, James, and Jason get behind Frobod, Tako, and Pahrem respectively. *No one's too keen on buddying up with a gargoyle.*

Looking to the ghosts I say, "The town's called Ashe March if you get lost. The signs, and anyone you encounter should be able to direct you." Then to everyone else I say, "Hold on tight. These things fly."

A little gasp sounds from Annette as Frobod's bike lifts off the ground, but everyone else is taking the novelty of soaring motor bikes in stride. Flying over treetops so we don't have to worry about fighting boars, the ride back to town is refreshing and peaceful with wind beating at my face. Zan's arms fasten around me like a mannequin, not a word passes his lips.

I pause at the crossroad beyond Ashfall Forrest to regroup and make sure our passengers are okay. To my surprise, George's ghosts bust out of the trees on foot right behind us. I'd expected them to arrive at the settlement an hour or so behind us, but I guess being part of a guide quest they're able to keep up regardless of how fast we travel.

I say, "We good?"

Frobod says, "Yeah."

Tako says, "Keep going." as they breeze past.

I look down as I accelerate, George's ghosts glide over the earth like marathon runners in fast motion. As NPCs, they don't draw agro from world monsters unless they're part of an opposing faction, or a world event. Some minutes later, I bring my bike down in front of Ashe March's gate and wave to the guard.

"Lord Melpomine." He says, more in acknowledgement than respect given our lack of reputation in Hades. "I see you've returned..." He trails. "With guests."

"That's right." I say. "New recruits to make Ashe March stronger. Can you direct me to the town hall?"

"Sure." He says, more warmth in his voice after announcing that I intend to support the town. "If I may see your map." I hand it over, and he marks a building with his finger, that leaves a red dot. "It's a large structure. You can't miss it."

The other bikes are touching down around me, and I say "I've got directions to the town hall. Let's take care of the ghosts, and then settle things with Zan."

"Job first." Tako says.

I say, "You really want to go to the adventurer's hall with all these people following?"

Leroy says, "Start with the town hall so we can collect the item, then we can split up and take care of what we've got to do. We'll probably get credit if just one of us returns Zan."

"Sounds like a plan." I say. "This way." as I begin rolling down the street.

The town hall looks much the same as all the other Ashe March buildings, white stucco walls, with heavy brown timber forming the frame. A desk, much like that of the adventurer's hall greets us in the foyer, with a little bespectacled woman knitting a pink sock sitting behind it.

She sets her knitting aside, and says, "Welcome to the town hall, how may I help you?" Her eyes drift to all the people behind me, and she amends "...all of you."

I say, "We've got some new souls that were just released in Hades. They'd like to make a life here."

She says, "Immigration then. We don't get many new ones this far out. They usually cross the rivers."

I say, "Yeah well... They had a hard time of it."

The woman, named Penny, rifles through her desk and pulls out a stack of forms. "Each of you needs to fill out one of these, date, and make your mark."

Frobod says, "I had no idea death was so bureaucratic."

"Hah!" Penny says, finding genuine amusement in his comment. "Paperwork makes the world go round. You didn't think we just let people come and go as they please did you? There are hells out there, and some individuals deserve to be in them. That's why new arrivals, must register as citizens." She nudges a form toward me.

I say, "I'm not immigrating." but take the stack of forms anyway and distribute them to George's ghosts.

Penny says, "If you don't remember how you died, see me for form 2b. If you have no memory of your life at all, you will also need 2c. The rest of you, please be sure to include your last living residence."

One of the women, the one with the rolling pin if I'm not mistaken says, "What if we were kidnapped?" She has a stubby pencil in her hand. "Do we write our final home, or the place we were taken?"

Penny asks, "What was the duration of the kidnapping?"

The woman says, "Ten months."

Penny says, "One year is what we use to establish residency, unless of course you purchased land which your descendents continue to occupy to this day. Please write your prior home address, as your abduction only lasted 10 months." She looks over the crowd of ghosts. "I trust this is the same for all of you?"

There are murmurs of ascent.

Frobod asks, "How did you know..?"

Penny winks and says, "They look like a set." She then looks to the rest of us in turn. "As for the rest of you, Ashe March appreciates your contribution to our community, and on behalf of Mayor Chatsworth, I would like to present you with a token of our appreciation." She ducks behind her desk and withdraws six velvet sacks that clink when they hit the countertop.

I loosen the draw string and peer inside.

You have completed the quest New Life!

You have gained:

56 Gold

10 Hades Marks

Ring of Hades Fellowship

+500 Reputation in Ashe March

I examine the ring.

Ring of Hades Fellowship

Type:	Ring
Slot:	Finger
A armor	0
Quality:	Rare
Equipped Bonus:	

Charisma +2, Stamina + 1

Residents of Ashe March will regard you as having one reputation level higher. (Maximum: Honored).

Glancing between Penny and the ghosts, I ask "Are we good here?"

Penny says. "That'll be all we need from you. We'll get these folks set up in temporary housing until they can establish homes and trades for themselves."

Lumberjack says, "We are forever grateful."

* * * * *

We're heading toward the adventurer's hall when I say, "I think we need to do the thing with Zan first."

"Why?" Tako asks.

I say, "Milnus said we wouldn't qualify for the train job until we finish the other one. The job's not finished until Zan's back with his wife."

Zan looks away.

Tako says, "Who's Milnus?"

I say, "The gnome with the quests."

Tako says, "Oh him."

Leroy says, "I'm gonna take Sajina to the hall to work out a contract. You should take Zan back home and everyone else can do what they want."

"Me?" Sajina asks.

Leroy says, "Yeah, bard. You're Mr. Charisma. We've got three more passengers on a full train. We've got to see if there's a way to earn their passage."

"I don't know..." Sajina says.

Frobod says, "It's Soc stuff. Just do your thing. No fighting. Just be charming, and pretend you're back in Durolan."

Sajina takes a deep breath and considers. I imagine him picturing himself the center of attention back at Fire and Soul, and he becomes more confident. "Alright." He says. "I've got this."

Leroy looks to the Gargoyle and says, "Equip your ring."

I say, "That just leaves Zan. I'm going. Who wants to come?"

Frobod says, "I'll go."

"Anyone else?" I ask. No responses. "Looks like it's just us." I regard Annette, James, and Jason and say "Go with Leroy to the Adventurers' Hall. We'll be back later."

It feels like Frobod and I haven't been alone in ages as we ride to Marcy's house, and I ask "How are you holding up?" Zan shifts his weight on the back of

my bike to remind me that we're not exactly alone. He's so quiet, hanging on like a dead weight that it's easy to forget him.

Frobod says, "I'm holding. Actually I'm pretty excited about the Zarentu thing. This could be the break we've been looking for."

I shrug. A part of me feels like the way out of Freehaven isn't coming from Dragonswood, but I keep it to myself. I have no concrete reason for believing it, it's just intuition. "We'll find the way sooner or later. Stay strong."

"Stay strong." He holds out his gauntleted fist for a fist bump, and I tap it with my own gloved hand.

We're approaching Marcy's cottage when I hear Zan groan. I turn my head to address him in profile, and say "You okay back there dude?"

He groans again. "So... hungry..."

"They forget to feed you?" I say, "You can have some of my rations when we get to your wife."

The only reply is a moan from the man that reverberates through my back. Frobod eyes him suspiciously.

We roll to a stop in front of Marcy's cottage, with the wood trim and adorable circular windows. I cut the engine.

"I'm..." Zan speaks in a punished voice. "... sorry."

"Huh?" That's all I can say, before a sharp pain sticks into my neck. I gasp, "Ahhhuugh!" but the short moment it takes me to produce that sound is all it takes for the pain to be replaced by pleasure. I can't move my limbs, and I don't care as waves of heat, and floaty tingling euphoria pulse through me, starting at my neck and stirring through my entire body. I moan, a "Ugh... mmmm" A sound far too sexual for my liking, and yet I also don't care like laughing gas at the dentist. It's so... good. I'm melting.

I feel a trickle of blood roll down my neck when suddenly there's a powerful crash, I'm in the dirt, and my big red fire choppers on it's side on the ground beside me. The ether bike's on the ground too. *Where's Zan?* I touch my neck, and am shocked to find all my fingers covered in hot red blood. The wound hurts when I touch it. It stings; the pleasure a fading dream.

I'm just getting my bearings when I realize Frobod's charging Zan with his great sword, as the man scuttles backward in the dirt.

"I'm sorry!" The half-elf cries, mouth smeared with blood, and bloody tears tracking down his face. Somehow he manages to evade Frobod's downward strike. The greatsword smashes into the dirt.

Frobod bellows, "We rescued you!" He swings again, potent and chaotic, another blow that misses the mark. "We risked ourselves to bring you back to your wife, and this is how you repay us?"

Zan raises his hands defensively as if to fend off a blow, much good may it do him should Frobod connect. He whines, a pitiful sound "I was just... so... hungry."

"I don't care!" Frobod roars. "You don't attack her!"

"STOP!" I shout. "It's not his fault. I didn't realize he'd been changed. It takes a few days for the transformation to complete."

Frobod's still a thunderhead, but at least he's not swinging. I hurry to my feet and extend a hand to help Zan up. I say, "Jeeze man. It's not like I was really gonna die. You're gonna risk screwing up our quest for this?"

Frobod barks, "You don't know that."

Zan takes my hand and unsteadily hobbles to his feet. Thankfully, he makes no effort to gnaw on my wrist. I say, "So what. I get drained dry. You pick up my corpse, and haul me back to Pahrem and Leroy. Sheesh. We've got 3 resers. If you kill him in front of his wife's house there's no telling what would happen. You wanna miss the train?"

Frobod hrumphs. "I didn't like the sounds you were making."

"Dude. Free-vamp bites inflict Ecstasy." I say. "It's how they feed without their victims fighting. Some people even get addicted to it."

Frobod says, "Yeah, I know." sounding petulant. "I just didn't want you to respawn outside of Hades."

I give him a sarcastic smile and say, "I'm sure that's all it was."

I look back to the cottage and find Marcy standing in the doorway, horror stricken. Her face is bone white, and her mouth hangs agape. I lead Zan. He shuffles like a prisoner on his way to death row. He's crying blood, as my blood stains my neck and the lower half of his face.

Marcy says, "What happened to you?"

Zan chokes up. "Vampires. They got me... They... changed... me. I need blood to survive."

Marcy takes a deep breath, holding something back so she can be the strong one in the relationship. She says "Okay..." She pauses. "Then you can take mine. I know you won't kill me."

"I can't!" Zan wails.

"And why's that?" Marcy says.

"Because you don't have any! Your dead!"

Marcy says, "Oh..." then continues in a quiet mutter. "So new to this, near forgot about that."

Frobod and I exchange looks, as he says, "What do you want to do?"

Marcy says, "It's simple then. You've got to go back. Live your life and I'll be waiting for ya."

Zan sobs, "I'm immortal."

Marcy scoffs, "Vampires can be killed. No use denying it."

Frobod gives voice to what Zan's thinking, "Vampire souls go to Tartarus."

Zan nods, confirming the assumption. "I'll go to hell."

"Ahh.. uhmm..." I say clearing my throat. "Not necessarily. It hasn't been more than a week since he changed you right?" Zan wordlessly shakes his head no. "So the transformation isn't complete. There's a chance that if you died today you'd become a ghost like any other. You haven't killed anyone have you, except in self defense?"

He shakes his head no. Soundless, his eyes are red, and wet with bloody tears.

I look to Frobod, he looks down at his VT and says "The quest hasn't updated. How do you even know that?"

I say, "I've played a bunch of vampires. They are more manageable in my opinion than weres. The transformation from human, if you started the game that way, takes a week. In that time you gradually take on more of their powers and weaknesses."

Shaking, Zan says. "You have to kill me."

Marcy says, "The hell you will! ... and send you to Tartarus? Ya want to be damned?"

Zan says, "You heard what they said. It's the only way we can be together."

Marcy says, "I won't have it! Not if there's even a chance you're damning yourself in the process."

Quest Update: Missing Hunter - In Death We Are Parted

Zan asks you to kill him, yet Marcy rejects this proposition. There's no guarantee Zan will return as a ghost if you strike the fatal blow, and yet it may be the only way to reunite the lovers. There are two paths you may follow to complete this quest.

Objective- Zan:

Decapitate Zan 0/1

Objective - Marcy:

Escort Zan back to Haven 0/1

Frobod grips his Greatsword and says, "Let's make this quick."

Marcy shrieks, "No!!!" but it's too late.

Zan bows his head, and Frobod comes in with a two handed swing without another word of discussion. The head goes flying, as Marcy wails, and beats Frobod's armor with her tight fist.

I'm more interested in what happens to Zan's body. While a large percentage of his flesh bursts into ash, unlike Dorian the half-elf vampire leaves behind a blackened skeleton with charred hunks of meat clinging to its bones. Marcy continually beats Frobod's chest, his face is stony and impassive. The widow's sobs are painful. I feel a part of me dying.

Quest Update: Missing Hunter - In Death We Are Parted

Zan has died. Escort him to the town hall and register him as a citizen of Ashe March.

Objective:

Register Zan as a citizen of Ashe Marche. 0/1

As soon as the prompt appears, a ghostly body takes shape from within the bones, seeping out of them like an ethereal jelly and condensing into a human... half-elf shaped form. I squat beside the bones, and extend my hand which the

gelatin figure grasps. I stand and pull the new ghost up, out of its corpse. As he rises, Zan becomes more solid, taking on more color. When he steps away from his corpse, he's as solid as either Frobod or me.

He gasps... and then laughs, an incredulous sound that's shocked to be alive. "Marcy..." He says, his voice tinged with amazement, "I'm here. I didn't go to Tartarus."

He touches her shoulder, she turns, and delivers a full fisted punch to Zan's nose, shouting "You fool!"

I can tell it hurt from the incredible snapping sound, but Zan just laughs and scoops his wife into his arms. They spin together in a tight embrace in front of the little cottage as Marcy's red skirt catches the air.

Frobod clears his throat. "We should get you registered so you don't get deported for being an illegal immigrant or some nonsense."

Part of me wants to smack Frobod for ruining their moment, but it's already broken so I say, "You think they'd do that?"

Frobod says, "They love their forms. Why register if not to have consequences for not registering?"

Marcy shoves her man towards us, he stumbles forward. She says, "Go. Get yourself registered. I'll inform the Adventurers' Guild that you've completed my task to satisfaction."

Zan, looking sheepish now that he's survived his ordeal, says, "Thank you. I was nearly lost."

Zan's more noticeable on the back of my bike now that he's a ghost. He hums a chipper, unfamiliar tune that tells me that he's not only musical when he's nervous.

When we enter the town hall, much quieter now without George's ghosts, penny sets down her knitting, adjusts her glasses, and says, "Picked up a straggler have you?"

"Ahh, no." I answer. "Recently deceased. He was alive and died within Hades."

"More recently than the others?" Penny asks.

"A few minutes ago." Frobod says.

"Cause of death?" Penny asks, checking off boxes behind her desk.

Frobod says, "Decapitation."

The clerk removes her spectacles and sucks on the end of one of the arms staring at Zan intensely. Her whole body grows tense. "Did the death occur within city limits?"

"Yes..." I say, reluctance creeping into my voice.

In an 'as of a matter of fact' tone, Penny asks, "Will you be pressing charges?"

Zan beams, and says "That won't be necessary."

Penny returns the smile and returns the glasses to her face. "If your happy, I'm happy. While I do love documentation, I loathe unnecessary work and...." she trails "investigations. You seem like proper folks, so I'm glad not to see you in shackles." She pushes a partially filled out form across the counter. "Complete form I1a, and sign here. I3c to apply for temporary housing, and IP24c which waves your right to the constable's investigation for a death within Ashe March

limits. Do be as detailed as possible, as there are few mortal deaths in the underworld and these accounts will become a matter of public record."

Zan pushes form I3c back to penny with a boyish grin on his face. "I already have a home."

Penny arches a ginger eyebrow and says, "Oh? You look like a boy caught in the embrace of first love."

He smiles, "My wife already lives here, and perhaps I have."

I nudge Frobod's arm and squeal, "That's adorable. She was his first love."

He rolls his eyes, too cool for love.

You have completed the quest Missing Hunter - In Death We Are Parted!

Return to Milnus in the Adventures' Hall to collect your reward.



Chapter 14 - To Pret Forest

It's late afternoon when we regroup at the Adventurers' Hall, and I find Leroy and Sajina sitting at one of the large circular tables with the diminutive gnome, Milnus, with his box of cards. Leroy's has a smug expression painted all over his face, meanwhile Sajina's relaxed in a way that I haven't seen since we started this adventure. He's still in his Gargoyle skin, but I can almost see the casual confident elf peaking out from behind those stony eyes.

I say, "How are things?"

Leroy claps the bard on the shoulder and says, "Sajina's the man." The fact that the musician doesn't grin like a little boy tells me that he's found some of his old swagger.

"Yes, well..." Milnus begins. "Now that you've proven yourself with Lady Marcy's assignment, I'm authorized and prepared to offer the bard a separate contract from the rest of you."

"Oh?" I ask.

"Yes." Milnus says, "He's to work as an entertainer for the duration of the trip in the more expensive cars. In exchange for this service, he'll be provided compensation, and your three additional passengers will be permitted to travel in the restricted area of the Shroudmoon Express."

"Restricted?" I ask. "

Milnus says, "Kitchens, storage compartments, and the staff lounge in cars three to four. There are no available private rooms or beds, however cots will be provided so they can rest."

I look to the gargoyle and say, "Good job. That's one less thing we have to deal with."

Milnus hands me and Frobod sacks of coins, and says "Payment for Lady Marcy's job." There's something very satisfying about holding a velvet sack of money in my palm.

Leroy says, "Everyone else has already been paid."

I ask, "Where are they?"

Leroy says, "There's a room downstairs where adventurers can relax and shoot the shit."

I say, "Anyone else show up yet?"

"No." Leroy says, "We're the first. That'll change as more people find gates, and figure out a way around Cerberus. It's a lot harder now since people can't just

search for the answers online, and people can only see pro-gamer vids if they've got the streaming media upgrade, and even then the other pros need to have someone on the outside to do their editing. In any case, I'm pretty sure my video's gonna be the first."

I say, "I've been meaning to ask you how that works."

"Assuming I'm not live, every time I turn off my recording the files are uploaded." Leroy says, "My wife has the password, so she can download, and now she's doing all the editing. Communication's only one way, but new videos are showing up in my channel so I know she's on top of it."

"That's nice of her." I say.

"It's our livelihood." Leroy reminds me.

Milnus clears his throat and withdraws the note card with the Shroudmoon Express job, from his box and pushes it toward me and says, "If you'll review the specifics of your next post and confirm your acceptance I can begin preparing."

Quest - Shroudmoon Express - Cabin Security

Difficulty: Challenging

Duration: 2 Days

The Shroudmoon Express needs professionals to maintain the peace between traveling guests, and put down any monsters, bandits, or other undesirable entities that attempt to board in transit.

Objectives:

Ride the Shroudmoon Express to Athelon necropolis from Coldwash 0/1

Passengers arrive safely 0/1

Rewards:

+500 Reputation with Ashe March Adventurers' Hall

200 Hades Gold Marks

500 Gold

Do you accept? Yes / No

I tap 'yes,' and pass the card to Frobod so he can do the same.

"Fantastic." Milnus says. "Coldwash is a half day's ride so you'd better hurry if you want to get there tonight. I'll mark it on your maps. The train leaves 6PM tomorrow, so you'd better not miss it."

Frobod looks between me and Leroy and says, "You want to go tonight?"

Milnus says, "You can make it if you leave first thing tomorrow morning."

"Yeah..." I say, "But then we'll be tired when we get there, and there's not much of a cushion for if something goes wrong along the way." I spread my map on the table, and Milnus touches our destination with his finger. A red mark appears in a town on the west coast. "So we're here..." I touch the dot indicating Ashe March, "... and we're going here." I follow the main road with my finger leading to our destination. It occurs to me that it's not the most direct route. In

fact, we'd have to go west, north, then west again, only to go south once we hit the coast.

I ask "What's this here?" I indicate a forested area with a dashed red line passing through it rather than the thick black ones that represent public roads.

"That'd be faster." Milnus says, "But only if you're not attacked along the way. The red indicates that road may be unsafe for travelers."

"What's there?" Frobod asks.

Milnus says, "That's the Pret Forest. Foreign ghosts there, they're not like us."

"Are they dangerous?" I ask.

Milnus says, "Depends who you ask. Some say they just wander around, begging for forgiveness."

"And the others?" Frobod asks.

Milnus offers a dry chuckle, "We haven't seen them."

Leroy says, "I catch your meaning."

Frobod says, "So what do you want to do?"

I say, "I'm pretty sure I know what Tako wants. Get there as fast as possible."

Sajina says, "Could make for an interesting story."

I say, "I'm fine with that if you all are."

Leroy says, "I'm good with that. I doubt we'll find something that'll take out our entire party."

I look to the others and say, "We're agreed?"

Leroy and Frobod, answer with a "Yeah." and "Yeah." Sajina just nods, seeming to have become braver since our last dungeon.

I pull out my VT and say, "I'll double check with the others, but I think it's decided."

Melpomine: There's two ways to get to the next quest, one long and safe, the other faster and possibly dangerous. Are you good with the short route?

TakoStar: Let's do it.

Pahrem: Whatever you wanna to do, boss. With Leroy Jensen in our group I ain't worried about nothin'.

TakoStar: Are we going?

I say, "Tako wants to know if we're going."

Leroy asks, "Now?"

I say, "I think so."

Leroy says, "Not yet. We still need to find a trainer for Sajina. If we can get him somewhat competent in magic, it'll help a whole lot in combat."

"I have to do my thing for the Sune quest too. I should take care of that before we go so I don't forget."

Leroy asks, "Is an hour enough time?"

"I think so." I say.

Melpomine: Unless any of you have important stuff to do, meet at the gate in an hour. Don't forget to check with Milnus to accept the quest.

I look to the gnome and ask, "Is there a temple of Sune in Ashe March?"
"Sune?" Milnus asks, "No... but you can pray at the Temple of Many Gods."
"What's that?" Frobod asks.

Milnus says, "It's a temple with a collection of generic alters where upon you can make sacrifices, or pray to the god of your choosing."

"Thanks." I say, "I'll be sure to visit." I stand and turn for the door, but the gnome catches my arm, and thrusts a sealed scroll into my hand.

He says, "Show this to the conductor so he knows of your contract."

I nod my head, and exit the hall.

The Temple of Many Gods is a wheel of columns that strike me as a hybridization of a Hellenic temple and Stonehenge. Massive, carved pillars create a circle, supporting a ring of heavy stone. Narrow rock paths between each set of columns create the spokes in the wheel. There are light and dark colored alters of varying colors—white, black, grey, blood red. They give off distinct emotional resonances. Curious, I take a step towards one of the darker ones that seems mysterious.

WARNING: You are approaching a dark alter.

Favored Deities: Nyx, Ahriman, Thoth, Asteria, Hecate, Chandra, Ratri.

Opposing Deities: Helios, Apollo, Sulis, Horus, Baldr, Freyr

Using this alter to pray to an opposing deity will incur that deity's wrath.

I take a step back, and the prompt disappears. I examine all the alters from the center of the circle, and choose a light granite alter that reminds me of clouds. I check the list of favored deities, and I'm relieved to see that Sune, Thor, and Zeus are all on the list.

The Temple of Many Gods is far more impersonal than my makeshift alter near the Gate of Hades. I wonder if I'll have another spiritual experience. I place a few sticks of incense on the alter, get on my knees, and touch my head to the ground in front of it.

You are praying. Do you want to offer tribute to Sune, God of Lightning and Travel? Yes / No

I choose 'yes,' and a cool wind stirs around me at the same time as a new icon appears in the top right hand corner of my vision.

Blessed

Sune favors you.

+1 Stamina

+5% Mounted speed for all members of your party if you are the party leader.

You've earned the respect of Sune's clergy.

Duration: 24 hours

"Thank you." I say, though it still feels a bit weird giving casual thanks to an artificial god, in spite of knowing that Sune is a very real personality that is capable of interacting with players. I want to feel the unknown presence I found when we first arrived in Hades.

I whisper, "I don't know if anyone's listening, but if you are thank you for guiding us back to Mirae."

The stone alter doesn't respond. My incense has vanished. I'm about to give up when I feel a warm hand upon my shoulder. I yelp, and spin, but I'm standing by myself. *Helios was never so direct.*

I wait a good five minutes, hoping for further interaction but none comes, and I begin to wonder if I've been talking to myself. The sensation on my shoulder. *Am I feeling what I want to feel?*

My mind drifts back to the mundane world. Not having anything else to do, I pull out a stick of goblin jerky, and chew as I exit the temple. I've got some time, so instead of mounting up I casually stroll through Ashe March on my way to the gate. Vendors have their shops, and Hadesfolk gossip and laugh as though they were still alive. It all strikes me as very mundane. Not paradise, and not hell. Just a comfortable extension of mortal existence into the afterlife.

Pahrem, Tako, and Frobod are waiting for me at the gate. Annette, Jason and James are with them though the NPCs are gathered off to the side having their own conversation. I pass them a few of my trail rations, not the good stuff from our chef, and they accept them gratefully.

Frobod says, "Just two more."

Tako says "Hurry their asses up."

"Hey." I say, "If Leroy can make Sajina more useful it's worth it."

Tako says, "I guess."

I say, "I shouldn't have to remind you what happens if we wipe, unless you want to trek all the way back here from Haven Durolan."

"Yeah, I know." Tako groans, "I just want to see her."

Pahrem says, "We all wanna see 'er."

Tako looks like he's about to say something about being special, when I add, "We know she's out there now. Better than that, she's waiting for us. There's no need to be reckless. We're going. We'll get her. We'll bring her back. There's no time limit until we leave Hades."

SalemLilly has joined the guild.

Pahrem wears a confused, expression that bleeds into a look of shock. She says, "Holy shit." in a tone that could be just as easily read as amazement as incredulity.

I say, "Someone you know?"

"Yeah..." Pahrem says, as she stares down at her VT, scrolling through contacts. She seems to find what she's looking for, because she repeats herself. "Holy shit. Pehrom's gonna flip his shit."

Frobod asks, "Who's SalemLilly?"

Pahrem says, "That's Lilly!" as if it should be obvious. She doesn't catch any recognition in our faces, so she explains, "Pehrom's wife!"

"Dude..." I say, thinking I catch her meaning.

Frobod asks, "So?"

Pahrem says, "She wasn't in hea before. Looks like we ain't the only one's on a trip tah find our loved ones."

Frobod says, "You've got to be kidding me."

Pahrem says, "No joke. I checked my VT. It's the same SalemLilly, not just some impersonator replacing a lowercase L with a capital I. Shit man, he's not gonna be happy, unless they fixed our shit. Can you log out?"

I shake my head no. "It's still non-functional."

"Damn." Pahrem says. "Means she chose to come in here with us and damn the consequences. Wouldn't I like to be a fly on the wall for that reunion?"

I say, "I guess we'll be meeting her. What's she like?"

Pahrem says, "Hard, loud. She won't take your shit... but at the same time she's good people."

Frobod says, "They sound like a match for each other."

Tako, quiet until now says, "Yeah well..." Seeming at a loss for words, as if suddenly the world didn't revolve around him reuniting with Mirae. "Good for them. At least now they're together."

StarPuncher has joined the guild.

ClashingBoomBoom has joined the guild.

TripleRex has joined the guild.

Might has joined the guild.

Severyn has joined the guild.

Sulbin has joined the guild.

TheWrath has joined the guild.

Lah'lan'illeilyn has joined the guild.

KingBlade has joined the guild.

Sultan has joined the guild.

RockHard has joined the guild.

TasteMyCrit has joined the guild.

Dongalor has joined the guild.

Tomilyn has joined the guild.

"Whoa!" I say. "What just happened?"

Frobod says, "You didn't send a mass invite?"

"No way, who would I ask?" I say.

Frobod says, "I don't know."

I say, "There's only two other people who have the rank to do that. Mirae... and Pehrom."

Tako says, "I'll ask Mirae." and then shakes his hand with his VT after he types something like he's about to smash it. "I forgot. Stupid quest is blocking our messages."

I say, "I'll ask Pehrom what's going on." and begin typing.

Melpomine: Dude! You been recruiting?

You cannot send messages to the living without the aid of magic.

Melpomine: Hello?

You cannot send messages to the living without the aid of magic.

I sigh and say, "Looks like we can't communicate with people in Haven anymore than we could send a message to Mirae when she came back online."

Pahrem asks, "Whattaya thinks happenin'?"

Tako says, "More recruits for Dragonsbane?"

I say, "I hope that's all it is."

Pahrem asks, "Do we have time to scry?"

I check the clock on my VT, and nod. "We've got a few minutes unless Leroy comes back early."

We all move to the side of the gate, where Pahrem sets up her bowl, and withdraws her vials of magic. Unlike last time they glow silver and blue as she empties them out, and they mist and swirl in the basin.

"What's with the color change?" I ask.

"Higha difficulty, so I'm breakin' out the good stuff for this scryin'. Reagents are more expensive."

Frobod asks, "It's the same spell, so why's it harder?"

Pahrem says, "Probably cause he's in Haven and we're in Hades. I just know what the prompts tell me."

Tako begins, "So..."

Pahrem cuts him off, "C'mon give a gal some space to work. Can't do it with all this yammerin' in my ear." The way she says 'ear' is more like 'ee-yah.'

Tako says, "Sorry."

Pahrem says, "Zip." and mimes closing a zipper across her lips.

We all take a clue and stop interrupting. The goblin lowers her face to the edge of the bowl close to the water, and begins to blow until the magic contained within takes on a mirror-like reflection, which then darkens to the black of ink, and reveals our goblin chef standing on top of a wooden crate at the head of Cupcake Keep's banquet hall.

Two stone gargoyles stand behind him with massive arms folded across their chests like body guards, Pehrom waves a meat cleaver in the air. A goblin woman I haven't seen before stands at his side, and the seats are filled with adventurers I've never encountered. Armored, armed.... ready for battle. Each with a dirty plate in front of them. They pump their fists in the air as Pehrom makes a declaration, though I can't make out the words.

Pahrem cocks her head in a way that tells me she's listening.

Frobod asks, "What's he saying?"

Pahrem says, "Shhh!" and closes her eyes in concentration. When she speaks her voice falls in barely a whisper "I'm listenin'."

Looking at the scene, I've got questions mounting of my own, like 'What the hell is happening in my castle?' It'd be one thing if the goblin were hosting a

buffet, but since when did we have gargoyles or a need for security? I'm starting to wonder how tall our keep is gonna be when we get home.

Pahrem says, "He's sayin'.... "If you're goin' down... don't suck the root. Ya gotta bite' em' with everything ya got..."

The image fades as Frobod says, "Is that an herb or something?"

Tako smirks.

"Nah." Pahrem says in her normal speaking voice. "That's all I could get. I dunno what's happenin' but it sounds like there's a battle."

"Give em' hell." I say. "Don't die like a noob. If you're gonna die, take a bunch of em' with you."

Pahrem's eyes light up with amusement. "I'm impressed half-elfy. How'd you get so good at speakin' goblin."

I roll my eyes. "I had a younger brother." Had being the operative word. I sigh, and say "I don't know what's happening, but I'm sure Jordan would be proud."

Pahrem just nods, then says, "Ya saw the chick standin' next to him? That's Lilly, his wife."

Frobod says, "I guessed."

Pahrem clarifies, "His real world wife. Not some in-game lady for role playin'. Means she signed in, and now she's as stuck as the rest of us."

The kind of pause where everyone's processing what was just said before thinking what to say settles between us, though it's not awkward. I'm just trying to wrap my mind around what Pehrom's feeling. It's gotta be good to be with family, but if I were in his shoes I'd be concerned for her safety. Hopefully she had the sense to sign in where someone would find her, or leave a note knowing she'd have to go on life support.

I say, "I wish I could message him. Let him know we're here whatever happens."

Pahrem waves a dismissive hand, "He'll be fine. He ain't da type for broodin', but if they fought, I'll bet no one could sleep all evenin'. Ya know, fight hard" she hits the word with a note that sounds like 'hahd,' "Make up harder, if ya catch my meaning."

"I think I do." I say. "How long have you known each other?"

Pahrem says, "Me n' Pehrom? God... If we're talkin' the player and not the character, gotta say it's been like seven or eight years, yeah?"

"Damn..." I say, feeling a bit like a fish out of water. I'm the Guild Master, but most of the Muffins, the incap ones anyway, seem like they've been together longer than most real life people I know. "Ya know. That's good."

Pahrem says, "Whattaya mean?"

"Just that..." I say, "Even though this guild is old, it's also kinda new. Makes me feel good to know that a lot of you have those kinds of bonds."

Pahrem says, "Yeah well, get used to it. You're part of the fam now so you're gonna get to know a whole lot more about all of us."

Leroy approaches with Sajina in tow with a smug smirk pulling at his lips. The gargoyle now has a grey hood and a pair of magic pauldrons that shower myriad sparkles over his shoulders. I don't have time to respond to Pahrem before Leroy says, "We're good to go."

I say, "Why do you look so satisfied?"

He says, "It's not every day you get to spend that many points at once. Meet our new mage." He gestures to Sajina.

Sajina says, "I'm still a bard."

Leroy says, "What, you think as an artist you can only do one thing?"

I ask, "Got your charismatic casting, then?"

Leroy puts a hand on Sajina's sparkly shoulder, and says "You bet we did. Once he gets used to using spells in combat, he's going to own."

Sajina says, "I know the game says that charismatic casting is more like art, but music's something I brought from the real world."

I ask, "You're a musician?"

The gargoyle says, "Working on my doctorate, or at least I was."

"Damn." I say, "Not many real world doctors in here. What kind of music do you play?"

He says, "Everything. You name it."

"Metal?" I ask, really wanting to see this gargoyle skin bust out an electric guitar.

"Of course." He says, "You know Michael Bishop, better known as the original base guitarist of GWAR, and later lead singer, had a PhD in music."

"Damn, they've been around like... sixty or eighty years haven't they?"

Sajina, sounding like a Metal scholar with his Indian accent says, "So long as metal survives, GWAR will never die. They just keep recruiting members to play the old characters. They only permanently retired one persona in the form of Oderus Urungus when Dave Brockie died of a heroin overdose."

I feel my eyes glazing over as I say, "I don't know who that is." *Who dies of drug overdoses anymore?*

Sajina shrugs, and says, "He's an old member. Suffice to say, my education does not preclude me from rocking the hell out."

"Good to know." I say, "How do you feel about your spells?"

Sajina says, "They'll take some time to get used to."

Leroy says, "You all ready?"

Tako says, "We've been waiting on you."

I look to Annette, Jason, and James, and say, "C'mon guys. We're movin'. It's time to go." as I head out the gate.

The guards give us a friendly "Farewell!" and "Safe travels." as we pass.

Before summoning our mounts I catch Leroy by the elbow and say, "Do you mind if I," I look to Pahrem and correct, "...we use your messenger when we stop for a break? I'm still thinking about what to say. I'll pay the cost."

Leroy says, "Yeah, what's up?"

I say, "The real world wife of one of our guild officers signed in a few minutes ago, which makes her stuck here like the rest of us. I've got a feeling he's freaking out, so I want to send some words of support."

Leroy shrugs, "He's still on cooldown for the discount rate, but if you can wait no problem. If you want to send it urgent, there's a fee for calling him back too early."

I wave my hand, "It can wait. Like I said, I don't even know what I want to write yet." I wave Pahrem over and say, "If there's anything you want to say to Pehrom in a bit, Leroy's gonna let us use his messenger."

The goblin says, "I'll think on it, but I think you're takin' it harder than me." She shrugs, "Pehrom's a big boy. He'll get ova it."

I wave my middle finger in the air and call "INFERNO!!!" then pump my fist in the air and say "Let's ride!" All the elechoppers pop into existence, and in a wave of heat that makes the air shimmer, Leroy calls his shrieking phoenix.

Sajina's wings spread out behind him and he says, "I can fly now too. I purchased the upgrade. It's not just gliding, but take off and landing?"

"Congrats, dude. That could be useful, especially as a caster. Can you fly faster than 600%?"

The gargoyles shake their heads, "Sorry. Not quite there yet, but I can hover."

"Stick to the bikes for now then." I say, "Still, congrats. I wish I could fly."

"Damn." He says, "I was looking forward to trying it out."

I say, "There will be time later."

Straddling my fire chopper, which I'm starting to think of as Big Red, with Annette behind me, I check my map to make sure I know which direction I'm going. A little pulse of light shows me where we're positioned on the map, and I roll forward a few paces, and watch the dot move to make sure we're going the right direction. Yeah, I'm that bad at sensing where I'm going.

I lift off the ground and switch over to party chat to make conversation easier. I say, "This is going to be a long ride."

Frobod says, "How long do you think before they install a network of city portals?"

I say, "I'd give it six months to a year. They make manual travel like this mandatory for a time to force people to explore the world. Wouldn't be surprised to discover as we stray farther from the gate, we'll find something to take us back to where we started."

Pahrem says, "Charon. He's basically a portal."

"Or that." I say, "Forcing us to gather Hades marks accomplishes the same thing."

I look beneath us, and the ground passes quickly beneath our wheels as we advance toward Coldwash, where we'll meet the Shroudmoon Express. I can see occasional monsters, giant woodland creatures like bears and boars, rustling in brush a ways from the road, but traveling by air is relatively safe in Freehaven. You only have to worry about the occasional hostile archer, and if you fly high enough you're beyond the agro radius of most monsters. The only real exceptions are capital cities where, if you're on their shit list, their bowmen will fire at anything no matter how high up.

Tako says, "This is going to take forever."

I shrug and say, "Most people probably aren't rushing for the coast. Relax and enjoy the wind in your face. Keep your eyes peeled for anything that looks interesting."

Leroy says, "I'm recording this whole thing, so be sure not to say anything you don't want my wife hearing."

Frobod says, "Our whole chat is going to be in one of your videos?"

"Nah." Leroy says, still looking ahead, "She'll speed it up and put some music over it. This is basically just a PoV Hades flyover to help people make sense of their maps when they get here."

Thinking of this as the real world I say, "If your butts get sore we'll take a break."

Frobod says, "I don't think that's gonna happen unless it's one of those mysterious upgrades."

I say, "Well then don't fall asleep. We all know that's possible now with the update."

Tako says, "I'll try to resist, but it's gonna be tough. I mean, this isn't even a real hell. I haven't seen one demon the size of a sky scraper."

I say, "Do you want to see a demon the size of a skyscraper?" putting heavy emphasis on the word want. Silence drifts between the tongues of air blowing in our wake. I turn my head to give him a look, "Do you?"

"I'm thinking!" Tako says.

Pahrem asks, "How is that not an automatic no?"

Tako grumps, "It'd be a lot more interesting than staring at trees and dirt roads for the next three hours."

Leroy says, "I'm with the rogue on this one. A giant demon would make awesome footage. A new world boss to get everyone excited about."

"Be careful what you wish for." I say, "This game has the potential to be way more accommodating than I'd like to admit."

Frobod asks, "Is that insider dev stuff?"

"No..." I say, "Just a gut feeling. When I was still working, Hades hadn't even been discussed at the office."

Leroy glances back over his shoulder at me, but then returns his head forward not wanting to mess up his PoV flight sequence.

Tako asks, "What's that mean?"

"It means," I say, "Either another department was handling it in secret, or we didn't make it."

Frobod chokes on something imaginary that he wasn't even trying to swallow. "You're telling me that this whole place could be Archangel's creation?"

I shrug. "Look for buggy architecture, or missing textures. Stuff to make it less professional. We put everything we release through several rounds of QC before it reaches customers, but independent developers aren't likely to be so rigorous."

Frobod frowns. "I don't know what to make of that."

"If it's anything," I say, "I'm leaning towards the secret department theory. I haven't seen any screw ups."

"That's comforting." Frobod says, not sounding comforted at all.

"Hey, we're in Hades now." I say. "We've still got a job to do."

Frobod looks as if he's about to say "What job?"

When Tako clarifies, "Rescue Mirae."

Things go pretty quiet after that, with only occasional beats of idle conversation. Our NPC passengers are silent the whole time, if they'd wanted to talk, without party chat, their voices would be fast drowned in the wind. The

flight takes forever, though it's nice to take in new scenery. The land is painted in the reds, golds, and browns of autumn which makes me feel festive.

Not much longer before Thanksgiving.

I wonder if we'll still celebrate the continental turkey events, and have access to all the seasonal quests. We had the annual Lagerfest, to correlate with Oktoberfest in the real world, but that was before the update. I'll admit to being sad if, by being stuck in here, we'll also miss out on all the seasonal events.

I say, "You think we'll still have Turkeyshoot this year?"

Tako says, "I hope so. I can't wait to see what Pehrom does with those delicious fugly birds."

I say, "Hey Leroy. How'd you do in the quick shoot last year?"

Leroy answers without turning his head back to face us, "Turkeygeddon."

Tako says, "You have to ask? He's Leroy Jensen, of course he got the top score."

"Was just making conversation." I say, my voice grows wistful. "I'm feeling nostalgic for the holidays for some reason. Kinda odd since I'm such a loner. If we're still in here, I want to do something special."

"Incoming." Leroy says.

"Huh?" I look around quickly, startled.

No enemies in sight, but I see what he meant. As if cut off by a force field, an entire forest is enshrouded in murky gloom. It's as if someone drew a line in the dirt, and on our side the sun shines, but on the other everything's tinted as if the whole wood stands behind sunglasses. The type of trees changes too, from the deciduous growths we've admired on the road, to dark shaded evergreens. It's as if shade were a somehow tangible thing that could be contained in and poured from a jar.

Tako asks, "Is this the Pret Forest?"

I gradually slow my flight until I come to a complete stop with my map in hand, and Big Red hanging in the air. I check our location, and sure enough we're hovering just beyond the boundary of Pret Forest. I nod to Tako.

Frobod says, "So what's the plan?"

Pahrem asks, "Any reason we can't just fly ova it?"

Leroy says, "We can try, but I doubt it'll be that easy. Why give a warning and suggest the long way if we could just fly over?"

Pahrem says, "Maybe everyone else doesn't have flyin' mounts. I ain't seen no one else flyin' since we got here."

I say, "We also haven't seen any other players."

Leroy says, "One person can try flying in and see if anything stops them. If something attacks then we're here to res."

Pahrem asks, "Who wants to go?"

Frobod says, "I'll do it. No point risking one of you resers."

Leroy asks, "Have at it then?" then looks back to us, "Anyone need anything before we go in?"

I say, "I think we're good." as I pass a trail ration back to Annette and then move around to give food to Jason and James.

Pahrem clarifies. "We're good."

Leroy makes a flamboyant gesture with his hand that reminds me of a cartoon butler and seems to say 'After you.' Frobod glides forward, slow and cautious a mere 100% ground running speed. All our eyes follow his slow path, and I feel my nerves stirring in anticipation.

Suddenly, a voice sounds from below. "What da hell?" He pronounces the word hell like 'heal.' "You wanna die?"

My eyes flash from Frobod to see an animated man wearing a bright orange tunic, and baggy linen pants that are cut off half way between his knees and ankles. He has a thin black moustache, and a small tuft of hair growing on his chin.

A few feet short of Frobod entering the forest I call "Hold up." and he stops. Everyone except Frobod drops down to meet the little man,

Leroy asks, "What's the problem?"

He says, "This forest is no good for travelers, and you don't want to fly. Pretty soon you'll fall down, an something'll eat you."

Leroy asks, "Like what?"

The man, named Chaun by his name plate, says "Lots of things. Not safe. You need a guide to make it through to da otha side. Take me. You no die. 100% grantee. I know the best way, but have to hurry. Almost dark."

Leroy asks, "What happens after dark?"

Chaun says, "Many ghosts change, and become more dangerous." Leroy, sensing that this may be a lengthy discussion joins us on the ground.

"You mean the pret?" I ask.

Chaun says, "Pret are fine. No problem. People say they're dangerous, but they're like big babies. They won't attack unless you tempt them. You should worry about Krasue and Krahang. They'll mess you up."

I say, "What do you want?"

Chaun says, "100 Hades Marks. No problem. I'll take you. Come out okay, 100% guaranteed."

Suddenly reminded of my time haggling and living in Asia I say, "That's ridiculous. We should be saving our marks for Charon. We'll follow the road and handle anything that comes for us."

"Okay." Chaun says, "Your funeral, but since you're new here and don't know. I'll give you the special price if you still want 50 marks. Everyone can go. Good?"

Haggling.

Manipulation + Commerce. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 4)

"Are you kidding me? My grandma knits better sweaters, and she's dead!"

Commerce skill increased by 1. Current level: 4

"Twenty." I say. "That's being generous. See that guy?" I motion to Leroy. "That's Leroy frickin' Jensen. He could solo this entire forest without breaking a sweat. I'm just offering to pay so we can make our way faster."

Leroy, playing along says, "She's right. I probably could."

Chaun grumbles something about being proud and too confident, and says, "Okay 30 marks, but no more. Less than that isn't worth it."

"Done." I say. I fetch fifteen marks from inventory, and say "Fifteen now, the rest when we're seen safely to the other side."

Chaun greedily snatches the coins from my hand, and says "Okay let's go!" He claps his hands and a bicycle bell 'ching ching' sounds as his mount appears; a play on a Thai tuk-tuk, but instead of a motorcycle leading a covered seat for two or three people, the rickshaw is guided by a simple bicycle. The undercarriage glows with an eerie magical lavender light that reminds me of LED underglow.

Tako groans, "That's gonna be a slow ass mount."

"Don't worry!" Chaun says, "We'll make good time."

I look to Annette Jason and James, and say, "Why don't you ride with Chaun. That's gotta be more comfortable than riding doubles and if we need to fight you'll be safely out of the way."

Annette says, "Thanks."

As Jason and James settle into place with Annette sandwiched in the middle, James says, "This is so much more comfortable."

Chaun looks to Tako and says, "See? Everyone's very happy."

He doesn't take the bait, and I say, "Everyone on the ground. Let's move out."



Chapter 15 - Haunted

Passing through the invisible barrier that separates the main road from the haunted forest is like stepping into a large tent with the distorted glow of sunlight seeping through. The air grows a touch cooler, though not enough to make anyone shiver, and everything dims. The trees are so tall that it's not always easy to catch a glimpse of the grey sky, and the dirt road crumbles beneath our tires.

"So far, so good." Frobod says. "Anyone see any ghosts?"

Chaun looks back with a smirk and says, "You won't see em' just yet."

I'm starting to wonder if he's acting as a tour guide, or someone whose looking out for our safety, and I can't tell which is better. Part of me wants to see the foreign spirits.

I say, "We were told that this place is crawling with foreign ghosts."

Chaun says, "Yes." as he peddles, as if what I'd stated should be obvious.

I continue, "How'd they get here."

"Ah..." he says, as if that answered an unspoken curiosity as to why I spoke the obvious. "Two centuries ago, many ghosts migrated to New Hades from southern and coastal Jade Necropoli seeking new fortunes and lifestyles ill afforded them at home. Younger souls, accustomed to freedom in life, were ill prepared for death under the rule of ancient feudal death lords, or the Jade Emperor who sacrificed thousands of mortal souls in life, to escort him to the afterlife."

Frobod asks, "What's New Hades?"

"I think it's like 'The New World' so the North American maps." I ask. "So they were refugees?"

Chaun shakes his head no. "We were colonists, much the same as the souls of the West. At that time, few regions of this part of High and Low Hades were inhabited."

"We?" Frobod asks.

Chaun says, "Those of us who can't or won't reincarnate."

"I see..." I say, as I take in our surroundings. The ride is much slower than expected due to Chaun's sluggish rickshaw. The trees cast shadows that creep long like gnarled fingers as the sun descends. A woman's laugh rings through the trees. It's a sound that straddles the line between mirth and cruelty.

I look, but can't find the source. Frobod tightens his grip on his handlebars, and one of Tako's hands strays toward the hilt of his dagger.

Pahrem asks, "What's that?"

Chaun says, "Ghosts." as if it were no matter.

A whirling shape like a human helicopter descends from above. It spins round and round so fast I feel myself growing second hand dizzy. It touches down some thirty paces ahead; an old half naked man, and a small young woman clinging to his back like an improbable backpack. His eyes are shielded by a pair of green tinted, bug-eyed, aviator goggles.

Chaun says, "Gik! Go away. No one has time for you. I have customers."

The woman laughs, a bit under five feet tall, tanned skinned, with shiny braided black hair. She taps her index finger to her lip in an over the top 'I'm too cute.' 'Who me?' expression, and grins.

We roll to a stop a few paces away.

"I just wanted to...." Gik explodes into motion, closing with Tako faster than I can think to equip Bite. She doesn't attack, and instead pushes her sweet little face into his neck, and inhales deeply. "... meet your friends. Especially when they smell so lovely."

I'm surprised he didn't stick her with that dagger.

"Gik." Chaun warns. "These are customers. Be gone now!"

The older man, the one who'd been giving the piggy back clears his throat uncomfortably. Like Gik, he's small of frame. Unlike the girl, he's clad in nothing but a loin cloth a scraggly white beard, and a constellation of brown moles decorating his body. Now that he's stationary I can see he has a pair of long flat rice baskets strapped to his arms that act like wings... or blades of a propeller.

Gik pouts. "You're never fun."

Chaun says, "The night's coming. I don't want to see you when it does."

"Fine." Gik huffs. "Let's go. I didn't want to talk to them anyway."

She loops around and leaps on the flying man's back, clinging to him like she's climbing a palm tree. He flaps his arms like wings, and then begins to spin faster and faster, floating off the ground like a hover craft. In a hand full of seconds, the pair disappear within the evergreen branches above.

Chaun sighs, "You'll want to stay away from them. Let's keep going."

A rustle sounds in the tree tops, as Gik and her eccentric, quiet companion disappear within the branches.

Tako says, "They didn't seem that bad."

The sound of retreating women's laughter fills the air.

Chaun grumbles, "That's 'cause you don't know her 'same as I do."

Pahrem says, "I like the old guy's goggles. "

Chaun, fidgeting with the grips of his handlebars says, "Keep going. I don't want night with them about."

Leroy says, "Let's go."

Chaun says, "Good, good. Now we go."

Our guide's a lot less chatty after the encounter, as he leads us down the long, vacant forest road. Aside from our run in with the laughing woman, there's not an NPC to be found, though my stomach twists every time I look into the brush, like it expects the lengthening shadows to leap up and grab me.

Forty-five minutes into the ride, I say, more to calm my nerves than honest inquiry, "It's a lot quieter than I imagined."

Chaun says, "That's because you have me."

Frobod says, "I'll call that a good thing."

Something moves in the trees ahead—dark, tall and monstrous. At first I think it's my imagination, but my eyes lock in on a shape that must be twenty... twenty five feet tall. It has long, thin, grotesque arms, and skeletal hands with knobby fingers. Its legs are pencil thin and anorexic with bony bulbs at the knees.

"Incoming." I say with unrest in my voice. Frobod pulls his greatsword from his back, and Tako equips his dagger.

Chaun looks back when I speak, and unleashes an indignant scoff as he slows his bike.

"What're you doing? It's just pret. You don't need weapons."

The armed members of our party exchange looks.

"They won't attack us?" Leroy asks.

"Not if you don't make the pret angry first." Chaun says.

Frobod reluctantly returns his sword to his back, and our procession continues a little ways down the road. Chaun stops at a clearing no more than twenty paces from the massive creatures. Now that we're close, I can better make out their figures—tall, dark, with horridly thin brittle limbs and enormous distended bellies. A few of the creatures take note, and begin to lumber our direction.

Chaun says, "If you want, you can show kindness to pret. They are very hungry. I can magic food for you so you can feed them. No problem. 1 mark for one person."

Sajina, quiet until now, says, "Are those ghosts?"

Chaun says, "Yes. Very tall ghosts."

I ask, "How did they get that way?"

"They were vain." Chaun explains. "Selfish when alive. Now they can't eat because pret mouths are so small. That's why you should show kindness to pret." The warning in those words is not lost on me.

The following quest is now available.

Quest - Showing Kindness to Pret

Difficulty: Easy

Your guide has provided you with the opportunity to show mercy, and forgiveness to these eternally starving souls who were selfish in life. In doing so, you become unlikely to suffer the same fate.

This quest may be repeated once per day.

Objectives:

Feed Pret

0/10

Rewards:

+500 Reputation - Pret Forest (First Time)

+200 Reputation - Pret Forest (Subsequent Completions)

I choose 'yes," and say, "Did you all get the quest?"

Leroy says, "Got it."

Sajina says, "I got it too."

Pahrem says, "I think we all did."

"Good." I say, "Might as well do it while we're here."

I look up from my VT and discover that more of the giant creatures have gathered, forming a half circle around us. Massive skeletal hands press together in a Thai wai greeting, freakishly large heads with sunken black eyes within shadow skin bow as if in prayer. Their bulbous foreheads nearly touch boney black fingers.

I pass Chaun a Hades Mark for each person in our party, and he begins chanting an incantation in an unfamiliar language. He makes large sweeping circular motions with his arms as if stirring a caldron of soup. Green, brown and white magic hangs in the air, until it condenses into a long trough filled with pale unappetizing gruel.

The first of the Pret, falls to it's rickety knees, and creeps to the food on all fours, as it draws closer, I'm shocked to see that the hole for it's mouth is the size of a popcorn kernel. It dips it's face in the mush, and sucks what it can through the minuscule opening in it's bolder sized head.

Another pret joins it and another and another. I check the quest prompt, to see that each ghost that joins the feast raises the completion counter by one. It's peaceful, they're so quiet in their consumption, and yet infinitely sad at the same time. I'm trying to imagine what it must be like to starve eternally without the release of dying.

Chaun says, "They say thank you," but I've heard no words from the large ghosts. I wonder, with such tiny mouths, how they can speak at all.

More pret are coming, but there's no room for extra heads in the trough. One of the new comers shrieks in rage, a high pitch whistling sound that hurts my ears. Without thinking I adopt a defensive stance, but massive hands grab one of the feeding ghosts by the neck, and slams it's forehead into the side of the container. It kicks the other pret in the ribs once, twice, three times. Ghostly bones crack under the impact. Then, as if nothing happened, the violent pret uses the victim's lifeless body as a cushion to kneel upon and consume its dinner.

Chaun says, "Okay. You showed kindness. We should go. Getting dark now."

I realize he's right. My half-elven low light vision has prevented me from recognizing how late it's become.

You have completed the quest Showing Kindness to Pret

You have been awarded:

+500 Reputation (Pret Forest)

Current reputation:

500/1000 (Neutral)

Sajina surprises me as he sings "Illuminatus!" casting a light spell on himself. His rocky body glows with inner light that illuminates our path. I look him over, give an enthusiastic thumbs up, and say "Get your magic on."

We're now back on the road riding through considerably darker terrain. The sky, when we can see it, is a dark blue which tells me that the sun is soon to set. Even though it's not full night, Sajina, and elechopper headlights brighten the way.

Leroy asks, "How much farther?"

Chaun says, "Maybe one hour to the edge of the forest if there's no stopping."

"Works for me." I say, keeping my eyes ahead. Somehow focusing on the dirt road makes our environment less eerie. It's only when I look off to the side imagining the unknowable denizens that could be lurking in the shadows that I feel uncomfortable.

Familiar laughter sounds around us. Chaun curses in a low rumble, and shouts, "I said go!" Young lady laughter sounds again.

Chaun looks over his shoulder and says, "This time I think weapons are okay."

Gik and her silent companion land in the street, and protrudes a pouty lip. "I thought you might be in a better mood after feeding the Pret. Won't you share them with us? There's so many, and they smell... so... good. Not like a baby or a mother but still very much alive."

"Errr..." Tako says, "That's not creepy." He unsheathes his dagger.

Chaun says, "Hurry! Sun's almost gone. Get ready!"

Frobod, not seeing the threat compared to the violent Pret, shrugs, and readies his greatsword. Leroy dismounts, hefts his war hammer, and says, "You tank?"

I say, "Uhhh... Sure." not quite knowing what to expect. I take Bite in hand and ready myself for an incoming attack.

Gik's highlighted in Big Red's headlight. She smiles, and then falls to her knees as if stabbed in the back, her face cast in a dead vacant expression. Then, as if cut by magic, her head falls from her shoulders to the ground. It rolls across the dirt path.

Her male companion now glows with pale fairy light, and his teeth elongate into a mouth full of ugly crocodile fangs. Gik's head starts to glimmer in a cloud of magic light, and a snake of glowing vapor connects her severed neck to her body. I expect it to magically reattach itself, but I'm wrong.

Her jaw snaps against the ground like a snarling zombie. As if attached to a string Gik's organs begin pulling out of the neck hole in her body, creeping along the streamer of light beneath the severed head. First the lungs... then the stomach... intestines... Each new internal organ that emerges causes Gik's head to rise a higher off the ground like an inflating balloon. Her face hovers, smiling as brilliantly as when we first met, floating viscera dangle beneath in her strange glowing light.

Chaun says, "Why are you waiting? Take them down!"

That's good enough for me. Gik lunges for Tako, her flying entrails lash around her in a whip of gore. He's fast enough to get out of the way, I spin bite,

and bash her right in the forehead. An arc of lightning jumps from Gik to her toothy companion.

Gik wails, a terrible sound that makes my bones quiver.

Horror.

Resist: Willpower.

Caliber of success: 3

Resist Successful

Frobod, Tako, Pahrem, and Sajina turn tail and run, bolting away from Gik in the direction from which we came. A shrieking face icon that reminds me of Edvard Munch's "The Scream" painting hovers over their heads, pulsing in violet light. Leroy and I keep our cool, but the sound's still unnerving.

The male swipes at me with a now clawed hand, and I easily evade. I swing bite, but it's electrified butt finds only air as Gik dips out of the way. She counters, I dodge. A little number two icon appears in the top right hand corner of my vision from my boots.

Leroy comes in with a powerful smash set to bust her skull. CRUNCH, Gik's health drops by thirty percent. I strike with Bite, but barely connect. Electricity jumps, taunting, between them.

My heart's beating fast. I've never faced a creature like this. I'm wondering if all Gik can do is scream and bite, when her floating head rears up, organs pull back, and then spring at me like a whip. I try to parry, but her guts plow past my stave, and sling three times around me like a fleshy grappling hook. Electricity leaps from my feet along the length of her entrails, to her hungry face, but she holds fast, constricting. I'm trying not to think about the fact that I'm grappled by intestines.

The male ghost, whatever he is, comes at me with another claw strike, but restrained as I am, there's little I can do to resist. Direct hit. I soak up all but two of the damage with stamina. Gik's floating head comes in for a bite like a boa constrictor, I struggle in her grasp, and manage to intercept her face with a nasty head butt. Stars swim in my vision.

As if that weren't bad enough, the cloud of magic surrounding Gik's floating organs, pulses momentarily brighter, and an ugly soreness blossoms in my head far beyond what my head butt could account for. My health falls, I'm now down to 40%, while Gik's health rises to 100. *Bloody ghosts have more health than mortals.*

Leroy comes in with a thunderous war hammer smash that sends the male flying. *How far are the other's fleeing?* Gik tightens her grasp in a way that makes me lose ten more percent of my health, then comes in for another bite. She doesn't connect because Leroy catches her jaw in another swipe of his massive hammer. Her guts loosen around me, and I squirm free. *Gross.* I want to take a shower. Gik health: 70%. Weird Dude Health: 60%.

I drop into full defense mode, and wait for incoming attacks. I'm expecting them to sweep in at the same time when I hear Sajina sing a long wide mouthed note like an opera singer. The scent of Ozone fills the air. KA-KRACK! A blinding blue-white pillar of electricity drops on the flying man like the finger of God.

Little streamers of smoke rise from his body. In spite of the damage. He's still got 20% health left.

He spins in place like a helicopter, and begins to rise. A flick of Tako's wrist, and his core mass is ventilated by a thrown blade. He plummets to the earth. Now there's just Gik, whose entrails are flapping in an imaginary wind like a gruesome banner. Frobod comes in with his great sword and chops. A length of gore drops to the road, but her lungs are still contracting and expanding. Sajina looses a volley of mage bolts which hammer those lungs with a whistle "Pop! Pop! Pop!" sound that reminds me of bottle rockets. Leroy smashes her in the forehead. In a hollow, ghostly wail, Gik's face and lungs fall to the earth..

Gik health: 0%

Pahrem whines. "C'mon guys. You ain't givin' me nothin' to do here."

I raise an index finger, noting my low health and throbbing in my head, "I've got wounds."

Pahrem says, "Yeah, but you're tank. You're supposed to have wounds." As she says this, the goblin waves her big green hands in a practiced gesture that encases me in a bubble of golden healing. My health ticks up... 35%, 40%.... 55%... 80%. "It's not like you were close to dyin'."

I groan and say "For me anything less than 40% is close to dying."

Pahrem teases with playfulness entering her voice, "C'mon. You almost never get hit."

I say, "In any case, world mobs are less interesting."

Frobod says, "You think a floating head with all her guts hanging out isn't interesting?"

"Ahh..." I backtrack, "I mean the challenge level isn't as high." I look to Tako and ask, "How's the loot?"

He says, "Crap. Two gold and 3 marks between both of them."

Leroy says, "Yeah, but she did have that draining health thing. I wonder if all ghosts can do it."

I say, "Speaking as the person who has been on the receiving end of that ability a few times now, it's not really a life drain as we're used to thinking of it. With Exsanguinator, for example, it cuts, does more damage and I'm healed. With the ghosts, it's more like they're transferring wounds to people. When I'm hit with it, it's like I'm suddenly damaged in the same places that you all had been striking in combat."

Leroy says, "Good information. I'll be sure to include it in the vid so people know what to expect. If you've got a fire weakness, it might not be a good idea for someone in your group to hit ghosts with fire." He pauses, and then continues. "Still, the fight wasn't that bad. They'll probably give people trouble if they come through here solo, but for a group as big as ours, piece of cake."

Chaun, sounding offended, says "It'd be a lot worse if I weren't here to help you. We don't take kindly to unaccompanied strangers."

Tako, sounding skeptical, says, "Gotta earn that coin somehow. We'll take your word for it."

Chaun says, "We should go before someone else smells you and wants to eat."

Leroy asks, "What were they?"

Chaun says, "She's krasue, he's krahang. I told you before, they'll mess you up, but only at night so lets go."

Beings stir in the brush as we pass, but none are so bold as to attack. Occasional tall, looming figures peer out from between the trees. I can only assume they're pret. Contrary to Chaun's earlier proclamations, it takes nearly an hour and a half to reach the western border of the Pret Forest.

Chaun dismounts and cracks his neck. Annette, Jason and James file out of his vehicle.

"Deal's a deal." I say, and pass him the 15 remaining Hades marks of his payment.

Chaun says, "My back hurts. Would you mind rubbing it for me?"

"Uhhh..." I hesitate.

Tako says, "We're kind of in a hurry."

Chaun strips off his shirt and says, "Just for a minute."

Frobod sighs, and says "Fine." No doubt hoping to pick up a hidden quest from it. He strips off his gauntlets and Chaun turns. I can't see him because Frobod's in the way, but by the way he, Leroy and Tako all groan "Ugh!" at the same time I can bet they've just seen something nasty. Pahrem, able to see no better than I says, "What is it?" as Chaun begins cackling.

Frobod asks, "Is that supposed to be a joke."

Chaun is now slapping his knee like he's just heard the funniest joke ever.

I nudge the death knight out of the way to get a better look and discover a giant gaping wound in our guide's back ripe with festering flesh. A whiff of decay punches me in the face as millipedes, maggots, and tiny worms burrow in his flesh.

I say, "Awe.. dude... That's just nasty." and turn my head to avoid sicking up.

Tako says, "Let's get out of here. Ain't no one got time for stank ass backs."

Pahrem, only now getting her peek says, "Whoa! Man... What the hell are you on about?"

Chaun's shoulders shake under the weight of all his laughter, as he gasps for air. "Come again!"

As we mount up, and ride pass, I say, "Not cool dude. Not cool."



Chapter 16 - Coldwash

It feels nice to be out of that ghastly forest. As soon as we cross the border into normal High Hades, the sky brightens and fills with a champagne of glittering stars. The road ahead is about as clear as the sky.

Frobod asks, "Carry on, or you want to camp around here for the night?"

As much as I'm charmed by the prospect of sleeping beneath this lovely sky, I shake my head, and say "Keep going. I just want to wake up and get on the train. Better not to risk any delays on the way."

Leroy says, "I agree with Mel. We're almost there, and it's better not to risk getting sidetracked."

A quick survey of our party tells me there are no objections, so I rev Big Red's engine and lift off the ground. I confirm our direction on the map and begin flying with everyone in toe. Once again, I'm sharing my bike with Annette who's less than talkative in the wind, but that's okay because I'm feeling entranced by the night sky as I often do during quiet nocturnal rides. It's dark so there's not much to look at below besides street lanterns, which serve as navigational beacons, and the sky.

I know we're approaching Coldwash, because like most cities, it stands out as a dome of light in the distance. Already it feels more developed than Ashe March due to its tall buildings and size.

I say, "Let's enter on the ground so we can talk to the guards."

No one expresses an objection, so I land my bike, and the rest of the group follows. Two men, one skinny, the other built like a heavyweight champion man the gate in steel armor. At first I think the big one is wearing a helm, but as I draw closer I realize the smooth bowling ball shape atop his torso is his actual head, and he has no eyes or even eye sockets. A giant mouth splits his melon like the human incarnation of pack man with only two small holes above his upper lip for a nose. I check his name plate for more information. "Mouth" is his name, and he's just a wraith like any other. No subrace attached.

I must be staring, because the smaller guard with brunette hair, and limp tentacle things hanging off his chin instead of a beard asks, "First time in the city?" His name's Tod.

I reluctantly give Tod my attention, not wanting to take my eyes off of Mouth and say, "Yeah... How could you tell?"

"You're staring." He says.

A low rumble of words rolls off Mouth, "Half the city's been fluxed." He enunciates every word making his appearance that much more creepy.

"Fluxed?" Leroy asks.

Tod says, "By the Shapers. Got a major hall in town."

Mouth clarifies, "Your bodies are like clay." He takes a moment to examine us, though how he's able to see without eyes is a wonder, "Well, maybe not your bodies. We don't see the living very often."

Frobod says, "So this is like... extreme body modification?"

Leroy asks, "Can you turn your limbs and flesh into weapons and armor?"

Mouth smiles and says, "Easily... Though we don't have flesh."

Leroy looks impressed, glances at me, and says, "That's some cool shit. Like a druid but less feral."

I say, "Some Vampires can do similar stuff with living and undead bodies. It's how they make the Once Men." Peering past the gates into the city, which must be packed with NPCs by day I think, "Never seen this kind of power used on such a large scale before though."

Returning my attention to Tod I ask, "Is there an place we can get a room? We're working security for the Shroudmoon Express and want to rest up first. We also have to find the place to catch the train."

Mouth says, "Give me your map and I'll mark it for you."

I hand it over, and with two touches of his plated index finger red dots appear on my map, before he hands it back.

I say, "Thanks for that. It's been a long ride and I don't think anyone was looking forward to wandering without directions."

Mouth says, "My pleasure." As strange as it is to think, the unease inspired by the guards' alien appearances erodes with Mouth and Tod acting so ordinary. I imagine that after spending a few hours in Coldwash most people become desensitized to everyone's sculpted visages.

Leroy asks, "Ready to go?"

I say, "Yeah."

Mouth says, "Welcome to Coldwash."

The first thing that strikes me after walking through the gate is that everything's made of stone like a proper capital city, unlike the more rustic architecture we've encountered in villages. Watch towers rise high along the perimeter of the settlement, and a few spires deeper in the city remind me of mage towers in Durolan. The streets under foot and wheel have proper cobbles as opposed to just dirt.

The Boneflower Inn isn't too hard to find. In less than eight minutes of entering the gate we're pulling up in front of a cozy little building like a real world bed and breakfast. The door's propped open with a large grey stone, and a welcoming yellow light spills out on to the street. We dismount, and I dispel our bikes with a series of 'Bloop boops!'

Clean, albeit weathered wooden floorboards creak under our feet when we enter. A male voice calls, "Just a moment! I'll be right with you." from a room behind the front desk. He sounds friendly. A lively hearth fire crackles in the front hall, and fills the room with warmth and charm.

A moments later, a man with human eyes set in an entirely skeletal face emerges wearing a bold wool sweater, and a black skullcap... No pun intended, at least I don't think.

Trying not to stare, I say "Tod told us this was a place we could get a good night's sleep."

"Aye, it is." He says, "If you've got the coin to pay. Will that be marks or gold?"

"Gold." I say. "We're saving our marks."

"How many rooms?"

I hesitate looking over everyone in the group, when he adds, "There's also a dormitory with ten beds if you don't mind sharing."

Leroy says, "That'll be fine. We're just here to catch up on sleep before we leave tomorrow."

I say, "No food or drink. Just our beds." and fish out my coin purse and settle our account. The cost is only about ten percent more than I'd expect to pay in Athelon which is impressive since the prices often increase exponentially when new content is released.

The innkeeper says, "Just this way..." and leads us to the end of the hall on the second floor with a black metal key in his hand. As when we entered, the floorboards squeak under our clunky footsteps. "Basic room. No frills. Just the beds you asked for."

"Perfect." I say, as I enter. "Who wants a top bunk?"

"I'm beat." Frobod says, staring down at his VT. With a few taps of his finger, his armor vanishes and is replaced with a lose fitting tunic. "I don't care. I just want to go to bed."

I sit on a lower bunk, and fast change my clothes into something similar. "Everyone good?" I ask.

Tako says, "We good."

The pillow beneath my head, and blanket weighing on my body, makes my body heavy and lethargic.

You are in bed.

Would you like to sleep? Yes / No



Chapter 17 - All Aboard the Shroudmoon Express

My eyes flutter open exactly six hours following the prompt. Leroy's snoring. A few minutes after that, Tako stirs and sits up in a top bunk. He gives me a reverse nod as if to say "Ey!" like the Fonz. His eyes point to the doorway, he cocks his head, and I nod.

Creak, thump, squeak as we make our way down to floor one.

The innkeeper says, "I trust your night was restful."

I say, "It was... very. Thanks."

"If there's anything I can get for you before you go...."

I shake my head. "Not yet, just figuring out what to do next." I consider the Thunderlord quest, and follow "Actually... If there's a temple of Sune, or many gods around here I'd like to make my devotions."

The innkeeper says, "We have both in Coldwash. Which do you prefer?"

"Sune." I say.

I pull out my map and he says, "I'll mark it for you."

Tako says, "Oh I get it. Just gonna leave me all alone here. You only think about yourself."

I say, "It's for the Thunderlord quest. This is how I become a Paladin."

"I get it." Tako says, "I'm just fucking with you."

I say, "It won't take too long. After that, I want to write a letter to Pehrom so Leroy can use his messenger. I'm sure there's interesting stuff to see in town." Tako chews on a stick of jerky and my stomach rumbles. "Good idea. Seems like I've been forgetting to eat until someone reminds me."

He says, "I can't wait to get back home so we can eat some real food."

"Which one?" I ask. "Real world, or Cupcake Keep?"

"Either." Tako says. "Take your pick. I can only eat so much jerky before I start craving a goblin burger."

I say, "I'm glad we even have that."

Tako says, "Hard to believe we're going to see Mirae. It feels like a year since she disappeared."

I eye him skeptically. "It's only been like two weeks. Not even."

Tako says, "You're not listening. I said it FEELS like a year. I thought men were supposed to be the inattentive ones."

"Ha-ha." I say in a deadpan voice, then continue in my normal tone, "... but yeah. It'll be good to see her and get her back. She must be bored out of her

mind. I wonder why she ended up here, instead of Haven like most of the other people."

Tako says, in a sagely voice, "The world may never know."

"Alright." I say, "Time to go pay Sune a visit. Tell everyone to meet at the train station when they wake up."

Tako says, "Who am I, the new Alfred?"

The innkeeper, forgotten until now says "I will tell them."

Nice to know he's been eves dropping.

Speaking to both Tako and the Innkeeper, I say "Rendezvous at four o'clock. That should give us enough time to find who we need to talk to and get set up before departure."

The man with the skull face says, "Noted."

I look to Tako and say, "I don't need a new Alfred."

* * * * *

The sun hits me full force in the face when I step outside The Boneflower. I squint to block out the mid day light while my eyes adjust. The street bustles with ghosts of every shape and size.

As a man nearly walks into me, muttering, "My apologies miss." I come to realize what the Ashe March guards meant by people not batting an eye at Sajina's appearance. The guy who just about knocked me over could almost be a gargoyle himself with his wide mouth, horned head, and clawed fingers. His features even look a bit rocky.

A woman across the street has angel wings, and empty eye sockets. Mouth wasn't wrong. A huge number of Coldwash citizens seem to have been modified from the standard human form ghost template. Monsters everywhere, doing mundane things; selling spectral bread from ghostly carts, sweeping the streets, and having their hair cut through the window of a barbershop by a barber who has knives instead of fingers.

I decide to walk since I've got time to burn before everyone's up, but even so it doesn't take long to get to Sune's temple. Like the one in Durolan, there's a wind chime and sky blue color theme, unlike Durolan, as many chimes are made of sea shells, bone, and hollow tubes of wood as are made of metal.

I don't see a priest selling incense like Ariel, so I begin a conversation with myself and whatever force might be listening.

"Is anyone there?"

No response. Wind chimes jangle, but no more than I'd expect. Part of me expects a full body apparition of... something. Sune? Someone else? It seems like every time I go to make these prayers I feel like someone's watching. *Do alters have eyes?*

I place several sticks of incense on the alter, and press my forehead to the stone the first priest of Sune gave me.

You are praying. Do you want to offer tribute to Sune, God of Lightning and Travel? Yes / No

I choose yes.

The wind stirs, and thunder rumbles in the distance. The Blessed buff appears in the top right hand corner of my vision.

Blessed

Sune favors you.

+1 Stamina

+1 Vigilance

You've earned the respect of Sune's clergy.

Duration: 24 hours

I hear something in the wind, but it's not a man. As the wind blows harder, I close my eyes and try hard to focus on my sense of sound.

Listening

Perception + Vigilance. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 2)

"I hear em' coming."

Vigilance skill increased by 1. Current level: 5

"I shouldn't play favorites." That was. a woman... and somehow familiar, but I can't place it. Certainly not the Lord of Lightning. The voice was so indistinct, it almost seems like my imagination. The wind rustles again, melodic chimes sound. "I miss you."

A chill bites that has nothing to do with the wind.

* * * * *

Praying done, I find myself a tree within a park where spectral birds tweet, and a pair of ghost lovers touch lips over a picnic basket on a red quilt beside a manmade pond. I'm about to sit down when I'm hit in the neck with a hacky sack. *Where'd it come from?*

A couple of kids, one a boy with dark brown vest and khaki britches, the other naked but sculpted, fluxed as Mouth called it, to look like a walking tree start laughing. I bend down, pick it up and examine it in my hand. It's a small brown lump like a giant truffle, unlike the colorful hacky sacks of Earth. The tree boy looks abashed as he says "Sorry," but the other kid continues to giggle and snort.

I say, "No problem." and toss it back. The human looking ghost taps it with his knee, catches it with his foot, and serves it to the tree-boy. I wonder if they're playing with it because they like it, or if they're forced to action by a routine set to have them kick that thing around every day in the same exact spot. With all the changes, at what point do NPCs establish their own free will?

I'm now sitting with my back against the tree watching the lovers, and kids who are back to kicking the small bag of rice or sand back and forth about twenty paces away. It's nice to do nothing for a while. Since the meeting at the Lodge of Arcanum I've felt constantly on the move. I take a deep breath, and savor the embrace of clean High Hades air passing through my nose and into my lungs. I can almost believe it's real.

Who could be missing me?

Mirae's the obvious choice, but it doesn't feel right. For one thing, she's not a disembodied voice, and she knows we're coming, and what does she have to play favorites over?

I doze for a time, not truly asleep, but resting with my eyes closed and the sensation of tree bark pressing into my scalp. The world feels slow. I can't find any answers. I sigh, pull out my VT and pick a pen and parchment from my inventory.

Pehrom -

The quest is going well. We should have Mirae in a couple days, and after that it's just a matter of getting out of Hades and back to Durolan. We've seen her in a scrying pool, and she looks good.

I heard about your wife. I hope you're all okay. She is, of course, welcome in the guild but I guess you already know that since you invited her. What's going on? What were those gargoyles, and who were all the people in the banquet hall? Is this about Dragonsbane, or is there something else going on that I need to know about?

Glad you're holding down the fort. If you need anything, we'll be here for you when we get back. I look forward to meeting your wife.

- M

I read over it several times. It feels very plain, and yet what else is there to say? *My condolences?* Seems out of place for a reunion, and Pahrem's right he's not one for brooding. I fold the paper, and stick it in an envelope for later delivery. From now until we meet, I'm content to just sit back, enjoy the shade and wait.

It's after four and I'm sitting on a bench outside the train station waiting for the last of our group to show up. When Leroy and Sajina approach I know we're ready to go.

I say, "Everyone ready?"

Frobod says, "We're here, aren't we?"

"Good." I say. "I have no idea if once I talk to someone it'll immediately start the next phase of the quest."

Sajina asks, "Who do we talk to?"

I shrug and say, "That's why we're here early."

Leroy says, "Might as well start with the ticket counter."

I say, "Before I forget. Send this to Pehrom when you get a chance." I pass him my letter.

He says, "I'll do it when we get settled in."

There's a little stone booth with bars over windows and a sign that says "Tickets" in bold red letters.

A bespectacled bald man sits at the window in a wooly black sweater. He's human in appearance save for harsh, red, train wheel patterns that have been

branded on his cheeks. He says, "If you're going to Athelon Necropolis, the next available seats are in 13 days for coach, and 8 for first class."

"We're not here to purchase tickets." I say.

He adjusts his glasses as if turning a knob on a microscope to get a better look at us. He says, in a polite, albeit skeptical voice, "Then how may I help you?"

I say, "I think we're here to see your boss." He doesn't say anything, but his right eyebrow creeps higher on his head. "We've taken a contract and will be working Shroudmoon Express security." I pause, Well... Security and I guess he's entertainment." I motion to Sajina.

The clerk says, "Why didn't you say so? Do you have papers?"

I fish the document Milnus gave me out of inventory and pass it through the bars of the window. Sajina steps forward and presents a similar document. The man's eyes flicker back and forth as he reads the text before reaching behind his desk and depositing a tent shaped "Back in 10 Minutes" sign on his side of the counter.

He stands, turns, and says, "Meet me in back."

Before we can meet behind the ticket booth he calls, "Conductor Watts! Your new hires are here."

We walk around the stone building to discover the clerk waving down a tall, lanky man in a black vested suit with gold buttons and a pocket watch chain dangling in an inverted rainbow. His black, yellow banded hat is much the same as any conductor's hat I've seen over the years, save for a crest depicting a dark crescent moon and the image of a skull. It catches me by surprise because it's Freeworld garb, albeit old fashioned.

The second surprise is when he speaks. His voice is good natured. I'd expected him to be all business, something about the stuffy attire, but his words are warm and welcoming.

Watts says, "I'm glad to see you've come early." a train hisses a steamy gasp from the other side of the station, a bell tolls to announce its arrival. I hadn't noticed the tracks before. It rolls to a slow stop sporting an eclectic assortment of cars. Three in a row look like they could have come right off Seattle's Light Link railroad, but after there's an antiquated car that looks like it belongs in an old time western movie filled with horse riding bandits calling for everyone to 'stick em' up,' and a brown behemoth with a slighting door that seems more appropriate for a freight train.

I must be gawking because Watts asks, "Is this your first time?"

I nod yes, "Train's here for cleaning, so why don't I give y'all a tour?"

"That'd be great." I say.

Leroy notes, "The cars seem a little mismatched."

Watts smiles as if Leroy had touched on a point of pride, "How much do y'all know about the Shroudmoon express."

"It's a train." Frobod says, "Travels between High and Low Hades, with rumors that it also appears in the real world. Err..." the death knight fumbles, "I mean the lands of the living."

I give him a look as if to say "Don't go thinking of Haven as the real anything." If Frobod starts losing track of reality, what hope do the rest of us have?

Watts beams, "All true, though we don't like to advertise the latter. It's... more of a glitch."

"A glitch?" Leroy asks.

"You know..." He says, "A kink in the system. Something doesn't go as planned."

Leroy says, "I know what a glitch is, but how does a train have a glitch?"

Watts shrugs. "It's magic. Strange things happen." The carefree tone of his voice indicates that it doesn't bother him.

Frobod asks, "When it glitches, what happens?"

Watts says, "I'll give you an example. Back in October we were supposed to make a stop in Portland Necropolis, that's Low Hades if you haven't been there, to pick up some cargo and a hand full of passengers. We pull into the station and there's no one there, at least no one we're expecting, and all the signs were different. A guy gets on the train holding a golden and red ticket like nothing I've ever seen before. I call my supervisor, and he tells me if I ever see a ticket like that I'm to let the passenger on the train, and forget I saw it, or it'd be my job. So, I did. He got off somewhere in Low Hades, and I never saw him again."

Sajina asks, "How do you know he came from the living world?"

Watts stares at the gargoyle incredulously, "Because he was alive. Same as all of you."

Tako says, "You can tell? Aside from all the fluxed ghosts, most of the dead we've seen have looked pretty normal."

Watts says, "You're not dead, so you wouldn't know, but the living have a glow about them that we can see. You're all brighter than anyone around you, and you don't have death marks."

Leroy asks, "What are those?"

Watts says, "Every soul in Hades is stained by marks that tell the story of how they died. Some are better at reading them than others."

"Good to know." I say, "but what does this have to do with the train."

"Nothing" Watts says, "Just explaining how I knew our passenger was alive. Anyway, follow me, and I'll give you the grand tour."

He leads us the direction the bell sounded. Tired puffs of quiet steam escape the top of a black steam engine with a massive white clock decorating its circular face. Behind it there's a comparatively modern electric engine that might have been in service sometime within the last hundred years.

"All aboard." Watts says, as he leaps up on to a step leading into the first car.

Not knowing what to expect, we follow. The scent of char hits my nose, as he pulls a sliding wooden door open. The wood's been burnt... badly... but inside it appears that they remodeled an old boxcar, adding burgundy carpet, a loft, and comfortable, albeit simple wooden seats like church pews with shallow indentations to cup your buttocks. They face each other for ease of conversation, and a few have bolted down coffee tables set between for people to rest their drinks or play cards. Yellow mage light lanterns, affixed to the wall above each bench cast the room in warm light.

Watts continues, "Cars one and two are for staff. Second level we have cots for those who need to take a rest. First floor's the lounge, in the next car you'll find the kitchen and more places to sit while you're on break "

Frobod says, "Looks like a it was for hauling farm equipment."

"Maybe." Watts says, "Burned up in 1937 with a father and three children inside. When it crossed over, we initially used it to transport goods throughout Hades, but about 20 years ago as newer cars started coming in, we decided to repurpose it as a staff lounge."

Frobod asks, "What do you mean crossed over?"

Watts, maintaining politeness, but looking as if Frobod asked something that even school kids should know says, "What do you know about relics?"

Frobod says, "Nothing, why?"

Leroy asks, "What's a relic?"

Watts motions to the car around him, "Sometimes when an object is destroyed, it continues it's existence in Hades, much like a person."

Leroy says, "So anything can become a relic?"

Watts says, "There two types of relic, natural and magical. Items with powerful emotional anchors cross over as natural relics. For example, wedding rings, a favorite teddy bear, or a train car that was destroyed in a moment of fatal tragedy. The engines, and each one of our cars are relics."

Leroy, enthusiastic, asks, "What about the magical kind?"

Watts says, "They come in two varieties, new and old. Most objects that are destroyed shortly after having been imbued with a newly laid permanent enchantment will cross over, though they are uncommon due to that most people are careful with newly created magical items."

Leroy asks, "And the others?"

Watts says, "Old relics are those items with magic so strong that after their physical destruction, an echo of their presence lingers in the afterlife. Some swords, for example, centuries old have been known to appear in Hades in the wake of their destruction."

I say, "But that's not what these cars are. Each one of these has a story."

Watts beams. "A story, and in most cases tragedy." He motions to the charred wood of the boxcar. "They have death marks that even you can see."

Pahrem says, "That'd be a lotta history if they were real." In the way of NPCs, Watts disregards the comment as he would any suggestion that Freehaven isn't the real world.

Looking to Annette, James, and Jason who have been lingering at the back of our group, Watts says, "You'll be confined to the first four cars for the duration of the trip. You may rest here now, or come back in about an hour. The train leaves at six sharp."

"We'll be here." Annette says, and takes a seat on one of the benches looking around as if to say "It'll do. I can't complain under the circumstances." She, like the others are weighed down by tiredness and bewilderment.

Watts, taking pity on the woman, says, "There are windows in the next car."

Annette says, "Here's fine for now." Jason and James settle into the seats across from her.

"Onward!" Watts says. Walking us through the car to another sliding door at the far end. "We added these doors during the remodel. Looks like they belong don't they."

Tako says, "Yeah... Really... Farmhouse Chic."

As we pass Watts into the next car, a 19th century dining car with a little room partitioned off that says "Kitchen.", he says "Our forgers do fantastic work." totally missing Tako's sarcasm.

This car is a lot more airy, with natural lighting. I can see people milling outside the Shroudmoon Express, in preparation for their journeys.

Pahrem says, "How many train's are there like this?"

"None." Watts says, "We're the only one."

Leroy says, "I guess that explains the long waits to get a ticket."

Watts says, "There's been talk of splitting the express into two shorter trains, but we haven't done it. Personally, I think we've got enough cars now to manage."

I ask, "How do you get them?"

"Government has a bounty on em'." Watts says, "Anyone who uncovers a new, functional relic car receives quite a settlement. Anyone who finds an engine... well... Let's just say their death won't be wanting for comfort. Fast, reliable transportation is big business."

Leroy asks, "Why don't you just make new ones?"

Watts says, "Cars? We've managed, but they start to break down after a couple of years. They're expensive. Engines? They don't work the same way they did in the mortal world. They run on magic that no one quite understands yet. They may look like steam, or sound like electricity, but I'm telling you there's no one in there adding fuel to the fire. High Hades doesn't even have electricity. We think it's the magic that causes the Hades forged cars to break down so quickly."

"Good to know." I say imagining relic hunting quests.

Watts says, "Let's move on." He ushers us into the next car which makes my skin rough with goose flesh, my breath puffs in a white cloud. "This is the first class ice bar."

Frobod asks, "You have an ice bar?"

Watts says, "Only for first class. Sometimes we like to theme the cars according to their destruction. In this case, the car we're standing in ran off the track and crashed into a frozen lake killing 12 people." He gestures to the wall, the surface of which looks warped with water damage. "Now we celebrate the history by having the temperature lowered with magic, and serving alcohol in glasses made out of ice. Anything that'd normally be made of glass is ice in this car, including the chandelier."

"Seems a bit extravagant for a rail car." Frobod says.

Watts shrugs in a way that suggests he agrees, but isn't complaining. "If they're willing to pay for it..." Watts lets that hang in the air before continuing. "Onward."

And so the tour goes, car after car featuring a brief history, and what goes on in them. Aside from a few themed first class cars, the majority serve the same purposes, though they vary in their appearances. There are dining cars, standard seats, and sleeper cars for long journeys.

I'm caught off guard when at the back of one of the economy class cabins Watts points out a ladder between the two connecting cars. He says, "If you haven't noticed, every car is equipped with one of these. You're security, care to guess why?"

Tako says, "To get on to the roof."

Watts says, "Correct!"

Tako says, "I'm smart like that."

Leroy says, "Why would we need to get on the roof?"

Watts says, "That's the interesting part. As security you're expected to defend the Shroudmoon Express and it's patrons from all dangers.... Including monsters. If we encounter something that is in pursuit of the train, and there are no cars with open windows in the vicinity, you'll have to go up top to do battle."

Tako says, "That sounds safe."

I say, "Dude, train top battles and chases have been in the movies forever. It makes sense that we'd find them in game."

Watts says, "I advise you not to fall off. That said, we provide magical tethers should your duties take you up top." He presses a black coin in my palm minted with the same moon and skull logo that appears on his hat. Everyone receives one. "It'll bring you back to the staff car from anywhere within Hades if you survive the fall."

You have received Shroudmoon Tether.

Shroudmoon Tether

Returns you to the staff cabin of the Shroudmoon Express. To activate, squeeze and make a wish to return to the Shroudmoon Express.

Expires at conclusion of Shroudmoon Express contract.

"And if we don't?" Frobod asks.

"Watts shrugs. "Perhaps you'll immigrate. There's also an alarm that will sound if the train is in immediate danger. Passengers will retreat to their seats and/or sleeping cabins, and you'll be summoned to take care of the problem. If the threat is obvious, you're to intercept with due haste. If not, meet in the staff cars for a briefing."

Frobod asks, "What if we're at the end of the train."

Watts says, "You won't be. The last half of the cars are all cargo."

Frobod says, "What if we're in the last passenger car, and the alarm sounds?"

"Use your tether. They also work while aboard the train. Why don't we try them out." Watts holds a coin that looks just like ours in hand, and closes his eyes, and says. "Just so." His image ripples, as if under water, and vanishes in a pulse of white light.

"Guess we're supposed to follow." Leroy says.

"After you." I say, and then Leroy disappears.

Tako's the next to vanish, then Sajina. Confident that the rest of the group can figure it out, I close my eyes, give the coin a squeeze, and think 'I wish I was in the staff car.' I feel dizzy though, I suspect that this stems more from being teleported to a location I couldn't see than anything else. It's not like stepping through a portal where you can see your destination, and the sudden change of scenery with the charred wood smell is disorienting. The rest of the group shimmer into the lounge right behind me.

Watts says, "I think that's about everything. If you have questions feel free to ask. Train leaves in..." He checks his pocket watch. "Forty-five minutes, so if you want to eat before you start, or run an errand in the city now's the time."

I say, "Thanks. I think we're good to hang out here for a while." I look to everyone else seeking confirmation. No one objects.

"Oh." Watts begins, "One more thing, be sure to pick up your sash in the next car before you start work. They're like a uniform. They tell everyone you're working security."

"Got it." I say, "Where're Annette and the boys?"

A lean woman in a shocking blue suit that makes her look like a 1960s stewardess enters as I ask, and says, "If you mean the mortals, they decided to take a nap." She points to the ceiling with her eyes in a way that says 'right above us.' "You can wake them if you want."

"That's fine." I say, "I was just curious. Let them sleep." I take a seat on one of the benches with a coffee table, and withdraw some of goblin jerky from inventory. "I wonder how long it'll take Pehrom to make pasta. I'm in dire need of spaghetti."

Pahrem says, "Lasagna."

"Lasagna..." I whimper.

Tako says, "Food of the gods."



Chapter 18 - Keeping it Safe

The first couple hours aboard the Shroudmoon Express are astounding in their mundanity; not a single bandit attack, or wayward creature trying to board the train. It's starting to feel like an actual job as we pace up and down the cars, looking for wrong doers and not finding any. As a game quest, I'd expected a lot more action. If I were still logging in and out and paying to be entertained, I'd be thinking this journey is a colossal waste of time. The thing is, we aren't and I'm more than happy to accept monsters not trying to kill us in exchange for a swift trip to rescue Mirae.

I push open the door to economy class cabin car seven when I see a big eared goblin woman standing on her seat, trying to reach the guy behind her with a clinched fist. Her hair's just barely long enough to form the short violet pig tails that stand out against her green skin. She has a steel nose ring, and a neck piece that looks like a spiked dog collar. She kinda reminds me of Scooti... if Scootiwutams was a little green woman.

"Hey!" I say, "Settle down."

"This guys a bastard!" She announces for all to hear. A number of ghost patrons in that look like humans stare, while others make a point of not making eye contact, and looking the other direction.

I say, "What's going on?"

The goblin, named Maeris by her name plate, also a ghost like all the others, "Thank the gods. You security?"

"I am..." I say, indicating the Shroudmoon sash with the moon and skull logo crossing my chest.

"Well this wise guy over here's trying to kill us. He won't stop fartin'! I dunno what he ate, but if he keeps it up I'm gonna force feed him a knuckle sandwich." She peeks over the back of the seat. "You hear?"

The man, named Atticus, is a balding human with a birdlike nose, and wire rimmed accountant's glasses. He shifts uncomfortably in his seat, and speaks, sounding embarrassed. "I have a condition."

"Miss... Maeris..." I use her name to make a personal connection, "I can't..."

It's at that moment the accountant looking man lets one rip, a loud "ppbbbbbbbtttt..." sound. The stench of anus hits me full in the face.

"Hey guy!" Maeris says, clinching her small fist, "Wash your butt crack! Think you can stick him outside on top or somethin'?"

I mumble so hopefully only the goblin can hear, "That's pretty bad." Usually the game filters out unpleasant environmental smells, but since this is part of a quest, I guess players aren't spared.

I say, "I can't make him put a cork in it."

Ppbbbt

Maeris says, "You think that'd work? I'd be happy to do it if it'll put a stop to it."

I say, "Don't do that. If you touch him, we'll have to put you off at the next stop."

"Ya gotta help a girl out here." The goblin says, "You see what we're dealin' with?"

Pbbbt

I look to Atticus and say, "You're not helping." Then back to Maeris. "Give me a minute to check something."

I pull out my VT.

Melpomine: Is the medical station empty?

A few moments pass before I get a response from one of the other party members.

LeroyJensen: I'm near there. Hold up while I check it out.

LeroyJensen: Yeah it's clear. What's going on?

Melpomine: We've got a natural gas problem in Economy 7, and passengers are upset. I'm thinking we can bring the guy there until he gets it out of his system, or maybe the healer can fix him.

LeroyJensen: Natural gas?

Melpomine: Never mind, but if you see one of the support staff, see if they have anything that can deodorize a car. Maybe there's a spell or something.

LeroyJensen: Errr... Okay. Economy, car 7?

Melpomine: Right.

I look to Atticus and say, "You're coming with me."

"Thank the gods!" Maeris says. "You gonna lock him up?"

I say, "You're not in trouble. Just gonna take you to medical to get you looked at. Maybe the healers can do something..." The man nods, embarrassed, and stands from his seat. He stares at the floor as if not seeing other people somehow means that they can't see him. "Let's go."

As we're passing through economy four another pbbbt. A man, clearly related to a young boy of about twelve, nudges him across the aisle and, says "You shootin' rabbits over there kid?"

Pbbt..

His mother, sitting to his left swats his shoulder and says, "We're in public!"

We hasten our pace as he wines, "I didn't do it!" with indignance coating his voice.

Things are quiet again in the next few hours, until Tako sends a message in party chat.

TakoStar: Can you guys give me a hand in economy car 9?
Melpomine: What's up?

TakoStar: Some kid lost his kumonezumi and passengers are losing their shit. I need help finding and catching it.

Melpomine: His what?
LeroyJensen: They're spider rats.
Melpomine: Do I want to know?
TakoStar: Do you like big furry rodents with lots of eyes and just as many legs?"
Melpomine: Not particularly.
TakoStar: Then probably not. So, can you come help?

I sigh and respond.

Melpomine: I'm on it.

That gets me thinking, should I go back to playing a were-spider a kumonezumi could be pretty useful.

Melpomine: Are you sure we can't kill it?
TakoStar: Have a heart. It's a kid's pet.

Damn. Werespiders learn to take on different shapes based on what mundane spiders they consume. I'm wondering if kumonezumi qualify. *Oh well.*

I arrive at car number 9 to discover passengers either standing on their seats, or backed against the window searching the ground frantically. As soon as I enter, a pudgy lady with a beehive hair do and in a pink moo moo dress nudges me out of the way and waddles into the little chamber between cars. A moment later, a brawny football looking dude with a crop top hair cut joins her, muttering "I don't do spiders" as he passes.

Tako says, "It's a fast little bugger."

I say, "Where is it?"

A lance of fire launches from the end of another passenger's finger as it points like it's shooting a gun. I can't tell if it's male or female because he or she has been fluxed so completely to resemble an Area-51 alien... right down to the ken doll space between it's smooth grey legs.

"Hey!" I say. "No fire on the express! Are you trying to burn up everyone here?"

The alien looking creature, cocks it's head, and returns its hand to his pocket as if holstering a pistol. It's only now that I realize that he... she... it has no mouth. *I wonder if ghosts have to eat, or if all the food here is for pleasure.*

Tako says, "Last I saw it was right over there." He motions with his hand, then a woman in the opposite direction shrieks and jumps up on her seat like the other passengers.

A kid, maybe thirteen or fourteen by my reckoning in a blue baseball hat, and matching baseball jersey says, "He won't hurt you. He's just scared." He's holding a cat carrier in his hand with the door wide open. His eyes are a big innocent teary blue like a cartoon character. *Freeworld garb.* I take notice.

"Kill it!" another woman says, and throws her shoe ineffectually.

"Hey." I say. "It's just a pet. We'll take care of it. No killing anything unless it bites someone."

Tako says, "I guess it's over there now."

I look to the kid and say, "Did you let it out on purpose?"

"He was lonely. I just wanted to give him some air. I didn't think he'd jump off my lap."

I say, "When we find your keep him inside. No more running around in here." Something moves in the corner of my vision, juvenile cat sized, grey, and furry. I point and say, "There!"

Tako darts after, but misses in a spectacular leap that ends in a THUMP leaving him chest down on the floor. He's not fast to rise, so I ask "Are you okay?"

"Shhh..." He says. "I see it." And reaches his hand under the seat to his right. His voice is calm as he continues, "Go around the other side in case it runs."

Deep in concentration, Tako reaches his hand deeper under the chair when, he yelps "Owe! Little bastard!" and puts his finger in his mouth. "Melpomine there! Go go go!"

It's the first time I've had a good look at the creature, it's grey fur looks soft, but individual legs twitch like a spider. I move slowly not wanting to spook it, and squat down. I extend my hand as if greeting an unfamiliar dog for the first time. Those eight legs twitch.

Keeping my voice calm I say, "There... No one's going to hurt you." It's fricking weird extending my hand with all those eyes locked on me.

Calm

Manipulation + Animal Ken. Success!

(Caliber of Success: 1)

"Please don't bite me..."

My hand's almost close enough to pat it's creepy little head when suddenly it rears up on four legs, and jumps. The little creature skitters up my arm leaving me with the sensation of many little limbs pat pat pattering across my skin. I grit my teeth. *"Get it off! Get it off! ... don't... move..."*

It's now at my shoulder where I can't see. I'm afraid it's going to touch my neck when I feel a little jolt of motion as the arachnid... rat... thing goes flying. A passenger just behind me screams, but the kid is fast and catches it like a football

pulled close to his chest. He nuzzles it's ratty nose with his own, and I say "Back in the carrier. Now."

He starts to say, "But... "

"Your spider rat thing-"

Tako corrects, "Kumonezumi."

I say "Kumonezumi, whatever. It's got to stay in the crate. If you can't do that we'll have to take it from you and place it in cargo."

"Fine..." He huffs, sounding sad. I could almost feel bad for him, if not for the memory of all those little legs running up my arm.

Case closed. I'm glad to see the kumonezumi returned to its cage.

I say, "I'm heading back to the staff car to take a break, and eat some jerky. You want to come?"

Tako says, "I'm good here for a while. Just needed some help catching the thing. Seems like you're better than me with animals."

I laugh and say, "Not really. Animal ken's only at level one, and I just got that when we met Cerberus."

Tako says, "Yeah, well thanks anyway. I can take it from here."

After a late dinner of tasteless trail rations, and goblin jerky, there's another long period of quiet as I stroll down and up the length of the Shroudmoon Express. Some passengers come to recognize me and smile as I pass. Sajina's having a grand time playing his harp in the ice bar, to the delight of first class passengers sipping ghost wine from delicate frozen glasses. His stone skin must protect him from feeling cold. He gives me a little nod as I pass through, and continue on my way.

It's about two AM now, and the majority of passengers are sleeping, or keeping themselves busy with quiet solitary hobbies. I've seen a few games of cards but nothing to suggest high stakes gambling that could cause a fight and put passengers in danger.

Sajina:	Guys help. Come to the ice bar.
Melpomine:	What's up?
Sajina:	Drunks getting grabby and starting a fight.
Melpomine:	In first class?
Sajina: Yes!	Hurry.
LeroyJensen:	Nothing happening here. I'm coming.

I use the tether stone to port to the staff car since it's far closer to the Ice Bar than where I'm standing. Leroy had the same idea, because the air shimmers and now he's standing right beside me. As we enter, a brunette woman in a dark blue cocktail dress cowers behind the bar trying to hide herself from the action as two men face off wielding icy shards of broken glasses as weapons.

"You keep your hands off her!" says the one closest to the door we just entered from. He's wearing a white button down dress shirt, with golden cuff links and khaki slacks, which tells me that he and the woman he's defending come from the Freeworld.

His opponent, clearly from Haven, sports a casual embroidered tunic, that looks expensive. I'd put him in his late 20's. He's red in the cheeks, and sways on

his feet. "You don't tell me what to do." He slurs. "I tell you. Do you know who my father is?"

The Freeworld man, named Dmitri says, "I don't care. You back off if you want to keep that hand of yours." As he speaks I realize he has a red cut on his face.

The drunken Haven man snaps his fingers, points at Dmitri, and says, "Teach him a lesson." His name is Merin.

A couple of goons who had been sitting at a table made of ice behind Merin stand. They too look a bit tipsy but their boss is the drunkest of the lot.

"Security!" I say, "Everyone sit down and put your weapons away."

Dmitri says, "I want him arrested. He groped my companion."

"This true?" I look to Sajina, who nods. Then says, "I think it's time for you to go back to your cabin."

"Don't you hear lady?" Merin says, "You don't tell me. I tell you. Do you know who my father is? I'll have your job."

I look to Leroy and say, "Let's take em'."

As soon as I step to Merin, one of the two extras moves to intercept me, but I maneuver out of his grasp, and punch him in the nose that sparks with a flash of lightning. His health drops by 20%.

Sajina plays his harp, as I look to Dmitri and say "Don't interfere unless you want to join em'."

Leroy says, "Sleep on the drunkard, I'll take the other add." and steps forward.

"Who you calling a drunk?" Merin says. Sajina continues to play. One step... two staggering steps... Merin falls flat on his face leaving Leroy and I to deal with his buddies.

The guy who tried to grab me comes in for a strike but I dip out of the way and use his momentum to send him smashing him into a table. *Oops*. The stem connecting the frigid furniture to the floor snaps, and the table top with all the drinks on top of it crashes to the floor. The a man and a woman in Haven clothes stand abruptly, scooting away from the mess so as not to be splashed by alcohol. "Sorry." I say, and look to the guy on the floor. I don't want to kill these guys like I would a normal opponent.

Then, when I least expect it, Frobod strolls in from the same door that we entered.

"Saw your chat thought I'd check-" His eyes move to the sleeping Merin, to the guy I just tossed, and to the one Leroy's closing in on.

I say, "Help me subdue him before he gets up!"

That's all the death knight needs. He barrels in and collapses on top of the guy who came at me. He struggles feebly on the ground, as Frobod says, "I've got rope. Can you hold him?"

I press my knee into his back as Frobod ties his hands from behind.

I say, "Two down..." and I'm surprised to see that Leroy's opponent isn't fighting.

Leroy says, "This one's gonna come peacefully. That right?" The guy standing in front of him nods. "Why don't you show us to your cabin?"

He nods again.

Leroy hefts Merin over his shoulder, as I say, "So sorry. They won't bother you any more." Then to the bar tender, who must shop at the same store as Alfred, I continue, "You think you can give these two some free drinks?" I look to Dmitri, "I know it doesn't make up for what happened but..." I shrug as if to say 'what more can I do?'

The couple that had been sitting at the broken table stare at the manhandled baddies gaping in astonishment. First class cabin, I've gotta believe their unaccustomed to tavern brawls. I say, "Maybe drinks for them too." as if I had any authority over the barkeep.

We toss Merin, and his hand tied friend unceremoniously in a cabin together. The bed makes a padded twump, as they hit the surface. Only the third is allowed to roam free.

Leroy says, "I'll stay here just in case they try to get out. I can handle them until someone comes to lock them in."

It's only a couple minutes until Watts shows up with a key ring in hand. The cabin lock clicks shut. POUND POUND POUND! "Let me out of here!" POUND POUND POUND! "When my father hears about...!"

I pound back on the door, "Keep it down in there I've never heard of your father, and don't care." I look to Watts, "That guy's annoying."

He sighs and says, "You did well. We'll keep them here until the next stop, where we'll let them off."

Frobod asks, "Will there be problems with his dad, whoever he is?"

Watts waves his hand dismissively, "A minor noble that thinks he's more important than he is. There's only one Shroudmoon Express, which means we hold all the cards."

I say, "Well I guess that's good to know."

POUND POUND POUND followed by a muted, "LET ME OUT!"

Watts answers, "You'll be let out at the next station where you will depart the train." He then looks to each of us and say, "It's late. This might be a good time for you to get some rest now that things have quieted down. The regular staff will cover for a few hours if you want a quick nap."

I check my VT for the time, 3 AM. Rest doesn't seem like such a bad idea, as I say, "Are you sure?"

Watts nods, "We'll wake you up if we need anything."

Back in the scorched car, Annette, Jason, and James are playing a game that somehow involves both cards and dice that I haven't seen before. I say, "How're you holding up?"

Annette responds, "A bit hungry, but a lot better than being with vampires."

I say, "You look better."

Annette says, "We had a good rest when we arrived."

Jason says, "You got any more food? I know you said not to eat the Hades stuff but every time I see someone munching it's really tempting."

I slap my forehead and say, "Ugh.. I'm so sorry. I forgot. If you ever feel like you're starving, just grab me okay?" I pull a good nine trail rations from inventory and distribute them for them to share. "That should cover you for a while, right?"

James says, "I think so. Thanks. Don't let us make you think we're ungrateful. If it weren't for you guys we'd be eaten rather than eating right now. "

"Don't worry." I say, "We'll get you back to the living soon, and you can eat all the food you want."

Leroy, Frobod and I all head up to the top level where we discover that Pahrem and Tako are already snoozing. The inherent char smell of the staff cabin is stronger closer to the ceiling. We stretch out on our cots and I find my eyes tracing the rough, blackened texture of the wood above me.

You are in bed.

Would you like to sleep? Yes / No



Chapter 19 - Deadscream

I jump and hit my back on the edge of the cot as I hit the floor. The harsh whine of an air horn sets my head rattling. Red mage lights pulse in the room like it's a nuclear meltdown.

BEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEERRRRR. Another ear splitting toot, followed by a trio of lower BOWWNG BOWWNG BOOOWWWNG sounds reminiscent of a big rig semi truck.

Tako groans, "Ugh!"

Pahrem says, "Alright, alright! I'm up already. Sheesh."

My head feels groggy. The sounds have stopped, but the red mage lights keep flashing.

Leroy says, "You think this is what they meant by sounding the alarm?"

I say, "Sounds like it."

Pahrem says, "Awe, man. What is it? Bad enough I had to run down a guy with an adult diaper tryin' to sneak into first class. I dunno how much more of this I can take."

"You had to...?"

Frobod, seeming to have adjusted better to the rude awakening than the rest of us cuts me off, "Let's go. I've got a good feeling about this." The death knight's out of bed, and making his way down the tight spiral steps to floor one. We're clumsily making our way behind him.

Watts intercepts us, breathing fast, with eyes that are wild and unsteady, constantly flickering around the cabin. "Security! We need you on the roof now!"

Leroy asks, "What is it?"

Watts all but shouts, "It's Deadscream! Get on the roof now and protect us!"

I pull out my VT and fast equip Bite. The rest of the group equips their combat gear, though Sajina's nowhere to be found. Watt's grips his pocket watch, fast squeezing it in his fist like a frantic heartbeat.

"Alright, we're goin'!" Pahrem says. "Who or what's a Deadscream?"

Watts says, "There's no time! Get out there now before he eats everyone on this train!"

As our group begins moving toward the exit, Watts relents and gives us at least some information. "He's a draconic mummy, only not quite. The ritual failed

so now he consumes souls in the hope of gathering enough power to complete the transformation into one of The Undying."

Tako says, "A dragon. I like it."

Pahrem says, "Ain't that what they tryin' ta do to Mirae, bring her back to life n' shit?"

Watts, panicking says, "Go!"

Quest Update: Quest - Shroudmoon Express - Cabin Security

Quest Update: Limited Edition: The Lost Champion - Part 2

Your presence has attracted the attention of Deadscream the Forsaken. Once a powerful draconic Chronomancer, he's now a ravenous undead horror due to a failed mummification ritual that should have made him reborn as one of The Undying.

Defeat him before he can consume the souls aboard the Shroudmoon Express, and return to the Lodge of Arcanum with any information about his condition you discover.

Conditions for Completion Updated

Quest - Shroudmoon Express - Cabin Security:

Defeat Deadscream

0/1

Limited Edition: The Lost Champion - Part 2

Report to the Lodge of Arcanum with your Findings

0/1

Leroy says, "I know the bard's not on security, but he can help. Send him up with us if you can find him."

Watts gives a decisive nod, though still fidgeting with his pocket watch.

As soon as we climb the ladder to the roof, a golden sunburst appears on our minimap indicating a unique rare-spawn creature that few players will have a chance to kill. The sky is alive and cloudless with brisk air and the eerie blue of twilight. My hair thrashes in the wind.

"Where is it?" I ask.

Leroy says, "A never before seen boss fight with no established strategy. My favorite. You want to tank?"

"Yeah." I say, "Be ready to off tank if there are adds, or I go down."

A massive body, wrapped in musty tattered bandages rides currents of air above us. They flutter off the ends of massive wings like dirty party streamers. A booming voice sounds, "I will be reborn."

Everyone but Sajina's present, so I call, "Open fire ranged until he's within melee distance. Treating this as tank n' spank until we learn the fight."

Frobod launches a large headed thin tailed necrobolt that impacts the dragon's bandaged chest. The wild tail beats back and fourth when it strikes trying to penetrate its skin. Pahrem tosses one of her g'nades and misses by a

mile, and I hurl my Darksteel Chakram which cuts into the dragon's rear haunch. As Deadscream circles, the chakram reforms on my wrist.

The undead dragon's now out of range for anyone but an archer, and Tako's still equipping his bow.

Taunt. Successful.
Deadscream attacks.

Deadscream swoops in, and bathes the entire top of our car in ugly red flame. *Damn it! Half the difficulty of this boss is not having had a chance to prepare.* Between the little tongues of crimson, shadows that look like skeletal limbs claw skyward. I recoil from the heat on my skin. Pahrem groans "Ugh!" as she casts a golden heal on herself. Leroy, Frobod and I are still at full health, but Tako's down to eighty percent. No more damage from the fire, but the edges of the railcar still dance with tiny crackling whips of flame.

Switching to party chat, I say, "My bad. Split up! I should have anticipated an AOE breath weapon." I put on a sprint to the far end of the now blackened top of our car. "I'll try to hold him here. Everyone else strike from behind. If his back's toward the front of the train, get out of reach of the fire."

No one follows my advance as Deadscream swoops in for another blast of red flame. I'm coated in the stuff, but the rest of the team's out of reach. My health drops by ten percent but Pahrem's fast on the heals. By the time I recover, the dragon's out of range, but when I look back Tako's making good use of his bow, Leroy casts smite, and Frobod launches another necrobolt.

I shout "Hey!" and thump Bite against the roof of the train to draw our opponent's attention.

Taunt. Successful.
Deadscream attacks.

Even though he's out of range of my chakram, I don't want to risk him turning on the rest of the party. A light in the sky flashes as Leroy unleashes another smite. Deadscream circles, and takes air into his lungs. *Damn it! Doesn't he ever come down?.*

WOOOOOOSH... Another blast of red. The wind from the dragon's passing buffets my body causing me to take a step back. Each blast seems to grow hotter as my health drops thirty percent. I can't even connect with a ranged attack to do damage because he flies away.

A golden bubble springs up around me as my health inches back upward. Deadscream circles. I'm expecting more fire. I shout, "Hey!" and spin my staff. "Afraid you're gonna get hurt if you come closer? We've fought dragons twice as big as you, and we're still here. Ever heard of Cimmerian? Blasted our way right out of his stomach. What do you think you're gonna do that he can't?"

Feeding the fire.
Manipulation + Empathy. Success!
(Caliber of Success: 3)

"I think I'll like him when he's angry..."

Deadscream's drifting around and around like a turkey vulture, when suddenly he makes a dive for the train. I think he's gonna knock us off the tracks, but instead he drops hard on the car in front of us. I can see him taking a deep breath, his chest expands.

Shadow Step (Rank 5) - Success!

In a blink I vanish and reappear right behind him.

CRITICAL HIT

You hit Deadscream for 18 damage.

Deadscream resists 14 points of damage.

A zap like a cattle prod sounds as I bring my staff down hard on the dragon's rump. Bandages smoke, and a black spot appears where there was none before. Deadscream roars, and chokes on his fire preventing the party from being roasted.

He flaps his massive wings to hover over the moving train, turns in the air, and settles down with his face before me. It's my first clear look at it... A pair of red eyes like hot coals peer out behind a decaying face covered in worn wraps that constrict Deadscream's snout like a loose muzzle.

He says, "You're strong. I will slay you, and devour your soul. Perhaps..." he sounds contemplative, an incongruous tone considering we're in the middle of a fight. "... you're just what I need to be reborn."

In party chat, I say, "If you've got it, use fire! The bandages blacken when they're hit with Bite. Let's make this lizard a funeral pyre."

I whirl Bite, and crack him on the side of the face leaving more burn marks where I connect.

Pahrem shouts, "Incoming!" and I hear a glassy break behind the dragon's back. FWOOOOF! Deadscream's back ignites like a gasoline soaked Yule log.

He whips his head around angrily to face his new target, and I say "Uh uh!" and smack him again with Bite. "I heard dragons taste like chicken!"

Taunt. Successful.

Deadscream attacks.

Something inside Deadscream snaps as his big ugly head twists back at me. His eyes are wild and affronted, he lunges with talons sticking out of bandaged limbs. I dodge out of the way of the first, but the second connects. *Ugh!* That stings. *Crap!* I forgot to cast flow like water in my haste to enter the battle.

CRITICAL HIT

Deadscream hits you for 39 damage.

You resist 32 points of damage.

My health plummets. *Thirty-nine fucking damage?* Thank God for uber stamina and high endurance. One more tap and I'm dead.

The heat of Deadscream's burning bandages burns my face like peering into an open oven. Deadscream health, 50%. *At least DPS is making progress...* though I can't see them. I can only assume that Frobod's chopping away with his greatsword, and Tako's doing what Tako does with his vicious daggers.

I hear the call, "LEEEERRROOOOOOY JENSEEEEEEN!"

Deadscream's coming in for another attack. *Fuck!* One hit and it'll be respawn. A giant hand made out of white holy fire materializes around my body. I can't move. A new buff paired with a debuff appears in the right hand corner of my vision.

Safeguard of the Divine Inferno

Threat increased by 50%

Deals 60% of incoming damage (rounded up) to attackers as holy damage, difficulty 8 to resist.

All incoming damage transferred to Player: LeroyJensen

Duration: 30 seconds

Paralysis

You can't move.

Duration: 30 seconds

I've never seen this pally spell before, and make a note to have Leroy teach me.

I struggle against the hand of fire, but it's no use. At least it doesn't burn me. Deadscream's claw rips at me, but I feel no pain. In fact, my health is climbing upward as Pahrem kicks off a lightning flash heal, followed by a heal over time spell. I rise from 10% to forty... fifty.... sixty percent. I still can't move, but Deadscream explodes in a blaze of white as if I'd set off a holy fireball in his face.

I check my interface since there's nothing else I can do while I'm immobilized, and Leroy's health is dropping. Pahrem casts a heal that negates some of the damage, and Deadscream attacks again wah-BOOM, it's clawed foreleg crashes against the fiery hand, as Leroy's health dips, and another blast of holy magic hits it in the face.

Deadscream health: 30% .

I'm just barely able to see Frobod connect with his greatsword, as the dragon adjusts his position. Deadscream health: 20%. He's almost dead.

He flaps his massive wings, rises off the surface of the car, and says, "You fight well little mortals. I will be reborn." Pahrem's fire crackles and pops as it eats his bandages. He doesn't sound like he's about to die which can only mean it's time for phase two.

"You know the best thing about chrono magic?" the dragon says, "There's always time to fix your mistakes."

A ghostly golden pocket watch the size of Deadscream's body hangs in the air. The hands stop moving, and then begin winding backwards faster and faster.

With each counterclockwise circle of the second hand, the damage to Deadscream is reversed. Pahrem's flames wink out, and rear wounds that I could only make out once he took to the air begin to close.

Deadscream health: 100%

The ethereal clock fades.

Unfortunately we can't say the same for our own wounds, as Pahrem works fast to top us all off and her manna pool hasn't regenerated. I'm wondering if we're about to experience more flames when Sajina hefts himself up onto the roof of the car. Instead of the Lyre he looted from Cerberus, he's wielding a violin, which he begins playing with astonishing swiftness.

Is that... classic rock?

A little voice inside my head whispers. "Thunder. Na na na NA na na na!" *Ancient classic rock.* The crazy bastard's playing AC/DC on the violin. It's one of the few songs that old that I know. I can feel my self getting pumped, swept up in the currents of song. A new buff appears in the top right corner of my vision.

Warsong (Rank 4)

+4 Dexterity

+2 Damage to all attacks

+3 Luck bonus to all rolls

+7 Initiative Bonus

Holy crap! That's a nice buff. He must have learned it while off spending points with Leroy in Ashe March. +2 damage means it doesn't even have to be rolled, it's just added to whatever the engine comes up with when we attack. +7 initiative means that we're all more likely to act first when the system determines the order of attacks or other combative actions. Don't even get me started on that luck bonus.

Leroy laughs and says, "That's my boy! Give em' hell!"

Frobod launches a necrobolt that smashes into Deadscream's wing and causes him to tumble in the air, but our opponent steadies himself before it's too late. Tako rapid looses a trio of arrows in Deadscream's core mass. Blossoms of liquid red well up under the bandages.

We've got this.

Deadscream says, "Not so fast." As another mirage of a giant clock shimmers in the air, this one in shades of blue.

A new debuff appears in the corner of my sight.

Time Locked

You are frozen in time, and cannot act.

Duration: 20 seconds

The air condenses into a violet mist. The world freezes. Deadscream's clock floats in the air. I'm free to think, but Deadscream and everyone else in the party stand like waxen dummies. Frobod's mid step, Leroy's lips are parted as if about to say something, and Tako, positioned several paces away from the rest of

DPS has just loosed another arrow. It hangs in the air motionless on course to the dragons heart.

TakoStar has died.
Frobod has died.

In party chat I hear "Bastard!" from Tako at the same time as Frobod says, "Son of a bitch!" and Pahrem asks, "What happened?"

I say, "What happened? To me you both look frozen in place."

Tako says, "He breathed fire on us."

Frobod adds, "Hits like a rocket."

The Time Locked buff begins to flash which tells me it's expiring. 3....
2...1...

Leroy says, "Let's do it agai-" but his words are cut short when he sees Tako and Frobod's corpses. One moment they're mid action, the next they're smoldering lumps on the Express's roof.

I say, "Pahrem, how's your manna?"

Pahrem says, "I've got enough... for now."

I spin Bite, and pound it against the top of the train. "Hey asshole! Eat this!"

Taunt. Successful.
Deadscream attacks.

As soon as the taunt takes hold I launch the Darksteel Chakram. It shimmers in the air, and cuts deep like a meat cleaver. Deadscream inhales and spews red flame all over me. My health drops to 80%.

Leroy says, "Sajina, need you on DPS now! Use fire!"

The violin song stops, as the instrument vanishes into his inventory. Waving the bow like a giant wand, he unleashes a long operatic note. The air shimmers with heat, and then burning stones the size of soccer balls hail from above. They crash into Deadscream, causing bandages to ignite on contact.

Deadscream thrashes trying to put out the flames then settles back down on the car where we battled before. I seize the advantage smashing Bite into the side of the dragon's face, and follow through with a swift kick to its snout. I hear more opera song. A wave of heat rolls over me, with an audible FWOOF as more of the dragon's wraps catch fire. The flames trail in the wind from the rushing train like my hair while riding the Thunder Bridge. Deadscream health: 60%

"Keep at it!" I say, as Pahrem nudges my health back up to 90%.

"LEEEERROOOYYY JENNNNNSEN!" Leroy bellows, and barrels in from behind wielding his hammer. A wet crack sounds as it smashes into Deadscream's body in a flash of holy light. WHAM, Leroy brings the hammer down again before I can even think to launch an attack of my own.

Just to be sure I'm not losing agro, I make kissing sounds at the dragon.

Taunt. Successful.
Deadscream attacks.

Deadscream comes in for a nasty claw, but I narrowly slip out of the way. *Luck bonus.* I counterattack with Bite, sending maggots of electricity burrowing into the dragon's neck. Another musical note sounds.

BOOM KAWHAM BOOM BOOM.... Sizzle... FWOOF.

Fiery Meteorites crash into Deadscream's body, then explode in a revitalized puff of flame. Deadscream health: 20%

"Not so fast." The dragon says.

The blue clock shimmers in the air. *Fuck!* We're so close. I'm not ready to go home, all the way back to Durolan and have to start the quest to find Mirae over. I'm getting ready for the purple mist to descend and everything to stop moving, but that doesn't happen. Deadscream comes in for another swipe with his talons.

Deadscream hits you for 19 damage.
You resist 17 points of damage.

I'm alive!

The sparks rebounding off my boots and into the dragon's foreleg, seem feeble indeed, but at least I'm still in this.

In party chat, Pahrem says, "What's goin' on?"

Leroy asks, "You okay? We're time locked."

I say, "I'm good!" just in time to drown, at close range, in an inferno of red.

CRITICAL HIT

Deadscream hits you for 32 damage.
You resist 8 points of damage.

You have died.



Chapter 20 - Resurrection and Reunion

The world goes dark and I stare down at the remains of my corpse. The Shroudmoon Express and ground beneath the tracks glows like the moon, though the sky is completely black. Tako and Frobod are sitting beside their bodies. The living members of our party, along with our foe are conspicuously absent. We just see their shadows dancing over the surface of the rail car.

Frobod says, "He got you too, huh?"

I say, "No bueno."

You are dead.

Would you like to resurrect at your bind point in Durolan? Yes / No

I choose no, and continue in party chat, "I'm out, so all of you had better survive."

No response from Leroy, but he's not here, so I'm just going to hope that means he's focused on combat.

Frobod says, "It's gonna suck if we have to come all the way back here from Durolan."

Tako, looking shaken by the comment, says, "That won't happen. We've got Leroy fucking Jensen in our party. The guy's a one man army."

I sigh and say, "Let's hope so, though if worse comes to worst I could probably Thunder Bridge us to Cerberus, though I don't know how we'd pass without Sajina."

Frobod says, "At least we could pick up some books for Charon's quest."

I facepalm. "We should have done that from the beginning. All of us dying would have been way easier than all these quests."

Frobod says, "Wouldn't have given Leroy much for his videos."

Tako says, "Who cares about Leroy's videos? We're here to save Mirae."

I say, "Yeah I know, but Frobod does have a point. He didn't have to help us, and we didn't know there'd be a quest like that. It's only fair. Relax, we're almost there."

You are dead.

LeroyJensen wants to resurrect you.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I say, "Looks like they killed Deadscream. Just got my resurrection. See you in a few seconds."

I choose yes.

The world atop the train car fades back to me. I cough. It hurts. I mumble, "Owe."

Leroy says, "We're gonna need your dwarf alias to resurrect everyone."

I nod and say, "I'll take Frobod."

Pahrem's hands begin to glow as she begins chanting in a fantasy language I don't understand. Her hands flow in clouds of gold. A few seconds later, a translucent grim reaper with angel wings appears over Tako's body and hits it with a burst of light. The reaper... ghost... thing disappears as soon as his eyes begin to flutter.

I withdraw my VT, open up the Alias menu, and choose Scootiwutams. Streamers of red light to match her armor wrap around me, as my form grows smaller, stockier, and my blond pony tail becomes a pair of black pig tails.

Speaking in a Scottish brogue, I say, "I got just enough manna to do it." Having not set up a macro for resurrections yet, I have to find the spell from the list, and manually select it. I place my hands on Frobod's chest and say, "Come back, out of darkness, and into light!"

He groans.

As if not having been unnerved by the prospect of starting over moments before, Tako cheers, "Scooti! Pleeeaaasse keep the dwarf skin for a bit?"

I say, "I like Melpomine. I'm coming to think of it as my home skin."

He sighs and says, "Fine. You're a butthole. Scooti's awesome."

I ask, "What did Deadscream drop?"

Leroy says, "We decided to wait for you."

In place of the dragon, there's a hefty looking chest on top of the car where Deadscream's body once was. I motion to Tako, who usually loots, and say "You do the honors."

He throws open the lid of the chest.

Mantle of the Undying Chronomancer

Type:

Cloth

Slot:

Shoulder

Quality:

Epic

Equipped Bonus:

+ 3 Stamina, +4 Intellect, +1 Dexterity

Special Properties:

Use: Reduces your cooldowns by 24 hours. (Does not effect other cooldown reducing spells and effects.)

Deadscream's Wraps

Type: Leather
Slot: Chest
Quality: Epic
Equipped bonus:
Dexterity + 4, Stamina + 3, Strength + 1

Special Properties:

Use: Become invisible for three minutes, or until you've damaged another character.

Leg Plates of the Undying

Type: Plate
Slot: Legs
Quality: Epic
Equipped Bonus:
Stamina + 6, Strength + 2

Special Properties:

.Regenerates 1 health for every 4 attacks made in combat.

Set Bonus: Undying plate 0/5

Regeneration occurs after one fewer attacks for each piece of undying plate equipped.
Heals 2 health if the set is complete.

Book of Death and Rebirth

Quest Item

Description:

A magical tome of ancient magic.

Mangled Dolly (Unique)

This item begins a quest.

Description:

A child's toy that's seen better days. Beneath it's dress is the mark of the San'ta Elves. Someone in the North Pole may be looking for this.

Activate to start this quest.

Dragon Heartstone

Quest Item

Description:

A valuable stone created by dragon wizards. Can be sold for more than 10,000 gold in the right markets.

You have received loot:

Mangled Dolly (Unique)

Dragon Heartstone

I say, "Did everyone just get the dolly and heartstone?"

Usually when a unique item drops that no one has to roll for, everyone receives a copy in their inventory.

Tako says, "I got the dolly."

Leroy says, "Me too."

Frobod asks, "What Heartstone?"

Tako says, "I'm staring right in the box and I don't see anything like that."

"Weird." I say, "I see it on the list of lootable items."

Leroy asks, "Are you on a quest?"

"I have a few..." I say, "Why?"

Leroy says, "Probably an item for a quest we're not on."

I say, "Alright. Time to distribute loot. I'll hold on to the book since it's for the Lost Champion turn-in. First up, Mantle of the Undying Chronomancer."

Tako hands the book over.

You have received loot:

Book of Death and Rebirth

Sajina says, "Should I take that since it has intelligence?"

Leroy shakes his head, "You're on Charismatic casting. Charisma is your dump stat now."

I say, "Pahrem then?"

She says, "Hell yeah I'll take it."

Frobod's silent.

I say, "Next up, the wraps. I'm gonna roll for them, since they have dexterity. Tako?"

Tako says, "You bet your ass I'll roll."

TakoStar rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 10

Melpomine rolls 1 (1-10) sided dice. Result: 4

"Boom!" Tako says, "Get yo hands off my chest piece!"

Pahrem says, "You're the one that opened the chest."

"Yeah," Tako says, "But you were thinking of it. Don't lie. You were imagining yourself wrapped up in these old bloody rags cuz they so sexy, but they're all mine!"

Frobod's still silent.

I shrug and say, "Congrats." since I still have my Swiftstrike set, though I do think it'd be kinda cool to have a mummy top for cosmetic reasons.

Leroy says, "I'm gonna have to challenge you for the leg plates."

I wave my hand and say, "Take em'. Yeah, I've got Scooti, but you've been wearing plate this whole quest, unless Frobod wants em."

Pahrem says, "It's a tank set."

I look to Frobod for comment, but he's just staring at his VT. "Frobod?" If I'm not mistaken, his eyes look a little wet.

He doesn't answer with words, instead he turns the face of his virtual tablet toward us. It's a quest prompt. We're all quiet as we try to figure out what's going on. "I knew it." Frobod says, in a voice raw with emotion. "As soon as they woke us up at the ass crack of dawn I knew it. Then when I saw the rare-spawn icon on the minimap..."

Pahrem says, "I don't get it."

Frobod, trying to fake reservation in his voice, but instead sounding hoarse, says, "Use the dolly. Open the quest."

I pull up the dolly in my VT, and tap to activate.

Quest

Winter Dungeonland - Part 1

Difficulty: Hard

You have found a child's toy with the mark of the reclusive San'ta Elves of the North Pole. Somewhere in the North, someone is looking for this childhood treasure. Find its owner, and discover how this dolly came to be in Hades.

Objectives:

Returned dolly	0/1
Discover origins of dolly	0/1

Chain Completion Rewards (Choose One):

- A unique evolving weapon (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving chest piece (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving helm (Legendary Potential)
- A unique evolving spell (Legendary Potential)
- Logout re-enabled

Additional Rewards (Limited Edition) (Choose One):

- Unlock Rebirthing as Ke'bla Elf
- Unlock Rebirthing as San'ta Elf
- Unlock Rebirthing as Kel'rog Elf

Restrictions:

Can only be completed in December.

Max party size: 5

This quest can be shared if you have five or less people in your party.

Do you accept? Yes / No

I choose yes.

So there it is. One dead boss, and now there's a way out of Freehaven. I wonder if anyone else has found one. I feel conflicted in a way that's hard to describe. The rational part of me knows I have to go back to the real world, but what's a cubical and a one woman apartment with a giant bean bag chair compared to living months, by the time the quest is complete, in a land full of magic, adventure and dragons? Of course I'll go home, but a quiet part of me wishes I didn't have to, or that there was no choice to be made.

I look to Frobod. There's no question as to the choice he'll make, and I'm happy. He deserves to see his daughter, and who knows, after this kind of emergency, maybe he and his ex wife will find a way to get back together. I'll miss him when he goes, but then, as hard as it is to believe, I'll be going too. Back to Seattle, while Frobod will wake up somewhere in Las Vegas. Dare I return to visit Mirae if it means the possibility of being locked in once again? Part of me wants to. I think I will, because I like the thrill of living on the edge. Not of life and death, but at the edge where the mundane world meets twin universes, three if you count Hades, that are fantastic and never were.

Frobod says, "I don't care about the armor as long as we do this quest."

* * * * *

The rest of the train ride is uneventful. I'm back in my Melpomine skin, and Leroy's beaming at his new armor.

He says, "I need to find the rest of this set. Restoring two health every time you attack is so OP."

I say, "20% of your health, right?"

He shakes his head no, "Maybe for other people but I've invested in special abilities that give me extra health levels. These days it's closer to fifteen."

I say, "Good luck finding the drops. Deadscream isn't exactly a common monster."

Leroy says, "I'm gonna find the rest of the set, and I'm going to be uber."

Pahrem says, "Like you ain't uber enough already."

Leroy shrugs, "There's no such thing as too uber."

Tako, "Like, this one time I went to the market and this guy offered me an uber Christmas sweater for a few copper, and I was like 'Hey man. That's too uber. You trying to kill me with that thing? Next time order a supply that's a little less...'"

I cut him off and say, "You're such a dork." I then look to Frobod and say "How are you doing?"

"Perfect." He says. "In fact, I couldn't be fucking better short of turning in this quest."

Pahrem says, "Winter Dungeonland. Sounds like a Santa quest."

"Hey." Tako says, "Not cool. In Freehaven Online, we have Great Uncle Winter. Not everyone in the world celebrates Christmas."

I roll my eyes at him. *Whatever.*

With a mighty hiss, the Shroudmoon express pulls into Athelon Necropolis station. It's remarkably familiar. Of course there's no train station in the land of the living, but the rest of the skyline looks much the same as it does in Haven.

**You have completed the quest Shroudmoon Express - Cabin Security!
Speak to Conductor Watts to collect your reward.**

The conductor enters as soon as the notification hits. He extends his hand, I shake, and he presses a sack of coins into my palm. "It's been a pleasure working with you on the Shroudmoon Express. Things got a little messy with Deadscream, but your performance was exemplary."

**You have gained:
+500 Reputation with Ashe March Adventurers' Hall
200 Hades Gold Marks
500 Gold**

Point break! You have gained ten points to distribute among attributes.

He makes the rounds, shaking each one of our hands in turn. I say, "You're welcome." Then looks to the others, "I got a ding." I close the popup, so I can save the points for later.

Frobod says, "Me too."

I say, "Anyone need time to buy attributes, or are we ready to go?"

Tako says, "Let's get out of here. We're almost there."

Part of me wants to tour Athelon Necropolis to see how similar it is to the human starting city in Haven, but I get Tako's haste. It's a good thing we have to wait until December to do Winter Dungeonland, or I'd half expect Frobod to be talking about dying, abandoning the Mirae quest, and going back to Durolan. I wave my middle finger in the air and shout "INFERNO!!!" followed by pumping my fist in the air and saying "Let's ride."

The elechoppers burst into existence with their customary engine gurgles and pops of color.

Leroy says, "Mount up." His phoenix screeches and the air grows hot when it's summoned.

Now we're flying over the city. So far as I can tell the main difference between Athelon and Athelon Necropolis is the presence of fluxed ghosts. There are still any number of human, dwarf, elf and gnome ghost citizens, but about one in five has undergone significant body modification. I'll bet the shops have different merchandise. A sign outside the Wayfarer's hall reads, "Closed for Renovations" which means for the time being there're no portals to Durolan Necropolis.

In any case, it's nice to not need a map to know where we're going. The geography passing below us is familiar. The whole time we're traveling I'm thinking about Mirae, what I'll say to her when we meet, and hoping she can shed some light on how she ended up in Hades in the first place. About an hour later, Durolan Necropolis looms on the horizon.

"There it is." I say. It doesn't feel real.

The tall mage towers make it feel like we're coming back home and yet... There's no Cupcake Keep in Durolan, or if there is, it's owned by a completely different person. It feels like we're coming back home and yet... we're just here to collect a member of our newfound adopted family.

I check the clock on my VT and say "Looks like we've got a few hours until she's at the tavern. What do you want to do until then?"

Tako says, "You could do the rat thing that helps you find people."

I noncommittally say, "Yeah..." feeling like I'm missing something. "Any idea on how we're gonna get back? I don't think we have enough money to pay Charon's passage, and waiting for the next Shroudmoon Express could take forever."

Leroy says, "I've got an idea for that, that involves Lorak."

Frobod asks, "What are you thinking?"

Leroy says, "Library quest."

I ask, "Can Lorak transport in-game items for you?"

Leroy shakes his head no. "Just messages. Something the conductor said gave me an idea."

Frobod asks, "What is it?"

Leroy says, "I'll tell you if it works."

Passing over the Durolan Necropolis wall, the guards are equipped with the same crustal tipped spears, and wizard's hats as in its Haven counterpart, but the uniforms are styled differently. While Haven Durolan guards sport the bold purple of a priest's robes during advent, Durolan Necropolis guards are draped in black and deep brandy wine red. They feel antiquated by comparison.

When we land in front of the bank Leroy says, "I'm heading to the book shop, if anyone wants to come. Otherwise, I say we meet at Fire and Soul at seven."

I shrug and say, "I'll come, why not?"

Sajina says, "I'm gonna check out the tavern early." He looks at Annette, Jason and James and says, "You wanna come?"

Jason shrugs. "Sure I guess. We're kinda hungry."

I pass over some more food rations, and say "Remember to stay away from Hades food." Then looking to the others, "We've gotta get back soon or we'll run out of rations."

Pahrem says, "I wanna go shoppin'."

Tako shrugs, and say "If you won't use your rat magic, I'll go with Pahrem."

I say, "Frobod?"

He says, "I'll be around."

I look to Leroy and say, "Looks like it's you and me." Then, to everyone else I reiterate, "Meeting at Fire and Soul. Seven o'clock. Don't be late."

Our group disperses as Leroy and I walk toward the market district, the guards regard me with polite interest, but none of the fawning I'd come to expect from my high reputation in Haven Durolan.

I say, "What are we doing?"

Leroy says, "First let's check the book shop."

We arrive at the building. It's cold and empty. A sign on the door states, "For purchase inquiries visit the property office." With dust on the window sill it feels like it's been standing this way a very long time.

I ask, "Did we strike out?"

Leroy says, "Not yet. Finding something for sale in Hades was a long shot anyway. Charon strikes me as quite a collector. I'm gonna get one of my guild mates to help. How many books do you think we need?"

I say, "You, Me, Pahrem, Tako, Frobod, Sajina, Mirae, Annette, Jason, James... If you're thinking to bring one for each person we're transporting you'll need at least ten assuming Charon doesn't have any already. It's a new quest, so I'm betting that his collection will be limited to the classics until players start completing it."

Leroy says, "Good call. I hadn't thought of the NPCs. I'll see if I can get ten plus a few extra."

He pulls a quill from his inventory, sits on the abandoned storefront steps and begins writing. It takes him a few minutes, because he's detailing very specific instructions. When he reaches the bottom of the parchment, he stops, re-reads what he wrote, and says "I think that'll do it."

I raise a questioning eyebrow.

He says, "You'll see..." then pauses, "... at least I hope you will, because if this doesn't work, I'm out of ideas."

Leroy retrieves the glass orb filled with swirls of red smoke from his inventory, and rubs it like he's summoning a genie, "Come forth my messenger."

PA-WOOF.

The scent of brimstone fills the air, as a closet of fire erupts in the space before us. Lorak steps from the conflagration with his horned head, two pronged tail, and skin the color of Santa's dirty jumpsuit.

He says, "I serve the Malefactors."

Leroy says, "Bring this to SilentBurn, and tell him to stop what he's doing and take care of this now. It's urgent. If Burn isn't available, give it to LowGhost. If ghosts isn't available, take it to the guild hall, and say whoever takes care of this now gets a promotion. I'll reimburse the costs."

Lorak takes the envelope in exchange for a drawstring sack of coins, bows, and says "As you command." He disappears, in another poof of flame.

"Now what do we do?"

Leroy says, "Wait."

"Wait for what?"

Leroy says, "If I'm right, a pile of books will appear in a few minutes."

"O..kay..." I pause, "How are you going to make that happen?"

He says, "My guild mate's going to make a purchase at the cash shop."

"... and?"

Leroy says, "The next thing he'll do is change the settings to free ownership so he can abandon the object in public."

I say, "He's buying books I take it. How does that help us get them here?"

Leroy says, "Burn and Ghost are enchanters." He must see the confusion I feel in my face, because he says, "Come on Mel, think. Remember what Watts told us about relics."

"They're created when an object of personal significance is destroyed, or..." I trail, "The same is true for a newly enchanted item."

"Ding. Ding. Ding." Leroy says, "I'm having them put basic enchantments on a bunch of books, and then burning them in front of this shop in Haven Durolan."

My skin crawls. Burning perfectly good books feels sacrilegious. "You couldn't have picked a different place? You've asked them to burn books in front of a bookstore."

Leroy shrugs, and looks back at the empty store front. "Guess I didn't think about that part. I just figured since we were coming here anyway..."

I say, "I guess I can't complain if it works. I just have a great love for fiction. Doing it here feels disrespectful."

Leroy says, "Sorry but really... It's not like it's the real world. I'll bet the shopkeepers don't even notice."

I say, "You'd be surprised what Havenfolk are picking up on these days." We hang around for about 30 minutes, when I say "Do you think they're coming?" referring to the books.

Leroy says, "Give them a few minutes. Odds are they weren't in Durolan."

At the forty-five to fifty minute mark, a green flame erupts on the cobblestones before us. Leroy roars, "YEAAAAAAH!!!" and punches his left palm with his fist. "I love it when I figure out a new solution to a game problem! I don't think anyone's done this!"

I say, "It might have happened already in Freeworld, but I dunno. I haven't spent much time as a ghost, and I'm not sure if relics worked like this before the merge."

Leroy says, "Don't be a buzz kill... Look! I can see them coming!"

Within the serpentine flames, the shapes of paperback books begin to take form. Leroy punches his palm again in exaltation and says, "Lets see what we got." as the fire quickly dies in sputtering crackles and pops. In it's place is a pyramid of fourteen different novels.

"Stephen King... The Stand, 11.22.63... Salem's Lot... looks like we got a few of his. Several new releases by authors I've never heard of. Grey and The Beautiful Dead by someone named Jun Prince. Looks like they came out of the bargain bin. " He checks the back of the Beautiful Dead, "Something about weres, ghosts, and early 21st century K-Pop Stars." He then goes through the others. "Mercedes Lackey... Tolkien... Looks like we've got a good selection."

I say, "Damn, I guess that's one less thing we have to worry about."

Leroy says, "Everyone can take one book so you can all complete the quest."

I help myself to one of the Prince books and say, "They came from the cash shop using real money. I can pay you back if we ever get out." I'm still thinking of this place like it's our new home. *What do I mean, "if?"*

Leroy says, "You're money's no good with me, or need I remind you that it's because of the quest you brought me along for, that we now have a way to get that logout button."

My cheeks grow hot, "Yeah. That's pretty valuable. It hasn't quite sunk in yet. We've been here so long that Freehaven's starting to feel more real than Meatsville."

* * * * *

It's now 6:45, and we're sitting inside the Necropolis version of Fire and Soul, it's a lot like the Haven tavern, save for our half skeletal waitress with a normal body on top down to her sternum, and a fleshless skeleton below down to her hips which are then fleshy again. Thankfully she's wearing a dress, which conceals everything save for the cut out where her stomach should be. Instead of a belly button, we're treated to glimpses of spine when she passes.

The décor is also a bit different, though nothing ghastly as you'd expect in the underworld. Where the Fire and Soul of Haven contrasts blue tiles and draperies, with a warm yellow fire, Necro-Durolan showcases tones of warm, red velvet like the cupcakes of the same name. The effect is that this place feels more cozy, aside from some of the creepier inhabitants like our waitress, and the other is cool and intellectual, much like the mage city itself.

Sajina's enjoying himself by playing his lyre near the hearth to the delight of our NPC travel companions, and ghostly customers. No classic rock, or turn of the century pop tonight, he's weaving notes into proper folk melodies, which has people swaying and bobbing their heads in appreciation. He even has his tame shadowstalker with him, red eyes burning, juggling to the beat of the music.

Tako says, "Where's Mirae?"

A round of applause sounds as the gargoyle breaks his tune. He says, "Thank you. Thank you." Before launching into another song. This one a bit more energetic than the smooth notes of the piece before, and I see Hadesfolk feet tapping.

Looking back to Tako I say, "She'll be here. I have little doubt she's coming."

Tako says, "But what if she doesn't? It's been days since we scryed and saw the message. What if something happened?"

Pahrem says, "Chill out, ya gotta relax. If seven thirty comes around and she still hasn't showed I'll scry again and see what she's up to."

I say, "She's right." Then look to Pahrem, "How was shopping?"

She says, "I bought a few things, but most of the good stuff costs Hades Marks, ain't no one in this group's got coin for that, but guess what..."

"What?" I say.

She says, "They've got an auction house here that's connected to Haven cities."

I say, "So we can trade with Haven?"

Pahrem says, "Looks like it."

Leroy says, "I'll include it in my guide when I come back. That could be a good way for people who are staying here to make money. Everyone'll want the new Hades stuff."

Tako looks like he's about to say something when a thin framed Sea Elf woman with slightly green hair drifts through the door way. My heart jumps. Tako's chair screeches against the floor tiles as he stands abruptly. Some of the patrons glance toward the discordant sound.

Now Tako's frozen, caught between the desire to run up embrace her, and swing her around, and having completely forgotten what he wanted to say. Mirae looks up, and smiles when she sees our table. It's a look that makes my heart go to jelly. It's like watching a ghost as she glides toward us.

"Hi!" She says, and gives me a short hug. She then pauses, eyes Tako and initiates a much longer embrace. He brushes a strand of hair behind her ear, and presses a long, sensual kiss to the top of her head, no doubt savoring her perfumed springtime scent. I don't want to stare because this is their moment, but at the same time seeing her alive, back from the dead, my new virtual little sister... It's a sight to behold.

Some thirty seconds into the embrace, Leroy clears his throat, "I guess this is who we're supposed to rescue?"

Tako and Mirae unravel from their embrace.

Pahrem says, "Hey, You're lookin' good, kid. It's good to see ya."

I say, "This is Mirae. Mirae, this is..."

She says, "Is that Leroy Jensen? Holy crap! Dude. I can't believe I'm meeting you. I mean, I knew you were coming since you sent that message, but dude! It's Leroy LEEEEERRROOOOOOOOY JEENNSSEN." Tako looks a bit perturbed. Mirae looks to me and says, "How'd you get this guy to come?"

Leroy winces, as if that wasn't his signature call. It's kinda weird, traveling with him this long, away from other players, because now when I see him he's just a regular guy, albeit a ridiculously overpowered took down Deadscream with half the party dead regular guy. I'm not sure if I can see him anymore through the lenses of celebrity tinted glasses.

I say, "He was actually an old gu-"

For the first time Frobod speaks up, honing in on an until now unexplored chord of empathy. "It was all you're boyfriend's idea. Mel wanted to make this a guild only event, but when Jensen showed up, your man put his foot down and said 'Only the best for Mirae.'"

I say, "Errr. uhh.. yeah that's exactly how it happened."

Mirae hugs Tako's arm to her chest, and rests her head on his shoulder. "You're the best guy ever, but..."

Tako, sounding caught off guard for the first time since I've met him, says, "What?"

Mirae says, "I don't think he's my boyfriend. We never made it official."

Tako says, "Did you meet someone else? Who is there to even meet in Hades? What have you been doing?"

Mirae says, "Well, Sten's here if you remember him. Half-goblin kid from Dragonswood. He's been keeping me company."

Tako says, "Sten?" a tone of shock in his voice. "The kid with all the ruffles?"

Mirae laughs, "That's the one!"

I can imagine what's going through Tako's head. This long apart, it'd be horrible if she met someone, but Sten? The kid's like 12 years old.

Tako says, "You two are uhh.." He touches the tips of his index fingers together.

Mirae says, "What? No. He's like two years old. I'm just saying he's been keeping me company. It was nice to see a familiar face when I got here."

Tako sighs with relief. "Alright then."

Frobod looks to Mirae and says, "I don't know what you all had going in the real world, but if you like him, this is your boyfriend. Never seen a guy so determined to make sure you were safe."

Mirae, speaking in a tone of "Awwwee," says, "Really?" and pecks his cheek.

I say, "It's been a hell of a journey... No pun intended."

Mirae asks, "What do you mean?"

I say, "We got a whole quest to rescue you." Remembering the quest item in my inventory, I withdraw the Essence of the Lost Champion and gently set it on the table. "You have to drink that for starters, then we escort you back to Haven."

Tako says, "We thought you were dead. We had a funeral and everything. It's been weeks."

Now Mirae looks confused, "Weeks?"

I say, "You haven't checked your game clock?"

Mirae says, "I have, but I thought it was just a bug. I've just been hanging around here a few days."

Tako, Frobod, and I exchange looks that say "Who wants to tell her?"

I decide to do it, and say "You went offline after you went in the digitization station. You didn't come back until the Hades expansion was announced in conjunction with the start of the Lost Champion quest. That was weeks after you died... or... at least we thought you had. What happened for you?"

Mirae says, "I went into the digitization chamber, and I was given all the warnings about how proceeding would mean the death of my real world body, at the gain of virtual immortality. I already knew that so I clicked through."

Tako asks, "Did it hurt?"

Mirae shakes her head no. "I felt light headed at first, and there was a tight feeling in my chest then nothing, a bit like a runner's high followed by re-engaging my senses in this new world. It was like waking up even though I was already awake."

Frobod frowns at this point, still opposed to any form of suicide regardless of whether or not consciousness survives.

Leroy says, "Go on. I want to hear this."

Mirae says, "Right... Well, the next window that popped up gave me the chance to play a new subrace."

Tako asks, "What are you?"

I inspect her.

Mirae	
Type:	Player
Race:	Wraith - Elf (Sea)
Appearance:	6
Challenge:	Above Average

I say "Looks like she's a wraith."

Tako says, "You wanted to become a ghost?"

Mirae shakes her head no. "I was supposed to become a mummy. Guess I didn't read the fine print. I was offered a chance to play a mummy, not a guarantee that I'd become one. I thought the chance was like... hey limited time offer, get this deal while it lasts."

Pahrem says, "Ain't that what Deadscream was? You want to be an undead monster?"

Leroy says, "The quest said Deadscream tried to become a mummy, but the ritual didn't have enough power."

"Oh." Pahrem says, "Is that what's gonna to happen to her?"

I say, "Let's hope not."

Mirae says, "Mummies are the opposite of undead, they're undying. They literally can't die, and when you become one you gain access to a whole new kind of magic."

Leroy perks up, "Can't die? What happens when you lose all your health, are you invincible or something?"

Mirae says, "I don't know, haven't played one yet. The passive ability description says that you regenerate one health per.... I forget how long, and when you drop to zero health you drop all threat and go unconscious until regeneration kicks in. It also says you have free access to Hades, though I don't get why that's a thing since you're all here."

I say, "Getting here isn't as easy as you think. You have to get past a boss just to go through the gate."

Leroy says, "That probably means Cerberus won't attack her."

Mirae says, "You saw Cerberus? Isn't he adorable?"

Frobod says, "I remember him being pretty scary."

Mirae says, "Well yeah, he looks scary, but he acts like a big puppy."

I ask, "That's probably because you're dead. Did you meet Charon?"

Mirae says, "Yeah, he's the one that brought me to Durolan Necropolis. He greets all the new souls."

Leroy says, "I think he's the one that's going to take us back to Haven, or at least the gate of Hades."

Frobod asks, "Do we have enough marks?"

Leroy says, "I almost forgot." and pulls the pile of relic books from his inventory. "Everyone take a novel for the library quest. I'm hoping these will all be new to him."

I say, "Leroy was pretty clever about bringing these over."

Leroy says, "In any case, if you want to become a Mummy you'd better drink that jar of magic sitting on the table pronto. If you don't this whole quest will have been for nothing."

Tako says, "You do still want to do it, right? There's a risk and... This isn't a game anymore. Not for you... This is your life now. You could end up like Deadscream."

Pahrem says, "It ain't pretty."

Tako says, "If you don't want to risk it, I'll just eat some of the food here and stay with you. We can be wraiths."

Mirae says, "Oh shut up." She takes the jar in her hands, unscrews the cap and chugs it in a series of long loud gulps without putting it down for air. *She's a ghost now. Maybe she doesn't need any.* She finishes it off with an Essence of the Lost Champion moustache and wipes the residue from her lips to her arm.

Quest Update: The Lost Champion - Part 2

You have fed a lost soul in Hades the Essence of the Lost Champion. Bring it to the Lodge of Arcanum in Durolan, before it's too late.

WARNING: The Ritual of the Undying must be completed within 24 hours of leaving Hades. Failure to conduct the ritual within the allotted time will result in catastrophic failure.

Frobod says, "Did you guys get the quest update?"

Mirae now glows in a halo of white ghost light that sets her apart from the other spirits. It's probably due to the essence she just consumed. It produces an aura of sanctity about her that makes me feel that she must not be harmed.

"Yeah." I say.

Pahrem says, "Got it."

Mirae says, "I just got a new quest. You're right, it's all about becoming a mummy."

I ask, "What happened after you picked the subrace?"

Mirae says, "There was a whole lot of stuff about being inaccessible for a time, and that I'd be taken to a new city, then I was standing next to Cerberus on a grassy hill with a dirt path leading to Charon."

I ask, "How long ago was that?"

Mirae says, "I don't know like.. five or six days ago? I got your message on my third day."

Tako says, "We should hurry."

Frobod looks to Mirae and says, "See what I mean? Determined."

Mirae blushes, "I guess this means I have a boyfriend now?"

Tako says, "I... yeah." as a boyish smile creeps across his face.

Leroy says, "You can relax a bit. The quest says the timer doesn't start until we leave Hades."

Tako says, "I know. I'm fresh out of jerky, and I just want some food."

Mirae asks, "Jerky?"

I say, "Pehrom's come a long way."

Mirae snuggles against Tako, rubbing her face into his arm like a cat. She says, "You think you could change it so Tako and I share a room?"
I smile and say, "I'll have to check the settings."



Chapter 21 - Clutching Your Balzac, Gripping Your Longfellow

After performing my daily devotions to Sune, watching Mirae say her goodbyes to Sten was touching. The way she hugged him made me feel that they'd developed a genuine connection in the short time they were here together. Mirae promised to let his family know that he's okay.

Now we're approaching a dock an hour outside of town where Charon is propped against a piling reading his book. I check the cover, *Great Expectations*. He smiles warmly and says, "Well hello." He's still wearing that dark sweater.

"Charon." I nod. "Keeping yourself entertained I see. How many times have you read that one?"

He gives us a resigned look, as if to say that his love of stories is both a blessing and a curse, "Four hundred and eighty-four, soon to be five in a few chapters. I do love Pip."

I say, "I don't know whether to feel sad or impressed. It must take a lot of time to read a book so many times."

Charon says, "Time is something I have in abundance. How can I help you?"

Tako says, "We need passage back to the gate."

I say, "The closest one to Durolan, if you can."

Charon says, "That'll be costly. How many individuals will be coming?" He counts. "Ten, if I'm not mistaken. Do you have 10,000 Hades Gold Marks?"

"No..." I say, "But I think we have something better."

"Oh?" Charon says. "I don't accept standard gold, and there's only one other thing I can think of that would interest me."

I ask, "Are you still looking for new books? Seem to remember you saying something about them being worth more than their weight in gold."

Charon's face grows somber, "I am, but alas not many cross the rainbow bridge clutching their Balzac, or gripping their Longfellow. New literature is so hard to find. A single book is worth more than its weight in gold. Many times that."

Tako snorts. "That's probably how I'll go out." Mirae swats his arm.

He apologizes, "Sorry."

I say, "They're authors."

Tako has shifty eyes as he says, "I knew that. I was just thinking it'd be profitable."

Charon says, "Do you have a Balzac for me to examine?"

I shake my head no, "I'm fresh out of Balzac. In fact I never had one."

Charon asks, "Perhaps you're hiding a Dickens somewhere?"

I shake my head, "No Dickens."

"I do have a Prince." I present him with my copy of The Beautiful Dead. "In fact, between us, we have a couple of Princes, Kings, Lackeys, Tolkiens, and some guys that are new even in our world."

Charon's eyes light up, as he says. "Hand it over. Let me see."

"Err.. Okay." I say, and pass him the novel. It's way more excitement than I could have imagined from the deity.

He licks his fingers and begins paging through... One page... two pages.. Ten... He then skips to the middle of the book, murmuring "Yes... yes.... yes!"

Mirae looks uneasy as she asks, "Is he okay?"

He raises a finger to her, that commands silence. Skipping ahead to the last chapter, he clutches the book to his breast, looks back, and gazes at the sky. No one speaks, we're just watching. The sound of water gently lapping against the shore eclipses the sounds of our breath.

"Charon?" Leroy says.

It takes him a moment to respond, as if stuck in a trance. When he does speak, the ferryman's voice is filled with reverence. "You mean to say you have ten such tomes?"

Leroy says, "Fourteen actually, but whose counting?"

Charon sits on the dock, as if to prevent himself from fainting, and says, "Place them here so I can see them."

Each of us complies, followed by Leroy with an extra four novels. Charon lifts, and inspects each one. "Yes... Yes..." He's making two piles. Those he hasn't inspected, and the ones he approves of. With each yes, comes another addition to the accepted pile. Charon, speaking to no one in particular, says, "Truly remarkable."

I say, "So we have a deal?"

He lifts his finger, and says "No." A new pile is born as Charon deposits a copy of Lord of the Rings away from the others. "I've read that one five hundred three times. Don't believe me? I can recite the entirety of Tom Bombadil's chapters."

Frodo says, "We believe you."

It's only then that I realize that Charon was simply rejecting the book rather than turning down the offer of transport.

Leroy says, "I guess I'll take that one back, but I brought extras."

When Charon reaches the end of the pile he reiterates, "Truly remarkable. The cost of passage is ten novels, but for the final three..." He eyes Leroy says, "What would you say to 10,000 Hades Gold Marks."

Leroy says, "Well.."

Charon adds, "Each of course."

Leroy says, "I hadn't consid-"

Charon says, "Not enough? 20,000 a piece then. That's 60,000 Hades Marks. You won't find a better offer."

Leroy says, "Okay."

Charon says, beaming with a genuine eye touching smile on his face, "It's done then."

A huge sack of coins materializes in his hand which he passes to Leroy.

You have completed the quest Charon's Library!

You have received:

+ 1000 Personal Reputation with Charon, Ferryman of Hades

(+200 reputation for each novel after the first)

Free passage along the rivers of Hades

50 Hades Gold Marks

300 Gold

Charon says, "Thanks be to all of you. Should you ever return to Hades, I will ferry you along it's rivers, free of charge. You've given me a gift fit for a king this day."

I say, "Wait... The free passage is permanent? You'll take us for free every time?"

Charon, "... but of course. You didn't think I'd take such treasures from you at the price of a single trip, did you?"

Tako says, "Holy crap. The whole time we've been here we've only earned like a thousand marks, and then free passage after that. "He looks to Leroy, "Man... You might not want to make the rewards of this quest public."

Leroy smirks, "Undying Plate here I come."

I say, "I wonder if the difficulty of the quest will increase as Charon's library expands."

Frobod says, "Who knows, doesn't matter now."

Pahrem says, "Speakin' as someone who was tryin' to do some shoppin' I'd say it's very relevant. 20,000 Hades Gold Marks can buy a lot of gear."

Charon says, "Shall we be off then?"

I say, "Lets."

The oversized gondola rocks as we board, it seems to have expanded to suit the needs of our party which Mirae is now a part of. He pushes off the dock which transforms into a river of fire as we drift closer to the center. I feel like I'm being roasted alive, though I take no damage. I begin to wonder how long it'll take us to get to the gate, when the boat begins gliding across the surface of the river at improbable speeds. Our surroundings blur past us in streaks of color that our eyes can't begin to track. *That's what happens when you have a God as your rower.* The crimsons and golds of the burning River Phlegethon, fade into the dreamy forgetful mists of the River Lethe as they seem to have merged.

We're still moving too fast for my eyes to follow. I don't know where I am. There's an elf with a strange white light surrounding her sitting across from me, but I can't place who she is. I feel like I should know, because... because... I look to a man sitting beside me, holding a great war hammer on the floor between his legs. I ask, "Do you know who I am?"

"Huh?" He says, and narrows his eyes intently, trying to grasp hold of a slippery thought that he can't handle. "I.. don't think so. I want do say you're familiar but I don't know. Do you know who I am?"

I shake my head no. I don't understand why I'm on a boat with all these strange people. I look back to the Ferryman. "Where are we going?"

A half-elf sitting next to the hallowed Sea-Elf says, "Yeah where are you taking us?"

A goblin woman says, "Are we okay?"

The Ferryman speaks, in a calming, controlled voice. "Hush... It won't be much longer. You've paid for safe passage."

I'm trying to figure out what that means, when memories start to take hold. Faces are becoming more familiar. Le.. something. Lenard? Leland.... Leroy, is sitting next to me! *Ugh... Frickin' Lethe.*

The gondola thuds against the little wooden dock from which we started our journey deeper into Hades, and Charon says, "We've arrived. I've brought you to the same gate as I trust the journey on the other side will be more familiar. It's about as far from your destination as the next closest gate on the River Styx."

I say, "Thank you Charon. We'll meet again."

The god says, "I look forward to it, and remember. I'm always looking for new books."



Chapter 22 - Undying

Cerberus wags his spaded tail as we pass through the gate, and head butts me so hard that it nearly sends me to my rump. It's not an attack. He's just happy to see me. Mirae pats the right head's nose.

I release a deep breath, and say "I was worried that he'd attack when we crossed through the gate."

Frobod says, "I guess he's only worried about the living going into Hades and the dead coming out."

Tako says, "What about Mirae?"

I say, "It must be because of that Halo."

Mirae confirms, "I've got a buff called 'Essence of the Undying.' No boost in stats, it just says that I'm one of the undying... almost, and that I need to complete the ritual within 24 hours."

I pat Cerberus's nose goodbye and say, "Sorry dog, can't stay. We've got places to be." The massive creature runs a small circle around himself, picks up the short bow I left at the end of our last encounter, and drops it at my feet.

I sigh. "Alright." I say. "One time." I pick up the poor quality wooden object, and hurl it back toward the gate. The three headed dog goes bounding after. Everyone but Mirae stares at me with expression akin to "What the fuck are you doing?"

The monstrous animal retrieves the gnarled bow, and drops it in front of me. I pick it up again, throw it, and when he goes bounding after I lower my voice and say "Let's go."

The animal whines as we depart.

Frobod says, "There's still a ton of Undead. How do you want to play this?"

I pull out my VT and fast equip all of MarineLu's caster gear. Bite vanishes, and I'm now sporting a pair of silver war fans.

Tako says, "What are you doing?"

I say, "I thought of this before we left. I'm going to Thunder Bridge us back to Durolan, but even in caster gear I don't have enough manna to take everyone. We don't know how long it'll take them to do the ritual to transform Mirae, and I'm not keen on taking chances."

Tako says, "I agree." in a decisive voice, and then less certainly follows "But if you have enough for more than two people, can I come?"

I nod and say, "Mirae and Tako, you come with me. I can take one more but I don't want to cut the party down too much if you've got to battle your way out of this cave."

Frobod says, "We can always just die and respwan."

I say, "Maybe you guys can, but I don't want to risk her respawning. Not to mention, I don't think that'll work for them either. " I indicate Annette, Jason, and James.

Pahrem asks, "So what's the plan?"

Leroy steps up, "I'm tank. You're heals. Sajina and Leroy are DPS. We can four-man our way out of here. No problem." He looks to me and says, "Once we're out, we'll make our way to the nearest city, find a Wayfarer's Hall, and take a portal. I'll cover the costs if you don't have the money. That little quest with Charon made me rich."

"Hades rich." Pahrem says.

Leroy says, "I've got money. Sound good to everyone?"

I say, "Yeah, meet at Cupcake Keep, and I'm sure Pehrom will cook up a feast. Send Lorak when you're in town."

Leroy says, "You're on my friends list. I'll just send a private message."

"Oh yeah..." I say, "We're in Haven now. I forgot we can send messages. Hit me up when you get back to town, and I'll see about getting some grub."

Now that we have access to sending messages to players in Haven I pull out my VT and fire off a quick hello to Pehrom.

Melpomine: We're back. Outside the Gate of Hades now, but I'm gonna ride the lightning home with Mirae and Tako. The rest will be coming the old fashioned way.

Pehrom: Good shit! She okay?

Melpomine: She is for now, but we've got to finish the quest ASAP or risk "catastrophic failure." Don't know how long it'll take, but I doubt more than a few hours.

Melpomine: I heard about your wife. Can't wait to meet her.

Pehrom: Well, she's here now so whatever.

Pehrom: About Mirae, Fuck yeah man. I'm glad it worked out.

Melpomine: Do you think you could prepare food for our group? We're all hungry and have been living on jerky and tasteless rations for a while.

Pehrom: No problem. We got 20 guys over here from Justice anyway. Few extra plates are no problem. How many you got?

Melpomine: Justice?

Melpomine: Ten would be good if you can manage. We picked up a few extras in Hades who are literally starving.

Pehrom: A bunch of dick bags attacked the keep when they learned you were gone.

Pehrom: We oughta formalize an alliance. They're good dudes to have on your side.

Pehrom: Did some recruiting and Justice helped out.

Melpomine: We'll talk when I get back.

Pehrom: Yeah well, don't mind the Gargoyles. Had to spend points for some emergency upgrades while you were gone. Ya won't recognize the place.
Melpomine: See you soon.

I stow my VT, and look to the group. "What do you guys know about Justice?"

"The guild?" Leroy asks.

I say, "Pehrom wants a formal alliance with them."

Leroy asks, "What happened?"

I say, "Who said anything happened?" pause, and continue "Cupcake Keep was attacked while we were gone because they knew the guild master was in Hades."

Leroy says, "That sounds like them, since the Muffins are small now. Justice is kind of a white knights guild. They go around protecting players from asshole PvPers that like ruining people's day." He jerks his head to Sajina, "Like if one of their members saw some guy pop out of nowhere and gank our bard before I taught him how to handle himself, they'd be all over the attacker sending him for respawn until he learned his lesson. They're kind of anti-bullies, or PvP bullies of bullies."

"They sound like interesting people." I look to the Toxic Muffins in our group, "I guess that explains why we got so many new members." then regard Sajina, "I know you were a soc before this adventure, but if you ever decide to leave the safety of major cities again, there will be a place for you with the Toxic Muffins. So far as socs go you're not so bad."

The gargoyle scratches the back of his stone head. "I'll think on it."

I say, "How often do you use this alias?"

Sajina says, "Just Halloween, when I'm questing or might see battle, which is to say... pretty much never."

I say, "So your not in a guild then?"

Sajina says, "My elf alias is."

I say, "I'll send you an invite." as I pull out my VT, "Our character stats were pooled, but each alias can join a different guild."

Sajina says, "Really?"

I nod. "Found that out the first day of the merge."

Sajina has joined the guild.

I say, "Welcome. We'll get you a recall stone when we have dinner." The gargoyle looks bashful albeit flattered, an odd contrast to his rocky face.

"Thanks..." He says. "I've never really been good at adventuring."

Leroy says, "You've got a sick build now. Keep practicing, and you'll destroy on the battlefield."

I say, "Leroy's right. You held your own against Deadscream, and that was no easy boss." I then turn to Tako and Mirae, and say, "Are you guys ready?"

Tako says, "Ready as I'll ever be."

Mirae says, "Let's do it."

I say, "Peace out." and begin whipping my fans around me in a blur of motion. Undead across the stream moan and horde together as air from my Windsoul Skystrikers sweeps through the cavern. I hold the entrance of the Lodge of Arcanum in my mind.

Speaking in the dull trancelike voice that comes while I'm casting, I say, "Hold hands and gather round."

My hair stirs around me, as a purple dome begins to take shape with arcs of electricity scurrying over its surface. The small hairs on my arms and back of my neck begin to rise. It feels like the elemental magic within me is about to detonate when one of my fans disappears into inventory, I latch on to Tako's wrist, and a bolt of lightning strikes the dome at a forty five degree angle. It jerks us over the pit of undead, connected to my remaining war fan, to which I'm holding fast.

Cast Thunder Bridge - Success!

It's a carnival ride from hell as we're towed at superhuman speed through the twists and sharp corners of the cave, until we launch out of it's yawning mouth like a comet. I'm dizzy as I think, *"Frobod wouldn't have liked this."*

It's only when we're under the clear blue sky that the cut screen begins, and we're super manning through the air as I've come to expect. Dizziness fades, and I appreciate the rush of moving so fast, high above the earth.

Tako shouts, "Whoa!" as Mirae screams, "This is awesome!"

It only now occurs to me that this is her first time.

KA-BLAM!

Thunder cracks as the cut screen fades, and we're deposited roughly outside the Lodge of Arcanum. Blue and purple spots dance in my vision. The intensity of the crack seems to grow with each additional traveler.

Mirae says, "That's it. I'm learning martial arts. Either I'm going off to find a monastery, or you're going to learn the instruction skill so you can teach me." She has giggles in her voice. The mood's been so heavy since she left that I'm falling in love with her carefree nature.

The young mage Rael in his blue robes embroidered in arcane symbols, sprints outside followed by a quartet of apprentices wearing flat grey. He says, "What's....?" Then his eyes settle on me. "Lady Lord Melpomine. Lord TakoStar." His eyes dart between us, then to Mirae who still casts an aura of pale ghost light. "Is this...? Is she? Come inside. Hurry. We haven't much time"

Right to business. I like that.

Rael continues, "You, and you." He indicates two of the apprentices. "Fetch Masters Marulan and Aluwyn. You two, inform the council of their return and that the ritual will soon begin."

The apprentices scurry off.

I say, "Before you start, we have something that may help you. We encountered Deadscream the Forsaken while in Hades. He was... almost... a draconic mummy." I withdraw the Book of Death and Rebirth from my inventory and present it to him with both hands.

Rael takes it under his arm, and leads us toward the lodge. He says, "This way." Up until now his voice has been urgent, but now there's a hint of something else... A mad scientist's glee. "This is so exciting. No one in Durolan has attempted this kind of magic in centuries. Just imagine if we can resurrect..." He looks like he's about to fan girl clap, but settles for an excited clinching of his fists due to the large book in his possession.

I say, thinking of Marulan's warnings about turning Mirae into an undead horror, "Don't be too hasty. Have a look at the book I brought you to see if it'll help."

We pass through long marble and stone halls with high columns. A few turns, and we eventually settle into a circular spell chamber, not unlike the one used to cast the portal that brought us to the gate of Hades. Violet geometric designs are set into the tiled floor. The main difference is instead of a crown at the center of the room, there's a smooth stone workbench which Rael sets the Book of Death and Rebirth on, and begins skimming.

Tako says, "Won't it take a while to go through the whole thing?"

"No..." Rael says in a distracted voice. "Yes... I can see this might be useful."

He closes the cover, reaches into the pocket of his robe, and sprinkles black powder over the surface of the book.

Mirae asks, "What is it?"

Rael says, "Expedience." He removes a bowl and a jar full of a clear liquid from under the bench, that smells of camphor. He pours some of the liquid into the bowl, wets his fingers and flicks droplets over the powder on the cover while moving his hands in a wide circular motion. He chants an arcane language which I do not understand.

"Te'rava textu, hala nembu shiol ri.

Te'rava textu, hala nembu shiol ri.

Te'rava textu, hala nembu shiol ri.

Te'rava textu, hala nembu shiol ri."

With each repetition of the phrase his hands make another circle paired with another flick of liquid over the cover. *That can't be good for an ancient text.*

At the conclusion of the spell, he lays his open palm on the surface of the cover, it glows sickly yellow, and returns to normal, save that the outside text has vanished beneath his palm.

Rael casts Tome Absorption. Success.

His breath catches, and his eyes grow frantic and wide. "By the gods."

"What is it?" Tako asks.

Rael says, "You've saved us all."

Tako asks, "Is Mirae going to be okay? What happened?"

Rael says, "She's going to be okay... now." He looks to me and says, "Thank you for bringing this to me."

I say, "I feel like I'm missing something."

Rael says, "The spell I just cast allowed me to absorb the knowledge of this book."

Glancing down at the blank cover, I get the feeling that he means "Absorb" quite literally, and wonder if he used the spell for less than altruistic purposes.

"That's good?" A note of question riding in my voice.

"It is. If I had enacted the ritual in the way I'd planned." He shudders. "It would have failed for sure. We don't need to discuss what would have happened to your friend here... and the city of Durolan."

I say, "I'm glad I brought it." with reservation in my voice. "You know what you have to do now?"

"I do." Rael says, "And it will be marvelous. Whew... That was close."

I say, "I'll take your word for it."

Mirae, oddly the least concerned of us all says, "So when do we start?" She looks to Tako. "I'll be fine."

Rael says, "Shortly. Come with me to the preparation chamber. Lady Lord Melpomine, Lord TakoStar, I have to ask you to wait outside. Either within the Lodge, or elsewhere. We can't risk compromising the ritual."

Tako says, "You mean we can't even watch?"

Rael, "It's too dangerous. Everything must be precise, and our wizards must have full concentration."

I put a comforting hand on Tako's arm. "Relax. They'll get it right."

* * * * *

Waiting outside the Lodge of Arcanum feels like watching Mirae go into the digitization station all over again, not knowing if she'll return. Tako is intense, and rebuffs any efforts I make to comfort him.

I say, "It won't be long."

He says, "Yeah." in a clipped tone.

I let out a deep breath, the chanting pouring out of the lodge is eerie. I can imagine people swaying back and forth like zombies with dull unthinking eyes. Every repetition of the chorus we hear is punctuated by a gong-like crash, and metallic ting. It seems to go on for ever.

Shadows stir, and seem to come to life, and in the corner of my eye, I could have sworn I saw a woman walking, who is no longer there. Am I seeing Hadesfolk? BWONNNG.. CRASSSH TING.

That sound again. Every time it hits my vision flickers as if I'm catching brief glimpses of Durolan Necropolis.

CRASH - DING.

I'm certain this time. For half a second, I see a pair of guards with their lumpy hats, crystal spears, and red and black armor. What are they doing? I wonder what's happening in Hades.

The sound changes. A chorus of male throats sing and hold a long low note. "Ahhhhhhhhh...." a step half way between a Gregorian chant, and the theme song of the Pearly Gates.

I catch myself singing "Ahhhhhh...."

Tako joins in, "Ahhhhhhhhh."

Havenfolk stop on the street and contribute to the chorus. I raise my arms to the heavens, without understanding why, and now Tako's doing it too... and the fruit vendor twenty feet away, and the guy standing beside a mail box.

"Ahhhhhhhhhhhhhh." The note lasts an eternity. It bounces off of buildings, sounding throughout the city in a ghostly song. "Ahhhhhhh."

Mind control?

"Ahhhhhhhhhhhhhh.."

Something appears in the sky above, a flying serpent with tiny wings, a feathered crest, with a spike upon its tail. "Ahhhhhhhhh..." It thrashes above the lodge, huge and powerful, before coiling in mid air and biting its own tail.

The music stops.

Our hands are still raised, though Havenfolk on the street wear confused expressions. The image of the flying snake breaks apart, becoming insubstantial until nothing is left save for a trail of cumulus clouds that might look like an O if you're trying hard to find it.

My arms fall. The streets are silent. There's ringing in my ears. The scenery feels hyper real.

"Mirae?" Tako asks.

It takes me a moment to find my voice. I stand, and say "I don't know. Let's go find out."

Two steps toward the Lodge, and a small figure greets us, bandaged from head to toe. She has clean wraps, unlike Deadscream.

"Mirae..." Tako says.

She's not saying anything. I don't think she can since her mouth is covered. Rael exits too, guiding her by the arm. Tako stiffens. The mage reaches around and begins to unwind her coverings. I hold my breath. Her mouth is revealed, and her skin is healthy. The beginning of a grin tugs at her lips. Now her eyes are visible, and they are exactly the same as before, save for presence of small golden flecks that interrupt the green.

I inspect her.

Mirae	
Type:	Player 
Race:	Elf (Sea) - Undying
Appearance:	6
Challenge:	Above Average

The only difference now is that her nameplate is trimmed in gold, and she lacks the white aura imparted by the Essence of the Lost Champion as a wraith.

I say, "It's still Mirae."

Tako runs toward her, and throws his arms around her small body. I'm amused to see that she pushes him off, kisses her hand, and pats him on the cheek. I approach at a more leisurely pace, and she says, "World first mummy!" She cheers, "I told you there'd be nothing to worry about. I can't die! How cool is that?"

You have completed the quest The Lost Champion - Part 2!

You have received:

+10,000 Reputation in Durolan
Point Break x 2

LeroyJensen: We just got credit for the Lost Champion Quest. Thanks! That concludes our deal.

Melpomine: Thanks for your help. It's a shame we didn't have time to do more training.

LeroyJensen: Don't forget our other agreement, you said you'd take me to Dragonswood for your quest turn in with the mortals.

LeroyJensen: Since you're helping me out with some of these vids, I might be able to work in some time to train you one afternoon next week. That'll give you some time to grind skill ups, and earn more points for spells and special abilities.

Melpomine: Thanks. Alright. Yeah, I haven't forgotten, you can come. How far are you from Durolan?

LeroyJensen: We'll probably be there in an hour.

Melpomine: See you at CK then.

Now that Mirae is transformed, I'm able to view her subracial features, by pulling up her profile on my VT. The mummy traits are granted on top of her sea elf racial bonuses.

The Undying (Mummy)

Subrace - Can be applied to any standard living race.

Bonus Traits:

Undying - You cannot be killed. Damage that takes you to zero health or below leaves you unconscious. Enemies will stop attacking you. You can be healed by other characters, or your health will return naturally at the rate of 1 per hour.

Heku Magic - You may now wield the power of ancient Heku magic.

Death's Insight - Having died, spent time as a wraith, and come back from Hades you retain any ghostly abilities you learned in Hades, and may continue to advance them at double the standard cost. Note: Some powers, such as Soul Shaping, cannot be used on the living. You may freely enter and depart Hades without fear of guardians. This bonus does not apply to party

members, and guardians will become hostile if attacked first, or you have healed a character they are fighting.

Alive - For the purposes of powers that affect and detect the living, you are considered to be twice as alive, and contain double the life energy of standard mortals

Access to new magic and ghost powers is pretty cool, but I'll have to think on the part about undying. By never dropping below zero health, it effectively grants her immunity to resurrection penalties after dying and rising at a bind point, but at the same time there's no more exploiting death for quick transport to your bind point. As a tank, I think it could be useful to be able to drop down to zero health, and then receive a heal that'll put me back in the fight, but that's not what Mirae is. As a healer, she won't be able to heal herself if she's unconscious.

I say, "Congratulations. It's good to have you back."

Mirae beams and says, "Thanks." before snuggling into Tako.

I say, "I'm gonna give you two some time to catch up while I turn in my paladin quest."

Mirae says, "You're not following Helios anymore?"

I say, "Scooti is still a Paladin of Helios, but I'm taking Melpomine a different direction. If all goes well, by dinner Durolan will have a new Thunderlord."

Mirae says, "Sune. Lightning. I can see it."



Chapter 23 - Lady Thunderlord

Scattered wind chimes in manicured trees sing their welcome as I arrive.

Ariel looks up from his incense stand and says, "Lord Melpomine. Back from your journey?"

"I am." I say, "And what a journey it was."

"Oh?" the old man asks, "Did you go someplace interesting?"

"All the way into and through Hades, then back to the living."

Ariel says, "Oh my, that is a journey. Have you returned with a treasure?"

On this point I feel less certain, as I begin depositing random vendor trash items on his table. I say, "They're unique to Hades. You won't find them in Haven."

"I see." Ariel says, a note of disappointment lacing his voice.

"They're not good enough?" I ask.

Ariel says, "What you offer to the Lord of Lightning and Travel is between you and him. It's not my place to judge. Perhaps one of these items has special significance to you..." He trails, sounding doubtful.

I shake my head. "Not really. I just thought since they were unique by Haven standards..."

Ariel says, "The essence of becoming a Thunderlord is sacrifice. You must give yourself to Sune completely, and show that you are sincere. What will you be without if you devote these items?"

I think on the question, a sigh touches my lips. *A few dozen gold most likely.*

Ariel says, "I can see from your expression that you must take time to choose wisely."

I equip Bite and frown not wanting to give it up.

Ariel says, "A fine weapon for a Thunderlord. Did you find it in Hades?"

"No." I say, "I've been using it for a while. It has sentimental value."

"Then keep it, and wield it proudly in the service of Sune. The Lord of Travel asks that you sacrifice something acquired on your journey."

I pull out my VT and scroll through everything we obtained on our quest. My eyes settle on the Dragon Heartstone, and I withdraw it from inventory. I read the description, "Can be sold for more than 10,000 gold in the right markets."

That's a lot of money. Two and a half times my Dragonswood Tournament earnings, that bankrupted Sleeve the bookie, and yet... It's a quest item. It'd be really nice to have the extra coin, and upgrade my gear, maybe buy some enchantments. I grit my teeth, and place the stone on Ariel's table.

Ariel says, "Oh. Now, that's a pretty stone. Where did you get it?"

I say, "It came from Deadscream the Forsaken. A soul eating undead dragon."

"In Hades?" Ariel asks.

I nod.

Ariel says, "It looks quite valuable, though I'm no expert on magic gems."

I ask, "Do you think it's appropriate?"

He says, "Your offerings to Lord Sune are not for me to judge." though his voice is more positive.

"Alright." I say, "I get the picture. It's a choice I have to make for myself."

He gives me a bemused smile, with a twinkle in his eye that says, "Wash your ears. That's what I've been saying."

"Thank you." I say. "I think I'm ready."

Ariel says, "Buy some incense before you start?"

I say, "Of course. Show me what you've got." I browse the wide selection of incense, make my selection, and fork over ten gold.

You have received Supreme Incense of the Stormlord.

Supreme Incense of the Stormlord 10 Gold
Blessed incense containing rare herbs that are very pleasing to Sune. Used in marital ceremonies, before dangerous journeys, and when considering a change of vocation.

Ariel says, "Good choice. Sune finds this most pleasing."

I take a deep breath, bow respectfully, and begin walking the stone path to the granite alter. Birds sing. No one else is visiting the temple at this time. This feels different from becoming a paladin of Helios. The Sunlord's clergy is more structured, and there were no less than twelve NPCs present for the ceremony. By contrast, with Sune... It's just me and him. ... and Ariel if you count the priest, though he plays no part in the devotion. He's just sort of watching, looming from afar. I wonder if this means Sune will give me more personal attention.

I think about the voice in the wind. *That wasn't Sune. Who's missing me?*

I kneel before the alter, and press my forehead to the earth before it. I then rise, and place the incense with the Dragon Heartstone on the alter as an offering. My heart irrationally hastens as I touch my forehead to the lightning bolt symbol of Sune.

It's not like it's a real god.

You are praying. Do you want to offer tribute to Sune, God of Lightning and Travel? Yes / No

I choose yes.

You are paying tribute with a quest item. Offering Dragon Heartstone to Sune may change your vocation. Do you wish to proceed? Yes / No

I choose yes.

The sky grows dark. So cloudy. The wind howls, causing branches to bend, and birds to abandon trees. Electricity builds in the air. There's no quest prompt.
Have I failed?

A voice sounds, omnipresent and sincere. "Rise my chosen."

Not the other voice.

I stumble to my feet.

My breath catches, awaiting my god's next words. He says nothing. The wind blusters causing my hair to wave in a tangle across my face.

My lips tremble, "My Lord...?"

A powerful gust makes me stagger.

A woman's voice mixes in. "J."

Scent of ozone.

"Sal?"

KA-CRASH!

Thunder.

A wall of blue fire incinerates me where I stand.

**Sune hits you for 1,476 damage.
You absorb 16 points of damage.
You have died.**

* * * * *

"Awake." a man's voice says, it's Ariel. "Awaken now Lady Thunderlord. You are reborn in the Stormlord's service."

My health's at 20%.... 30%... Ariel's healing. 50%. I didn't get a resurrection prompt, or find myself disembodied and standing by my corpse, so I can only assume this is a scripted event... Though the moments before are fogged in a dreamlike haze. I don't know what I heard.

Ariel says, "Welcome back to the living... Once again."

You have completed the quest Thunderlord!

You have gained:

Title: Thunderlord

Ability to cast divine spells

+5000 reputation with clergy of deities allied with Sune.

You are now Honored with Sune's clergy

"Thanks..." I say. "I didn't expect the lightning."

Ariel says, "He's the god of Lightning and Travel."

"I know." I say, "I'm a Thunderlord." A note of self deprecating humor slips into my face. "Thank you for the resurrection."

Ariel says, "In his service."

I echo, "In his service."



Chapter 24 - Home Again

Dinner is amazing. No lasagna as we might have hoped, but Pehrom has figured out how to make pasta out of raw Haven ingredients. By now the Justice members the chef have mentioned have gone home.

Tako says, with a mouth full of food, "Chicken parm is love."

Sajina says, "I like the chicken." He'd changed to his elf skin before entering Durolan to avoid being attacked by guards, but once within the walls of guild headquarters he changed back to his stone form.

Pehrom wasn't kidding, a lot has changed. For starters, the keep is three stories higher than it was before we left, and six stone bastard sword wielding gargoyles police the grounds. I haven't had the grand tour yet, but I'm pretty sure I saw balisstras mounted on the roof that hadn't been there before.

Pehrom says, "Mel... Tako.. Frobod.. Fuck it... everyone who don't know already, this is Lilly, my old lady."

A big eared, black haired, red eyed goblin woman stands beside him with her hair pulled into a sporty pony tail. She has pouty lips and a pretty face.... attractive for a goblin. *Does that make me racist?*

She says, "Creep. Who ya callin' old lady?" She then regards me and says, "The hubby says good things about ya."

I say, "We're glad to have you. When I heard the news, I was worried about you."

She says, "I'm still here aren't I? I ain't a stupid girl back in Meatsville. I made sure I wasn't dyin'."

I ask, "So what's the deal with the defenses?"

Pehrom says, "So I was muckin' around with the interface after my promotion, right? And I accidentally set the keep to PvP mode. Word got out that you were in Hades, and this bunch of cock snobbers came out of nowhere and declared war tryin' to loot us dry!"

I say, "How'd they know I was in Hades?"

Pehrom says, "I was trying to get some more people to help in the kitchen since I was sellin' jerky and it was takin' off n' shit. Some people wanted to join, and I was like 'Hold up. I've gotta talk to Mel, but she's in Hades.' Then you know how it goes... they tell a friend, and they tell two friends, and pretty soon it's a monster clusterfuck on our doorstep. Luckily those Justice guys stepped in, and we we're able to defend."

I say, "You could have invited without asking."

"Yeah..." Pehrom says, "I could have, but since we're partners and I figured you'd be back in a few days, I thought I should wait a bit."

I ask, "What changed your mind?"

Lilly says, "This dope over here, didn't know he could send invites. Sure, get us tangled in a muthafuckin' war, but he don't know how to send a guild invite. That's my husband for ya."

Pehrom says, "Hey! I invited. I did good by the Toxic Muffins. I ain't ever been an officer before."

"With my help." Lilly says. "Anyway, we got a bunch of guys who were happy to work for food, but a couple of loud ones also wanted guild benefits. It's the whole LE thing, since you're names on the leader board with Dragonsbane. Pretty soon, they all wanted a taste of that LE goodness. I don't blame em'. Enemy at our doorstep, and I said, 'Rob, we don't have time for negotiation' send em' all the invite and let's get planin'."

Frobod says, "Rob?"

Pehrom says, "That's my name in the real world."

I say, "I'm Justine."

Lilly gives me a reverse nod. "Nice to meet ya. I'm Lilly. It's not just a cleva name."

Frobod says, "Aaron."

Tako adds, "Chris."

Mirae says, "My name's Amy."

Pahrem says, "I'm Leah."

It's surreal hearing everyone confess their real world identities, and it brings us closer together. More like a family, or at the very least crossing the line over that divides gaming buddy, and real friendship. Until now they've all just been Mirae, Frobod, Tako, and..." I look to Leroy and say "What's your name?"

Leroy says, "I'm Leroy. What you see is what you get."

I look to Sajina, curious if he'll join the discussion.

He says, "I'm Mandeep."

Pehrom says, "What you, from India or somethin'?"

Sajina says, "Los Angeles, though I am Indian."

I say, "He's a kickass bard, and now a sorcerer."

Pehrom says, "Hot shit. That oughta help if we gotta fight anymore battles."

Sajina, modest as always, says, "I am a bard, but I'm still learning the sorcerer thing."

Leroy says, "Don't listen to him. We spent his points together, and I made him a damn monster."

Pehrom says, "How many did he have to spend?"

Sajina says, "Put it this way... I've been playing since the game started, but I was never really into adventuring. I just stayed around town playing music, and leveling my social abilities."

Pehrom whistles, "Fuck me. That's like a brand new character with a million quadrillion XP, and you had Jensen do your build for ya? How's your attributes."

Sajina says, "I've been investing in Dexterity and Charisma for a long time, since they help my music playing and performance abilities. Haven't dinged as much as you guys fighting mons since I've stayed in town, but it happens sometimes completing social and intrigue quests."

Leroy chuckles, "I'm not much of a DPS player, but I think we managed."

I say, "We've also got big news, but I'm not sure how to break it..."

"Yeah?" Pehrom asks, "What's that?"

"We found a logout quest."

It's old news to most of us, but we're all quiet waiting for their reaction. It's Lilly who breaks the silence, with an explosive "Holy shit!" She nudges Pehrom, "Ya hear that? We can go home honey."

Pehrom, sounding less enthusiastic says, "Yeah, that sounds awesome. We'll have to talk about it."

I say, "There are some complications. There's an item that starts the quest chain, and we all got a copy of it, but to do the turn in, you have to have the item because the first objective is to return a lost doll to it's owner."

Leroy says, "That means we can't just share it with everyone. They might get the quest, but won't be able to complete it without a dolly in their group."

Pehrom says, "So what you got seven dolls now?"

Mirae says, "I didn't get one. It dropped before I was in the party."

I say, "I'm surprised you're not more surprised."

Tako says, "I told her."

Pahrem, largely quiet, says, "Figures. Couples don't leave no room for surprises."

Pehrom asks, "What are ya gonna do with em?"

I say, "I'm saving mine for the quest. As for everyone else... You all got the loot fairly, so as far as I'm concerned you can keep them, sell them, give them to a friend or whatever else you want."

Leroy says, "I'm going to use mine too. Sorry to say, I won't be joining you for this one. I've got a responsibility to my guild to share something this big."

I say, "We've got a few weeks until December so I say we plan our party, decide who's going and then figure out the rest."

Sajina says, "You know... I'm not much for adventuring, but I'd really like to have that logout button, and to be honest, there are no other adventurers I'd rather go with."

Pahrem says, "Awwwee. Listen to this guy. Start of the quest I was all like 'This guy is useless,' but now it's like he's becomin' part of the family."

I say, "We'll keep that in mind."

Sajina says, "I'd especially like to come with you Leroy since, you were the one that helped me build this character."

Leroy shrugs, "I'm flattered but..." his voice becomes more mercenary, "We might work something out. I can't use my dolly, and take a spot away from one of my guild mates, but if you were willing to part with yours so we could form two groups... Having you in my party effectively opens four more spots for the Malefactors."

Pahrem says, "You do know you're a Toxic Muffin now, right?"

Sajina says, "Sorry."

I say, "I don't hold it against him. They have history now." I give the gargoyle an encouraging smile. "Besides, I have a feeling that a large percentage of our guild won't be all that interested in the logout reward."

Pahrem says, "I hear ya, but what about those other rewards? Unique evolving items with legendary potential!"

Pehrom perks up, "Legendary?"

Pahrem says, "You heard it."

Pehrom says, "That's a sweet ass drop."

I say, "I dunno. Like I said, we have a few weeks. We can figure it out later." I look to Leroy and say, "I'm going to turn in early tonight, are you down to head to Dragonswood tomorrow morning?"

Frobod says, "Oh! I almost forgot. About those humans..."

Looking around the room I say, "Where are they?"

Pehrom says, "They were less impressed with the food, and went to the public bath."

I say, "Durolan has a public bathhouse?"

Lilly says, "No way! We got one in the basement. Don't cha know anything about your castle?"

"Er..." I say, "I didn't realize that."

Pehrom says, "Anyway, Alfred's down there helpin' em relax and get clean."

I look to Frobod and say, "What were you going to say about them?"

The death knight says, "There getting kinda crazy, now that they are out of Hades. More life is flowing back into them."

"... and?" I say.

Frobod says, "They don't want to have to worry about vampires anymore."

I say, "Understandable given all they've been through. What's that got to do with anything?"

Frobod says, "They want Lily to infect them."

Pehrom's wife says, "What? They think I got a disease or something?"

Frobod says, "Not you, the other Lilly. Melpomine's... Justine's... Alt." I take note that he made an effort to use my real name. "She's a Freeworld wererat."

Lilly says, "We're puttin' a stop to that right there. Mel, nice to meet ya, but you're Squeaks. I ain't gonna be confused with a wererat."

"Squeaks?" I ask.

Lilly says, "That's your alt's new name."

"They've got to be crazy." I say.

Frobod says, "I told you they were getting nutty. The whole lot of them says they want to be changed so they'll never be vamp food again."

Lilly says, "What does bein' a wererat have to do with not gettin' eaten by vampires?"

Frobod says, "Freeworld Wererat blood is toxic. It'll melt blood drinkers from the inside out."

I ask, "Do they realize what that means? They aren't like us, able to just switch aliases at will. They are choosing a life of anger."

Frobod says, "I think they're already pretty angry now that they know they're safe."

I sigh and say, "I'll think about it. I'm not doing anything without talking to Zarentu. Bringing him a trio of Freeworld humans is one thing, but he might not take kindly to infesting his castle with wererats."

Leroy stands from the table, wipes his mouth with a napkin, and extends his hand to Pehrom. "As always, it's been an amazing meal."

Pehrom shakes, "You got it man. Friend of Mel's is a friend of mine."

Leroy says, "We'll be in touch, but right now I need to get back to the Malefactors. I've been away too long." He looks to me and says. "You're sleeping early, so what do you say we meet outside Dragonswood Keep at eight AM tomorrow? Can you bring the kids?"

I assume by 'kids' he means the NPC humans.

"I'll be there."



Chapter 25 - The Final Turn In

Leroy swoops down on his phoenix, and I lead a procession of Elechoppers to Zarentu's gate. Surprisingly, Annette, Jason, and James require no instruction to operate the mounts. I suppose it's either because they're NPCs, or because they're free folk riding Freeworld items.

Archibald bows respectfully, such a contrast from our first meeting where we were required to present invitations. He says, "Good morning to you, Thunderlord Melpomine. May I be the first of Dragonswood to congratulate you on your promotion."

"Promotion?" I ask.

Archibald says, "Perhaps promotion wasn't the right word, I refer simply to your Paladin status."

I say, "Ah. Well, thanks. No need to bow. Word travels fast huh?"

"Like the wind." Archibald chuckles, apparently thinking himself quite clever. "Because Sune is the god of-"

"I get it." I say. "You're very funny." Then motion first to Leroy, and the three free folk riding on elechoppers. "They're with me. These three in particular I need to introduce to Lord Zarentu."

"By dragon's teeth." Archibald says, "Is that Lord LeroyJensen?" He bows, "Your reputation precedes you."

"Well met." He says, "I'm just here to keep Mel company. Her business is with Zarentu, and these three humans."

I ask, "Where's Lyle?"

Archibald puffs up, and confides stuffily, "He's taking care of the necessities."

I raise a brow.

Leroy says, "He's taking a dump."

They've certainly amped up the realism since we've been gone. I can't remember a single time an NPC has had to relieve himself if it wasn't somehow related to a quest.

"Just so." Archibald confirms, "No matter. Master Aztram... I just saw him somewhere around here...." He calls out, "Master Aztram!"

The elderly half elf hobbles around the corner. "There's no need to shout." I note his walk and say, "Are you hurt?"

Aztram says, "No matter, I just pulled a muscle. What brings you to Dragonswood Keep this early in the morning?"

I say, "We've got some people I think Zarentu would like to meet. This is Annette, Jason, and James. They're from the Free World."

"Really now?" Aztram examines them with renewed interest, "That is fascinating. I'm sure Lord Zarentu will be more than happy to make their acquaintance."

Jason asks, "Is he really a dragon?"

Aztram, speaking as though the man in his 20s were a child, says, "Oh yes. Quite a few residents of Dragonswood Keep are dragons. But worry not, Lord Zarentu is a Light Dragon and friendly to mortals."

James asks, "Are you?"

Aztram chuckles, "You flatter me boy, but no. I'd hardly look this old if I were one of dragon kind. Come, and we shall find him."

* * * * *

Zarentu, the blonde haired, yellow eyed dragon in human form, steeples his fingers, behind his desk in his study.

"These are free folk?" He asks. I nod my head. He points to Annette and makes a twirling 'come hither' motion with his wrist. "I want to look at you."

I say, "It's okay. He won't hurt you."

She approaches cautiously. Zarentu leans forward, and gently takes her wrist caressing her light skin, and makes a show of sniffing. She relaxes under his touch, having expected perhaps to be manhandled.

He says, "They look and smell just like any humans. Are you sure, they're from this Free World?" He releases her.

"They are." I say, "We found them in Hades, being held captive by a Freeworld vampire."

"Hades?" Zarentu says. "You have been busy, but they are not ghosts."

"No." Annette says, a spark of rage entering her voice. "We were their blood supply. They, meaning the fangers. They tied us over their bar and tapped us like kegs!"

Zarentu says, "That does sound awful." He looks to me. "Thank you for bringing these three to my attention." He regards Annette and then Jason and James. "Do you agree to share what you know about the Free World while you reside in my keep?"

"I..." Annette says.

Zarentu says, "I'm not forcing you." Though part of me wonders if Zarentu would let these three go easily if they refused.

Annette says, "I don't see why not. We can answer some questions if we know the answers."

Zarentu says, "Does she speak for all of you?"

Jason says, "Sure."

James says, "We're just happy to be alive. If you're a friend of Melpomine... We'll trust you."

"Wonderful." Zarentu says, "Then you are welcome to stay, as long as you like. I'll have rooms prepared."

Annette asks, "That's it?"

Zarentu raises an amused eyebrow, "You were expecting more?"
Annette shakes her head, "Not from you, but Melpomine."
Zarentu corrects, "That's Thunderlord Melpomine. She's a Paladin now."
He looks to me and says, "Congratulations on your title."
Annette says, "I don't know what that is, but it sounds nice."
Zarentu says, "I see you have much to learn."
Annette says, "We want to become Rodekin like you. We've talked about it and before you go, we want you to bite us. It's the only way we won't be tapped again."
Zarentu perks up, "Rodekin?"
I say, "They want to become wererats. The Free World kind, not like they are in Haven."
Zarentu scoffs, "I assure you, there's no reason to fear vampires here. I am a light dragon." He then looks to me, "I remember you saying that the Free World weres were different."
I say, "They don't lose their minds. They just have anger management issues."
Zarentu says, "And you are one of these... Rodekin?"
I shake my head no, "I'm not... Melpomine isn't... but I can become one. I can transform into a human that's been infected with the curse." I look to Annette, "Do you realize what you're asking? You're going to be angry all the time until you learn to control it."
Annette snaps, "I don't care! I'm already angry! We will not be food again."
Zarentu says, "If they want to become these... Rodekin," he tastes the word, "...and you have the ability to make this happen. I see no reason why you should not. It could make for an interesting study."
I say, "You want wererats in your castle?"
Zarentu says, "Well, they won't be common wererats if I am to believe you. I think it's important to learn about Free World creatures. What better way than to host them as my guests?"
I say, "They can be violent... They probably will be until they learn to keep their urges under control, but not mindless. Remember this. They are not monsters."
Zarentu says, "I think a castle of dragons can handle a few rodent temper tantrums."
Looking to Annette I ask, "Are you sure this is what you want?"
James says, "Do it."
I look to Zarentu and say, "I want your word that you won't kill them."
He waves his hand dismissively. "Done."
Speaking to the humans, I say "You may not survive."
Annette says, "Do it."
Jason says, "We've talked it over. This is what we want."
I pull out my VT, and use it to transform into my Lily alias. Streamers of psychedelic color enwrap me as I appear once again in bell bottom pants, a tie-dye shirt, and enormous pink heart shaped sunglasses. *I really need to reset Lily's default gear.*

I begin to transform... A hairless tail sprouts from the seat of my jeans, and my face elongates rat toothed, mousy muzzle. Fur sprouts all over my body, and my fingers are tipped with wicked were claws.

Zarentu watches, leaning forward in his chair, smirking both enthralled and amused.

I meet Annette's determined eyes, with my black ones.

I chitter, "Last chance."

Zarentu says, "It talks! Wonderful!"

My rage meter grows red. "I'm still a person!"

Annette says, "I want this."

I'm a blur of motion that empties my rage meter. My claws rend deep tears across her chest. Blood splatters. I come in with my teeth and bite.

Do you wish to infect Annette with the Nativity Pestilence? Yes / No

The End
of
Freehaven Online: Book Two
Lady Thunderlord,
Into Hades

